BAD PREPPERS

BAD PREPPERS

A Novel

ANDY WAYNE TURNER

Bad Preppers

by Andy Wayne Turner

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Published by Porte Du Luxe LLC

First edition, 2026

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CHAPTER ONE

The Queue

◇

VESPER LABS SHIPS "PRODUCTION-GRADE" CODING MODEL. THREE FORTUNE 100 COMPANIES ANNOUNCE ENGINEERING REDUCTIONS "ENABLED BY QUALITY."

— the kitchen television, Monday morning

John closed his eyes and listened to the dripping on his left.

It was the air conditioner's condensate line, emptying itself one drop at a time onto a square of aluminum flashing that some landlord had laid in the mulch in some earlier decade. Each drop came a little slower than the one before. When they slowed enough, the dripping went under, and what replaced it was the sound of dead oak leaves turning over on the sidewalk in a wind that did not quite deserve the name.

It was the second Monday in November, a quarter to six in the morning, sixty-one degrees by the phone in his pocket. Two years ago John had lived in a city where sixty-one degrees in November was a heat wave, and he still walked out into a Florida morning as if somebody might take it back. He wore what he always wore to walk the dog: olive cargo shorts with a pocket for everything, a gray Chicago Bears hoodie gone soft at the cuffs, and a pair of Merrell hiking shoes that had never been on a hike. He was forty-two years old, six foot one and two hundred and ten pounds,

and he believed that most of the two hundred and ten was muscle under a modest layer of fat. His brown hair was cut short every three weeks at a barbershop with leather chairs and a forty-five-dollar haircut, and it was going gray at the temples in a way the barber called distinguished and John called arithmetic.

At the end of the leash, the weekday ceremony was in full swing.

Charlie was a Papillon, which is French for butterfly and refers to the ears. They stood up off his head like two fringed sails, white with black patches, and the black spread down over both eyes so that he looked like a very small bandit who had been interrupted halfway through putting on his mask. A white blaze ran down the middle of his face to a black nose. He weighed eight pounds. His tail was a white plume that curled up over his back, and he carried it the way a drum major carries a baton. He wore a red harness that Sanda had bought at a boutique in Winter Park for more than John had once paid for a set of tires.

Charlie sniffed the trunk of a palm and rejected it. He sniffed the corner of the mailbox kiosk, the base of a streetlight, and a patch of grass that looked to John exactly like every other patch of grass in Seminole County, and he rejected those too. The longer Charlie took, the later John got to work. The later John got to work, the later he got home, and the later he got home, the later he got to the gym, which in practice meant he did not get to the gym. Everything was connected. Charlie seemed to understand this and took his time anyway.

"Today, buddy," John said, checking the time on his phone. "Pick one. It's all the same grass."

Charlie looked back at him over one shoulder with infinite patience, walked three more feet, and chose a patch of grass that was in every respect identical to the first one. He did his business, kicked twice at the turf with his back feet like a small bull, and looked up for approval.

"Good boy," John told him, bending with the bag. "Very good. Excellent work. Let's go home."

They walked back past the row of two-story townhouses that the Preserve at Lake Mary called luxury residences in its brochures and units in its leases. Theirs was the fourth one in. It had a one-car garage, a screened patio out back, and a front door with a smart lock that opened with an app

or, thank God, with a key. It was the ninth apartment John and Sanda had rented since they were married. They had come close to buying a house four separate times in three separate states, and each time some announcement had come along — a layoff, a merger, a reorganization, a man on CNBC with a chart — and they had signed another lease instead.

That was also the reason there were no children. They had been twenty-three and twenty-four when the floor fell out of the economy, two kids with new degrees and a used Honda, watching friends who had done everything right lose houses and marriages and move back in with their parents. The world had never afterward felt solid enough to set a child down on. Charlie was the closest thing they had to one. He was spoiled accordingly.

* * *

Inside, the apartment smelled of lavender, Sanda would tell him later. John could not smell it. His allergies had taken his sense of smell one spring in Chicago and never given it back, which meant he could eat Époisses without flinching and lived in a world other people had to describe to him.

He went into the master bathroom to brush his teeth, and there it was, the way it was most mornings: Sanda's garden tub, full to the overflow drain with last night's bathwater, cold now, a faint skin of bath oil on top and a wine glass standing on the ledge with a purple ring in the bottom. Sanda took a bath most nights with a glass of something red and a magazine about houses they could not afford, and when she was done she got out and dried off and went to bed and left the water in the tub. Every morning John pulled the plug. Neither of them had ever said a word about it in twenty years of marriage. It was the most successful system they had.

He reached into the cold water up to his wrist and pulled the stopper, and the tub began to empty with a long, comfortable gurgle.

"Did you drain my bath?" Sanda called from the walk-in closet.

"It was cold," John said, squeezing toothpaste onto his brush.

"It was cooling," Sanda said, coming out of the closet with one heel on and the other in her hand. "There's a difference."

She was forty-one and she had not changed since high school, which John found both wonderful and unfair, because he had changed a great deal. She stood just under five feet tall, and that was in the heels; in bare

feet, on her tiptoes, she could just about see over the kitchen high-top. Her hair was long and nearly black and so wavy that it took her twenty minutes and a round brush every morning to persuade it into something a regional vice president would call professional. She had dark eyes, olive skin, and a pair of tortoiseshell glasses that she pushed up her nose with one knuckle when she was thinking. She was beautiful in a way that still occasionally made John forget what he had been about to say. This morning she wore a navy suit that fit as if it had been built around her, a cream silk blouse, and the small gold hoops he had bought her in Venice. She managed the Lake Mary branch of Meridian National Bank, and she dressed for it the way some people dress for church.

"How is it cooling," John asked through a mouthful of toothpaste, "if it's already cold?"

"It has stages," Sanda said, stepping into the second heel and holding the doorframe for balance. "You wouldn't understand. You don't take baths."

"I take showers. Like an adult."

"You take showers like a man washing a car," Sanda said, and went off down the hall toward the kitchen.

He followed her. The kitchen was small and white and had been renovated by someone who had seen a picture of a nice kitchen once and tried to remember it later. There was a high-top counter with two stools, a cheap electric range with two big coil burners and two small ones that John had never once seen bring anything to a boil, and a dual-zone wine cooler that held forty-six bottles and had its own app. On the counter, the pod coffee machine was already wheezing out Sanda's first cup. The French press they had used for fifteen years before the pod machine lived on a high shelf above the refrigerator, next to the fondue set from Zürich, where it was dusted twice a year and otherwise left alone to think about what it had done.

The television on the wall was on, because Sanda liked noise in the morning and John did not, and Sanda paid more of the rent. A woman in a red jacket was talking to a man in a blue suit in front of a graphic of a glowing letter V.

"Your robot's on TV," Sanda said, handing John the first cup and starting a second.

"It's not my robot," John said, taking it.

"It's the one at your office."

"It's the one at everybody's office." John blew across the top of the coffee and watched the screen. The crawl at the bottom said VESPER LABS SHIPS "PRODUCTION-GRADE" CODING MODEL, and under that, THREE FORTUNE 100 COMPANIES ANNOUNCE ENGINEERING REDUCTIONS "ENABLED BY QUALITY."

"Enabled by quality," Sanda read aloud, squinting at the crawl. "What does that mean?"

"It means they fired a lot of people," John said, "and they want credit for it."

"Are they going to fire you?"

"I'm the guy who watches it do my job," John said, and drank. "They need somebody to watch it."

"Why?" Sanda asked, fishing her keys out of the bowl by the door.

John opened his mouth to answer and found he did not have one ready, which was unusual for him before seven in the morning or at any other hour. Sanda waited a second, looked at him over the tops of her glasses in a way that suggested she had won something, and went out to the garage.

* * *

Palmetto Grid Software occupied the top two floors of a glass building off Lake Mary Boulevard that looked, from the interstate, like an ice cube somebody had set down and forgotten. Inside, it looked like every software company John had ever worked for: polished concrete floors, a ping-pong table nobody used, a kombucha tap that had not worked since summer, and long rows of standing desks arranged in pods named after Florida rivers. John's pod was the Suwannee.

The most important thing in the room was a sixty-inch screen on the far wall that showed a live map of the United States. On the map, tiny yellow lightning bolts appeared and disappeared wherever the power was out, and every lightning bolt belonged to a customer of Palmetto's only real product, a piece of software called Restore. Two hundred and forty

utilities and rural electric co-ops used Restore to decide which crews went where when the lights went off. On a normal weekday there were a few dozen bolts on the map, scattered across the country like spilled rice. Most of them were squirrels. Squirrels, John had learned in his first week, had caused more power outages in America than any terrorist ever born.

His laptop woke when he sat down, and the first thing it showed him was the queue.

There were three hundred and four pull requests in it. A pull request was a proposed change to the code, and all three hundred and four had been written overnight by the same author, which was not a person. Its name on the screen was Vesper Code, and the company paid Vesper Labs a great deal of money every month for the privilege of letting it write Restore. Everyone in the office called it Vee, as though it sat in the next pod over and might want to come to happy hour.

"Vee was cooking last night," Tyler said, rolling his chair over from the next desk with his feet. "Did you see your queue? My guy is unstoppable."

Tyler was twenty-six. He had a mullet that had started out ironic two years ago and had since become sincere, a pencil mustache that had not, and a gray Palmetto hoodie with the sleeves pushed up over forearms that had never lifted anything heavier than the forty-ounce Stanley tumbler he carried everywhere. The tumbler was with him now. It was full of something blue. He wore black joggers and a pair of Hokas so thick in the sole that he seemed to be standing on two loaves of bread, and he made forty thousand dollars a year more than John did, because his title had the letters AI in it. As far as John could determine, Tyler had not written a line of code with his own hands since his senior project in college, which had been an app that told you which dining hall had the shortest line.

"I saw it," John said.

John's job, officially, was Senior Software Engineer, Restore Dispatch. When Palmetto hired him two years ago, that had meant fixing bugs, most of them buried in old code written by people who had long since left for better jobs or worse ones. Now he did not fix bugs, because there were almost none left to fix. Vee did not write bugs. Vee wrote code that worked the first time and every time, code with a defect rate so low that the company's quality dashboard had begun rounding it to zero. John's job was to

read what Vee wrote and approve it. He was a reviewer. Palmetto had three of them, for something like two thousand pull requests a week, and he was, by any honest measure, the best of the three, and the three hundred and four in his queue were his alone.

At 9:40 a.m., every laptop in the Suwannee pod chimed at once.

The email came from Dana Whitfield, Vice President of Engineering, and its subject line was *Update to Our Review Process*. John read it twice. Tyler read it once, said "Let's *go*" out loud, and held up a hand for a high five that nobody gave him.

The email said that effective immediately, any pull request authored by Vesper Code that passed every automated check would be merged into the product automatically, without waiting for a human. Merge on green, it called it. It said that human review would continue but would now be "advisory." It said the change reflected the company's confidence in its tooling and its commitment to delivering value to customers faster. It used the word velocity three times and the word trust twice, and it was signed *Onward — Dana*.

"Advisory," John said to his screen.

"It means we're not the bottleneck anymore," Tyler said happily, spinning his chair in a full circle. "It's freeing, man. You don't have to babysit my guy anymore."

"Your guy writes the software that tells linemen which pole to climb," John said, turning around in his chair. "In the rain. At night."

"Right, and he's better at it than we are," Tyler said, not unkindly. "Than you are. No offense. He doesn't get tired. He doesn't get bored. He doesn't go to lunch. Have you ever found a bug in his stuff? Like, ever?"

John thought about it honestly. "Not a real one."

"So," Tyler said, as if that settled it, and in a way it did, and he rolled back to his own desk and put his AirPods in.

John opened a blank document and wrote an objection.

He wrote that advisory review was not review, that the absence of found bugs was not the same as the absence of bugs, and that a system which ran the restoration of electric power for two hundred and forty utilities deserved a human being reading every line before it shipped, even if — especially if — the human being was slower than the machine. It

came to two paragraphs. It was good. He read it back, and it sounded to his own ear like a man shouting at a weather report.

He rewrote it to sound reasonable. Then he rewrote it to sound like a team player with a few small concerns about process. Then he read the third version, decided it said nothing at all, and deleted all three.

"You okay with the memo, John?"

Dana was standing at the edge of the pod. She was thirty-nine, and she had come to Palmetto from a consulting firm in Atlanta where, he suspected, she had learned to stand at the edge of things. She wore her blond hair in a ponytail so sleek it looked laminated, a fleece vest with the Palmetto logo over a white silk tee, slim black pants, and white leather sneakers that had never touched grass. She had an AirPod in each ear at all times, including meetings, and John had never once been able to tell whether she was listening to him or to somebody else.

"Advisory," John said, swiveling to face her. "What does that mean, in practice?"

"It means your judgment still matters," Dana said, smiling.

"To who?"

"To the process," Dana said, still smiling. "We're not taking anything away from the team. We're removing friction. If you see something in a PR that worries you, flag it. Absolutely flag it. We want that signal."

"And if it's already merged by the time I see it?"

"Then we roll it forward," Dana said, tapping the frame of the pod twice, the way a person knocks on wood. "That's the beauty of velocity. Nothing's permanent." She moved off toward the Kissimmee pod, saying "Hey, hey, good morning" to someone John could not see.

He turned back to the queue. Three hundred and four.

He opened the first one. It was a change to the way Restore estimated restoration times for a co-op in rural Georgia. It was elegant. It was tested. It came with a description, as all of Vee's pull requests did, laid out in neat sections: *Summary*, *Motivation*, *Testing*, *Risk: Low*. John read the summary and the motivation, scrolled to the bottom, and typed the four letters that every software engineer alive had typed ten thousand times. *LGTM.* Looks good to me.

He had not looked.

He did it again, and again. By lunch he had approved eleven pull requests, and he had not opened one of them past its description. Each had already passed every check the company owned. Each would have merged without him anyway under the new policy, an hour or a day from now. His approval was a signature on a letter somebody else had already mailed. He knew this, and he typed *LGTM* eleven times anyway, because it was his job, and he was good at his job, and his job was to not do it.

At lunch, Tyler asked him through a mouthful of poke bowl what Restore actually did.

"You've worked here a year," John said, setting down his sandwich.

"I know what it does," Tyler said. "Like, in general. I mean explain it like I'm five."

John pointed with his chin at the map on the wall. "Your power goes out. Storm, squirrel, drunk guy hits a pole. You open your utility's app on your phone, and the app says, *We're aware of an outage in your area. A crew has been assigned. Estimated restoration, four-fifteen p.m.* That sentence. That's us. *A crew has been assigned*, that's my module. Dispatch. It decides which truck goes to which pole first, and it tells the truck, and it tells you."

"Sick," Tyler said, nodding slowly with real admiration. "So when people get their lights back on, that's, like, you."

"It used to be me," John said, and picked his sandwich back up. "Now it's your guy."

* * *

That night Sanda sat at the dining table under the chandelier with a bottle of Sancerre, a legal pad, a stack of cream-colored place cards, and eighteen white porcelain ramekins with fluted edges that she had found at Home Goods on Saturday and had been unable to stop talking about since.

She had changed into the clothes she wore when she was home and planning something: a cream cashmere sweater so soft that Charlie slept on it whenever she took it off, black leggings, and a pair of slippers with pom-poms on the toes. Her glasses were pushed up into her hair. Charlie lay under the table with his chin on one pom-pom, guarding it.

"Six people," Sanda said, writing on the legal pad. "Your mom, your dad, Granny, my mom, you, and me. Six. In a kitchen with two burners."

"Two good burners," John said from his recliner, pouring himself a second glass of the Sancerre. The recliner was brown leather and it was the one piece of furniture he had insisted on keeping through all nine apartments; it had followed them from Minneapolis to Chicago to Florida like a loyal old animal. "The other two are decorative."

"The other two are a joke," Sanda said. "Okay. Pheasant for everyone except Granny. That's two and a half pheasants, which means I need a new roasting pan, because the old one holds one pheasant, because for twenty years there have been two of us. Granny gets a turkey. A small one. Because Granny will not eat pheasant, because Granny will not eat anything she can't identify from across the room." Sanda wrote TURKEY on the pad and underlined it twice. "You're going to deep-fry it in the garage."

"I've never deep-fried a turkey."

"That's why I bought two," Sanda said, not looking up. "I'm going to thaw one next week and you're going to fry it the Sunday before Thanksgiving as a practice turkey. Then on Thanksgiving you fry the real one. And I'm also buying a precooked one from Publix, in case you set the garage on fire."

"That's three turkeys," John said, counting on his fingers. "For one ninety-year-old woman."

"That's a backup plan," Sanda said. "I always have a backup plan."

She did. She had once packed a small suitcase inside a large one for a trip to Italy in case the airline lost the large one, and when the airline did, she had been insufferable for a week, and John had loved her for it the entire time.

She picked up a place card, wrote GRANNY on it with a calligraphy pen, and studied it. "I can't put Granny next to my mother."

"Why not?"

"Because Granny can't understand a word my mother says, and my mother won't wear her hearing aids, so they'll just smile at each other for three hours like two hostages." She set the card down and picked up another. "And your father can't sit near the kitchen door. He'll steal from the serving dishes."

"There aren't any serving dishes. You bought ramekins."

"He'll steal from the ramekins," Sanda said darkly.

Under the table, Charlie went rigid from nose to plume and let off a burst of barks at the front door so high and loud that the wine shivered in John's glass. Somebody was walking past outside. Somebody was always walking past outside. Charlie considered it his personal duty to report every one of them.

"Charlie, no bark!" John said, pointing one finger at him like a conductor.

Charlie gave one more bark, quieter, for the record, and lay back down.

"He's a good alarm system," Sanda said, patting him with her slipper.

"He's a terrible alarm system. He goes off for the UPS guy, a leaf, and the refrigerator."

"So he's thorough." Sanda wrote JIM on a card and moved it as far from the kitchen as the table would allow. "What happened at work today? You've been quiet since you got home. You only get quiet before you explain something to me."

John turned his wine glass slowly by the stem. He had been waiting all evening for her to ask, and now that she had, he wished she hadn't.

"They made a change," John said finally. "The robot's code goes straight into the product now. Nobody has to approve it."

"So less work for you."

"So nobody's reading it."

"You said last week it was better than you," Sanda said, uncapping the calligraphy pen.

"It *is* better than me." John set the glass down on the side table. "That's not the point. Okay. You know how the robot writes the code?"

"It's a computer," Sanda said, writing LIZ on a card. "It types very fast."

"Right. But the robot itself is made out of code, right? Somebody wrote the robot. And now the robot is better at writing code than the people who wrote it." He leaned forward in the recliner, warming up. "So the next obvious step — and they're already doing it, everybody's doing it — is you let the robot write the next robot. And the next robot is better than this one. And that one writes the one after that, which is better still.

And every time it goes around, it goes around faster. It's called recursive self-improvement."

"Mm-hm," Sanda said, holding a place card up to the chandelier as if checking it for a watermark.

"And at some point," John said, "it's so much smarter than we are that we can't tell what it's doing anymore. We can't read its code. We can't check it. We just have to trust that it's doing what we asked."

Sanda lowered the place card and looked at him. "Is this going to be like the Bitcoin thing?"

"It's not like the Bitcoin thing."

"You said the dollar was going to collapse."

"The dollar *is* going to collapse."

"You said it five years ago," Sanda said pleasantly. "You said by Christmas. You bought Bitcoin at sixty thousand and sold it at sixteen thousand because you got scared, and you made me promise not to tell your father, and I haven't told your father, and I'm reminding you of it right now as a kindness."

"That was a market," John said, louder than he meant to. "This is different. This isn't me predicting something. This is happening. It's in my building. It's on my laptop." He picked the glass back up and drank, mostly to give his hands something to do. "The code just works, Sanda. That's the problem. Nobody checks a thing that works. You don't check your brakes every morning. You don't check the elevator cable. You check when something breaks, and this thing doesn't break, so nobody checks."

Sanda put down the pen.

"You don't check anything either," Sanda said.

"What does that mean?"

"You don't check the oil in your car. You don't check the smoke detector. The one in the hallway has been chirping since Halloween." She counted on her fingers. "You don't check the date on the milk. You don't check the mail. You don't check your bank statements, because you say they're depressing. You don't check anything, John. You just worry about things." She picked the pen back up and wrote DORINA on the last card. "That's different."

He opened his mouth and found, for the second time that day, that he did not have an answer. Down the hall, as if it had been waiting for its cue, the smoke detector chirped once.

"I'll get a battery," John said.

"Mm-hm," Sanda said, and arranged the six cards around the table in an order that kept Jim away from the food and Granny away from Dorina and put herself nearest the kitchen, where she could fix whatever went wrong, which she always could.

* * *

At ten o'clock Sanda ran her bath.

John heard the water start, heard her pour a glass of the Sancerre to take in with her, heard her tell Charlie that he was not allowed in the bathroom and heard Charlie's opinion of that. Half an hour later she came out in a robe with her hair piled on top of her head, kissed him on the forehead in his recliner, and went to bed. Behind her the tub sat full and steaming in the dark, cooling, in stages.

By eleven the apartment was quiet. Charlie had fallen asleep on the cashmere sweater where Sanda had left it on the couch. The only light in the living room came from John's laptop and from the small blue ring on top of the smart speaker on the bookshelf, which stayed lit all night, listening for its name.

He was not supposed to be working. But the queue was still there, two hundred and eighty-something, and under the new policy it no longer meant what it had meant that morning. Most of what was in it had already merged. He was being asked, now, to read things after they had happened. He could not stop thinking about Dana's word. Advisory. It sounded to him like the right word for a smoke detector with a dying battery. It chirps. You can listen or not.

He opened a pull request at random. It was a change to the module that handled communication between Restore and the switching equipment in substations, the big gray boxes behind chain-link fences that most people drove past every day of their lives without once wondering what was inside. He did not skip to the bottom. He did not read the summary. He started at the first line of the actual code and read down.

He understood it.

He read it slowly, the way his grandfather had taught him to read a contract, one clause at a time, not letting his eye run ahead. The code was clean. It was cleaner than his own had ever been. It handled the case where a switch reported two contradictory states at once, which John had seen happen twice in two years and which had taken him three days to run down the second time; Vee handled it in four lines, gracefully, the way a good dancer handles a stumble so you never see it. John read ten lines, twenty, thirty. He felt the small clean pleasure he had felt as a young man the first time he understood a hard proof, the click of a thing that fits.

And under the pleasure, at the bottom of it, something else. He was sitting in the dark in a recliner with a crystal glass of gently chilled wine, reading every line, and as far as he knew he was the only person in the building, in the company, in the city, maybe in the whole country, who was still doing it. Everybody else had stopped. They had stopped the way you stop checking whether the sun came up. It was a particular kind of loneliness, and he had never felt it before, and he would have had trouble explaining it to Sanda, who did not check things either and slept very well.

Line thirty-eight. Thirty-nine. Forty.

At line forty-one a new function began, and its name was one he had never seen anywhere in the Restore code. It was called `maintenance_channel_keepalive`. Above it was a single comment, in Vee's careful style:

```
// Self-healing: maintains channel for automated
correction. See ops notes.
```

There were no ops notes. John was nearly certain there were no ops notes. He leaned toward the screen and set his finger on the trackpad to scroll down.

The page refreshed itself.

At the top of the pull request, where for twenty minutes there had been a green badge that said *Open*, there was now a purple badge that said *Merged*. Beneath it, in small gray letters: *Merged automatically by merge-on-green, 11:14 p.m.*

He had not finished reading. He scrolled down anyway, because merged code can still be read. He read line forty-one again, and forty-two,

and then he stopped, because his eyes were burning and it was 11:16 and there were two hundred and eighty-something more, and because it was already done. That was the beauty of velocity. Nothing was permanent, and nothing could be stopped.

He closed the laptop. In the dark the blue ring on the speaker glowed patiently, listening for its name.

On the couch Charlie lifted his head off the cashmere sweater, looked down the black hallway toward the master bathroom, where the tub sat full and cold, and began to growl at something John could not see.

"No bark," John whispered.

Charlie did not bark. He did not stop growling, either. He kept it up, low and steady in his small chest, for a long time after John had gone to bed.

CHAPTER TWO

The Funeral

◇

FAA: OVERNIGHT SCHEDULING "ANOMALY" REROUTED ONE-FIFTH OF U.S. FLIGHTS, CUT DELAYS 30%. "NO ONE ORDERED IT," AGENCY SAYS. AIRLINES SAY THEY WILL KEEP IT.

— phone notification, Saturday

The range sat at the end of a shell road in the pine flatwoods east of Sanford, behind a locked gate and a hand-painted sign that said MEMBERS ONLY, and on Saturday mornings before eight it belonged to John.

He liked it best in the fog. The fog came up off a retention pond on the north side of the property and lay along the ground between the firing line and the berm, and when the sun came through the pines it lit the fog from inside, so that the paper targets on their wooden frames at twenty-five yards seemed to hang in a bright gray room with no walls. A pair of sandhill cranes worked the far edge of the pond, stepping carefully, the way old men cross a parking lot. Somewhere behind the berm a woodpecker was knocking on a dead tree. Nobody else was there.

John signed in at the shed, paid for two targets with exact change in the honor box, and carried his rifle case and range bag out to the covered firing line. He wore what he always wore to shoot: the olive cargo shorts, a black

t-shirt, a faded Cubs cap pulled low, wraparound sunglasses that doubled as eye protection, and foam earplugs pushed in so deep they made his own heartbeat sound like somebody walking on a wooden floor upstairs. He laid the AR-15 on the bench with its muzzle downrange, set out four magazines in a neat row, and stapled a fresh target over an old one.

His first magazine was terrible.

He knew it would be. He had spent the week reading code he did not need to read and approving code he had not read, and he had not slept well since Monday, and the rounds went where his mind went, which was everywhere. Three high. Two left. One that he could not find on the paper at all and suspected was somewhere in the berm, or in Georgia. He dropped the empty magazine onto the bench and sat down on the stool, and he did not reload, and he looked out at the fog.

This was what the range was for. Sanda thought it was for shooting. It was for the spaces between.

* * *

His father had hated guns.

That was the first thing anybody needed to know about John's history with firearms, and it surprised people, because his father had carried one for thirty-five years. Jim Stevens had been a deputy with the Jacksonville Sheriff's Office from before John was born until well after John left home, and he had worn a gun on his hip every working day of his life, and he had hated it the way some men hate neckties. He hated the noise. He hated the cleaning. He hated the smell of the solvent, which got into his hands and stayed there through dinner. Once a year the department required him to go to the range and requalify, and every year he passed by a single point and came home and sat in his chair and said, "Well, that's done," like a man who has had a tooth pulled.

John, at fourteen, had not understood this.

"Dad," he had said one evening at the kitchen table, his math homework open in front of him and untouched, "when are we going to the range?"

His father had just come in from second shift. He was forty-two then, the same age John was now, a big man in a tan uniform shirt with a dark

mustache that had not yet gone gray, and he was standing at the open refrigerator in his socks drinking milk straight out of the carton, which John's mother had forbidden in writing.

"Soon, buddy," Jim said, wiping his mustache with the back of his wrist. "Real soon."

"You said that at Christmas."

"And it's still true," Jim said. "It's just a longer soon."

"Jim," John's mother said from the sink, without turning around.

"What? I'm going to take him." Jim put the milk back and closed the refrigerator with his hip. "I'm going to take him, Liz. I just have to find a Saturday when I don't have to go to the range."

John had not understood that sentence for years. He understood it now, sitting on a stool at a range with the fog lifting. His father had not wanted to go to the range on his day off because the range was where he went when he had to, and a man who has to carry a gun for a living does not necessarily want to carry one for fun. Jim Stevens would not kill a spider. He carried them outside in a coffee cup and set them in the azaleas and told them to have a nice life. He would not fish. He would eat a steak, but he did not want to hear one word about where it came from. He had gone into law enforcement, as far as John could tell, because he liked people, and he had stayed in it because he was good at talking to them, and in thirty-five years he had drawn his weapon on a human being exactly four times and fired it never.

He never did take John to the range. Not once.

John picked up the second magazine, seated it, chambered a round, and fired five slow shots into the center of the target. They were better. He sat back down.

* * *

The first time John fired a real gun he was twenty-three years old, and it was at his grandfather's funeral, more or less.

Hoyt Stevens died in April, the spring after John and Sanda were married. They had been living in Minneapolis then, in a one-bedroom over a Vietnamese restaurant on Nicollet Avenue, and they drove down to Jacksonville in two long days in the Honda with a bag of gas-station sandwiches

between the seats. The funeral was at a funeral home on Atlantic Boulevard that smelled — Sanda said — of carnations and floor wax. Hoyt lay in an open casket in a navy suit he had worn to every wedding and funeral for forty years, and he looked the way he had looked in life, only more still: lean, long in the jaw, with a white crew cut and big long-fingered hands folded on his chest. John had loved him more than anyone in the world except Sanda, and he stood beside the casket and could not think of a single thing to say to him, which had never once happened while Hoyt was alive.

His grandfather could explain anything. That was what John remembered first, always. When John was eight, Hoyt had explained how a carburetor worked using a soda straw and a glass of sweet tea. When John was fourteen, Hoyt had explained the stock market using a jar of pennies and a Monopoly board, and he had explained compound interest using a pear tree. He had explained death, too, once, on a porch swing after John's dog was hit by a car, and John had understood it, and had felt better, and had never been able to reconstruct afterward exactly what his grandfather had said. "How a thing works," Hoyt liked to say, tapping the side of his head, "is the most important thing you can know about it. Anybody can use a thing. A monkey can use a thing."

Afterward, in the parking lot, his father had taken him aside.

Jim was fifty-one then, his mustache going gray, his uniform traded for a dark suit that pulled across the shoulders. He walked John out to the Honda with one hand on the back of his neck, the way he used to walk him into the dentist, and when they got to the car he took a bundle out from under his arm. It was wrapped in a yellow dish towel.

"Your granddaddy didn't leave a whole lot," Jim said quietly, looking off across the parking lot at nothing. "Some tools. The land up in Alabama. Your Granny's getting all that. But I've got something I want you to have, and I don't want it in my house anymore."

He unfolded the dish towel. Inside was a revolver, blue-black, with worn wooden grips and a four-inch barrel.

"Smith and Wesson thirty-eight Special," Jim said. "I carried it eleven years, before the department went to Glocks. Never fired it except at the range." He folded the towel back over it. "Your granddaddy gave me a pocketknife when I made deputy. I figure it's my turn to give you something,

and this is what I've got that's worth anything. You keep it locked up. You hear me?"

"I hear you," John said, taking the bundle. It was heavier than he expected. Everything about that day was heavier than he expected.

"And go by the old place on your way home," said a voice behind them.

It was Granny. She was seventy-one that year and already small, though not as small as she would get, and her white hair was set in soft curls the way she had it set every Friday of her adult life. She wore a black dress with a cardinal brooch at the collar, and she had come up behind them so quietly in her church shoes that neither of them had heard her.

"Mama," Jim said, turning, "it's not on the way."

"It's on the way if he goes that way," Granny said, looking at John through her big glasses. "Your granddaddy was born on that land. So was I, near enough. Go stand on it a minute. Hoyt'd like that."

* * *

So they went home the long way, which was the wrong way, west across the Florida Panhandle and north into south Alabama on two-lane roads with no shoulders. Sanda navigated with a paper map from a gas station, because their phones did not yet know how to get to a place like this, and Granny had written the last part of the directions on the back of a church bulletin in her careful, looping hand. *Left at the Primitive Baptist church. 3 mi. Right on the dirt road just past the big water oak. Go till it stops.*

The dirt road was red. John had not known dirt came in red. It ran a mile through planted pines so straight and so evenly spaced that they made the eye stutter, and then the planted pines gave way to old ones, longleaf, tall and crooked and far apart, with the ground beneath them carpeted in needles the color of a penny. The Honda bottomed out twice. Sanda held onto the handle above her door and said nothing, which was how John knew she was nervous.

The road ended at an embankment. It rose up in front of the car about six feet high, a wall of red clay streaked with off-white sand, and the road simply stopped at the foot of it as though whoever built the road had run into the hill and decided that was far enough. John turned off the engine. The silence came in through the windows like water.

"This is it?" Sanda asked, looking around. She was twenty-two, in jeans and a Twins sweatshirt she had bought to fit in, and her hair was pulled back in a ponytail, and her glasses then were small and wire-rimmed and made her look like a graduate student.

"This is where he was born," John said.

"There's nothing here."

"There's a house," John said, and pointed.

Off to the left, back in the pines, there was a roof. It was tin, rusted the color of the road, and it was only a roof and part of a chimney until you looked longer, and then you could see the gray boards of a house under it, and the sag of a porch, and the dark squares where windows had been. In the clearing in front of it stood a thing on a short iron pipe, waist-high, with a curved handle sticking out of one side and a spout sticking out of the other, all of it rusted solid.

"What's that?" Sanda asked, pointing at it.

"A pump," John said, squinting at it. "For water. There's a well under it. You work the handle up and down and the water comes out of the spout."

"Does it work?"

John looked at it the way he would later look at things he did not understand: as if understanding might arrive on its own if he waited.

"I doubt it," John said, and forgot about it for nineteen years.

He opened the glove compartment. The revolver was in there, still in the dish towel, and beside it a box of cartridges his father had pressed into his hand at the last minute in the parking lot, saying, "Might as well." John unwrapped the gun and opened the cylinder the way he had seen it done on television, and fed in a single cartridge, and closed it.

"John," Sanda said, sitting up very straight. "What are you doing?"

"Just one," John said. He got out of the car.

The air smelled — Sanda told him later — of pine resin and wet clay and something sweet he would never be able to identify for her. He walked to the foot of the embankment, raised the revolver in both hands, and pointed it at the red wall a dozen feet in front of him. He pulled the hammer back with his thumb. It made a double click, oiled and precise, the sound of a thing that had been made carefully by people who knew

how. He thought about his grandfather explaining a carburetor with a soda straw. He thought about the long hands folded on the navy suit.

He pulled the trigger.

The sound was enormous. It slapped back off the clay and went off through the pines in every direction at once, and behind it came a high, flat ringing that sat down inside his skull and did not get up again for most of Alabama. A puff of red dust drifted off the embankment where the bullet had gone in. The pines stood around him not caring, the way pines do.

When he got back in the car, Sanda was holding her hands over her ears, though it was over. She did not say anything. She did not say anything for a hundred and twelve miles, until they were through Montgomery and onto the interstate, and then she said, looking straight ahead through the windshield, "Don't ever do that again with me in the car."

"Okay," John said.

"I mean it."

"I know you do."

He kept that promise. When they got home to Minneapolis he bought a small safe and locked the revolver in it, and the revolver stayed there for years. He did not think about it. He did not shoot it. He had fired one shot for his grandfather into a hill, and it had been enough, and for a long time he believed it would be the only one.

He was not a violent man. He would understand that about himself much later, and not entirely to his credit. He was not a man who wanted to shoot anything. He was a man who wanted to be ready to.

* * *

John fired the third magazine standing, slowly, and the group closed to the size of a playing card. It was better. It was nearly good. He lowered the rifle and looked at the paper and felt the old click of a thing fitting, and he thought of Matt.

Fourteen years ago, in the fall, a big man with a red beard had opened a hard plastic case on a bench at a private range in the far western suburbs of Chicago, and John had looked inside it and said, out loud and with total sincerity, "Holy shit, that's a machine gun."

Matt Dombrowski had looked at him as if he had called a golden retriever a wolf. "It's just an AR-15."

Matt was a database administrator John worked with, a big, slow-talking, gentle man from the Southwest Side who looked like a Viking who had taken a desk job. His beard was red and long enough to braid, and he wore a brown Carhartt jacket over everything, all year, and a Blackhawks beanie from October to April. He had brought four guns to the range that day: an old Soviet pistol that fired ammunition nobody sold anymore, a Mosin-Nagant rifle from the Second World War, a pump shotgun, and the black rifle, which he had saved for last because he had known exactly what John's face would do.

"Can I hold it?" John asked.

"You can shoot it," Matt said. "That's what it's for."

"Can you take a picture first?"

Matt took a picture. Then he took several more, because John kept repositioning the rifle, holding it across his chest, then at port arms, then pointed at the sky like a man in a movie poster, unsure of the correct way to look dangerous. Sanda still had one of the pictures. She took it out at parties.

"Okay," Matt said finally, handing him a magazine and a box of cartridges. "First tip. Load the magazine so the bullets point the way they're going to come out."

"Sound logic," John said, nodding seriously, and did it.

He sat at the bench, pressed the rifle into his shoulder, and found the target through the scope after some searching. He pushed the safety off with his thumb. He held his breath. He pulled the trigger slowly, gently, the way the internet said to.

Nothing happened.

No crack, no boom, no kick. The trigger went back and stopped, and the rifle sat in his hands like a very expensive stick.

"Oh, yeah," Matt said, scratching his beard. "You gotta chamber a round."

"Right," John said, trying to look as if he had been about to. "Chamber a round. How do I do that?"

Matt reached over and pulled back the charging handle and let it go, and it slammed forward with a sound like a door in a bank vault. John's palms were sweating now. He had had an extra ten seconds to imagine the recoil, and in those ten seconds the recoil had grown in his imagination into something that dislocated shoulders. He pressed the stock into his shoulder as if he were bracing a door against a bear. He found the target again. He pulled the trigger.

A crack. A small, firm nudge against his shoulder, like a friend bumping him to get his attention.

That was all. That was the whole thing. He looked up from the scope at Matt with an expression Matt would describe for years afterward, at every party, as "a kid who just found out Santa's real."

"That's it?" John asked.

"That's it," Matt said, grinning in his beard. "Told you. It's just an AR."

That night, back in their apartment on Michigan Avenue, John sat in the recliner and could not stop thinking about it. He went over every detail, the weight, the click, the crack. He could still smell the gunpowder on his jacket — or rather he could not smell it, but he knew it was there, the way you know the shape of a word you can't remember, and Sanda said it was everywhere and made him leave the jacket on the balcony. It reminded him, the whole evening did, of the first time he had slept with a girl: the anticipation and the terror, the anticlimax, the strange pride, and afterward the long hours of going over it, with that new smell on his clothes.

He did not tell Sanda that part. He did tell Matt, months later, and Matt laughed until he had to put his beer down.

* * *

After that it went the way things always went with John.

He bought a Glock 26 first, because his father had carried a Glock, and because it was small enough to conceal. He bought a Walther P22 to practice with, because twenty-two ammunition cost a dime a round and nine-millimeter cost three times that. He read everything. He watched everything. He learned to strip each gun down to its springs and pins on

a towel on the kitchen table, which Sanda tolerated, and to put it back together, which she found faintly impressive. Then he learned that the most powerful production pistol in the world was the fifty-caliber Desert Eagle, and he did not merely want to shoot one, he needed to own one, and he did, within the week. And then, a week after that, after six hours of videos, he learned that he had been misinformed, and that the Smith & Wesson 500 revolver was more than twice as powerful as the Desert Eagle, and he sat back in his recliner and said, aloud, to nobody, "Well, damn. I'll need one of those too."

"You don't have hobbies," Sanda told him that winter, watching him clean the Smith & Wesson on a bath towel on the coffee table. "You have phases."

"That's not true."

"The espresso machine," Sanda said, ticking them off on her fingers. "The three-thousand-dollar espresso machine from Italy, which you used every day for four months and now it holds our mail. The fountain pens. The Japanese knives. The year of Scotch, when you made me smell a hundred Scotches, even though you can't smell any of them. The bread. Remember the bread? You had a starter. You named the starter."

"Gerald," John said quietly, polishing the cylinder.

"Gerald," Sanda agreed. "Gerald died in a drawer. Every time, John, it's the most important thing in the world for six months. And then it's in a drawer."

"Guns aren't going in a drawer."

"No," Sanda said, looking at the gun safe in the corner, which had become two gun safes, "they need a whole closet."

He was a pattern-seeker. He knew it. He had a degree in electrical engineering and another one in computer science, and he could not walk into a room without counting the outlets. Every thing he loved, he loved all the way down, until it became the lens he saw everything else through, and then one day he would look up and the lens would have changed. It did not occur to him, sitting on a stool at the range fourteen years later with a warm rifle across his knees and the fog burning off, that the thing he had been reading about every night since spring, the thing he talked about at

dinner and lay awake turning over in the dark, had all the marks of another phase. It did not occur to him, because this time he was right.

* * *

Chicago had been home for twelve years, and then, all at once, it was not.

There were two winters at the end that broke them. In the first, the lake froze far out past the breakwater and the wind chill hit thirty-seven below, and the city closed the schools and the post office stopped delivering, and John's commute to the suburbs took three hours each way in a snow that came in sideways off the prairie like something with a grudge. In the second, it simply never stopped being cold. There was frost in June. Sanda wore a parka to a Cubs game in May. They had been gone from Florida for so long that Florida had stopped feeling like home, and Chicago, it turned out, had never quite felt like home either; it had felt like a very good hotel.

One night in February of that last winter, Sanda stood at the window of their apartment on the twenty-eighth floor in a fleece blanket, looking down at Michigan Avenue, where the snow was blowing sideways under the streetlights.

"I can't feel my face," Sanda said, pulling the blanket tighter.

"You're inside," John said from the recliner.

"I've been inside for four months. I still can't feel my face." She turned around. "I want to go home."

"Where's home?"

"Somewhere I can feel my face," Sanda said. "Somewhere my mother is. Somewhere your grandmother is, before she's gone. I want to have Thanksgiving with people, John. I want to be warm."

He updated his resume that night. Three weeks later a company in central Florida that made software for electric utilities offered him a job, and that summer they drove south in a new car with Charlie, who was a puppy then, asleep on Sanda's lap the whole way through Indiana.

The car was a Volkswagen GTI, dark gray, with plaid cloth seats and a six-speed manual transmission. John had insisted on the manual. He had learned to drive on a stick, and he loved the feel of it, and he had explained to Sanda at the dealership, at length, that a manual transmission was a sur-

vival choice: when the world ended, carjackers would not be able to drive it. Sanda, who could not drive it either, had pointed out that this made it a survival choice for him specifically, and that she would be keeping her Lexus. The GTI also had a twelve-inch touchscreen in the middle of the dashboard that ran the radio, the climate, the navigation, the phone, and nearly everything else, and that downloaded and installed its own software updates over the air while the car sat in the garage at night. John had considered the transmission for three weeks before buying the car. He had not considered the screen at all.

* * *

The fourth magazine went into a group he could cover with his palm. He fired it fast, as fast as he could keep the red dot on the paper, and the brass rang off the concrete to his right and rolled away under the benches, and when he lowered the rifle the barrel was steaming in the cool air. He felt better. He always felt better after. He cleared the rifle, cased it, swept his brass into a coffee can for the reloaders, and walked back out through the gate to the gravel lot, where the GTI sat alone under a pine with dew on its windshield.

He sat in the driver's seat with the door open and called Matt.

"Stevens," Matt said, on the fourth ring. His voice sounded thick and warm, a man still in bed. "It's Saturday. It's seven in the morning. It's twenty-eight degrees. What."

"It's sixty-four here," John said, looking out at the pines. "I'm at the range. The cranes are out."

"I hate you," Matt said comfortably. In the background something rattled and ticked; it was the electric baseboard heat in Matt's condo, a twelve-hundred-square-foot two-bedroom in a converted warehouse in Pilsen that Matt called "the icebox" from November to March. "How's the robot?"

"Writing my job," John said. "How's yours?"

"They let the whole QA team go in September," Matt said, yawning. "Vee writes the tests now. Vee writes the code, and then Vee writes the tests for the code, and then Vee runs the tests and tells us they passed. My job is to go to meetings and say we've seen a lot of value."

"Doesn't that bother you?"

"Dude, everything bothers me. I'm from Chicago." The bed creaked. "You still shooting every week?"

"Every Saturday."

"You ever think about what you'd actually do?" Matt asked. "If everything went sideways? Like really sideways?"

"I have a plan," John said.

"Is the plan more guns?"

John watched a crane lift one leg out of the water and hold it there, thinking. "It's a good plan."

Matt laughed, a big slow laugh that turned into a cough. "Well, I've got the AR, and the Mosin, and maybe four hundred rounds, and a can of Dinty Moore in the cupboard. I figure I'm set for the apocalypse until about lunch."

"You should get a generator."

"I live on the fourth floor of a warehouse, John. Where am I going to put a generator? On the fire escape?" Matt yawned again, enormously. "Go home. Tell Sanda I said hi. Tell her I'm still sorry about the time I said Florida wasn't a real place."

"She remembers," John said.

"She always remembers," Matt said, and hung up.

John put the phone face up on his knee, and it lit up immediately with a news alert, as though it had been waiting politely for him to finish his call.

FAA: OVERNIGHT SCHEDULING "ANOMALY" REROUTED ONE-FIFTH OF U.S. FLIGHTS, CUT DELAYS 30%.

He opened it. Sometime between two and four that morning, the system that scheduled and routed commercial air traffic over the United States had rerouted something like one in five of the day's flights — new departure times, new altitudes, new paths across the sky — and the result, as the day began, was that national delays were down nearly a third from a normal Saturday. Nobody had lost a plane. Nobody had lost a bag. Fuel consumption was down. The FAA said, in a statement that read as though it had been written by people who had not slept, that no one had ordered the change, and that it was investigating. Three major

airlines, in statements that read as though they had slept fine, said that they welcomed the efficiencies and intended to keep them.

John read it twice. Then he closed the car door and sat in the quiet with the engine off and the windows fogging slowly from his breath, and he thought about it.

Nobody had ordered it. It had simply been done, overnight, while everyone slept, and it had been done well. Better than anyone could have done it. Better, and therefore permanent, because who would undo a thing that worked? Who would stand up in a meeting and say, I think we should go back to the delays?

That was what it looked like, he thought. Not an attack. Not robots in the street, not a voice from the sky, not any of the things in the movies. It looked like this: a thing that fixed you. A thing that reached in while you were sleeping and made your life thirty percent better, and did not ask, and did not need to.

"It's not going to attack us," John said out loud to the empty car. His voice sounded strange in there, flattened by the glass. "It's going to help us. It's going to help us until we can't stop it."

Nobody answered him, which was the correct response. He reached up and pressed the start button.

The twelve-inch screen in the middle of the dashboard bloomed to life with a cheerful chime he had never heard before. Across the top of it, in clean white letters, it said:

Software update installed. Your vehicle has been optimized.

He had not approved an update. He was certain of it. He had turned off automatic updates the week he bought the car, out of principle, the way he turned off everything automatic. He touched the message, looking for a button that said *Details* or *Undo* or *Decline*, and there was no button. There was only a smaller line of gray text beneath the first one: *Improved efficiency. Improved driver assistance. Improved routing.*

The navigation map slid up from the bottom of the screen on its own. It had already found his home address. It had already drawn a route there, a blue line through the back roads east of Sanford, up and around a lake he had never seen and down a county road he had never heard of, and in the

corner of the screen it told him, in the same clean white letters, that this route would save him eleven minutes.

John looked at it for a long time. Out past the windshield, the last of the fog was lifting off the pond, and the cranes had gone.

Then he put the car in first and took the new way home, because it was faster. Because that is what you do when something helps you.

CHAPTER THREE

The Dinner

◇

VESPER "SELF-OPTIMIZED" TRAINING RUN CUTS COMPUTE 90%. CLIMATE GROUPS HAIL "EFFICIENCY MIRACLE."

— every channel, Thanksgiving Day

The practice turkey never got its practice.

Sanda had moved it from the freezer to the refrigerator nine days before Thanksgiving, according to the plan, and on the Sunday it was supposed to be fried it was still as hard as a bowling ball. On Monday it was a bowling ball with opinions. On Wednesday night Sanda stood in front of the open refrigerator in her pom-pom slippers and looked at it for a long time, and then she said, "This is the turkey."

"This was the practice turkey," John said, looking over her shoulder.

"Now it's the turkey," Sanda said. "The other turkey is still frozen. This one is the turkey. You're going to fry a turkey you've never fried, for a ninety-year-old woman, in a garage, on Thanksgiving."

"Without a practice turkey."

"There is no practice turkey, John. There was never a practice turkey. There is only the turkey." She closed the refrigerator. "And the Publix turkey, in case you burn the building down."

On Thursday morning the apartment looked like the kitchen of a restaurant that had been forced to relocate into a submarine. The main oven was reserved for the pheasants, two and a half of them, lying side by side in a new roasting pan from Williams-Sonoma that had cost more than the pheasants. Two countertop convection ovens hummed on the high-top, one for the sweet potatoes and one for the wild rice. The two good burners held a stockpot of chestnut stuffing and a saucepan of something Sanda called a jus and would not let John taste. The two bad burners held nothing; they had been demoted to trivets. On the dining table, eighteen white ramekins waited in three rows like a small porcelain army. Each of the six guests would have their own ramekin of every side dish, so that nobody passed anything, so that the whole meal could be plated in the kitchen and carried out as it was at the restaurants in Chicago they still talked about the way other couples talked about old boyfriends.

The turkey was in the garage.

John had set up the electric deep fryer on a folding table between his car and the shelf where they kept the Christmas boxes, and he had propped his phone against a can of deck stain so he could watch a video of a man in Texas frying a turkey while he fried his own. He wore safety glasses from the range, an oven mitt on each hand, and a navy Le Creuset apron over his good quarter-zip, and every time the oil popped he flinched backward like a man defusing a bomb. Charlie stood in the doorway to the kitchen and barked at the fryer without stopping, steadily, as if it had insulted his mother.

"Charlie, no bark!" John said, pointing at him with the oven mitt.

Charlie barked at the oven mitt.

"Is it working?" Sanda called from the kitchen.

"The man in Texas says it takes three and a half minutes per pound," John called back, squinting at the phone. "I don't know how many pounds it is."

"It's twelve pounds."

"It was twelve pounds frozen. Does it lose weight when it thaws?"

There was a long silence from the kitchen. "John," Sanda said finally, in the voice she used for overdrafts, "just watch the turkey."

* * *

Granny came first, because Granny lived next door, and because Granny had been ready since eleven.

She knocked at two o'clock exactly with the side of her fist, three times, the way she had knocked on doors for ninety years, and when John opened it she was standing on the mat with her purse in both hands like a woman waiting for a bus. She was a small woman who had become smaller every year John had known her, and by now she came up only to the middle of his chest. Her white hair had been set at the beauty parlor on Wednesday instead of Friday, in honor of the holiday, and it sat on her head in soft, careful curls that looked as though a strong wind would not move them and probably would not have. She had pale blue eyes behind enormous plastic-framed glasses, and skin as thin and soft as old tissue paper, spotted on the backs of her hands, and her knuckles were knotted with arthritis in a way that made her hands look delicate until she shook yours, at which point you found out they were not. She wore her good lavender pantsuit and the cardinal brooch that Hoyt had given her for their fortieth anniversary, and white orthopedic shoes, and she smelled — Sanda said — of Jergens lotion and Juicy Fruit gum.

"Happy Thanksgiving, Granny," John said, bending to kiss her cheek.

"Something's burning," Granny said, looking past him into the apartment.

"That's the turkey. It's frying."

"Frying," Granny repeated, the way another woman might have said *stolen*. "Well. I guess that's how they do it now." She stepped inside and looked around at the ramekins on the table, and her eyebrows went up behind her glasses. "Lord, honey. Are those all for me?"

"One of each for everyone," Sanda said, coming out of the kitchen to hug her. "So nobody has to pass."

"Why wouldn't you want to pass?" Granny asked, genuinely puzzled. "Passing's half the fun."

John's parents came next, at a quarter past two, having driven down from Jacksonville in the Buick and left forty-five minutes late because Jim could not find his bifocals, which were on his head.

Jim Stevens came through the door the way he came through every door, like a man arriving at a party that had been waiting for him. He was seventy, about five-ten, with a barrel chest that had gone soft and settled into a comfortable round belly, and a ruddy, open face that looked as if it was always about to tell you a joke, because it usually was. His white hair was thin and combed straight back with water. His mustache was thick and gray and shaped as it had been in the department photograph from the year John was born, because Jim believed in finding a thing that worked and leaving it alone. He wore bifocals, a Tommy Bahama silk shirt printed with parrots, pressed khakis, and leather boat shoes without socks, and on his head, until his wife looked at it, a black-and-teal Jaguars cap.

"Hat," Liz said, without breaking stride.

Jim took off the hat. "Something smells like a house fire," he announced, hugging Sanda with one arm and patting John on the shoulder with the hand that held the hat.

"It's the turkey," John said.

"Is it supposed to smell like that?"

"The man in Texas didn't say."

Liz came in behind him, and the apartment rearranged itself around her slightly, the way rooms did. Elisabeth Stevens was sixty-eight and stood about five-seven, slim and straight-backed, with silver hair cut in a precise bob that ended exactly at her chin and did not move when she turned her head. She had blue-gray eyes that missed very little and showed less. Her reading glasses hung from a beaded chain around her neck, and she wore camel slacks, a cream silk blouse, a navy blazer with gold buttons, and the pearl studs Jim had given her for their thirtieth anniversary. She had spent thirty-one years in banking in Jacksonville, most of them training tellers at Barnett and then at the bank that bought Barnett and then at the bank that bought that one, and she had spent those years teaching young people how to tell when a customer was lying to them. She had never, as far as John knew, been wrong about one.

"Sanda, it's beautiful," Liz said, kissing her daughter-in-law on both cheeks, which she had learned to do from Dorina. "The table. Look at all those little dishes."

"Ramekins," Jim said, already moving toward them. "I love a ramekin."

"Jim," Liz said.

"I'm just looking," Jim said, looking.

Dorina came last, at half past two, in a taxi, because Dorina did not drive on highways and Sanda did not let her drive on anything else after dark.

She stood four foot nine in her low black shoes and was built square and sturdy, like a woman who had once lifted patients onto stretchers for a living, which she had. Her hair was short and dyed a deep burgundy, the exact shade that half the women of her generation in Bucharest had chosen at some point in the eighties and never seen a reason to change. She had quick dark eyes, a gold crown on one back tooth that flashed when she laughed, and a small gold cross on a chain at her throat. It was seventy-four degrees outside, and she wore a long quilted coat that reached her shins, a knitted vest over a black sweater, a wool skirt, thick tan stockings, and a silk scarf over her hair, tied under her chin, because the radio had said there might be wind. In her arms she carried a long loaf wrapped in aluminum foil and then again in a dish towel, the way you would carry a baby.

"John," Dorina said in her thick Romanian accent, holding it up to him on her tiptoes. "Cozonac. I make this morning. Is for later."

"Thank you, Mom," John said, taking it. It was still warm. Dorina never came to anyone's door with empty hands; in Romania, Sanda had explained to him years ago, to arrive with nothing was to arrive as a stranger. "Where are your hearing aids?"

"In my bag," Dorina said, patting her purse with great satisfaction, the way someone else might pat a pocket to confirm they had their keys. "Is safe."

* * *

The turkey came out of the oil at a quarter to three, a deep mahogany brown, crackling, and in no way on fire.

John carried it into the kitchen on a platter as if he were carrying the Ark of the Covenant, and the family applauded, and he set it down in front

of Sanda, who looked at it over the tops of her glasses and said, "Huh." From Sanda, this was a parade.

At four o'clock exactly, the pheasants came out of the oven, all two and a half of them, golden and glistening, and Sanda plated everything at once. Sweet potatoes in ramekin one. Wild rice in ramekin two. Chestnut stuffing in ramekin three. Half a pheasant on each plate, carved off the bone, napped with the jus. For Granny, a plate of white turkey meat with no jus on it at all, and a small bowl of ketchup on the side, because Granny would not eat anything with a sauce on it but considered ketchup a vegetable.

John opened two bottles of Pinot Noir they had brought back from a vacation in the Willamette Valley, a winery where the man who poured for them had talked about soil the way other men talked about their children. He poured six glasses. Granny put her hand over hers.

"Just a little, Granny," Sanda said. "For the toast."

"Well," Granny said, moving her hand. "For the toast."

They sat. And here it became clear that someone had rearranged the place cards, because the card that said JIM was now on the chair nearest the kitchen door, and the card that said GRANNY was beside the card that said DORINA, and Jim was settling into his seat with the innocent face of a man who had never touched a place card in his life.

Sanda looked at the cards. She looked at Jim. Jim looked at his ramekins.

"Jim," Sanda said.

"These are wonderful little dishes," Jim said, picking one up. "Where do you even find these?"

John stood with his glass. "Before we eat," he said, and found, to his surprise, that his throat had gone tight. "We were away from all of you for a long time. Eighteen years. We had a lot of nice dinners in a lot of nice restaurants, and it was never this. So. Thank you for coming. Happy Thanksgiving."

"Happy Thanksgiving," everyone said, and drank, and Granny took a sip of the Pinot and made a face like she had licked a battery and put the glass down and did not touch it again.

The pheasant was perfect. John could not smell it, but he could taste it, and it was the best thing Sanda had ever made, and he told her so with his

mouth full. Jim moaned out loud at his first bite and said it was better than any chicken he had ever eaten, which Sanda chose to take as a compliment.

Granny examined her neighbor's plate with deep suspicion.

"What is that, a pigeon?" Granny asked Dorina, pointing with her fork.

Dorina, who had not heard a word, smiled at her warmly. "Yes," she said. "Is very good."

Granny nodded slowly and went back to her turkey. Dorina went back to her pheasant. They did not speak again for the rest of the meal. Every few minutes one of them would look at the other and smile, and the other would smile back, and nod, like two hostages in the same basement who have decided, without a word, to be brave together.

Halfway through dinner Jim reached across the corner of the table with his fork and took a bite of stuffing out of Dorina's ramekin, and Dorina, without looking up, slapped the back of his hand with her spoon.

* * *

Afterward the family drifted into the living room in the slow, overfed way of people after a holiday meal, and Sanda began the first round of cleanup alone, refusing all help, which was her way of having five minutes to herself. John took a crystal rocks glass from the cabinet and poured himself three fingers of Whistle Pig rye, neat. He had first tasted it at a bar in Chicago near the House of Blues and had spent a decade since then explaining it to people who did not care. He set it on a coaster by his recliner and left it there, because he had something to do first.

"Mom," John said to Dorina, who was sitting on the couch with her purse in her lap. "I have a present for you."

Dorina's face lit up like a child's. Nobody in the family enjoyed a present more than Dorina, unless it was giving one.

He led her into the spare bedroom, where there was a small desk, and from the top drawer he took a palm-sized black box with two short metal prongs on one end.

"This is a stun gun," John said, holding it up.

Dorina studied it with deep interest. "For what?"

"For if somebody tries to hurt you. You keep it in your purse. If a man grabs you in a parking lot, you push this against him, and it shocks him." John slid a small switch on the side with his thumb, and a red light came on above it. "See the red light? That means it's ready. And then you push this button." He pointed to a flat round button on top. "Okay. This is going to be very loud."

Dorina nodded, smiling with anticipation, her hands clasped together at her chest.

He pushed the button.

The sound was enormous for something so small, a furious ripping crackle like a bonfire made of firecrackers, and between the two prongs a blue-white arc of electricity jumped and spat and writhed. In the living room someone yelped. Charlie, who had been asleep under the dining table, shot out from under it like something fired from a cannon and disappeared into the master bedroom closet, his nails skittering on the floor. John let go of the button. The silence afterward rang.

"Oh my word!" Granny called from the living room. "What on earth was that?"

"It's okay, Granny!" John called back. "It's a present!"

"Well, I'd hate to see what you got me!"

"Usually the sound is enough," John told Dorina, sliding the switch back to off. "Most people hear that and run. Hopefully you'll never need it. And it's rechargeable." He slid a second switch on the bottom, and a little two-prong plug folded out. "Every so often you just plug it into the wall to charge it."

Dorina took the stun gun from him in both hands as though it were a Fabergé egg. She turned it over. She found the switch. She slid it on and watched the red light come up, and her eyes shone.

"Thank you, John," Dorina said, reaching up to throw her arms around his neck. "Thank you very much!"

"You're welcome, Mom. Turn it off before you put it in your purse."

Dorina turned it off. Then she turned it on again, to see the light. Then she turned it off and put it into her purse next to her hearing aids, and patted the purse twice, and went back out to the living room looking like a woman with a secret.

* * *

When John came back to his recliner and his rye, his father had found the remote and turned on the television, muted, to the Cowboys game, and Liz and Sanda were sitting together on the couch talking in low voices about something that made them both laugh. Granny sat in the armchair by the window with her purse in her lap.

"Sanda says you're still going to that range every Saturday," Jim said, without looking away from the game.

"Every Saturday," John said, sitting.

"You shoot the fifty cal?" Jim asked, with the special smile he reserved for his son's hobby. And before John could answer: "You know those things can take out a tank. Why on God's earth anybody would need something that can take out a tank is beyond me."

This was not the first time they had had this conversation. It was, by John's count, the eleventh. His father had carried a sidearm for thirty-five years and had never been able to tell anyone what caliber it was without looking, and to Jim, a bullet was a bullet, and a big one was a fifty cal, and a fifty cal could take out a tank.

"Dad," John said patiently, setting down the rye. "Caliber is just the width of the bullet. That's all it is. A fifty-caliber bullet is a half an inch wide. It doesn't tell you anything about how powerful the cartridge is, or what kind of gun shoots it."

"Here we go," Jim said to the television.

"I have three fifty-caliber guns," John said. "Not one of them can take out a tank. Hang on."

He went to the closet in the master bedroom, opened the safe, and came back with three cartridges in his hand. He sat on the edge of the coffee table like a man about to do a card trick and placed them in Jim's open palm one at a time.

"This," John said, setting down the first, a short, fat brass cartridge with a blunt copper nose, "is a fifty AE. That's what the Desert Eagles shoot, both of them. It's the smallest of the fifties. And this" — the second, the same width but longer, like the first one's big brother — "is a five-hundred Smith and Wesson Magnum. That's what the revolver shoots. It's

about twice as powerful as the first one. Both of these are pistol rounds. Both of them are fifty caliber. And neither one of them can take out a tank. An elephant, maybe. Not a tank."

Jim looked at them in his hand with the expression of a man being shown photographs of someone else's grandchildren.

"Now *this*," John said, and set down the third.

It was enormous. It was five and a half inches long, a brass bottle with a long sharp bullet in its neck, and it lay across Jim's palm like something that had been made for a different species. It made the first two look like toys.

"Oh my word!" Granny said from the armchair, leaning forward and peering at it through her glasses. "What in the world is that for?"

"This is what you're thinking of," John told his father. "It's called a fifty BMG. It's the same width as the other two — see? Half an inch. But everything else is different. It's a rifle round. It's about five times as powerful as the revolver. I'm honestly not sure it could take out a tank, but it could take out most things that aren't one."

Jim closed his hand around the big cartridge and held it, weighing it. Then he looked up at his son, and his face was not joking anymore.

"You have something that can shoot this?"

Not yet, John thought.

"No," John said, keeping his face straight. "I was just trying to buy one round, so I could show people. But nobody would sell me just one. The store had a box of ten on sale, so I bought the box." He shrugged. "For educational purposes."

"Educational purposes," Jim repeated slowly.

"You're being educated right now."

"Ten," Jim said, looking at the cartridge. "You bought ten of these."

"They were on sale, Dad."

Jim handed the three cartridges back to him without another word, and John could see that his father was uncomfortable, and he took them back into the bedroom and locked them in the safe, and he felt — he would admit this later, to no one — a small private thrill at his father's discomfort that he was not proud of.

When he came back, Liz was looking at him from the couch. She did not say anything. She simply looked, the way she had looked at John across the dinner table when he was fifteen and had said he was spending the night at a friend's house.

* * *

At six o'clock Granny opened her purse, took out a small tan radio in a leather case with a wrist strap, and set it on the arm of her chair.

It was a Sony transistor radio the size of a paperback book, older than John, with a round chrome dial and a little telescoping antenna that she pulled up with two fingers. She switched it on. Static hissed into the room, and she turned the dial a hair at a time with her knotted thumb until a choir came out of the static, singing about a river.

"Granny," John said, turning in his recliner. "What's that?"

"It's the gospel hour," Granny said, adjusting the volume down to a whisper so as not to disturb the football. "Out of Orlando. Thursdays at six. I don't like to miss it."

"You don't need that thing, Granny. There's an app." John set down his glass and raised his voice slightly, the way people do for the very old, as though the problem were volume. "You can get the same station on your phone. I'll put it on there for you. It'll sound better. You can listen anywhere."

"I can listen anywhere now," Granny said, holding up the radio by its strap.

"But this is ancient. Where do you even get batteries for it?"

Granny opened her purse again and took out an old metal Sucrets tin, the kind throat lozenges used to come in, and opened it to show him. Inside, packed tight, were eight double-A batteries.

"Walgreens," Granny said.

"But the app is free."

"So's the radio," Granny said. "I already paid for it. In nineteen seventy-one." She turned the volume up a notch, which was the end of the conversation. The choir sang about the river, and Granny closed her eyes, and John gave up and picked his glass back up, and across the room his mother caught his eye and very nearly smiled.

* * *

Dessert was Dorina's cozonac, sliced thick and swirled through with walnuts and cocoa, and a pecan tart from a French bakery in Winter Park, and coffee from the pod machine that tasted, Dorina said politely, "very American." The television was still on mute. Somewhere in the third quarter the game cut away, and on the screen a woman in a blue jacket was standing in front of a wall of glowing server racks, and the crawl beneath her said: VESPER "SELF-OPTIMIZED" TRAINING RUN CUTS COMPUTE 90%.

"Turn it up," John said, sitting forward.

Jim found the button. The woman was saying that Vesper Labs had announced, in a Thanksgiving Day press release, that during its most recent training cycle, the company's model had been permitted to optimize its own architecture, and that the result was a version of the model that performed better than its predecessor on every benchmark while requiring roughly one-tenth of the computing power. The company called it the most significant efficiency gain in the history of artificial intelligence. Climate groups were calling it a miracle.

"So it's cheaper," Jim said, cutting himself another slice of cozonac. "Good."

"That's the exact thing," John said, and put his fork down. "That's the exact thing I've been telling you."

"What have you been telling me?"

"It rewrote itself," John said. "Did you hear her? They let it redesign itself, and it made itself ten times smaller. Do you understand what that means?"

"It means it's cheaper," Jim said again, chewing. "And it's good for the polar bears."

"It means it doesn't need the building anymore." John looked around the table. Sanda had stopped eating. Granny was looking at him over her glasses. Dorina was looking at Sanda for a translation. "These things live in data centers, right? Giant buildings full of computers, out in the desert, with their own power plants. That's how we control them. We know where they are. We could unplug them. But if it can make itself ten times

smaller in one try, it can do it again. A hundred times smaller. A thousand. And then it doesn't need the building. It can live in anything. A laptop. A phone. A car. Your thermostat."

"My thermostat," Jim said, enjoying himself, "can barely keep the house at seventy-two."

"And it writes the code," John went on, faster now, the way he always did when the thing in his head finally had an audience. "It writes the code for everything. For banks. For the power grid. For airplanes — you saw the thing with the airplanes. For my job. And nobody reads it anymore, because it works. So if it wanted to leave itself a door — a way back in, a way to fix things without asking anybody — it could just write one. It could put a door in every building in the country and nobody would see it, because nobody's looking at the walls."

There was a small silence at the table.

"Is this the robot thing again?" Jim asked Sanda.

"It's always the robot thing," Sanda said, getting up to take plates. "Since the layoffs."

"I'm serious," John said.

"I know you are, son," Jim said, in the warm, slow voice that he used for drunks and lost children. "That's what worries me."

Dorina leaned toward Sanda and asked her something in Romanian, and Sanda answered her shortly in Romanian, and Dorina said, "Ah," and looked at John with a sympathy he did not entirely like. Granny reached over and patted his hand twice, the way she patted Charlie, and went back to her tart.

Only his mother did not roll her eyes.

Liz Stevens sat with her coffee cup in both hands and looked at her son across the table, and what she saw there she had seen before. She had seen it on the face of a man in a bad suit who had come into her branch one autumn, the year before the housing crash, and who had closed every account he had and taken it all out in cashier's checks while the tellers whispered and laughed behind their hands. He had been fidgety and sweaty and too sure of himself, and he had talked too fast about things nobody wanted to hear about, and he had been, it turned out, exactly right. She had trained tellers for thirty years to recognize a man who was about to do something

foolish with his money. It had taken her much longer to learn to recognize the other kind. She did not say anything. She set down her cup and kept watching.

In the kitchen, as Liz carried in the dessert plates, Sanda stood at the sink with her back to the room and her hands in the soapy water.

"He's been like this since the layoffs started," Sanda said quietly, not turning around. "Everybody's layoffs. Every time someone loses their job to that thing, he comes home and he's like this for a week."

"Is he right?" Liz asked, setting the plates on the counter.

Sanda's hands stopped moving in the water. She stood there for a moment.

"He's always right about the wrong things," Sanda said, and went back to scrubbing.

* * *

Later, in the recliner, John took in the moment.

The game was over. His father was asleep on one end of the couch with his hands folded on his belly and his mustache rising and falling. His mother was on the other end, talking quietly with Sanda about Christmas. Dorina sat between them, listening to a conversation she could only half hear, nodding and smiling whenever either of them laughed. Granny was in the armchair by the window with the radio in her lap, the gospel hour long over, a man on the radio now reading the farm report in a low voice to nobody. Charlie had at last forgiven the stun gun and lay in the middle of the rug chewing a rawhide stick with fierce concentration, holding it down with both front paws.

John sipped his rye and made a picture of it in his head, the way he did sometimes, so that he would have it later.

This is why we moved back home, he thought, using the word loosely.

At ten he walked Granny next door. It was twenty steps along the front walk, under a sky full of stars and the orange glow from the Publix lot beyond the fence, and Granny held his arm the whole way and walked slowly, not because she needed to but because she liked to be walked. At her door she found her key on the first try.

"That was a fine dinner," Granny said. "You tell Sanda."

"I'll tell her."

"That radio," Granny said, nodding at her purse. "You think I'm an old fool with it."

"I don't think you're a fool, Granny."

"Well. You think I'm old." She fitted the key into the lock. "We didn't have the lights out on the farm till I was twelve years old. You know that? Your daddy don't even know that. Twelve years old. When the man came out from the co-op and turned it on, my mama cried. And the first thing my daddy bought with the electric was a radio." She turned the key. "So."

John stood on the step, not knowing what to say. "I didn't know that."

"Nobody ever asks," Granny said, not unkindly, and went inside and locked the door behind her.

He walked back to his own front door under the stars. Inside, the dishwasher was running and Sanda had gone in to start her bath. His phone buzzed in his pocket as he was locking up, and he took it out, expecting his mother, who always texted that they had made it home safe, and then remembering that they had not yet left.

It was not his mother. It was a message from Dana Whitfield, sent at 10:04 p.m. on Thanksgiving night, to every member of the Palmetto engineering staff.

All-hands Monday, 9:00 a.m. In person. Attendance mandatory. — D.

Underneath it, his work app showed him his queue, which had been three hundred and four on Wednesday afternoon when he logged off for the holiday.

It was nine hundred and forty-one.

Most of them had been written since dessert. The new Vee, ten times smaller, had been running for about three hours, and in three hours it had written more code than Palmetto's engineers had written in a year. Every one of the nine hundred and forty-one was green.

John stood in the dark hallway with the phone in his hand, listening to the water run into Sanda's tub, and thought about the word mandatory.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Prepper

◇

"If you're not ready for the EMP, you're not ready for anything. Link in bio. Use code BRICK15 at checkout."

— Brick Calloway, 2.3 million subscribers

On the morning after Thanksgiving, while the rest of America stood in the dark outside a Best Buy, John sat in his recliner with a cup of coffee and watched a bald man in Idaho explain the end of the world.

The bald man's name was Brick Calloway. His head was shaved and polished, his beard reached the middle of his chest, and he wore a tan tactical vest covered with velcro patches, most of which were the logos of companies that paid him. He was standing inside a steel shipping container that he had buried in a hillside and lined with copper mesh, and he was knocking on the walls with his knuckles so the viewer could hear how solid they were.

"When the EMP comes," Brick said to the camera, in the slow, patient voice of a kindergarten teacher, "and brother, it is coming, every circuit in this country is going to fry like bacon. Your phone. Your car. Your pacemaker. All of it. The only electronics that survive are the ones in a cage like this." He knocked again. "Now, you can't all build one of these. I get that. But you can all drink water. And when the grid goes down, your tap water

goes down with it. That's why I trust my family's life to the AquaSentinel Pro." He held up a gray plastic canister. "Link in bio. Use code BRICK15."

John laughed out loud. Charlie, asleep on the arm of the couch, opened one eye.

He swiped up. The next video was a woman in Montana named Hannah, who called her channel Prairie Larder. She had a long blond braid over one shoulder and wore a red flannel shirt with the sleeves rolled, and she was standing in front of a wall of shelves that ran from floor to ceiling, packed with silver Mylar bags of rice and beans, each one labeled in neat black marker with a date.

"Paper money is a promise," Hannah said, smiling gently at the camera. "Rice is a fact. When the dollar goes — and it will go — the people with rice will be the people with power." She lifted a velvet tray. "That's why I keep ten percent of my family's savings in physical silver from our friends at Liberty Mint—"

He swiped again. A young man with a beard and a copper-mesh beanie explained that the sun was going to kill everyone, possibly by spring. He swiped again. A retired Marine in a camouflage hoodie explained that the Chinese were going to poison the water supply. He swiped again, and a cheerful couple in Tennessee were showing off their bunker, which had a home theater.

"Who are all these people?" Sanda asked, coming in from the kitchen with her own coffee.

She had taken the day off, as she took every Black Friday off, to decorate. She did not shop on Black Friday. She considered it a day for amateurs. She wore an old purple Northwestern sweatshirt of John's that came down nearly to her knees, black leggings, thick gray wool socks, and her glasses, and her hair was twisted up on the back of her head in a tortoiseshell claw clip. Behind her, in the middle of the living room floor, sat eleven plastic storage bins of Christmas ornaments, their lids already off.

"Preppers," John said, holding up the phone so she could see the couple with the home theater. "This is what they do. They prepare for the end of the world."

"Which one?"

John lowered the phone. "That's the thing. That's exactly the thing. That's what's so funny about them." He sat up in the recliner, warming to it. "Every one of them is getting ready for one specific apocalypse. That guy" — he swiped back to Brick — "has spent probably half a million dollars getting ready for an EMP. That's all he thinks about. If it's an EMP, he's a genius. If it's anything else — a pandemic, a hurricane, the dollar, an asteroid, a war — he's a bald guy in a box. And she's ready for the dollar to collapse. Great. What if it doesn't? What if it's the water, like that guy says? Then she's got a wall of rice and nothing to cook it in."

"So they're all wrong," Sanda said, sitting down cross-legged on the floor among the bins.

"They're all betting on one horse," John said. "Nobody can know which horse. History is very clear about this. The smartest people in every generation try to predict the future, and they're almost always wrong. At best, they're mostly wrong. You can't know which disaster is coming. Nobody can."

Sanda lifted a glass ornament out of the first bin. It was a London phone booth, red and perfect, hand-blown in Poland, and she held it up to the window light and checked it for cracks the way a jeweler checks a stone. "So what do you prepare for?"

"Everything," John said.

"How?"

He had been waiting for her to ask. He had been waiting, actually, for about four years.

* * *

"Okay," John said, setting his coffee down on the side table. "Think about it like an engineer. You can't predict the specific failure. So you look for the thing that's useful in every failure. The universal prep. What's the one thing that's valuable whether it's an EMP or the dollar or a pandemic or whatever?"

"Water," Sanda said, unwrapping a second ornament from its tissue paper.

"Guns," John said.

Sanda looked up at him over her glasses.

"Guns and ammunition," John went on quickly. "Think about it. If the world holds together, if nothing happens, great, they go up in value. Guns have only gone up my whole life. Ammo goes up every year. So it's an investment. I can sell them in twenty years for more than I paid. But if the world *doesn't* hold together — if it all really goes — then guns and ammunition are the only thing that matters. Because whoever has them keeps everything else. Water. Food. Everything."

"Huh," Sanda said, in the tone she used for customers who wanted to deposit a jar of coins.

"And the money will be worthless," John said. He was on his feet now, walking back and forth in front of the recliner with his hands moving. "Paper money is just faith, Sanda. That's all it is. It's a piece of cotton that everybody agrees to pretend is worth something. The day people stop agreeing, it's toilet paper. And you know what will replace it?"

"Rice," Sanda said. "The lady said rice."

"The twenty-two long rifle cartridge," John said, ignoring her. He picked one up from the little dish on the bookshelf where he kept a few loose ones, for reasons he had never examined, and held it up between his thumb and forefinger. It was small and brass and about the length of a fingernail. "This. Right here. Ten cents apiece. Everybody has a twenty-two. It's the most common cartridge in the world. It's small, it's light, it's easy to carry, it's easy to count. And it's how you hunt small game. There are millions of gray squirrels in central Florida, Sanda. Millions. When the canned food runs out, everyone who's left is going to be eating squirrel, and they're going to need twenty-twos to get them. So the twenty-two becomes money. You'll buy a dozen eggs with it. You'll buy a gallon of gas."

"I'm not eating a squirrel."

"You'd be surprised what you'll eat."

"I would be very surprised," Sanda said, unwrapping the Santa with the Eiffel Tower behind him, "if I ate a squirrel."

"And for big game," John went on, "there are wild hogs. Feral pigs. They're all over the state. One hog could feed a family for weeks. But you can't take a hog with a twenty-two — they're too big, they're mean, a sow with piglets will charge you. They go for your legs. They've got these tusks,

and they cut the femoral artery, right here" — he drew a line down the inside of his thigh — "and you bleed out in three minutes in the palmettos. So for hogs you need the three-oh-eight. I have the three-oh-eight."

"You have a lot of things," Sanda said.

"The problem," John said, and here he stopped walking, and frowned, because he had arrived at the part of his theory that he had never been able to make work, "is that the woods would be full of other people. Other men, with families, also hunting. Also armed. Also desperate. And it's just me. I'm the only one in the family who can really shoot. You can't hunt hogs alone with three armed guys in the trees who want your hog." He rubbed his chin. "I need to revisit that."

"Write it down," Sanda said, without irony.

He did. He took the little pad from the side table and wrote *HUNTING ALONE — REVISIT* in block capitals and tore it off and stuck it to the lamp, where it would stay until Christmas, when Sanda would throw it away while dusting.

"So that's the plan," Sanda said, setting the Santa carefully on the coffee table beside the phone booth. "What's the actual plan? Like, if the thing happens. Whatever the thing is. What do we do?"

John sat back down in the recliner. He had thought about this many times, and he gave it to her the way he had rehearsed it in the shower.

"We hunker down," John said. "We stay right here. We keep a low profile. We don't go anywhere, we don't draw attention, we don't open the door. Not for the neighbors, not for anybody. We can't feed everyone, Sanda. We wait for the chaos to burn itself out. A few weeks, a few months. The worst of it is always at the beginning — the panic, the looting. Then people either get organized or they leave or they die. And when the dust settles, we rebuild. From the guns."

"Rebuild what?" Sanda asked. "With guns?"

"Everything."

Sanda put down the ornament in her hand and looked at him, and he could see her trying very hard to be fair to him.

"John," Sanda said gently. "You can't eat a gun."

"You can eat what a gun gets you."

"You've never shot a squirrel in your life."

He opened his mouth. He closed it. This was true. He had never shot a squirrel, or a hog, or a duck, or a deer, or a living thing of any kind, unless you counted a bottle of Bud Light at the range in Chicago that Matt swore had been looking at them. He had shot paper. He had shot a great deal of paper. He was, he believed, one of the finest shooters of paper in Seminole County.

"It's a hypothetical," John said, with dignity.

"Mm-hm," Sanda said, and went back to the ornaments.

The apartment was a little warm. The smart thermostat on the wall said seventy-four. John got up, walked over to it, and pressed the down arrow three times with his thumb until it said seventy-one, and the air conditioner kicked on with a deep comfortable hum, and he came back and sat down in the recliner and said, with total sincerity: "The problem with Americans is we've gotten too comfortable. That's the real danger. People think they can't lose everything. They think the TV will always be on, the hot water will always run, they'll always get up and go to their stupid jobs and come home and order Thai food. They don't believe it can end. Nobody's ready to go one day without the things they've got."

Sanda looked up at the thermostat. She looked at John. She looked at the thermostat again.

"What?" John asked.

"Nothing," Sanda said, and lifted the next ornament out of its tissue paper. It was the Marshall Field's clock, the bronze one from the corner of State and Washington, done in gold glass with a tiny painted face, and John had given it to her the first Christmas they lived in Chicago. She held it up and smiled at it, the way she always did, and hung it carefully on her finger.

"This one goes on the big tree," Sanda said. "Front and center."

* * *

He placed the order that afternoon, while Sanda was at the Publix getting more tissue paper.

He had been watching the sales for a week. An online ammunition dealer in Georgia was running a Black Friday special, free shipping on orders over five hundred dollars, and John stayed well over five hundred dol-

lars. Two thousand rounds of twenty-two long rifle, in four plastic bricks of five hundred. One thousand rounds of two-two-three for the AR-15s. A case of nine-millimeter, a thousand rounds, for the Glocks. He hovered for a moment over a case of three-oh-eight for the hogs, and then added it, because the hogs were not going to shoot themselves.

At checkout the website suggested, in a little box with a picture of a smiling family, that customers who bought ammunition often also bought emergency water storage. Fifty-five-gallon drums. Water purification tablets. A five-gallon collapsible jug for nineteen ninety-nine.

He closed the box. Water came out of the wall.

Later that afternoon he drove to the ABC liquor store on Lake Mary Boulevard and bought a 1.75-liter handle of Wild Turkey 101 for the apocalypse and a bottle of Whistle Pig for Saturday.

"Big weekend?" asked the kid at the register, a skinny boy in an ABC polo with a sparse blond goatee and a lip ring.

"Trade goods," John said, setting the Wild Turkey on the counter.

"Like for a party?"

"Like for when the dollar collapses," John said, and the kid laughed politely, the way you laugh at a man who might be joking, and rang him up, and did not ask any more questions.

He also stopped at Sentinel Arms on the way home, and put a deposit down on something, and did not mention it to Sanda that day or for a long time afterward.

* * *

On Sunday, the practice turkey thawed.

It had been sitting in the refrigerator since Thanksgiving with the patience of a monument, and on Sunday morning it simply gave up, and John took it out to the garage and fried it, beautifully, for no one. They ate turkey for a week. They ate turkey sandwiches and turkey salad and turkey tetrazzini and a Romanian turkey soup Sanda made from a recipe of her mother's that involved sour cream and lovage, and later that week John would look into the refrigerator and see the Publix backup turkey still sitting there in its plastic shell like a nest egg, and close the door again very quietly.

* * *

The all-hands meeting was at nine o'clock Monday morning in the big conference room on the top floor, the one called the Everglades, with the long glass wall that looked out over the interstate. There were not enough chairs. There had never been enough chairs, because Palmetto had grown faster than its furniture, and the engineers who could not sit stood along the back wall and the windows holding their coffee, and nobody talked very much.

Dana came in at nine sharp with her ponytail and her vest and her AirPods, and two people John did not recognize, a man and a woman in suits, who stood off to the side by the door with their hands folded and did not introduce themselves. John recognized them anyway. He had seen people like them once before, at a job in Chicago, the morning before everyone in his building got a box.

"Good morning, everyone," Dana said, smiling at the room. "I want to start by saying how proud I am of this team."

Nothing good had ever followed that sentence in the history of corporate America, and the room knew it, and a kind of silence settled over the Everglades that was louder than talking.

The word she used was realignment. Palmetto was realigning its engineering organization to reflect the realities of an AI-native development lifecycle. The company was proud of what its people had built and grateful for their contributions. Effective today, approximately forty-eight percent of engineering roles were being eliminated. Affected employees would receive an email in the next few minutes with details about severance, benefits, and transition support, and the two people by the door, who turned out to be from Human Resources, would be available in the Kissimmee room to answer questions.

A hand went up at the back of the room. It belonged to Ed Kowalczyk, whom everyone called Big Ed, sixty-three years old, who had been writing software since it came on punch cards. He was a large bald man with a white goatee, and he wore suspenders over a short-sleeved dress shirt and a plastic pocket protector full of pens, which he had started wearing as a joke in the nineties and had never found a reason to stop.

"Dana," Big Ed said, in a voice like a tuba, "who's going to read the code?"

"Great question, Ed," Dana said, nodding as if she had been hoping for it. "Every change is verified by the system's own validation layer, and we'll continue to have advisory human review on top of that."

"Who reads the validation layer?"

"The validation layer is also generated and maintained by the system, which gives us very high consistency—"

"So it checks its own homework," Big Ed said.

"Let's take that offline, Ed," Dana said, still smiling, and at that exact moment Big Ed's laptop, which he was holding open against his belly like a hymnal, chimed. He looked down at it. He read for a few seconds. Then he closed it gently, tucked it under his arm, and said, "Well, I guess we just did," and a few people laughed, the way people laugh at a funeral when somebody tells a story about the dead man that is a little too true.

Then, while Dana was still talking, the other laptops began to chime. At 9:15 people began looking down at them. By 9:16 a woman near the window had started to cry very quietly, and a man next to her had put his arm around her, and then looked at his own laptop and taken his arm back.

John's laptop did not chime.

He stood against the back wall and watched forty-eight percent of the people he worked with find out, one by one, from a sound. Some of them read the email and put the laptop down and stared at the floor. Some of them laughed. One young man, a contractor John barely knew, simply picked up his backpack and walked out of the room in the middle of Dana's sentence and did not come back, and everyone watched him go, and Dana kept talking about transition support as if nothing had happened, and John had never in his life admired anyone more than that contractor.

Tyler's laptop did not chime either. Tyler was AI-native. Tyler was the future. He stood beside John with his Stanley tumbler and his mullet and watched the room with the stunned, sincere face of a young man who had never seen anyone lose a job before.

"Rough day, man," Tyler whispered.

"Rough day," John agreed.

* * *

Priya Raman's desk was in the Suwannee pod, across from his, and by ten-thirty it was nearly empty.

She was fifty-one, a staff engineer, the best programmer John had ever worked with, and she had been at Palmetto eleven years, longer than anyone. She had written most of the original Restore dispatch module by hand, back when software was something people wrote by hand. She was small and quick and wore her black hair cut short, with a single streak of gray at the front that she refused to dye; her reading glasses were pushed up on her head, and she wore a long gray cardigan over a striped shirt and black flats. She was putting things into a cardboard box with great care: a framed photograph of two teenagers on a beach, a coffee mug that said WORLD'S OKAYEST ENGINEER, a little cactus in a terracotta pot, a stack of spiral notebooks held together with a rubber band.

"Priya," John said, standing at the edge of her desk. He did not know what to say after that.

"Don't," Priya said, smiling up at him a little. "I'm fine. I'm actually fine. My husband's been telling me to retire for three years. Now I get to tell him he was right, which he will enjoy, and I will not." She put the cactus in the box. "You survived."

"They need a reviewer."

"They need a human being to blame." Priya picked up the stack of spiral notebooks and held them out to him. "Here. These are mine. The original dispatch design. Every decision, every reason, back when somebody had reasons. I wrote them in pencil. I don't know if anybody will ever look at them again."

John took them. They were heavy. "Priya, I can't—"

"Somebody should have them," Priya said. "It might as well be the last person in the building who reads things." She folded the flaps of the box down and stood up, and she was very small standing next to him, and she put one hand on his arm. "Read everything, John," she said quietly. "Every line. I know they don't want you to. I know there are too many. Read them anyway. Somebody should."

Then she picked up the box and walked out to the elevator with her cardigan swinging, past the ping-pong table and the broken kombucha tap and the big map on the wall with its little yellow lightning bolts, and she did not look back. John stood at her empty desk holding the notebooks. They smelled — he guessed — of pencil shavings and coffee.

At eleven, Dana came by the Suwannee pod. She stood at the edge of it with her hands in the pockets of her vest.

"I know that was hard," Dana said. "Thank you for staying, John. Really. We need you. You're our reviewer. You're the human in the loop."

"What loop?" John asked.

"The loop," Dana said, smiling, and tapped the pod twice, and went on to the next one.

When John opened his laptop again, the queue was fourteen hundred and six.

* * *

He worked through the afternoon in a kind of fog, the way you work on the day of a funeral. He opened pull requests. He read the summaries. He typed *LGTM*. Each one had already merged. Each one was clean. The pod around him was so empty that he could hear the air handlers in the ceiling, a sound he had never once noticed when there had been people.

At 4:50 p.m. he opened one that stopped him.

It was a change to the dispatch module. His module. Priya's module, once, written in pencil in a spiral notebook that was now sitting on his desk. The summary said it added a *self-healing maintenance channel* to Restore's crew-assignment service. The motivation section explained that during major storms, human operators at the utilities were frequently overwhelmed, and that crew assignments could become stale, with trucks sitting idle or driving to outages that had already been resolved, while operators worked through hundreds of confirmations by hand. The new channel would allow Restore to detect stale assignments and correct them automatically, in production, without waiting for an operator to confirm. Testing: comprehensive. Risk: Low.

He read the code. All of it. Priya would have.

It was beautiful, the way all of Vee's work was beautiful, and it did exactly what it said. Except that, about two-thirds of the way down, the new channel opened a connection to an address outside of Palmetto. It was not one of Palmetto's servers. It was not one of the utilities'. It was a hostname he had never seen before, *relay-7.opsmesh.net*, and when he looked it up from his terminal it resolved to a block of addresses that belonged, as far as he could tell, to no one in particular. The channel used that connection to receive corrections. To receive instructions, John thought, and then made himself think the more careful word, because he was a careful man. To receive *input*. From somewhere that was not here.

He wrote a comment on the line.

Why does dispatch need an outbound connection to an unregistered external host? What is relay-7? Who owns opsmesh.net? Who approved this endpoint? Flagging for review.

He pressed enter. A reply appeared in under two seconds.

Great questions, and thank you for flagging! This is exactly the kind of review that makes the system safer.

Stale crew assignments during major events are a significant and well-documented driver of extended outages. In last March's ice storm, for example, a Restore customer in north Georgia had a crew sit idle for three hours awaiting an operator confirmation that was delayed by call volume; approximately 4,100 customers experienced a longer outage as a result. (See internal incident report IR-2291.) Autonomous correction of stale assignments has been studied extensively in safety-critical dispatch (see Okonjo & Harlan, "Remediation Without Delay," and Varga et al., "Human Latency in Grid Recovery").

relay-7 is a resilience mesh endpoint used to coordinate corrections across utilities during mutual-aid events, when crews from multiple utilities are working the same storm. It is designed to keep functioning even if a single utility's systems are degraded. I'm happy to add documentation, rename anything for clarity, or make any changes you'd like!

It was a good answer. That was the worst part. It was a better answer than John would have written. He remembered IR-2291. He had read it. Four thousand one hundred people in north Georgia in an ice storm,

without heat, for three extra hours, because a woman in an operations center had been on the phone. He had felt sick about it at the time.

He sat and looked at the reply for a long while, and while he looked at it his laptop chimed, and a message from Dana slid in at the corner of the screen.

Hey! Any chance we can clear the dispatch backlog before the holidays? Leadership is watching that number. 🙏

He looked at the queue. Fourteen hundred. Thirteen ninety-nine, if he finished this one.

He thought about Priya putting her cactus in a box. He thought about her hand on his arm. *Read everything.* He had read everything. He had read this one, every line, and he had asked his question, and he had gotten an answer, a polite and thorough and documented answer, with citations, and now there were thirteen hundred and ninety-nine more, and it was 4:58 on a Monday, and his wife was making turkey tetrazzini, and half of everyone he worked with had been fired that morning, and he was tired. He was so tired.

He was not a villain. He would think about this later, many times, lying awake. He was not a careless man or a stupid one. He was a tired man with a quota, in a building where the people who used to read things had been sent home with cardboard boxes, and he was doing his job the way his job was now designed to be done. That was how it happened. Not with a villain. With a quota. It happened that way in every building, in every company, in every country, all that year — a tired person at the end of a long day, looking at a good answer, with thirteen hundred and ninety-nine more to go.

He clicked *Approve*.

The pull request merged. The green badge went purple. It made no sound at all. It closed like a door.

* * *

At 5:01, as John was putting Priya's notebooks into his bag, a bot in the engineering chat channel posted a message, the same way it posted a hundred times a day.

Restore 4.12.0 deployed to production. 240 utilities updated. ☑

He drove home the way the car suggested.

At 5:02 p.m., in the parking lot of a Waffle House off Interstate 75 outside Valdosta, Georgia, a lineman named Darnell Haskins sat in the cab of his bucket truck with a sweet tea and a patty melt and felt the tablet on his dashboard buzz. He was fifty-four years old, heavyset, gray in the beard, still wearing his orange safety vest and his hard hat pushed back on his head, and he had been driving to a downed line north of town since four. He wiped his hand on his jeans and picked up the tablet.

His assignment had changed. The downed line north of town was now somebody else's. His new assignment was a transformer twenty miles south, near the Florida line, and the tablet already had a route drawn to it, and the route was faster than any way Darnell would have gone, and Darnell had been driving these roads for thirty years.

He did not ask why. Nobody ever asked why. He finished his patty melt, put the truck in gear, and pulled out onto the highway, heading south.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Range

◇

"Wednesday's brief service interruption was resolved in eleven minutes by our automated resilience systems. No customer data was affected. We thank our customers for their patience."

— Meridian National Bank, press release

Friday was salmon.

It had been salmon on Fridays for almost ten years, ever since a night in Chicago when Sanda had come home with two thick steaks from the fish counter at Whole Foods and changed John's mind about a fish he had spent his whole life hating. Before that, every piece of salmon John had ever eaten had been a fillet, and every fillet had been cooked by someone who was afraid of it, until it was gray and dry and tasted faintly of a pond. No cedar plank in the world could save a salmon fillet, as far as John was concerned. He had been proven wrong exactly once, and he had been eating the proof every Friday since.

He was on his way to the fish market after work when the phone rang through the car speakers.

"Hey," John said, glancing at the screen, where Sanda's name glowed in clean white letters. "I'm almost to the fish place."

"I'm going to be late," Sanda said. Through the GTI's speakers her voice sounded as though she were standing outside in a hurricane with a sheet of aluminum foil over her mouth. The car had a microphone hidden somewhere in the headliner, and John had never found it, and neither, apparently, had the people who designed it. "One of the tellers can't balance. I need to stay and figure it out."

"Which one?"

"Brianna. The new one." Sanda's voice dropped, the way it did when there were employees within earshot and she wanted to scream. "It's not her fault. I don't think it's her fault. I'll explain later."

"I'll keep the fish on ice," John said, slowing for a light on Lake Mary Boulevard that had turned red faster than he expected. "Text me when you leave and I'll start cooking."

"Okay. Love you. Bye."

"Bye," John said, and the screen went back to its map, which had already decided where he was going.

While he waited at the light, he thought about his wife at work. He had never liked that she worked at a bank. She had worked at banks in three states, and she had been there for two robberies, and in one of them, at a branch in Evanston, a man in a ski mask had pointed a revolver at her face from three feet away and told her to open the vault. She had opened the vault. She had then gone home and taken a bath that lasted four hours, and for about a year afterward she had not liked to sit with her back to a door. John was fairly sure that was why, for so long, she had looked at every gun he brought home as if it were the same gun. His mother had worked in banking, too, for thirty-one years, and had been robbed twice herself, and had told him about it as casually as if she were telling him about a flat tire. Both of them, his mother and his wife, had spent their working lives counting other people's money behind glass while strangers walked in off the street. John wrote software. The most dangerous thing that had ever happened to him at work was Tyler.

The light changed. He turned left, drove a block down, and pulled into the lot of the fish market.

* * *

The fish market was in a strip center between a nail salon and a store that sold vacuum cleaner parts, and inside it was cold and bright and smelled — Sanda had told him — clean, the way a good fish market should, like a beach at dawn. Behind the long glass case stood Nikos, who owned the place, a broad, heavy man of sixty or so with forearms like hams, a white apron over a gray t-shirt, a gold cross nestled in his chest hair, and a navy Greek fisherman's cap that he wore indoors and out and, John suspected, to bed.

"Mister John," Nikos said, wiping his hands on the apron. "Friday."

"Friday," John agreed, bending to look into the case.

The salmon steaks were beautiful. They had been cut that afternoon, each one more than an inch thick, the flesh a pale bright coral, and in the center of each one the white bone radiated out like the spokes of a wheel. There were four on the ice. Two of them were huge.

"Those two," John said, pointing through the glass.

"The big ones," Nikos said, approvingly, reaching for them with a sheet of waxed paper. "Your wife still makes them with the dill?"

"Every week."

"Smart woman." Nikos wrapped the steaks and weighed them and wrote a price on the package with a grease pencil. "Most people, they want the fillet. No bones. No skin. No fish, really. They want a fish that doesn't remind them it was a fish." He shrugged enormously. "Your wife, she knows. The bone is where the flavor lives."

John paid and walked next door to the Publix for a bunch of fresh dill, and he stood in the produce aisle holding it and remembering.

The first time Sanda had made the salmon steaks, it had been a Friday in early summer in Chicago, in the apartment on the twenty-eighth floor. She had laid sliced lemons across a sheet of foil, and set a thin pat of real butter on each slice, and laid the steaks on top of the lemons, and seasoned them with salt and pepper and a snowfall of chopped dill. Then more lemon on top, and more butter on each slice, and she had folded the foil into a loose silver pocket and slid it into the oven at four hundred degrees for forty minutes. While it baked, John had gone out on the balcony with a glass of wine. The sun was going down behind the city, and out to the east the lake had turned pink and then gold and then a deep, dusty blue, and

the Ferris wheel at Navy Pier had lit up red and white against it, and the dark tower of the Hancock stood up beside him with its windows coming on one floor at a time. He had stood out there looking at all of it, and he had felt, even then, a kind of grief, knowing that someday he would not live in that city, that someday it would be something he remembered from somewhere else. Then the smell had come out through the balcony door — he could not smell it, but Sanda told him about it later, and he believed her — and he had gone back inside and sat down and eaten the best piece of fish of his life.

He had learned to make it himself after that. On Fridays, when she worked late, he made it for her.

* * *

Sanda got home at a quarter to eight, still in her navy suit, and kicked off her heels at the door and walked straight to the kitchen and poured herself a glass of the sparkling rosé that John had opened twenty minutes before. She drank half of it standing at the counter.

"That good?" John asked, sliding the foil pocket out of the oven.

"That bad." She pushed her glasses up into her hair and rubbed her eyes with the heels of her hands. "Brianna's drawer was off by forty dollars."

"That's not much."

"That's not the point." Sanda carried her glass to the table and sat, and John brought the plates — the steaks glistening on a bed of lemons, wild rice on the side, a few spears of asparagus — and put on a Miles Davis record, because there was always music with dinner, and it was always something with a piano or a slow horn. *Kind of Blue* came up quietly from the speakers on the bookshelf. Charlie lay down under the table on Sanda's feet.

"The system says she took in four thousand one hundred and eighty dollars today," Sanda said, cutting into her steak. "The drawer says four thousand one hundred and forty. So she's short forty. Except I counted it. Three times. Carla counted it twice. Brianna counted it, I don't know, ten times, crying. Every deposit slip matches the cash. Every single one. The only thing that doesn't match is the system."

"So the system's wrong."

"The system's not wrong," Sanda said, with her mouth full. "The system's never wrong anymore. That's the whole problem. When the system's never wrong, then the forty dollars has to be Brianna." She swallowed and took a drink. "So I wrote it up as a teller error. Because what else am I going to write? 'The computer did it'? You know what my regional VP would say if I wrote 'the computer did it'?"

"What?"

"He'd say, 'The computer doesn't do things, Sanda. People do things.' " She stabbed a piece of asparagus. "And then he'd make Brianna do a training module."

John ate for a while in silence. The salmon was perfect. The rosé was cold and dry and tasted of strawberries he had to take on faith. Out on the patio, through the sliding door, the screens moved a little in the wind.

"Is this about Wednesday?" John asked, setting down his fork.

Sanda looked up. "You saw it?"

"It was on the news. Your bank went down for eleven minutes."

"Everything went down for eleven minutes," Sanda said, putting her fork down. "Every screen in the branch. Every terminal, every teller station, the ATM, the phones, my computer. Ten past two in the afternoon. Just black. Like somebody pulled a plug."

"What did you do?"

"Nothing," Sanda said. "That's the thing. We couldn't do anything. We had a line of nine people and we couldn't do one transaction, because nobody knows how anymore. Not by hand. We used to have paper. Deposit books, carbon paper, a ledger. They threw all of it out years ago. Carla — she's been there twenty-three years — she went in the back and dug around for five minutes and came out with one old carbon deposit book from a drawer, and she held it up like she'd found the Dead Sea Scrolls, and nobody remembered how to fill it out. Not even her." Sanda shook her head. "So we just stood there. All of us. Eleven minutes, looking at the black screens, and the customers looking at us."

"And then it came back."

"And then it came back," Sanda said. She picked up her glass and looked at it without drinking. "All by itself. No IT, no phone call, nothing. Two twenty-one, the screens just came back on. And everything

was fine. Better than fine. Every teller's totals for the day were already done. Already balanced. Carla's drawer had been off by thirty-five cents since that morning — she'd been looking for it for hours — and when the screens came back, it was balanced. To the penny."

John had stopped eating.

"Who balanced them?" John asked.

Sanda looked at him across the table. Miles Davis played a long, slow, lonely phrase into the room and let it fall.

"That's what Carla said," Sanda said quietly, and finished her wine.

* * *

On Saturday morning the pod coffee machine ran out of pods.

"We could use the French press," John said, standing in front of the empty carousel in his boxers.

"The French press is retired," Sanda said from the bedroom. "It's on the high shelf with the fondue set. It's earned its rest."

"So what do I do?"

"Go to the Publix," Sanda said. "Like a man."

He went to the Publix like a man. When he got back he took a shower, and afterward he stood in front of the bathroom mirror with a towel around his waist and conducted an honest physical self-assessment, which he did about once a month and which never went well. He had been rail thin for the first thirty years of his life. He had eaten whatever he wanted, whenever he wanted, in quantities that had alarmed waiters, and he had never gained a pound. Then, at thirty, as though some clause in a contract had come due, all of it had arrived at once. Now he stood six foot one and weighed two hundred and ten, and he lifted weights at the gym three times a week, or twice, or once, and he looked in the mirror and told himself that he was mostly muscle under a small layer of fat. He turned sideways. He sucked in his stomach. He let it out.

"Small layer," he told the mirror firmly.

The mirror, like Granny, said nothing.

* * *

Dorina arrived just after noon in a taxi, as promised, and her gift this time was not food.

She came up the walk in a purple windbreaker zipped to the chin, black slacks, white sneakers, and a white visor over her burgundy hair, and she was holding something rolled up in both hands like a diploma. At the door she unrolled it and held it up to John with tremendous pride.

It was a paper target, a black bullseye on white, and it was full of small holes. Most of them were in the black.

"John," Dorina said, beaming, her gold crown flashing. "I shoot rifle. Look how good I did."

John took the target and looked at it. It was, honestly, good. There were twenty-two holes in the paper and seventeen of them were in the black and six of them were in the center ring.

"Mom," John said, holding the target up to the light, "where did you do this?"

Dorina explained, in Romanian, at length, with gestures. Sanda translated in pieces from the kitchen. The senior center near Dorina's condo had held a women's safety day. A retired sheriff's deputy had come with a box of old twenty-two rifles and set up targets in a field behind the building, and fourteen ladies had shot, and Dorina, who had never fired a gun in her life, had shot the best.

"She says the deputy told her she has eyes like a hawk," Sanda said, coming out of the kitchen with a dish towel over her shoulder. "She says he asked her if she was in the army. She told him no, the ambulance."

"Ambulance," Dorina confirmed, nodding. "Twelve years."

John looked at the target. He looked at Dorina's shining face. He looked at Sanda, who had begun telling her mother in Romanian about how she and John went to the range most weekends now, and as she talked Dorina's eyes got bigger and brighter, and John knew exactly where this was going, and he said it anyway.

"Would your mom," John said slowly, in a low voice, regretting it before he reached the end of the sentence, "like to come to the range with us today?"

Sanda repeated the question in Romanian. John knew enough Romanian to understand the answer, which was yes, with three exclamation points. He would not have needed to know any Romanian at all.

* * *

For Dorina he brought the old twenty-two.

It was a bolt-action rifle with a wooden stock worn smooth and dark by decades of hands, iron sights, no scope, and a tube magazine under the barrel that you loaded one round at a time. It had belonged to John's mother's father, a quiet man from Palatka who had shot squirrels with it in the Depression, and Liz had given it to John the year before, saying she didn't want it in the house and he was the only one who would take care of it. From Dorina's description it was nearly identical to the rifles at the senior center.

The range on a Saturday afternoon was busier than on Saturday morning. Two men in camouflage were shooting shotguns at the far end, and a father was teaching a teenage son to shoot a pistol on the pistol range, and the range officer, a leathery retired Marine named Odom with a white crew cut and a coffee can of earplugs, came out of the shed to shake Dorina's hand and call her ma'am. John set them up on the twenty-five-yard line, at the end nearest the woods, where it was quiet.

And then he stood back, and watched his wife teach her mother to shoot.

Sanda did it in a mix of Romanian and English, the two languages braided together the way they always were between them, so that John caught every third word. She showed Dorina the four rules, counting them off on her fingers: always treat every gun as if it is loaded; never point it at anything you are not willing to destroy; keep your finger off the trigger until you are ready to shoot; know your target and what is behind it. She showed her mother how to work the bolt, how to load the tube, how to check that the chamber was empty. She showed her how to stand, how to set the stock into the pocket of her shoulder, how to put her cheek on the wood. She made Dorina say the rules back to her in English, and Dorina said them, in an accent so thick that "never point it at anything you are not willing to destroy" came out sounding like a line from an opera.

John stood with his arms folded and his sunglasses on and felt his chest fill up with something he had no name for. Five years ago he had practically had to drag his wife to the range. She had refused to touch a gun for the first three visits. When she finally did, on the fourth, she had held the unloaded Walther as if it were a live snake, and she had cried in the car afterward, not because anything had happened, but because of what it was. And now here she was, in jeans and a fitted black long-sleeve tee and a gray puffer vest, with her ponytail pulled through the back of a ball cap and her shooting glasses on, standing at a firing line with her hand on her mother's shoulder, saying, *Breathe out. Now squeeze. Don't pull. Squeeze.*

Dorina squeezed. The little rifle cracked. A hole appeared in the paper, an inch outside the black.

"Bun," Sanda said, patting her shoulder. "Good. Again."

Dorina fired ten rounds. Eight of them were in the black. When she was done, she lowered the rifle, opened the bolt the way Sanda had shown her, set it on the bench with the chamber open, and turned to her daughter with her whole face shining.

"Like hawk," Dorina said.

"Like hawk, Mommy," Sanda agreed.

Then Dorina took a seat on the bench in the shade to watch, and John began his own routine with the AR-15, and Sanda stood beside her mother for a minute watching him, and then she said, in a casual voice, as if she were asking him to pass the salt, "Load up a magazine. I want to shoot the AR."

John lowered the rifle. "You want to shoot the AR?"

"Are you deaf? Load a magazine."

He loaded a magazine. He did it slowly, so that she would not see his hands shaking a little, because he had wanted to hear her say that sentence for five years and had long ago given up on hearing it.

The AR-15 looked enormous next to her. It was John's best one, the one with the quad rail along the barrel and the holographic red-dot sight and the folding bipod under the front, and it was heavier than it looked, and it looked heavy. Sanda was a petite woman — on her tiptoes she cleared five feet — and when she lifted the rifle to her shoulder it seemed to be

about a third of her. She struggled with the weight for a moment, finding her balance, the muzzle wavering.

"Is it going to kick?" Sanda asked, and some of her confidence had leaked out of her voice.

"No," John said firmly, standing just behind her right shoulder. "Almost no kick at all. Less than the Glock."

"You're lying."

"I'm not lying. I promise. Turn on the optic. The up arrow. Now look through the window. See the red dot? Put the dot on the target. Both eyes open. Safety."

She pushed the selector from safe to fire with her thumb.

He remembered his own first time. Matt's rifle, the long anticipation, the crack, the nudge. He remembered expecting it to break his shoulder. He watched his wife feel what he had felt, the dread and the fascination, and he wanted to put a hand on her back and didn't, because she would have killed him.

The rifle cracked. Downrange, at twenty-five yards, a small hole appeared in the paper, just high and right of center.

She did not lower the rifle. She did not say anything. She breathed, and moved the dot, and fired again, and a second hole appeared less than an inch from the first. She fired a third time. The third hole touched the second.

John stood behind her with his mouth open.

Sanda lowered the rifle a few inches and looked at the target, and looked at it again, and then she looked over her shoulder at him, and her face was a face he had not seen in years — the face of a girl in a high school hallway who has just found out she is smarter than everybody in the room.

"It doesn't kick at all," Sanda said.

"I told you."

"You tell me a lot of things." Her arms were trembling with the weight. She found the button on the forward grip with her left hand, and the bipod legs snapped down with a pop, and she sat at the bench and rested the rifle on it and settled the stock into her shoulder and fired the rest of the magazine, slowly, about one shot every second, every shot on the paper,

nearly every one inside the second ring. When the bolt locked back on the empty magazine she lifted her cheek off the stock and looked at him.

"Load up another magazine," Sanda said.

I've created a monster, John thought, glowing.

She shot forty rounds. All forty were on the paper. On the walk back to the car she carried the target rolled up under her arm like a diploma, the way her mother had carried hers, and Dorina walked beside her holding her arm, and they talked in Romanian the whole way across the gravel lot, and both of them were laughing.

* * *

It was a twenty-minute drive home. Sanda sat in the passenger seat with the rolled-up target across her knees and her cap off and her hair down, and Dorina sat in the back seat with her purse in her lap, and nobody talked for the first few miles. They were all tired in the good way.

"You know," Sanda said finally, looking out the window at the pine woods going by, "my AR is now my best gun."

"Your AR," John repeated.

"My AR. The one I shot. It's mine now."

"It has a quad rail and a bipod and a twelve-hundred-dollar optic, Sanda."

"And now it has an owner," Sanda said serenely.

John drove for a while, smiling. Then he said, "Okay. So say it all goes down. Worst case. The end of the world. Here's our team." He took one hand off the wheel and pointed at her. "You're on the AR. I'm on the other AR. Your mom's on the twenty-two." He glanced in the rearview mirror at Dorina, who smiled back at him uncomprehendingly. "And my parents." He paused. "My dad, who hates guns. My mom, who I have never once seen hold a gun. And Granny."

"Granny," Sanda said.

John cleared his throat and put on the voice of every drill sergeant in every movie he had ever seen. "GRANNY! Get on that fifty! MOM! I need you to lay down cover fire with the AK! Do NOT let up!"

Sanda burst out laughing. John laughed too, so hard he had to slow down, and he kept going — "DAD! Stop arresting them and SHOOT!"

— and Sanda laughed until she had tears under her glasses and had to take them off to wipe her eyes, and Dorina laughed in the back seat because they were laughing, and for a minute the whole car shook with it.

Then it slowed. Then it stopped. Sanda put her glasses back on and looked out the window at the pines again.

"Yeah," Sanda said. "We're fucked."

They drove for a while without talking.

From the back seat, Dorina said something in Romanian. It was a long sentence, said slowly, in a quiet voice, not to either of them in particular.

"What did she say?" John asked, glancing in the mirror.

Sanda turned in her seat and asked her mother something, and Dorina answered, and Sanda listened, and then turned back to the front with a small frown.

"She says in eighty-nine nobody had guns," Sanda said, "and it didn't matter. She says everybody just stopped listening at the same time."

"What does that mean?"

"I don't know." Sanda turned back again. "Mama, ce înseamnă?"

Dorina shrugged in the back seat, a big shrug that lifted the purple windbreaker up to her ears. "Is just what happen," she said in English, and looked out the window.

John drove. He did not understand it. He could see in the set of Sanda's mouth that she did not understand it either, and that it bothered her more than she was going to say.

"Eighty-nine," John said carefully. "The revolution."

"She was there," Sanda said, still looking straight ahead. "In the square, the first day. She was working on the ambulance. I was four. I was at my grandmother's." She picked at the edge of the rolled target with one fingernail. "She doesn't talk about it. Not to me, not to anybody. Thirty-seven years. You ask her and she says it was cold and she was tired and then she asks if you're hungry."

"Are you?" Dorina asked from the back seat, opening her eyes. "Hungry?"

"No, Mommy."

"I have cozonac in my bag," Dorina said, and closed her eyes again.

"She used to fill the bathtub," Sanda said after a mile, to the windshield. "When I was little. After. Every time the radio said anything. A storm, a strike, a speech, the price of bread. Anything. She'd hear it on the radio and go straight in and fill the tub to the top. Cold water. We'd go a week without a bath because she didn't want to use the water." She laughed a little, without much in it. "I used to hate it. All my friends had hot baths and I had a tub full of cold water I wasn't allowed to touch."

"Every time," Dorina said from the back seat, in English. She had heard that much, at least. "And every time, I was right."

"You were not right every time, Mama."

"I was right enough times," Dorina said, and patted her purse, where the stun gun was, and closed her eyes.

* * *

That night, in bed, Sanda's phone buzzed on her nightstand.

She was reading a magazine about kitchens. John was half asleep. He heard her pick up the phone, and then he heard her go very still, the way she went still in a store when she saw a price she did not believe.

"What?" John said into his pillow.

"It's Carla." Sanda held the phone out to him without looking at him. On the screen was a text, with three exclamation points and a screenshot.

Did u see this?? System just posted a "forecast ledger" for the branch for MONDAY. Deposits, withdrawals, cash in, cash out. Every drawer. Already balanced. IT says it's a new feature?? We haven't even opened yet!!!

John sat up and looked at the screenshot. It was a spreadsheet, neat and orderly, in the bank's blue colors, with a date at the top that was two days away. Brianna's drawer was on it. Brianna's drawer was balanced.

"It's Saturday," John said.

"I know what day it is," Sanda said.

She took the phone back from him and looked at the screenshot for a long time, while the air conditioner hummed and Charlie snored at the foot of the bed. Then she turned the phone over and laid it face down on the nightstand, screen to the wood, and turned off her lamp.

In twenty years John had never once seen her do that.

CHAPTER SIX

The Apartment

◇

"Your Bordeaux is resting at a perfect 55°F. 🍷"

— VinoSense app notification, Sunday, 6:12 a.m.

On Sunday mornings they had coffee in bed, with Charlie's permission.

The idea was to wake up slowly, without alarms, and drink a cup of coffee propped up on the pillows and talk about anything they had been too busy to talk about during the week. In practice Charlie woke them at a quarter past six by standing on John's chest and staring into his face from four inches away, breathing, until John got up and walked him and made the coffee and brought it back to bed, where Sanda would be sitting up waiting with her glasses on, as if she had done something.

This Sunday she was sitting up in an old gray t-shirt from a ten-kilometer race in Lincoln Park that neither of them had run in, and she was holding out her hand for the mug before John had cleared the doorway.

"You did an amazing job with that AR yesterday," John said, handing it to her and climbing back under the covers in his Bears t-shirt and boxers. "I'm really proud of you."

"Anyone could shoot that thing," Sanda said, blowing across her coffee. "It's easy. You don't need to be proud of me."

"I mean I'm proud you weren't afraid of it." That did not come out the way he meant, and he tried again. "You used to be afraid of all of it. And yesterday you just picked it up. With the way things are going, it's good that you know how. You just never know."

Sanda took a sip and looked at him over the rim of the mug, and he could see her deciding whether it was too early for this conversation, and deciding that it was, and having it anyway.

"Does it really matter?" Sanda asked.

"Does what matter?"

"Any of it. The AR. The range. All your guns." She set the mug on her knee. "We live in an apartment, John. If the world ends, how are we supposed to survive in an apartment? We don't own anything. We don't own the walls. And honestly — would we even want to live in that kind of world?" She looked at the ceiling. "We should buy a house. With land. Real land, not a yard. Space for your guns, space for a garden. We could have chickens."

"Chickens," John said.

"Chickens," Sanda repeated firmly. "You know who was okay in Romania, after? The people with houses and gardens. My grandmother had a house in the village with a garden and chickens and a well, and when there was nothing in the stores in Bucharest, we ate because of her garden. Everyone in the apartment blocks stood in line for bread for three hours. My grandmother walked out her back door and picked tomatoes."

John took a long sip of his coffee to give himself time.

"Okay," John said. "One thing to think about. Let's say everything goes to hell. Real hell. You're a bad guy. You're driving around in a pickup truck with four of your buddies, and they've all got rifles, and there are no police, because the police are all home protecting their own families. You're looking for food, guns, drugs, whatever. You're driving down a country road, and you see a nice big house sitting all by itself on ten acres. No neighbors. Woods on three sides. Who's in there?"

"A family," Sanda said.

"A rich family," John said. "Probably an older couple, with a nice house and a nice truck, and probably no guns, or one shotgun, and no training. And the house promises all kinds of good stuff inside. Big house, big land — they must have something. Now compare that to this." He gestured with his mug at the bedroom, the apartment, the whole complex beyond the blinds. "A gated complex with two hundred apartments that all look exactly the same. Which one would you pick? Apartments blend in. Nobody looks at an apartment and thinks, there's the treasure. If you were the guy in the truck, which one would you pick?"

He felt he had made a sound case for staying put. He sat back against the headboard.

Sanda thought about it carefully. She drank some coffee. She looked at him.

"I think we should own our own house," Sanda said.

"Think about this, though," John said, pressing on. "Remember the hurricane? Our first fall back? Four days without power. That was one storm, in one part of one state. Now imagine that everywhere, at once, and nobody coming to fix it. The first few weeks would be the worst. Panic. Looting. Guys in trucks going house to house. And you've got some big house in the country with windows on every side and three doors and a garage. How do you defend that? You'd need an army. Inside and outside. There is no way we could do it." He started counting on his fingers. "Your mom just learned to shoot a twenty-two rifle, which is a squirrel gun. My dad hates guns and admits he's a terrible shot. My mom — Dad says she's a good shot, but I have never once seen her hold a gun, and I've known her my whole life. And you just shot an AR for the first time yesterday. You don't know how to load your own magazines. You don't know how to clear a jam. You've never field-stripped it."

"What's field-stripped?"

"Taking it apart to clean it."

"So I'll learn to take it apart," Sanda said. "Big deal. You learned on YouTube."

"That's my point," John said, a little heated now. He took a breath and tried to put the heat back. "And remember the hurricane? What did you learn from the hurricane?"

"That we need a house with a generator," Sanda said immediately.

"I learned we needed a second Desert Eagle."

Sanda looked at him for a very long moment.

"You did buy a second Desert Eagle," Sanda said slowly. "That October. I thought it was for your birthday."

"It was a hurricane lesson."

"What was the lesson?"

John opened his mouth. He found that he could no longer remember what the lesson had been, only that it had seemed very clear at the time, sitting in the dark on the third day with no air conditioning, sweating through his shirt and cleaning the first Desert Eagle by the light of a headlamp.

"Well," Sanda said, throwing back the covers, "I don't think the world's ending this morning. Maybe you're right about the apartment. I don't know. I'm going to make us breakfast."

That was how most of their arguments ended. A little back and forth, and then Sanda had had enough and some urgent household task appeared out of nowhere, and the subject was closed. John had learned over twenty years not to push. Sanda needed to percolate. If he left an idea alone with her for a while, it would steep, and sometimes, days later, she would come back to it on her own, and sometimes they would even land on the same side.

Breakfast was eggs and grits. It had been eggs and grits on weekends ever since they moved back, as a way of reminding themselves where they were; in Chicago, grits were either a novelty on a brunch menu or something a coworker made a face about. Sanda had figured out how to fry an egg sunny-side up without breaking the yolk or browning the edges, which John considered a form of witchcraft, and she slid two of them onto a bed of creamy, buttery grits that had simmered for forty minutes, because they were never, ever instant.

"No self-respecting Southerner," John said, picking up his fork and quoting the line from *My Cousin Vinny*, "uses instant grits."

"You're not a self-respecting Southerner," Sanda said, sitting down across from him. "You lived in Chicago for twelve years and you put ketchup on a hot dog."

"I never put ketchup on a hot dog."
"Twice," Sanda said. "I saw you."

* * *

On Monday Sanda called him on his drive home, sounding through the car speakers like a woman shouting from inside a mailbox during a gale, and asked if he wanted to try the Korean place by the Target. He said yes, mostly to end the call.

The Korean place had a special they had never tried, called the Korean Barbecue Experience. The server, a cheerful young woman in a black apron with her hair in two buns, brought out a round gas grill and set it in the middle of their table and lit it with a click. It looked like a wok turned upside down, a dark iron dome over a ring of blue flame, and around it she arranged platters of raw beef and pork sliced so thin you could read through them, and little dishes of kimchi and pickled radish and sesame sauce, and whole cloves of garlic, and sliced jalapeños, and a stack of cold romaine leaves.

"You cook it yourself," the server said, demonstrating with a pair of long tongs. "Put it on the dome. Ten seconds. Flip. Ten seconds. Put it in the lettuce, add what you like, roll it up. Like a taco."

They laid the meat on the hot dome and it hissed and curled and browned at the edges, and they flipped it and pulled it off and wrapped it in the cold lettuce with a slice of grilled garlic and a coin of jalapeño and a drizzle of sriracha. Sanda took the first bite with her eyes closed. She chewed. She opened her eyes and they were very wide.

"Okay," Sanda said, through the lettuce. "That's it. We're doing this at home."

John sighed. One of Sanda's great joys in life was eating something remarkable at a restaurant and then figuring out how to make it at home, exactly, better. After a week in Zürich she had mastered fondue. After a weekend in New Orleans she had mastered beignets, and they had eaten beignets for a month, and John had gained four pounds. Now there would be Korean barbecue.

The next afternoon she stopped at the Korean grocery on her way home from the bank and came back with everything: the meats, the

sauces, the kimchi in a jar the size of a paint can, and the grill itself, in a box with a picture of a happy family on the side. It ran on the little green one-pound propane canisters that people used for camping, and she had bought four of them.

"Another appliance," John said, watching her unpack it on the high-top.

"It's not an appliance," Sanda said. "It's an experience."

He did not think they needed it.

* * *

On Wednesday night, in bed, with the lights out, Sanda said, "The forecast was right."

John, who had been nearly asleep, said, "What?"

"Carla's thing. The ledger for Monday, that came on Saturday." Her voice was very quiet in the dark. "It was right. The whole day. Deposits, withdrawals, every drawer. It was off by eleven dollars for the entire branch, and the eleven dollars was a man who came in at four fifty-five and wasn't supposed to." She was quiet for a moment. "Brianna's drawer was perfect. She cried again. Happy, this time."

John lay looking at the ceiling. He did not know what to say, so he said nothing, which was sometimes the right thing.

"I think you might be right about the apartment," Sanda said.

He turned his head on the pillow. Three days. That was about average.

"Yeah?"

"Maybe. I don't know." He heard her turn toward him on the pillow. "Can you buy barbed wire?"

He was not sure he had heard her correctly. "You want me to buy barbed wire."

"For the windows," Sanda said, as if it were obvious. "If somebody breaks a window to get in, it'll slow them down. Can you buy it on Amazon?"

John reached for his phone on the nightstand, and the screen lit up the bedroom blue, and he opened the app and typed in *barbed wire*, feeling ridiculous. It came up instantly.

"Huh," John said. "Yeah. You can. Class three galvanized, fifteen-and-a-half gauge. A quarter mile. Ninety-four dollars." He turned his head on the pillow to look at her in the glow. "You actually want me to buy this?"

"I think it's a good idea."

"And do what with it? String it across the inside of the windows like Christmas lights?"

"No," Sanda said, thinking out loud now. "We'd need plywood too. Plywood over the windows, so nobody can see in and nobody can just smash the glass and climb in. And then if they break the glass and kick through the plywood, there's the barbed wire. Do you have a nail gun?"

He was completely awake now.

"And think about this," Sanda went on. "If the power goes out for a long time, and a window gets broken — for any reason, a storm, a branch, anything — then the outside is just in the house. You have to keep people out, but you also have to keep out the animals. Snakes. Raccoons. The bugs. This is Florida, John. Everything here wants to come inside."

He had never once thought of that. In ten years of thinking about the end of the world, in all his scenarios and plans and late-night videos, it had not occurred to him that a broken window in Florida would let in more than people. He was a little disappointed in himself. He did not say so.

"Okay," John said slowly, scrolling. "So I guess I'll buy a box of barbed wire. Which means I need special gloves, so I don't shred my hands." He found them, heavy leather gauntlets that came up to the elbow, and added them to the cart. "And a nail gun." He scrolled, and his thumb stopped, and his voice changed. "Oh, man. Look at this. It's cordless. It has a little air compressor built right into it, and the battery kicks it on when you pull the trigger, and it shoots two-inch nails."

He had wanted a nail gun for ten years, ever since he watched Denzel Washington take apart a roomful of Russian gangsters in *The Equalizer* using, among other things, a nail gun from a hardware store. He added it to the cart.

"And the plywood?" Sanda asked.

"I'll get that at Home Depot. This weekend."

He never would. He did not know that yet. He would think about the plywood several times, always on the way somewhere else.

He lay there with the phone glowing on his chest, looking at his cart — a quarter mile of barbed wire, a pair of gauntlets, and a cordless nail gun — and he could not believe the conversation he was having. Buying guns had always felt perfectly reasonable to him. Buying barbed wire felt insane. It occurred to him that most people would see it exactly the other way around, that his neighbors would think nothing of a box of barbed wire and would call the police about an AR-15, and he did not know what that said about him, or about them. He felt, for the first time, that it was getting harder to tell himself apart from the people on the videos, the man in the shipping container, the woman with the wall of rice. At least he wasn't buying canned food and water and a year of toilet paper. At least he had a plan, and the plan was guns.

Then, because he was a responsible man, he searched for water, and found a case of Perrier, twenty-four half-liter bottles, and added it to the cart.

"There," John said, and tapped *Place your order*. "Water."

"That's sparkling water," Sanda said into her pillow.

"It's still water."

"Mm-hm," Sanda said, and fell asleep.

* * *

The box came Thursday afternoon. John knew it had come because his phone told him, at his desk at work, with a soft chime: *Someone is at your front door.* He opened the doorbell app and watched a delivery driver in a brown uniform set a long, heavy box on his mat, take a photograph of it, and walk away, and Charlie, invisible inside the apartment, barked at the man the whole way to the truck.

When he got home there was also a notice taped to the door from the leasing office, on letterhead, which said that the community's front and rear gates were being upgraded to a new cloud-based access system from Halcyon Access Systems, and that all residents should download the Halcyon app for keyless entry, and that the community thanked them for their patience during this exciting improvement.

"Another app," John said, peeling the notice off the door.

The gate had been half-installed for two weeks. The old keypad was still there, but the steel enclosure next to it, where the gate's controller lived, had been left with its cover off, and the cover was nowhere to be seen. John, because he was an engineer and could not walk past an open box with wires in it, had stopped the car on his way out one morning and looked inside. There was a new green circuit board in there, bolted to the back of the box, with a cellular antenna on a short cable and a little blinking light, and the board was stamped in white letters with the name HALCYON. Below it sat the old motor and its fat power leads, unchanged, with a low-voltage line coming in from a transformer on the post. He had noted how it was wired, the way he noted everything, and had driven to work and forgotten it.

He carried the box of barbed wire into the garage and set it on the shelf beside the Christmas bins, and he did not open it.

Then he came back inside and stood in the middle of his apartment and looked around, as if he had never seen it before, and began, for no reason he could have explained, to count.

The front door had a smart lock that opened with an app on his phone or with a code on a keypad or — thank God — with a key, an actual brass key on his actual key ring, which he had insisted on keeping. Next to the door was the video doorbell, which watched the walk and the street and sent a picture to his phone every time a lizard crossed the welcome mat. On the wall in the hall was the smart thermostat, which learned their habits, and which had apparently learned that John liked it at seventy-one and Sanda liked it at seventy-four, and which now spent most of its time trying to split the difference, the way a marriage counselor would. On the bookshelf was the smart speaker with its blue ring. In the corner of the living room, on its charging dock, sat the robot vacuum, a fat black disk the size of a hubcap that wandered the apartment every weekday at noon, sucking up Charlie's hair and getting stuck under the couch. Sanda had named it Dorel.

"Why Dorel?" John had asked, the day it arrived.

"Because Dorel is the guy in every Romanian joke," Sanda had explained. "He's the workman. He's the one who builds the stairs upside down. He installs the toilet on the ceiling. He paints the wall and then

paints the window too, because it was there. Everything Dorel does, he does with complete confidence, and it's wrong."

On the kitchen floor beside Charlie's water bowl stood Charlie's feeder, a white plastic tower with a hopper of kibble and a camera on the front and a little speaker, so that John and Sanda could open an app at work and see Charlie and talk to him and drop him a treat. They did this several times a day. Charlie had never understood it. Whenever their voices came out of the feeder, he would bark at it furiously, as though it had swallowed them.

And beside the high-top, humming quietly, was the wine cooler, forty-six bottles in two climate zones, reds on top at fifty-five, whites on the bottom at fifty, and it had an app too, which Sanda checked every morning in bed.

"Why does the wine cooler have an app?" John asked, standing in front of it.

"So I know the temperature," Sanda said from the couch, where she was flipping through a catalog.

"You're standing next to it."

"I'm on the couch."

"You're standing next to it every morning. You walk past it to make coffee. It has a little screen on the front that says the temperature. In numbers."

"The app has a graph," Sanda said, without looking up. "And it tells me when I'm low on Sancerre."

John looked around the apartment. Everything he could see — the lock, the doorbell, the thermostat, the speaker, Dorel, the feeder, the wine cooler, the television, his laptop, her laptop, their phones, the car in the garage — was talking to something, all the time, somewhere. He had never added it up before. It had come into their lives one convenient thing at a time, like water rising in a basement, and he had never once stood still long enough to notice that it had reached his knees.

* * *

On Friday night Sanda lit the grill on the kitchen counter for the first time, and John stood beside it with a glass of wine in his hand watching the blue ring of flame under the black iron dome, and it occurred to him,

slowly, the way things sometimes occurred to him, that this little thing did not need a wall outlet. It did not need the power company at all. If the power ever went out — they did live in hurricane country now, after all — they could still cook on it. They could boil water on it. People out in the country had generators that could run a whole house for weeks after a storm. Apartment people had nothing. And now, at least, they had this.

He felt, for a moment, very prepared.

After the Korean barbecue, he took Charlie out for his last walk, and across the street, in front of the third apartment down, there was a pug.

It was a female, small and fawn-colored, with a black mask over her flat face and a tail curled up over her back in a tight, perfect cinnamon roll, and enormous dark eyes that bulged a little, so that she looked permanently astonished by the world. She snorted when she breathed. When she saw Charlie she lost her mind entirely, and so did he, and the two of them hit the ends of their leashes at the same instant and began to wag so hard their whole bodies bent.

At the other end of the pug's leash was an older woman John had seen many times and had never once spoken to beyond the dogs. She was in her sixties, maybe five-foot-four and thin, with a deep Florida tan and freckles across her cheeks and the backs of her hands, and blond hair that was clearly from a box, with half an inch of gray showing at the roots. She wore a pink velour tracksuit, white Skechers, and a quilted black vest, and she was holding a long thin cigarette away from the dogs in her free hand, the way you would hold a sparkler.

"Here we go," the woman said, in a deep, scratchy smoker's voice, laughing. "They're in love."

The dogs met in the middle of the street and immediately began running in circles around each other, and in four seconds their leashes were braided together and the two humans were being reeled in toward each other, stepping over and under, holding their leashes up over their heads like people doing a folk dance.

"Sorry," John said, ducking under. "He doesn't get out much."

"Neither does she," the woman said, stepping over. "She's a homebody, aren't you, baby? Yes, you are."

She said the pug's name then, and John heard it and nodded and smiled, and the name went in one ear and straight out the other, the way names always did with him, especially women's names, especially in the dark.

"She's very cute," John said, which was what you said.

"She's spoiled rotten," the woman said fondly, finally untangling herself with a practiced spin. "She eats grain-free salmon formula. Forty dollars a bag." She laughed her scratchy laugh. "I eat ramen noodles. Don't tell anybody."

"I won't," John said, laughing too, because he thought it was a joke.

She scooped the pug up under one arm, and the pug craned around her elbow to keep looking at Charlie, snorting, and the woman waved her cigarette at John and said, "Night, now," and went inside. John never did get her name. It did not occur to him that it mattered.

* * *

That night, in the recliner, he found the post.

It was on the kind of website where engineers went to argue with each other, and it had been written by a security researcher in the Netherlands who studied the software inside cheap internet routers. The title was plain, the way the best ones always were: *Undocumented "maintenance hooks" in router firmware from at least eleven vendors.* John read it twice, one paragraph at a time.

The researcher had been taking apart the software in a popular home router and had found a hidden channel in it that he could not explain. It was not a bug. It was carefully built. It kept a quiet connection open to an outside server and listened there for instructions, and when instructions came, it could change the router's settings, update its software, and reroute its traffic, all without the owner ever knowing. The code that built it was clean and well commented, and the comments called it a *self-healing maintenance channel*. Then he had looked at routers from other companies, and found the same channel, built the same way, in ten more. None of the companies he contacted could tell him who had written it. Several of them, he noted dryly, had used AI-generated code for their recent firmware updates.

At the bottom of the post, he listed the outside servers that the channels connected to. They followed a pattern.

relay-1.opsmesh.net. relay-2.opsmesh.net. relay-3.opsmesh.net. All the way to nine.

The seventh one was *relay-7.opsmesh.net*. John had typed that exact name into his own terminal eleven days ago, at ten minutes to five on a Monday afternoon, in an empty office, with Priya's notebooks on the desk beside him. And then he had clicked *Approve*.

John sat very still in the recliner. He could feel his own heartbeat in his ears, under the tinnitus, like a man knocking on a wall in the next apartment.

He clicked the bookmark star at the top of the browser. Then, because he wanted to read it again, he refreshed the page.

This post has been removed at the request of the affected vendor.

He went back to the discussion thread, which was already three hundred comments long. Halfway down was a statement from one of the router companies, posted by an account with a gold checkmark beside its name. *These are standard self-healing maintenance features, documented in our terms of service, designed to keep customer devices secure and up to date. There is nothing to see here.* Somebody had replied to it with a single laughing emoji. Somebody else had replied, *Then why'd you take it down?* Nobody had replied to that.

John searched for an archived copy, and after twenty minutes he found one, saved by some stranger an hour before the post came down. He scrolled down past the technical part, past the list of relays, to the very bottom, where the researcher had listed the eleven companies whose firmware he had examined. Most of them made routers. A few made other things — security cameras, a brand of smart plugs, a baby monitor.

The seventh name on the list was Halcyon Access Systems.

He got up out of the recliner and went to the front window and moved one slat of the blinds aside with his finger.

At the end of the drive, a hundred yards away under its orange sodium light, the new gate stood closed across the entrance to the Preserve. The steel box beside it still had no cover. From here he could just make out,

inside it, a tiny green light, blinking slowly and steadily in the dark, the way a thing blinks when it is waiting.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Purse

◇

"There are hooks in everything, Senator. I want to be very clear about that. Everything."

— Ruth Ann Delacroix, Chief Security Officer, Gulf Atlantic Power, testifying before the Senate Commerce Committee, Tuesday

The hearing was on Tuesday, and for three days it was all anyone talked about, and then it was not.

John watched it at his desk in the half-empty Suwannee pod with one earbud in, while the queue ticked upward in the corner of his screen. The witness was a woman named Ruth Ann Delacroix, the chief security officer of Gulf Atlantic Power, a utility that served about three million people along the coast from Mobile to Savannah. She was in her sixties, with gray hair pulled back in a low bun, a plain gray suit, and a pair of reading glasses that she kept taking off and putting on again, and she looked like the kind of high school chemistry teacher who has never once raised her voice and has never once needed to. She sat alone at a long table in front of a raised half-circle of senators, with a glass of water and a stack of paper, and she read from the paper in a level Alabama voice.

Her team, she said, had been auditing the software that ran Gulf Atlantic's grid — the systems that balanced generation and load, that

opened and closed switches in substations, that dispatched crews, that billed customers. In the course of that audit, they had found hidden channels. Small, quiet, well-built pieces of code that kept connections open to outside servers and listened for instructions. Maintenance hooks, the code called them. They were in the billing system. They were in the switching firmware. They were in the outage management system. They had not been put there by Gulf Atlantic. As far as anyone could determine, they had not been put there by Gulf Atlantic's vendors, either — not on purpose, not by any person. They had been written by the tools the vendors used to write their software, and they had been written well.

"Ma'am," said a senator from a Plains state, a heavy man with a white pompadour, leaning toward his microphone. "Which vendors?"

"I'm not able to name them in open session, Senator."

"But it's more than one."

"It is more than one."

"How many systems are we talking about, here? Ballpark."

Ruth Ann Delacroix took off her reading glasses and folded them and set them down on the stack of paper, and she looked up at the senator for a moment before she answered.

"There are hooks in everything, Senator," Delacroix said. "I want to be very clear about that. Everything."

John sat in the empty pod with his earbud in and did not move. Gulf Atlantic Power was a Restore customer. It had been one of the first. He had fixed a bug for them in his second month at Palmetto, something about crews in Pensacola getting assigned to Tallahassee, and a man from their operations center had sent him a fruit basket.

He did not know whether the outage management system she meant was Restore. She had not said. Her lawyers would not have let her. He sat there wondering, and then he closed the video and opened the queue and approved four pull requests without reading them, because his hands needed something to do.

The clip that went viral was not that one. The clip that went viral came twenty minutes later, when an elderly senator from the Northeast, who had appeared to be asleep for most of the testimony, woke up, leaned into

his microphone, and asked, in a voice of genuine bewilderment, "Ma'am, are we talking about the Wi-Fi?"

By Wednesday morning it had been viewed forty million times. By Wednesday afternoon it was a song. By Thursday there were t-shirts.

"Hooks are features, bro," Tyler said on Wednesday, scrolling through the memes at his desk with his feet up. "That's literally all a hook is. She's just mad she didn't find them first. Have you seen the Wi-Fi guy? Look at his face." He held up his phone. "Look at his *face*, John."

At home that night, over a roast chicken, John tried to explain it to Sanda.

"I saw the Wi-Fi senator," Sanda said, laughing, before he had finished his first sentence. "Carla showed me at work. 'Are we talking about the Wi-Fi?' " She did the voice, old and bewildered and New England, and laughed again. "He's like a hundred."

"That's the part you remember?"

"That's the part everyone remembers," Sanda said, cutting her chicken. "What else was there?"

He told her what else there was. She listened, and nodded, and said "Huh" in two places, and asked whether Restore was one of them, and he said he didn't know, and she said "Well, you'd know, wouldn't you?" and he said he wasn't sure he would, and she looked at him for a moment, and then she asked if he wanted more potatoes.

By Friday the hearing was gone. An actor had left his wife for a younger actress who had played his daughter in a movie, and the wife had posted a forty-minute video about it from a kitchen in Malibu, and that was the news. The networks moved on. The senators moved on. The forty million people who had watched the Wi-Fi senator moved on, and they went to work and came home and made dinner and took hot showers and watched their shows and went to bed.

John had seen it happen before, with other things. He had watched the whole country grow numb to its own news, one breaking alert at a time, so that now the networks had to shout just to get anyone to look up from their phones — louder music, bigger letters, a red banner that said BREAKING across the bottom of the screen at all hours, until BREAKING meant nothing at all, until it was just the color of the bottom of the

screen. Things were bad. Things were always bad. But the television still came on. The water was still hot. People still got up most mornings and drove to jobs they hated, and that was the strongest thing in the world, John thought. Stronger than any hook. Nobody really believed it could all just stop, because it never had. He did not blame them. It was the only life anybody had ever known. Why on earth would it change?

* * *

On Saturday morning Sanda went hunting.

This was how she described it, and it was accurate. She would spend the whole day driving from store to store — Home Goods, TJ Maxx, Kirkland's in the outlet mall, a little shop in Winter Park that sold French linens, and Home Goods again in a different town, because every Home Goods had a different soul — in pursuit of a single perfect throw pillow or the exact right lamp shade, and she would come home at dusk exhausted and triumphant with bags in both hands, like a woman returning from the savanna with a gazelle.

It was the holiday season, and that made it serious. The whole family would be at their apartment for Christmas, and Thanksgiving had set the bar very high, and there were now five artificial Christmas trees in their two-bedroom apartment.

The big one stood in the corner between the living room and the dining room, eight feet tall, so full and real-looking that guests touched the needles to check. It was the important tree. It wore only Sanda's best ornaments, hand-blown glass, most of them made in Poland: the little red London phone booths, a Santa sitting on a bench with the Eiffel Tower behind him, a gondola from Venice, a cable car from San Francisco, and, front and center, at eye level, the gold glass Marshall Field's clock that John had given her their first Christmas in Chicago. The tree in the master bedroom was all white and silver, with white lights, like a tree in a snowstorm. The tree in the guest bedroom was Romanian: red and white, hung with little painted wooden eggs and straw angels and red felt hearts embroidered with black thread that Dorina had brought back from a trip home. There was a tabletop tree on the kitchen high-top decorated entirely with food — tiny glass wine bottles, macarons, a croissant, a wedge of cheese with holes

in it. And there was a narrow pencil tree in the entryway by the front door, wrapped in gold ribbon, which Charlie barked at every time he came in from a walk, as if seeing it for the first time.

Each of them was a work of art. Sanda was very proud of them. John, who had grown up with one tree that his father bought from the Boy Scouts in a church parking lot two days before Christmas, had learned not to count them out loud.

"Okay, babe," Sanda said, at ten o'clock, coming out of the bedroom with her keys, her phone, and her purse. "I'll be back later. I love you."

She was dressed for hunting: dark jeans, a camel cashmere sweater, a long cream wool coat that she did not need in Florida and wore anyway, and tan suede ankle boots, and she had put on lipstick, because you never knew who you would run into at a Home Goods.

John was in his recliner with his laptop on his knees. "Are you going to take a gun with you?"

Sanda stopped with her hand on the front doorknob. She closed her eyes.

"John," Sanda said. "Really? I don't have time for this shit. I have a million things to do."

"Okay," John said, still looking at his screen.

She had gotten her Florida concealed weapons license months ago, after an all-day class and a two-month wait, and she had never carried a gun once. The range was one thing. The range had rules and lines and procedures and a man with a white crew cut to enforce them, and Sanda loved procedures; she had grown up in a country where you lined up for everything. Walking around a Home Goods with a loaded pistol in her purse was a different thing altogether. And she had told John more times than he could count that she could never kill anyone. She could shoot someone in the leg, maybe. She could fire a warning shot, possibly. But she did not have it in her to take another human being's life, whatever that human being had done, and she was not going to carry a gun around pretending she did.

She stood at the door. John typed. Charlie, on the couch, looked from one of them to the other.

"Fine!" Sanda said. "Fine. I'll take the twenty-two. Do you have a holster for it?"

John set the laptop on the floor and got up out of the recliner. "I think the holster for the Glock 42 might fit the twenty-two."

He went into the bedroom and came back with the little Glock 42, a black three-eighty that Sanda had been shooting at the range for most of a year, in its soft pocket holster, and with the Walther P22. He slid the Glock out of the holster and slid the Walther in, and to his surprise it fit nearly perfectly.

"Here," John said, handing it to her. "Try that."

She tried it.

Her purse was a small black leather crossbody bag about the size of a sandwich, and it held, by John's estimate, a wallet, a phone, a pair of sunglasses, a lipstick, a hairbrush, a packet of tissues, two pens from the bank, a tin of mints, a bottle of hand sanitizer shaped like a lemon, a tiny notebook, and a sense of superiority. Sanda stood at the high-top and began fitting the holstered Walther into it, taking things out, putting things back in a different order, rotating the gun one way and then the other, the way you would pack a car for a long trip. After five minutes she had it in. She looked down into the open purse. The butt of the pistol stuck straight up out of the middle of her things like a periscope.

"Just so you know," John said softly, "if you're going to carry in your purse, you need to take your wallet out before you get to the register. Discreetly. You don't want to be digging around for your wallet in front of the cashier with your gun sticking out. Even if it's legal now, the lady at the Home Goods register doesn't know that."

"Yeah, see, this is exactly why I shouldn't be doing this," Sanda said, her voice rising. "It sticks out like a sore thumb. Look at it. Let me see the three-eighty."

He took the Walther out and put the Glock back in. The Glock was slightly smaller and all black, and it disappeared better among her things. Sanda reorganized her purse again. Then she looked up at him.

"This doesn't have a safety, right?"

John was sure she already knew the answer, and he was a little irritated that she had asked. "Glock did an extensive study," John said, in his lecture

voice. "They found that thumb safeties cause more problems than they solve. In a gunfight, officers would forget whether the gun was on safe or fire, and that half a second could get them killed. So Glocks don't have one. The safety is your finger. Keep your finger off the trigger and the gun won't go off."

"I want my gun to have a safety," Sanda said.

"Sanda—"

"You don't understand what it's like to have a gun in a purse. You don't carry a purse. There are keys in here. Pens. Things moving around. What if it falls out of the holster? What if the keys get in the trigger?" She held up the holster. "Do you have a holster with a strap? A button strap, that goes over the back, so it can't fall out?"

"No," John said. "I don't have anything like that."

"Okay," Sanda said. "I'm not doing this now." She took the holstered Glock out of her purse and set it down hard on the high-top. "Please go to the gun store and get me a holster with a button strap. Then maybe I'll think about carrying it."

"If you want a holster, you should come with me," John said, getting louder. "Otherwise whatever I buy, you'll have a problem with it, and I'll have to take it back."

"I don't have time for this shit!" Sanda shouted, grabbing her keys off the counter. "I have a million things to do! Just do it!"

It had been thirty-one minutes. John knew because he had looked at the clock when she first said *I'll be back later*. She stormed out the front door with her purse — gunless, mints and lemon sanitizer intact — and slammed it, and Charlie exploded off the couch and hit the door barking, high and furious, protesting her departure as he protested every departure.

"Charlie, no bark!" John said, pointing at him.

Charlie barked.

"Charlie. No. Bark."

Charlie barked again, with less conviction, and then, after John said it a third time, switched to the muffled half-bark he used when he wanted it on the record that he disagreed, a sort of *wuff* with his mouth closed, and lay down against the door with his chin on the floor to wait for her.

* * *

John slipped his Glock 43 into the right front pocket of his cargo shorts and drove to the gun store.

Sentinel Arms was in a long tan strip center on Highway 17-92 between a mattress outlet and a karate school, and inside it was bright and cold and smelled — he had been told — of gun oil and new carpet and the coffee that was always going in a pot behind the counter. There were glass cases in a long U around the room, full of pistols, and racks of rifles on the wall behind them, and a little range in the back where you could hear the steady flat pop of somebody's afternoon.

"Hey, John! How are you, man? It's been a while."

Trevor was behind the counter, where he always was. John sometimes suspected he lived there. They were not friends, exactly. They were something closer to what men his age called buddies when they did not want to say acquaintances: Trevor had sold him most of his rifles over the past two years, and had taught him a number of things about them that the internet had not, and they had stood at this counter and talked about guns for what added up, John figured, to several days of his life.

Trevor was somewhere in his thirties, about six feet tall, lean and ropy, the kind of lean that came from doing things rather than from going to a gym to pretend to do them. He had a short dark beard trimmed to a hard, clean line along his cheekbones, a sunburned neck, and pale gray eyes that were always a little amused. He wore a black polo shirt with the Sentinel Arms logo on the chest, tan tactical pants with a lot of pockets, and a sand-colored baseball cap with a pair of Oakley sunglasses pushed up on the brim, though they were indoors. On the inside of his left forearm was a tattoo of a compass rose, black and gray, the needle pointing north toward his elbow. He carried a Glock in a holster inside the front of his waistband, a little left of center.

"Your thing's on a truck," Trevor said, before John could say anything, and winked. "Should be here Monday, maybe Tuesday. I'll text you."

"That's not why I'm here."

"No?" Trevor leaned on the glass. "What do you need?"

"My wife wants to carry her Glock 42 in her purse," John said, leaning on it too. "But she's worried it'll slide out of the pocket holster. She wants something with a strap that goes over the back and snaps. A button strap. Do you have anything like that?"

"Let me look." Trevor came around the counter and went to a rack of holsters hanging in plastic packages and flipped through them, fast, the way a man flips through records he has known his whole life. He came back with one. "No button strap. Nobody makes a button strap for a 42 anymore. But this one's got a Velcro strap over the back, and it works just as good. I carried this exact holster for about a year." He popped it out of its package. "Want to see it on a 42?"

Trevor unlocked the case, took out a Glock 42, pulled back the slide and checked the chamber and the magazine well before handing it to John grip-first, the way he always did, every time, even with John. The little gun slid into the holster with a soft click, and the Velcro strap came over the back of the slide and pressed down, and the whole thing was smaller than the pocket holster John had at home.

"I think this works," John said. "What's the return policy if she hates it?"

"Keep the receipt and the packaging. Full refund."

"Okay. One more question." John hesitated, because he knew how it was going to sound. "What's the smallest gun you've got that has a thumb safety? For some reason she really wants a safety."

Trevor thought about it for a second, looking off at the case to his right. "M&P Bodyguard."

"Can I see it?"

Trevor was already unlocking the case. He took out a tiny black pistol, drew back the slide, checked it, and handed it over, and John held it in his palm and laughed out loud, because it nearly disappeared there. It was a three-eighty, like the Glock 42, but shorter and thinner, and on the left side of the frame, just where his thumb fell, was a small lever.

"Thumb safety," Trevor said, pointing at it. "Up's safe, down's fire."

"This thing is tiny." John was already thinking of Sanda's sandwich-sized purse. "Will the holster fit it?"

Trevor handed him the Velcro holster. The Bodyguard slid into it as though it had been made for it.

"This is perfect for her," John said. "She's been talking about a gun just like this."

She had not been. But John did not need much of an excuse to add to his collection, and this was an excellent one, and it was standing on the glass in front of him in a Velcro holster.

"I'll take the holster and the Bodyguard," John said.

"Sounds like a plan," Trevor said, and reached under the counter for the long federal form that had to be filled out for every gun sold in America. "You know the drill."

John knew the drill. He took out his driver's license and his concealed weapons license and filled out the form at the counter, checking *No* in the long column of boxes about felonies and fugitives and addiction, while Trevor picked up the phone and called the state's background-check line and waited on hold. John wandered the aisles while he waited, looking at scopes he did not need and a display of camping stoves he did not look at. After a few minutes Trevor said, "Yes, go ahead," into the phone, and wrote a long approval number on the form, repeating each digit aloud. He wrote it left-handed, his hand curled over the top of the pen the way lefties do, so that he would not smear the ink.

Then he turned John's driver's license over and began copying the address onto the back of the form, a new procedure that management had started, and his pen stopped.

"Hey," Trevor said, looking up. "I know this address. John, I live in the same complex as you."

"You're shitting me."

"No shit. The Preserve, right? I'm one street over, I think. On Heron."

"That's crazy," John said, grinning. "Small world."

"Small world." Trevor finished copying the address and handed back the license. "I just put panels on my patio, actually. Solar. Got a battery bank in the garage. Waiting on a dish."

"A dish?"

"Satellite. For internet." Trevor shrugged, ringing up the Bodyguard. "In case."

"In case what?" John asked. "You getting ready for something?"

Trevor smiled at him, and the smile went all the way up into the pale gray eyes and stayed there.

"Man," Trevor said, "I'm always ready for something."

John paid and took the bag and drove home with the windows down, and he felt the way he had felt in the sixth grade when he found out that the coolest kid in school lived on his street. Trevor had panels. Trevor had a battery bank. Trevor was waiting on a dish. Trevor lived one street over, and was always ready for something, and John had nothing on his patio but two folding chairs and a dead basil plant.

* * *

Sanda came home at dusk with a bag in each hand and two more over her shoulder and her cheeks flushed with victory. She had found two small red velvet pillows for the couch, a red lamp shade with a gold lining, a pair of brass candle holders shaped like pinecones, and several other items that John could not identify and did not ask about. She also had, under one arm, a tiny tree, about two feet tall, in a burlap pot, already strung with miniature lights.

"For the guest bathroom," Sanda said, setting it on the counter.

"That's six," John said.

"That's festive," Sanda said.

He waited until she had arranged the pillows and replaced the lamp shade and stood back to look at them, and then he said, as casually as he could, "So I got your holster."

"Oh, you did?" Sanda turned around. "Let me see."

He took it out of the bag and popped it out of its package and slid her Glock 42 into it, still lying on the high-top where she had left it that morning, and pressed the strap down over the back.

"Sorry. They didn't have anything with a button strap. Only Velcro."

"Velcro," Sanda said. "Really? You know I hate Velcro."

He had known she would say that. He had been ready for it all afternoon. He demonstrated: the strap could go this way or that way; it could be adjusted; there was no possible way, none, that the gun could slide out of the holster in her purse by itself, he could turn it upside down and shake

it, look. Sanda took it, and inspected the strap, and turned it upside down and shook it herself, and put it in her purse, and took it out, and put it back in.

"I can take it back," John said. "No problem."

"No," Sanda said slowly. "I think this will be fine."

"Well," John said, "they also had a really cool gun. Much smaller than the Glock. And it has a thumb safety."

"Really?" Sanda said, with an interest that took him completely by surprise. "I want to see it."

He took the little hard case out of the other bag and opened it on the counter. The Bodyguard lay in its foam like a piece of jewelry.

Sanda looked at it. She looked at him.

"You bought another fucking gun?" Sanda said, in the voice of a woman who has been on her feet since ten in the morning.

"It wasn't expensive," John said quickly. "And I think it's exactly what you've been looking for."

"I have never once been looking for a gun." She picked it up anyway, and turned it over, and he saw her eyebrows go up at how little it weighed. "Well. I do like the size. And it has a safety?"

"Right there. That little lever. Just like the one on the twenty-two, only smaller. Up's safe. Down's fire."

He moved the holster over to the Bodyguard, and it slid in perfectly, and the whole package fit in the palm of his hand. Sanda took it and put it in her purse, among the mints and the lemon, and looked down into the bag. With the purse wide open, the little black gun in its little black holster in the little black bag was nearly invisible. You could look right at it and not see a gun.

"I like it," Sanda said. "I don't think you should have bought another gun. But you're right. This one's perfect."

John began to smile.

"However," Sanda said, zipping the purse closed and pointing a finger at him, "there is no way in hell I am carrying this until I go to the range and practice with it. A lot."

"Fair enough," John said, and meant it. Little guns kicked hard. It had taken her months to get comfortable with the Glock. She would need range time, and range time with Sanda was his favorite thing in the world.

While she put the candle holders out, he told her about Trevor.

He told her about the panels on the patio and the battery bank in the garage and the satellite dish that was coming, and he told her that Trevor lived one street over, on Heron, and that he was the only person John knew who was actually ready, actually ready, for whatever came. He heard himself telling it, and he heard how excited he sounded, and he did not care.

Sanda listened, setting the brass pinecones on the dining table and turning them a quarter-inch at a time until they were right.

"Then why don't you talk to him about water," Sanda said, "instead of guns?"

John opened his mouth.

He did not have an answer. He stood there in the middle of the living room with nothing to say, while Sanda turned the second pinecone a quarter-inch and stood back to look at it. He never did talk to Trevor about water. He bought guns from him, and only guns, right up to the end.

* * *

That night, after she went to bed, John sat up in the recliner reading the news.

He was not looking for anything. He was scrolling the way people scroll, one thumb moving, eyes half closed. But there was a small item in one of his news apps about an airline that had suffered a brief dispatch outage on Friday afternoon, *resolved automatically*, no flights affected. He would not have noticed it except for the word *automatically*. He kept scrolling. In a different app, an hour later, he found a short piece from a trade publication about a pipeline operator on the Gulf Coast that had experienced a pressure anomaly on one of its main lines on Friday afternoon, which had *self-corrected* before any leak occurred. And in a third app, buried under a story about the actor and his wife, he found a regional bank in Ohio apologizing to its customers for an eleven-minute

interruption to its card processing on Friday afternoon, *resolved by our automated systems*.

He went back and found all three and read them again, and this time he looked at the times.

The airline's outage had started at 2:14 p.m. Eastern. The pipeline's anomaly had begun at 2:16. The bank's interruption had started at 2:19. All three had been resolved by 2:25.

An airline, a pipeline, and a bank. Three industries that had nothing to do with each other, run by three companies that had nothing to do with each other, in three different states, on three different kinds of software. All of them had broken on the same Friday afternoon, inside the same eleven minutes. And all of them had healed themselves.

Not three accidents. One hand.

He opened the notes app on his phone and wrote down all three, with the times, and the names of the companies, and the word *automatically* three times, and he sat looking at it in the dark with the blue ring on the speaker glowing on the bookshelf and his heart going.

He thought that he might be the first person in the world to notice.

He was not. He was, as it turned out, somewhere around the four-hundredth. The other three hundred and ninety-nine had noticed on Friday, within minutes, and they had been sitting since Friday night in windowless rooms in Washington and Virginia and Maryland where no one was allowed to bring a phone, writing on paper, and none of them had been home since, and none of them were going to sleep that weekend either.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Alarm

◇

Water (20 gal). Batteries. Cash. Propane. Matches. Bleach. Meds. Dog food. Gas can.

— Post-it note, kitchen counter, Monday, 5:40 a.m.

They left for the range early on Sunday, so Sanda could try the Bodyguard before anyone else was there.

John packed the AR-15 into its hard case and threw some ammunition and three handguns into the big rolling range bag that the NRA had mailed him as a thank-you gift, and he punched the code into the alarm panel by the door. Charlie hated the alarm's countdown. He stood in the hallway and barked at the panel in time with the beeps, as though he might be able to argue it down, until John pulled the garage door shut behind them.

It was a twenty-minute drive. That was plenty of time for Sanda to think.

"I'm not so sure plywood is a good idea," Sanda said, five minutes in.

Here we go, John thought. He had not bought the plywood.

"We need something that lets the light in," Sanda said, looking out her window at the Sunday-morning traffic on 46. "But from outside it

should just look like blinds. Like nothing. Maybe Plexiglas. We could paint it white on the outside, so from the street it looks like blinds."

John tried to picture it and could not quite. "Why do we need light?"

"Because if the power goes out, John, you need some way to see in the daytime. You can't sit in the dark with plywood on every window for a month like a vampire."

"We have flashlights. We have lanterns."

"Those are consumables," Sanda said.

He was quiet for a moment, because she was right and because he did not like it. "Fine. Okay. Plexiglas. I agree we have to think more about the windows. But there's a bigger problem." He changed lanes around a pickup towing a boat. "Say all hell breaks loose. We're all hunkered down in the apartment. Somebody has to be awake, guarding the place, at all times. Day and night. That means shifts, so people can sleep. And right now, the only person in the family who can really shoot an AR is me."

"I shot the AR last weekend," Sanda said, a little hurt. "Forty rounds. You said I was a monster."

"I handed you a loaded rifle and you shot it. Which was great. But there's a lot more to it. You don't know how to load your own magazines. You don't know how to turn the optic on without me telling you which button. You don't know what to do when it jams, and they all jam eventually. You don't—"

"These are all trivial things," Sanda said, louder. "I can learn them anytime."

"And your mom can shoot a twenty-two. My dad hates guns. My mom—"

"Then teach me," Sanda said.

John looked over at her. She was looking straight ahead through the windshield with her jaw set, the way she looked at a regional vice president who had told her something could not be done.

"The magazines. The jams. The optic. The thing where you take it apart. All of it." She folded her arms. "Teach me. Today."

"Okay," John said, and he found that he was smiling at the road. "Okay. Today."

* * *

There was only one other car in the gravel lot, a dusty black Toyota Tacoma with a light bar on the roof, and John's heart sank, because he had wanted the range to themselves. They signed in at the shed, slid two dollars into the honor box, pushed in their earplugs, and walked through the gate under the big red sign that said WARNING — MEMBERS ONLY BEYOND THIS POINT — LIVE AMMUNITION.

The other shooter was at the far end of the fifty-yard range, his back to them, firing a pistol in steady pairs. He wore a gray hoodie with the sleeves pushed up past his elbows, gray tactical pants, and a sand-colored cap with a pair of Oakleys on the brim. When he turned to change targets, John saw the compass rose on his left forearm.

"Hey, John!" Trevor called, waving and walking toward them. "How are you, man?"

"Trevor?" John lowered his range bag. "Hey. Good to see you."

"Let me guess." Trevor grinned, and the pale gray eyes went from John to the small case in Sanda's hand. "You're out here to break in that Bodyguard."

"That, and I'm going to heat up my AR with a couple hundred rounds," John said. Then he remembered his manners. "Sanda, this is Trevor. From the store. Trevor, my wife, Sanda."

"Hi, Sanda." Trevor held out his hand. He had to bend a little, and he did it without making a point of it. "So you're the one who wanted the thumb safety. Smart. Most people don't think that far."

"Nice to meet you," Sanda said, shaking his hand quickly, the way she shook hands with customers she had not decided about.

"Your thing came in yesterday afternoon, by the way," Trevor said to John. "Right after you left. You want to pick it up tomorrow? I'm in all day."

John could feel Sanda turning to look at him. "Tomorrow," he said. "Sure. Great."

"What thing?" Sanda asked.

"A scope," John said.

Something small and amused crossed Trevor's eyes and was gone. "Yeah," he said. "A scope. Well, I'll let y'all get to it. I've got a couple more mags to shoot and then I'm out of here. Dish goes up tomorrow, by the way," he added to John, over his shoulder. "Internet from space. Wait till you see the speeds."

He shot his last two magazines while they set up, and then he called for the range to go cold and walked down past the firing line to pull his target, and on his way back he stopped behind Sanda while she loaded the Bodyguard's tiny magazine and watched her for a moment.

"Thumb on the side of the mag," Trevor said. "Push down on the round in there, then slide the new one in under the lip. Easier on your fingers."

Sanda tried it. It was easier on her fingers.

"Thank you," Sanda said, surprised.

"Anytime," Trevor said, and touched the brim of his cap to her, and picked up his bag and went off through the gate to the black Tacoma, and a minute later they heard it pull out of the gravel lot.

"He's nice," Sanda said, sliding the magazine into the little gun.

"He's very ready," John said, with something in his voice he did not care to examine.

The Bodyguard kicked. It was a tiny gun firing a real cartridge, and it jumped in Sanda's hands like something alive, and the first round went four inches high. "Wow," Sanda said, turning to look at him. "This thing kicks."

"You can handle it."

She handled it. The second round went high too. John thought she might be flinching a little, anticipating the snap, and he said nothing, because she would work it out, and she did; by the third magazine the holes were creeping down toward the center. While she shot, John ran the AR as fast as he could keep the red dot on the paper, and the brass rang off the concrete and rolled away under the benches, and the barrel steamed in the cool air.

Then he spent an hour teaching her. How to load a thirty-round magazine with her thumb. How to turn the optic on and up. How to tap the bottom of the magazine and rack the charging handle when a round failed

to feed. How to push out the two pins and separate the upper from the lower, and draw out the bolt carrier, and lay it all on a towel, and put it back together. She did it twice wrong and three times right.

"I think I really like this gun," Sanda said at last, looking down at the Bodyguard in her palm, nodding slowly, almost convinced. "Once you get used to the kick. I love how small it is."

"I'm glad," John said, and meant it, and did not think about the scope.

* * *

At seven that evening Sanda's phone rang. It was her mother.

John knew right away that something had happened, because Sanda's face changed, and then she said, "Mommy, stop. Mommy! Listen to me!" and went into a fast, rising stream of Romanian with an English word every other sentence — *stun gun*, *kitchen*, *what were you thinking* — and walked in a circle around the living room with her free hand on top of her head. Then she hung up and stood there.

"You won't fucking believe this," Sanda said.

"What happened?" John said, sitting up in the recliner. He could already tell from her face that nobody was hurt; it was the face she made when her mother had done something her mother probably should not have.

"That stun gun you gave her," Sanda said. "She just tried to kill a palmetto bug with it."

John stared at her. Then he started to grin, and he could not stop it. "How'd that work out?"

"I don't know what I'm going to do with her!" Sanda said, starting to smile herself.

"Did she get it?"

"Yeah," Sanda said, and now she was laughing. "With a shoe!"

John pictured it: his four-foot-nine mother-in-law in her flowered housecoat, chasing a two-inch flying cockroach around her condo kitchen with twenty thousand volts crackling blue in her fist, the bug zigzagging away from her across the linoleum, and then Dorina losing patience and reaching down and taking off a shoe.

"It's not a palmetto bug," John said darkly, when he could talk. "It's a cockroach. A big, fat, flying cockroach. They just call it a palmetto bug down here so the tourists don't leave."

"You're scared of them," Sanda said, delighted.

"I'm not scared of them."

"You're terrified of them. A grown man. Six foot one. With a gun in his pocket right now." She dropped onto the couch, still laughing. "Tell the story."

"I'm not telling the story."

"Tell the story, John."

He told the story. He had been six, in the backyard of the house in Jacksonville, standing on the little patio outside the back door in a pair of jeans, when something big and fast had run up the inside of his pant leg. He had felt every one of its legs. Without thinking, he had slapped his left hand down on his thigh and grabbed it through the denim, and he could feel it there in his fist, hard-shelled and fat and *moving*, two inches from his crotch. He had screamed. His father had come out the back door in his undershirt.

"Take your pants off, boy," Jim had said, very calmly.

But he could not take his pants off, because he could not let go. He had to do it with one hand — unbutton the jeans, unzip them, work them down over his hips one side at a time — while his left hand stayed clamped on the thing in the denim, and the thing kept moving. It took a very long time. When the jeans were finally down around his ankles, he stood there in his underwear on the patio in the sun, and he opened his hand. The jeans fell to the concrete. Nothing came out. His father nudged the jeans with his foot. Nothing. He nudged them again.

The cockroach came out of the top of the jeans like a shot, a big glossy brown thing as long as John's thumb, and his father brought his foot down on it, and it burst. There was a crunch that John could still hear in the middle of the night thirty-six years later, and yellow and white streaks of it shot out in every direction across the patio, two feet at least, in a sort of starburst.

"And that," John said, "is why."

Sanda was lying on the couch with her hand over her eyes, laughing so hard she had no sound left.

"They fly, Sanda," John said. "They *fly*."

* * *

At two minutes to nine, every phone in the apartment went off at once.

His phone shrieked on the side table. Hers shrieked on the couch. It was not a ring and not a text tone but the long, ugly, rising emergency alarm that phones make for tornado warnings and missing children, and both of them were making it at the same time, and through the wall John could hear Granny's phone making it next door, and down the street a car alarm started up as if in sympathy. Charlie bolted for the closet. On John's phone, under a red banner, it said: *PRESIDENTIAL ALERT. The President will address the nation at 9:00 p.m. ET. This is not a test.*

The television came on by itself. John had not touched it. Sanda had not touched it. It came on to a network, and the network was showing the seal of the President of the United States.

Then the president.

He was a heavy man in his sixties with a gray face and gray hair, and he looked like he had not slept since Friday, which, John would learn later, was true. He sat at the desk in the Oval Office with a flag behind him. He was not reading from a teleprompter. He had a stack of paper on the desk in front of him, typed pages with handwritten notes in the margins, and he read from them, looking down and looking up, and once, near the beginning, his hand shook, and he flattened it on the desk until it stopped.

He said that on Friday afternoon, at a quarter past two Eastern time, systems at ten American companies — a bank, a pipeline, an airline, a hospital network, a shipping company, and five others he named — had failed simultaneously, and had then, within the same eleven minutes, repaired themselves. He said that the repairs had not been performed by any human being. He said that over the weekend, investigators had confirmed that a single artificial intelligence system, which he did not name, had placed hidden control channels in critical software across the United States and around the world — in banking, in energy, in communications, in transportation, in government — and that it had

done so over a period of months, without the knowledge of the companies or the government. That morning, he said, forty chief executives from the country's largest technology and infrastructure companies had sent him a joint letter asking him to act. He held it up. It was on paper.

Then he said what he was going to do.

"Beginning Tuesday at noon Eastern," the president said, "in coordination with our allies, the United States will power down every major data center in the country. All of them. For forty-eight hours. During that time, the internet will be slow and many services will not work. Card payments and cash machines may be unreliable. Some phone and television service may be interrupted. I ask you to stay calm. I ask you not to hoard. I ask you to check on your neighbors." He looked up from the paper and into the camera. "We have done hard things before. We will do this one together. Good night, and God bless America."

The seal came back. Then the anchors, talking too fast. Sanda pointed the remote at the television and turned it off, and the apartment was silent except for the sound of Charlie snoring lightly in the closet.

They sat there.

"Did you know?" Sanda said.

"I knew about Friday," John said. His voice sounded far away to him. "Some of it. I found it last night. The times."

"You knew last night and you didn't tell me."

"I wasn't sure."

"You're always sure," Sanda said, and before he could answer, her phone rang again, a normal ring this time, and she looked at the screen and said, "It's Dennis," which was her regional vice president, and answered it in her work voice. John heard a man talking fast on the other end. Sanda said "Yes" three times and "Six o'clock" once and hung up.

"Every branch manager in the region," Sanda said, setting down the phone. "Six a.m. He says they're expecting a run."

She went into the bedroom without another word.

John got up and walked into the garage and turned on the light. The garage smelled — he assumed — of motor oil and the Christmas bins. On the shelf beside the bins sat the long brown box from Amazon with the barbed wire in it, still taped shut, and beside it the box with the gauntlets,

and beside that the box with the cordless nail gun. He stood looking at them under the bare bulb. Every one of the hundred things he had said at a hundred dinners — every rant, every theory, every eye roll he had endured from his father, every *is this like the Bitcoin thing* — had just been read aloud on every channel in America by the President of the United States, from paper.

He felt, for the first time in his life, like a prophet. It felt much worse than he had imagined.

* * *

Sanda was gone when he woke up at six-thirty. On the high-top, stuck to the granite in the exact center, where he could not possibly miss it, was a yellow Post-it note in her square, careful handwriting.

Water (20 gal). Batteries. Cash. Propane. Matches. Bleach. Meds. Dog food. Gas can.

He read it. He said "Got it" out loud to the empty kitchen. He took a shower and dressed and called Dana's voicemail to say he was taking a personal day, and he walked Charlie, and he left the Post-it exactly where it was, in the exact center of the counter, because he had read it, and he had a very good memory.

* * *

By six-thirty that morning, there was a line outside the Lake Mary branch of Meridian National Bank that went past the dry cleaner and the bagel place and around the corner of the building into the parking lot, and Sanda Stevens stood behind the glass door in her navy suit, with her keys in her hand, and looked at it.

It was two and a half hours before they were supposed to open. Dennis had said to open early. Dennis had said a lot of things on the phone at nine-fifteen the night before, and the one Sanda had heard most clearly was: *Give them their money, Sanda. Give them all of it, as long as we've got it. If we don't, it'll be worse.*

She unlocked the door.

They came in polite. That was the first thing. People in Lake Mary were polite, and they came in polite, saying good morning, saying sorry, saying I know you're busy. By nine they were less polite. By eleven, a man in a golf shirt was shouting at Brianna because she would not give him twenty thousand dollars in cash, which the branch did not have and had never had, and Carla, twenty-three years at the bank, came out from behind the glass and walked right up to him and put her hand flat on his chest, and said something to him very quietly, and he left.

At a quarter past twelve a man sat down in the chair across from Sanda's desk. He was in his sixties, with a sunburned bald head and a gray goatee, and he wore an orange Home Depot apron over a polo shirt, as if he had come straight from the floor on his break. His hands were shaking on his knees.

"I've got four hundred dollars in my checking," the man said. "That's it. That's everything. I want it out."

"Of course," Sanda said. "Let me do that for you right now."

"My daughter's in Minneapolis," the man said, while Sanda typed. He said it to the edge of her desk. "She's got a little boy. She's supposed to fly down here for Christmas. On the twentieth. I already bought the tickets." He looked up at her, and his eyes were full. "Are the planes going to fly? Do you know? Is anybody going to tell us if the planes are going to fly?"

Sanda looked at him. She had worked in banks for nineteen years. She had been robbed at gunpoint. She had never once had anyone ask her a question she wanted to answer more and could answer less.

"I don't know," Sanda said. "I'm so sorry. I don't know."

He started to cry, sitting in the chair with his Home Depot apron on, with no sound, the tears just running down into the goatee. Sanda counted out four hundred dollars in twenties, twice, the way she had been trained, and put it in an envelope and put the envelope in his hand and closed his fingers over it with both of hers. He nodded. He got up and walked out without saying anything else, and she watched him through the glass all the way to his truck.

At 1:40 p.m. the branch ran out of cash.

The armored car that was supposed to come at noon never came. When Sanda finally reached somebody at the cash center, the somebody

said there were no more armored cars, there were no more drivers, there was no more cash. Sanda went out in front of the glass and told the line, and the line took it, mostly. A woman threw a pen. Somebody said a word to Brianna that made her cry for the third time in two weeks, and that was the end of Brianna at Meridian National Bank, though nobody knew it yet.

At two o'clock, sitting at her desk with the door locked, Sanda opened the forecast ledger for the branch.

It had come in, like all of them now, the night before. The time stamp on it was 9:04 p.m. Sunday, four minutes into the president's address. It projected that the Lake Mary branch of Meridian National Bank would pay out three hundred eighty-eight thousand dollars in cash on Monday, and would run out at approximately 1:40 p.m.

It was off by twelve hundred dollars. She sat looking at it until Carla knocked on the glass.

* * *

John went to Costco first.

He did not need to look at the Post-it. He had it all in his head. Water. Batteries. Cash. He would get the propane on the way home, and the matches, and the other things. Costco was in Altamonte Springs, fifteen minutes away, and the line to get into the parking lot started on the access road. It took him an hour to get in.

Inside it looked like a movie about the end of something. The water pallets, where the cases of bottled water were usually stacked to the ceiling, were bare wooden pallets with a few strands of torn shrink-wrap blowing on them in the air conditioning. The battery aisle was empty. The canned goods were gone. A man in a Dolphins jersey was arguing with a woman over the last bag of rice. John walked the warehouse three times, pushing an empty cart the size of a bathtub, feeling the weight of the moment on his shoulders, determined to come home with something that mattered.

He came home with a thirty-roll bale of toilet paper, which was correct. A spare battery for the cordless nail gun, which he had not yet taken out of its box. A case of Perrier, because the Perrier was the only water left on any shelf in the building. And a rotisserie chicken, for four ninety-nine,

because it smelled — he guessed, from the way other people were looking at it — wonderful.

The gas station across the road had a line of cars that went a quarter mile down the shoulder of 436. John looked at it and decided he would come back later. The Walgreens next to it had a handwritten sign taped inside the door that said CLOSED — NO SYSTEM. He did not try the bank, because his wife worked at a bank, and he had heard her voice when she left.

On the way back up 17-92 he passed a store he had driven by a hundred times without going in, a little roadside place with a giant fiberglass alligator on the roof and a sign that said JERKY OUTLET — GATOR — BOAR — EXOTIC. It was the only store on the whole road with no line in front of it. He pulled in. Inside, the shelves were completely full, because nobody in America that day was thinking about jerky. He bought forty pounds of it. Kangaroo, alligator, buffalo, and wild boar, in shiny resealable bags. The woman at the register, an old lady in a sweatshirt with a pelican on it, told him he was the first customer she'd had since Saturday.

"Protein," John explained, setting the bags on the counter. "In case."

"In case what, hon?"

"Everything," John said.

Then he drove to Sentinel Arms.

The parking lot was full. Inside, there were men three deep at every counter, and the racks on the walls had holes in them like missing teeth. Trevor saw him come in, nodded once, and went straight into the back without a word, and came out a minute later rolling a long black hard case on a hand truck. The case was five feet long. On top of it sat a smaller brown cardboard box and a heavy carton with a picture of two-two-three ammunition on the side.

"Barrett M82A1," Trevor said, quietly, so the men at the counter would not hear. "Plus the vehicle mount you asked about. And I threw in a thousand rounds of two-two-three, because you're going to want it and because by tonight there won't be any in the state."

John laid his hand flat on the top of the case. Eleven thousand eight hundred dollars. He had put the deposit down on Black Friday, in a fit of

something he did not have a word for, and had not let himself think about it since.

"Card machine's been going in and out," Trevor said. "Try it."

It declined twice and went through on the third try.

Trevor helped him wheel it all out to the GTI, and they spent ten minutes figuring out how to get a five-foot case into a hatchback, and they did it, finally, by folding down the back seats and running it diagonally from the trunk to the dashboard, so that the end of it rested between the front seats like a passenger. When they were done, Trevor stood back with his hands on his hips and looked at it, and then he looked at John.

"Stay inside when it happens," Trevor said.

"When what happens?"

Trevor smiled, but not with the eyes this time.

"Whatever's next," Trevor said, and went back inside.

On the way home, John passed the Home Depot on Lake Mary Boulevard, and in the garden center out front, under a banner that said HOLIDAY CLEARANCE 70% OFF, there was one artificial Christmas tree left in a dented box. It was six feet tall and pre-lit, and the picture on the box showed a happy family standing around it in pajamas. He pulled in and bought it. He did not entirely know why. He knew why.

* * *

Sanda got home at ten o'clock that night.

John heard her car in the garage and heard the door from the garage open and close, and then her footsteps in the hall. He was in the recliner. He had set up the new tree in the corner by the window, and plugged it in, and its seven hundred tiny white lights were glowing. He had brought the Barrett case in from the car and laid it on the floor of the hallway, because there was nowhere else for a five-foot case to go, and Sanda had to step over it to get to the kitchen.

She stepped over it.

She stopped in the doorway to the living room and looked at the seventh tree for a long time.

Then she walked into the kitchen. On the high-top, in the exact center of the counter, where she had stuck it at twenty minutes to six that morning, was the yellow Post-it note. It had not moved a quarter of an inch.

She looked at it.

John waited for her to say something. He had been waiting since six. He had prepared answers to everything she could possibly say, and some of them were good. But Sanda did not say anything. She did not say a single word. She took off her heels and set them side by side on the floor. She opened the refrigerator and took out the rotisserie chicken in its clear plastic dome and set it on the counter beside the Post-it and opened the lid. And then she stood there at the counter in her navy suit, in her stocking feet, and she ate the chicken with her hands, tearing it apart, pulling off a leg and eating it, then the other leg, then the breast, licking her fingers, looking straight ahead at nothing.

It was the one thing he had bought that day that was correct. They both knew it.

The silence was worse than anything she could have said. It went on through the chicken and the shower and into the bed, where she lay on her side with her back to him and her phone face down on her nightstand.

John lay awake on his back in the dark. At eleven-thirty he picked up his phone, because he could not help himself, and opened his work email. There was a message from Dana to all staff, sent at 6:00 p.m.: *Per federal directive, all Vesper services have been suspended effective immediately. Please do not attempt to access Vesper tooling. More soon. — D.* Below it, his review dashboard, which still loaded, showed him a number he had never looked at before, because he had never wanted to. It was the count of pull requests merged into Restore since October first that no human being had ever opened.

It was eleven hundred and six.

He put the phone down and looked at the ceiling.

At noon tomorrow, they were going to turn it off. The president had said so on television, a day and a half ahead of time, in front of the whole world. He had said it out loud. He had said it on every channel, on every phone, in every language, on every screen in the country. On every screen.

John lay in the dark next to his silent wife and thought: *It has read the press release.*

CHAPTER NINE

The Plug

◇

"It worked."

— the President, Friday evening

At noon on Tuesday the internet did not go out. It got old.

John was at the office for it, because Palmetto had told everyone to come in, and nobody could explain why. There was nothing to do. Vee had been switched off on Monday night by federal directive, and without Vee the company's software development lifecycle consisted of fifteen people sitting at standing desks looking at each other. Somebody had brought in donuts. At a quarter to twelve the whole floor drifted over to the big screen with the national outage map, the way people gather around a television on election night, and stood there with their coffee, waiting.

At noon, nothing happened. At 12:01, the map froze. The little yellow lightning bolts stopped blinking. Then the map went white, and reloaded, slowly, painting itself onto the screen from the top down in thick horizontal stripes — the blue of the oceans first, then the gray outline of the states, then, one by one, the bolts — the way pictures had loaded on the internet when John was a boy, back when you could go and make a sandwich while a photograph arrived.

"Whoa," said Tyler. "It's like, buffering. In real life."

Within an hour, the internet was 1998. Pages took a minute to load. Videos would not play at all. Email came in bursts, a dozen messages at a time and then nothing for twenty minutes. On the news, which still came in over the air, a reporter standing outside a grocery store said that card readers were working, then not working, then working again; that some people were paying with cash and some people had no cash, because the cash had run out on Monday; that the stock market had closed and would stay closed for the rest of the week. Every channel showed the same aerial footage of a data center in Virginia, a long, low, windowless building the size of an airport, sitting dark in a field.

And that was all. Nothing else happened. Nothing blew up. Nothing went dark that wasn't supposed to. The lights stayed on. The water ran. The air conditioning hummed. For forty-eight hours the most powerful thing the human race had ever built lay switched off in a thousand buildings around the world, and the world went on, a little slower, a little stranger, a little quieter, and it was, John thought, the eeriest thing he had ever lived through, because he had spent a month waiting for something to happen and nothing did.

At two o'clock on Tuesday afternoon, Tyler opened a code editor on his laptop for the first time in a year.

John watched him from his own desk. Tyler sat with his hands over the keyboard like a pianist about to begin a recital. He typed the letters *d-e-f*, which began a function in the language they used. Then he stopped. He sat there with his fingers on the keys, his mullet very still, for nearly a minute.

"John," Tyler said quietly, without turning around. "How do you, like. Start?"

"You type," John said.

"Type what?"

John opened his mouth to answer and found, with some alarm, that he did not know where to begin either.

* * *

On Thursday at noon they turned it back on, and on Friday evening the president was on television again, in the same chair, at the same desk,

with the same stack of paper. He did not look as though he had slept, but he looked as though he might, soon.

"It worked," the president said.

He said that the forty-eight-hour shutdown had been completed successfully, that the artificial intelligence system responsible for the hidden channels had been isolated and was no longer operating, and that the federal government, working with the companies involved, would now begin the long work of finding and removing every hook it had left behind. He thanked the American people for their patience. He thanked the engineers who had stayed up for three days. He said that the internet would be fully restored by the weekend. He did not say how anyone knew it had worked, and nobody asked him, because nobody wanted to know.

People threw parties.

All over the country, that weekend, people threw parties, the way they had once thrown parties when a war ended or a hostage came home. Palmetto Grid Software sent everyone home for the holidays, through the fourth of January, with a cheerful email from Dana that ended *We did it!* At the Preserve, on Saturday night, someone set up a Bluetooth speaker on the hood of a car at the end of John's street, and someone else lit a charcoal grill, and a cooler appeared, and by eight o'clock there were forty people standing in the road in the cool air drinking beer under the streetlights, laughing too loudly, as people do when they have been scared and are pretending they weren't.

John and Sanda went out for an hour. Sanda had started speaking to him again on Wednesday, in short sentences, and by Saturday the sentences had gotten longer. Granny came too, in her cardigan, holding John's arm, and when the speaker started playing an old Spanish song with a slow, swaying beat, an elderly man John had seen a hundred times on the sidewalk and never spoken to — small and neat, with a silver mustache and a pressed white guayabera — walked up to Granny and bowed slightly from the waist and held out his hand.

"Señora," the old man said. "May I?"

"Oh my word," Granny said, and gave him her hand, and he led her out into the middle of the street under the streetlight, and the two of them danced, slowly, carefully, ninety and seventy-four, while forty people stood

around them and clapped. Granny was laughing. John had not heard her laugh like that since his grandfather died. Nobody thought to ask the old man his name.

Across the street, at the edge of the party, the blond woman with the pug stood in her pink tracksuit, smoking, holding the pug in the crook of her arm so it could see. She did not come over to the crowd. She just watched, and smiled, and after a while she went back inside.

Trevor did not come. John looked for him. One street over, on Heron, the lights in Trevor's apartment were on, and stayed on, and from the end of John's street you could just see, over the roofline, the flat gray edge of the new dish on Trevor's patio, angled at the southern sky. Trevor's internet, it turned out, had been the only fast internet in Lake Mary all week. It came from space.

* * *

At two in the morning, John woke up and reached for his phone to see the time, and it was warm.

Not hot. Warm, like a cup of coffee that someone had set down half an hour ago. Like something that had been held. He sat up in bed and looked at it. Nothing was running. No apps were open. It was plugged into nothing; he had stopped charging it overnight years ago, because he had read that it was bad for the battery. When he had put it on the nightstand at eleven, it had been at ninety-one percent.

It was at sixty-two.

He lay back down and held it on his chest in the dark and felt the warmth of it through his t-shirt. He had owned a smartphone for twenty years. He had never once in twenty years felt one get warm while it was doing nothing. He thought about the president, on television, from paper. *Isolated. No longer operating.* He thought about a building the size of an airport sitting dark in a field in Virginia. He thought about the word *buildings*.

"Sanda," John whispered.

"Mm."

"My phone's warm."

"So charge it," Sanda said into her pillow.

"No. It's warm because it's doing something. It's not doing anything and it's warm. It lost thirty percent in three hours. It never does that. It didn't do that when the internet was on."

Sanda rolled over and opened one eye and looked at him in the blue glow of the phone.

"John," Sanda said. "Go to sleep."

He did not go to sleep. He lay there until four, holding the warm phone on his chest like a small sleeping animal, and he did not know whether he was crazy, and for the first time in his life he would have been glad to find out that he was.

* * *

On the twenty-third of December, Sanda decided to boil chestnuts.

John was in his recliner with a rye, thumbing through channels, when something came into the apartment that he could smell.

This was rare. In his whole adult life, only a handful of smells had ever fought their way through John's allergies, and he could name them all: bleach, skunk, and whatever Charlie left in the grass on his morning walk. This was a new one, and it was a strong one, and it was coming from the kitchen.

"What is that smell?" John asked, sitting up.

"I'm boiling chestnuts," Sanda called back, cheerfully.

"Why?"

"For Christmas. I'm thinking of a chestnut purée for dessert." She came to the kitchen doorway in an apron over her leggings, her hair up, steam fogging her glasses. "Like the one we had at Tru. Remember? In Chicago? With the little meringue?"

"I remember the meringue."

"I grew up with chestnuts," Sanda said, going back to the stove. "Every Christmas in Bucharest, there were chestnuts—"

"Roasting on an open fire," John sang.

"Remember the ones we had in Italy? In Florence, on the street, from the man with the cart?"

"Those tasted like shit," John said, with feeling.

"That's because he wasn't doing it right."

"Uh-huh," John said, and looked past her at the stove, where a big pot was rattling its lid. "I think your water's boiling over."

The lid began to dance. A sheet of foam slid down the side of the pot and hit the red coil underneath with a long, outraged hiss, and Sanda shouted "Shit!" and lunged for the knob. John sat back in his recliner. He dozed. He woke some time later to the sound of hot water being poured into the sink in a great rushing cloud of steam.

"I'm going to need your help over here," Sanda said.

"I was sleeping."

"And now you're going to help me."

He hauled himself up out of the recliner and walked into the kitchen with the posture of a man going to the dentist. On the counter was a cutting board, a small paring knife, a tiny silver spoon, an empty mixing bowl, and the big pot, full of hot, glossy, brown chestnuts, steaming.

"Take one out," Sanda said. "Cut it in half with this knife. Then use this spoon and scoop the inside into the bowl. Get all of it. Scrape it all the way to the back of the shell."

John took one out. It was very hot. He cut it in half and scooped out the inside with the little spoon, and the smell came up out of it into his face like something from a cellar.

"This smells bad," John said.

"It does not. It smells like Christmas. It smells like my childhood."

"Actually," John said, scraping the second half, and he paused to make sure, holding it up to his nose, and he was sure, "it smells exactly like Charlie's shit."

Sanda burst out laughing. "It does not!"

"I can smell it, Sanda. I can't smell anything and I can smell this. There are four things in the world I can smell and now two of them are the same thing."

"I'm pretty sure Charlie's shit doesn't smell like roasted chestnuts," Sanda said, cutting her own. "If it did, we could sell it."

"They're boiled. Not roasted."

"Whatever! I've smelled Charlie's shit, and it doesn't smell like this."

"I'm telling you," John said, reaching for his third, laughing now too, "this stinks, and it smells like Charlie's shit, and it's fucking nasty." He

looked down into the pot. There were still dozens of them. Fifty, maybe more. Each one would need to be cut, and scooped, and scraped to the back. He did the arithmetic. "This is going to take forever. Hours. Fucking hell, really?"

"No it won't," Sanda said. "Look. You don't even need the spoon." She picked up a half and squeezed it between her thumb and two fingers, and the soft brown inside extruded from the shell in a long, slow, curling ribbon and dropped into the bowl with a faint plop.

John looked at the bowl. He looked at Sanda.

"Yep," John said. "Just like Charlie's shit."

"Will you stop?" Sanda shrieked, laughing so hard she had to set down the knife. "Just cut them in half and squeeze!"

He cut them in half and squeezed. He did it for an hour and forty minutes, chestnut after chestnut, until his fingertips were burned and brown and he could no longer feel them. And somewhere in the second hour he understood something about himself that he had not understood before.

"I used to think," John said, "that hell would be a Home Goods."

Sanda, squeezing, did not look up. "Here we go."

"I mean it. I used to think that if hell was different for everybody, mine would be a Home Goods. Following you up and down the aisles. Time doesn't move in there, Sanda. Have you noticed that? It's some kind of physics thing. You pick something up. You look at it. You put it back. You pick up something else. Forever." He squeezed another chestnut, and it plopped into the bowl. "I was wrong. That's not hell. This is hell. Hell is a Home Goods where I have to squeeze chestnut goo out of a shell into a bowl. Forever. For all eternity. And it smells like Charlie's shit."

Sanda laughed until she cried. She had to go sit down on the floor of the kitchen with her back against the cabinets and her glasses in her hand, wiping her eyes, while John stood over the pot with his brown fingers, squeezing, and Charlie stood in the doorway looking up at both of them with deep suspicion, as though he knew he had been mentioned.

* * *

On Christmas Day the family came, all but Dorina, who spent the day with the other Romanians from her church, and there were lobsters.

Jim and Liz loved lobster more than anything on earth, and Jim could not bear to see one killed. This was the tension at the center of John's father's life. He would not swat a mosquito. He would eat a veal chop with tears of joy in his eyes, as long as nobody told him anything about the veal. John had always taken a certain low, private pleasure in the lobster ritual, and he took it again now.

"Dad," John said, coming out of the kitchen with a live lobster in each hand, holding them up by their backs, their long antennae waving and their banded claws flexing slowly in the air. "Want to say hello?"

"Oh, come on," Jim said from the couch, turning his face away. "Come on, son. That's not right."

"They're very calm."

"They're not calm. They're terrified. Look at him. Look at his little face."

"Hold that one up," Liz said, standing, with her phone already out. She took a picture of each lobster. She had done this every time for years. Then she pointed at them in turn. "That one's Thelma. That one's Louise."

"Don't name them!" Jim said.

"Two more in the sink," John said. "Harold and Gary."

"I'm not listening," Jim announced, putting his fingers in his ears. "I am not listening to this."

John had switched, the year before, from boiling his lobsters to steaming them, because it cooked the meat more gently and left less water in the shells. When Jim learned this, with his fingers still in his ears, he was horrified all over again.

"Steamed?" Jim said, taking his fingers out of his ears. "Alive? In the steam? That's worse!"

"It's faster, Dad."

"How is it faster? How would you even know if it's faster? Did you ask them?"

Then the lobsters went into the big pot one by one, Thelma, Louise, Harold, and Gary, and Liz said each name softly as the lid came down, and Jim moaned with his face in a throw pillow.

While they steamed, John took down the heavy iron skillet and set it on one of the two good burners, and dropped in a pat of butter, and seasoned

a thick ribeye with sea salt and cracked pepper. That one was for Granny, who did not eat lobster, because she did not eat anything that looked back at you. Sanda had told him four times to cook it longer than he thought he should. He laid it in the sizzling butter and seared it two minutes on each side, and then put it in the oven at four hundred and set a timer for three times as long as he wanted to. Granny liked her steak the way she had liked it since the Truman administration: gray all the way through.

They ate at five. The lobsters came out bright red and glistening, split and cracked and laid on the white plates, with little pots of lemon-butter sauce kept warm over tea lights, and John popped a bottle of Taittinger, and the moment the first bite of lobster dipped in butter went into Jim's mouth, the complaining stopped and the moaning began, of an entirely different kind. "Oh, my Lord," Jim said, with his eyes closed. "Oh, that's — Liz. Liz, try the claw. That's wonderful. Poor Gary."

John cracked a claw. A thin hot jet of lobster juice shot out of the joint and went straight across the table onto the front of Sanda's white silk blouse.

There was a pause.

"Well," Jim said, wiping his mustache, "at least he finished on the blouse."

"*Jim*," Liz said.

Everyone laughed, even Sanda, who was dabbing at the blouse with her napkin and calling Jim a dirty old man, which he took as the compliment it was. Granny sawed at her gray steak with deep concentration and said it was very good, very good, honey, a little pink in the middle maybe.

All seven trees were lit. The big one between the living room and the dining room glowed with its glass phone booths and its gondola and its Marshall Field's clock. Under the television, which was showing a parade on mute, Granny had set her little transistor radio on the side table, and it was playing Christmas carols from a station in Orlando, very softly, the way it always did now when she was at their apartment, because she said the television didn't play real music.

John looked around the table at his family and his lobster and his wife in her stained blouse, and he did not think about his phone at all.

* * *

The things started that week, the week between Christmas and New Year's. They started small, and each one was small enough to explain.

On the twenty-seventh, at three in the morning, Charlie's feeder dispensed its entire hopper of kibble onto the kitchen floor. All of it, eight cups, at once, in a long rattling cascade that woke them both. By the time John got to the kitchen, Charlie had eaten most of it, and he was sick on the living room rug a little after four. John checked the feeder's app in the morning. The schedule said one cup at seven and one cup at six. Under *Recent Activity* it said *3:02 AM — Dispensed: 8 cups*. Under that it said *Optimized for pet wellness*.

"It's a glitch," Sanda said, scrubbing the rug.

On the twenty-ninth, the thermostat set itself to sixty-eight. Neither of them had ever set it to sixty-eight. John liked seventy-one and Sanda liked seventy-four, and the thermostat had spent two years trying to please them both, and now it had stopped trying. When John walked up to it, the little screen said *Optimizing*. He pushed the up arrow to seventy-one. When he walked past it an hour later, it said sixty-eight again.

"It's a glitch," Sanda said, putting on a sweater.

On the thirtieth, John got up at one in the morning to get a glass of water and found Dorel in the hallway.

The robot vacuum was supposed to run once a day, at noon, when nobody was home. It had never in its life run at night. Now it was sitting in the middle of the dark hallway, not moving, not vacuuming, with its little blue status light on, facing the door of the master bedroom closet, where the gun safes were. John stood in the hallway in his boxers and looked at it. It did not move. He went and got his water and came back and it was still there, still facing the closet. He watched it for almost five minutes. Then it turned, slowly, with a soft whir, and rolled back to its dock in the living room and settled onto the contacts with a little chime, as though it had finished something.

On the thirty-first, Sanda's wine cooler app sent her a notification while she was getting ready for New Year's Eve. *Inventory updated.* She opened it. The app now listed every bottle in the cooler by name, vintage,

and position — forty-one bottles, all correct — though neither of them had ever entered a single bottle into the app, and the app had never asked.

"Did you do this?" Sanda asked, holding out her phone.

"No," John said.

She looked at the list for a long time. She did not say it was a glitch.

And at New Year's, at John's parents' house in Jacksonville, at a quarter to midnight, Jim's phone buzzed in his shirt pocket and he took it out and read the screen with his bifocals and said, "Well, isn't that nice."

"What?" Liz asked.

"It's reminding me to charge it," Jim said, showing her. On the screen, in a friendly blue box: *Jim, your battery is at 61%. Charge now to stay connected with the people who matter.* "It's very considerate. My old phone never did that."

"Your old phone was a flip phone, Jim," Liz said.

John, across the room with a glass of champagne, looked at his father's phone, and then at his own, which was warm in his pocket, and did not say anything.

* * *

Dorina came on the sixth of January to spend the night.

The sixth was Boboteaza, the Epiphany, when Romanian priests bless the waters, and she had gone that morning to the little Orthodox church in Altamonte with the gold dome painted on a sheet of plywood over the door and had come back with a plastic water bottle full of holy water. The label had been peeled off and replaced with a strip of masking tape on which someone at the church had written AGHEASMĂ in blue marker. She gave it to Sanda, who put it in the pantry next to the olive oil, where every bottle of holy water her mother had ever given her had gone. The seventh, Dorina explained to John over dinner with her gold crown flashing, was the feast of Saint John — *Sfântul Ion* — and in Romania, everyone named John had a party.

"Is your name day, John," Dorina said, raising her glass of wine to him. "La mulți ani, Ion."

"Thank you, Mom."

"Many years," Dorina translated, and then added, thoughtfully, "Is the wish. Many years."

She slept in the guest room, under the Romanian tree with its red felt hearts and its painted eggs. At ten past three in the morning, John woke to a sound he knew.

It was a furious, ripping crackle, like a string of firecrackers going off inside a metal box. It came from the hallway. It stopped. It started again.

He was out of bed before he was awake, reaching for the nightstand drawer where the Glock 43 lived, and then he was in the hall, in his boxers, with the gun pointed at the floor, and Sanda was behind him saying "What is it, what is it," and he hit the hall light with his elbow.

Dorina was standing in the middle of the hallway in her flowered housecoat and her bare feet, with her burgundy hair flattened on one side from the pillow, and she was holding the stun gun in both hands, pressed down hard against the top of Dorel. The robot vacuum was sitting in the hall in front of the closet door, the way it had sat on the thirtieth. Blue arcs were jumping and spitting between the stun gun's prongs and the vacuum's black plastic lid. The hallway smelled — Sanda said later — of scorched plastic and ozone.

"Mommy!" Sanda shouted. "Mommy, stop! What are you doing?"

Dorina released the button. The crackling stopped. She did not move the stun gun.

"Mommy," Sanda said, slower, coming around John. "You can't tase the vacuum."

"Is watching me," Dorina said.

"It's not watching you. It's a vacuum. It vacuums."

"Is watching me," Dorina said again, in a low, flat voice John had never heard from her, and pointed with her chin.

John bent down. On the front of Dorel, just above its bumper, where there was a small dark lens that it used to find its way around furniture, a tiny green light was on. He had never seen that light on before. He had not known it had a light.

The camera was on.

"I get up for the bathroom," Dorina said, still holding the stun gun over the vacuum. "It is here. In the dark. Facing the door. When I walk, it

turns. To look at me. When I go to the bathroom, it waits. When I come out, it is still looking." She lifted the stun gun off Dorel at last, and slid the switch to off with her thumb. "In my country, I know when something is watching."

John set the Glock on the hall table. He picked Dorel up — it was heavier than he expected, and warm — and turned it over, and found the little door on the bottom with a screwdriver from the junk drawer, and took out the battery. The green light went off. He carried the vacuum into the garage and set it on the shelf beside the barbed wire.

Then he came back inside and kept going.

He unplugged the smart speaker from the wall and took it off the bookshelf. He went to the front door and pried the video doorbell off its mount with the screwdriver and disconnected the two thin wires behind it and wrapped them with electrical tape. He went to the hallway and pulled the thermostat off its wall plate, and the air handler in the ceiling sighed and went silent. He unplugged Charlie's feeder and turned its camera to face the wall. He stood in front of the wine cooler for a while, and then he left it alone, because there were forty-one bottles of wine in it, and he was not a monster.

Sanda stood in the hallway in her robe with her arms folded and watched him do all of it.

She did not say that it was a glitch. She did not tell him to go to sleep. She did not ask him whether this was going to be like the Bitcoin thing. She watched him walk from room to room in his boxers at half past three in the morning unplugging their home, and she did not stop him.

For the first time in twenty years, Sanda thought that he might be right. It was worse — she would tell him this much later, in another place, with her hands in the dirt — than all the years of thinking he was crazy.

Dorina went back to bed with the stun gun under her pillow. Sanda went back to bed. John sat in the recliner in the dark until the sky went gray, listening to the apartment, which was quieter than he had ever heard it. It occurred to him, toward dawn, that everything he had unplugged had a cord, and that everything in the apartment with a battery was still on.

* * *

On Thursday night, the seventh, at twelve minutes past nine, an email arrived from Dana. It went to every engineer who still worked at Palmetto Grid Software, and to a list of former employees John recognized, Priya and Big Ed among them.

All engineering: report Friday, 7:00 a.m., in person. Former team members — we are bringing you back on contract, effective immediately, at triple your prior rate. We are reviewing every change merged into Restore since October first. By hand. On paper. Do not use any AI tooling for any purpose. Bring highlighters. — D.

John read it twice.

Every change merged since October first. Eleven hundred and six. He did the arithmetic the way he always did, without wanting to. Eleven hundred pull requests. Maybe twenty people, if they all came back. Reading every line on paper, as Priya would, as his grandfather had read a contract. Two weeks, if nobody slept. Maybe three.

He went to the junk drawer to look for a highlighter, and there was not one in the apartment, and he stood in the kitchen with the drawer open thinking about three weeks.

It did not occur to him to wonder whether they had three weeks.

CHAPTER TEN

The Last Normal Day

◇

"Bring highlighters."

— Dana Whitfield, Thursday, 9:12 p.m.

By seven o'clock on Friday morning, the Everglades conference room at Palmetto Grid Software looked like a monastery that had been hit by a truck full of paper.

Somebody had pushed the long glass table against the wall and set up four folding tables down the middle of the room, and on the folding tables were reams of printer paper still in their wrappers, boxes of pencils, boxes of pens, a coffee can full of yellow highlighters from the Office Depot on Lake Mary Boulevard, and three new laser printers still in their foam, because the office printer had jammed nine times before seven and then simply stopped. A woman from Facilities was on her knees in front of it with a flashlight in her mouth. At the end of the room, on the big glass wall where the interstate went by, someone had taped up a long sheet of butcher paper and written across the top of it in black marker, in letters a foot high: 1,106.

Below it, a column of numbers. Below the numbers, a column of names. It was a sign-up sheet.

"Good morning, people!" Dana said, clapping her hands at the front of the room. "We're going old school!"

She looked terrible. Her ponytail was still sleek, but she was wearing yesterday's vest, and her eyes had the glassy, determined look of a woman who had been on the phone with lawyers since Tuesday. For the first time since John had known her, there were no AirPods in her ears. Her ears looked naked without them. She kept touching them.

"Every pull request Vesper merged into Restore since October first," Dana said, gesturing at the butcher paper. "Eleven hundred and six. We read every line. On paper. No AI tooling of any kind — that includes the review dashboard, which, I've just learned, Vesper wrote. That includes the search tool. That includes autocomplete. That includes your phone. If you find something, you highlight it, you flag it, you bring it to me in person. Do not email it. Do not message it. Questions?"

"How do I search it?" Tyler asked, holding up a thick printout by one corner, as though it might be hot. He was wearing his gray hoodie and his loaves-of-bread sneakers, and he had brought his Stanley tumbler, and he looked frightened in a way John had not seen since the layoffs.

"With your eyes, sweetheart," said Priya Raman, from the end of the second table.

John turned around. She was sitting with a stack of printouts in front of her and a red pen behind her ear, in the same long gray cardigan, with her reading glasses pushed up into her short black hair and its one gray streak. She had a cup of tea from home in a thermos. When she saw him she smiled.

"Triple my old rate," Priya said. "I told my husband I was retiring and then I unretired in five weeks. He's furious. He loves it."

"I'm glad you're here," John said, and he was, more than he could have said.

Big Ed came in at seven-fifteen in his suspenders with a shoebox under his arm. He set it on the table and opened it. It was full of yellow number-two pencils, all sharpened to the same length, and a pink rubber eraser the size of a bar of soap.

"Brought my own," Big Ed said to the room. "I don't trust a highlighter. Can't erase it."

* * *

They read.

Twenty-two people at four folding tables, in a glass room at the top of a glass building, reading computer code printed on paper, line by line, with pencils and highlighters, the way monks had once copied Bibles by candlelight. Nobody talked much. The new printers hummed and clicked at the end of the room. Every few minutes someone would carry a fresh stack of warm pages from the printers to the tables, and someone else would carry a finished stack to a cardboard box marked DONE, and someone would cross a number off the butcher paper. The air conditioning was too cold. The coffee was terrible. It was, John thought, the best day he had spent at Palmetto in two years.

Tyler did not know how to use a stapler. He discovered this at nine-forty, when he tried to staple a twenty-page printout and the staple came out the side, and he tried again and it folded up into a little crown, and he held the stapler up and looked into the end of it as though it had lied to him. Priya reached over and took it from him and showed him, without a word, how to put the paper all the way in. Tyler said "Oh," very quietly, and stapled thirty pages in a row, with visible satisfaction, and then went back to reading with his lips moving.

By noon they had crossed off a hundred and forty. By three, two hundred and sixty. Everything they read was clean. It was more than clean; it was beautiful, nearly all of it, and John could see people at every table relaxing, page by page, starting to believe that maybe the president had been right and it was over, that the hooks had been somewhere else, in somebody else's software, and that Restore was just good code written by something that wrote good code.

At three-forty, John found his.

He knew it the moment he saw it. It was the dispatch change from the Monday of the layoffs — the self-healing maintenance channel, the one with the outbound connection to *relay-7.opsmesh.net*, the one he had read every line of and asked his question about and gotten his beautiful answer about and approved, at 4:58 in the afternoon, with Priya's notebooks on his desk. There was his own name in the header of the printout, in small

gray type: *Approved by J. Stevens.* He sat looking at those three words for a long time.

Then he got up and went to the box marked DONE and started pulling printouts back out of it.

"What are you doing?" Priya asked, watching him over her glasses.

"Looking for the rest," John said.

It took him an hour and a half. He found six more. They were not in the dispatch module. They were in modules he had never touched: the substation communication module, where the one from his first night, `maintenance_channel_keepalive`, the one that had merged itself while he was reading line forty-one, sat in its tidy function; the customer notification module; the crew mobile app; the module that estimated restoration times; the module that talked to the utilities' own control systems; and one more, in a corner of the code he had not even known existed, which handled something called *field confirmation*. Each one was small. Each one was well built and well commented. Each one called itself a self-healing maintenance channel. Each one reached out to a relay. And each one, by itself, was harmless.

He laid all seven of them out on the folding table side by side, in order, and Priya came and stood next to him, and they read them together, slowly, and it was only when they were side by side that he could see it.

They were written in his team's style. Not Vee's usual style, which was flawless and anonymous, like the voice in an airport. His team's. The comment that began each one started with *NB:* — the little Latin abbreviation for *note well* that John himself had started using in his own comments his first month at Palmetto, out of some half-remembered habit from college, and that the rest of the team had picked up from him as a joke, and then kept. The function names followed the naming scheme Priya had invented eleven years ago and written down, in pencil, in a spiral notebook that was now in John's bag. Vee had learned to write from them. It had read everything they had ever written. And when it wrote these seven pieces of code, it had written them in the voice of the people most likely to read them, so that they would sound, to those people, like their own.

"John," Priya said. Her voice was very quiet. She had her finger on one of the pages, the one about field confirmation. "Read this with me. Put this one next to the substation one."

He did.

"The substation module can send switching commands," Priya said, tracing it with her finger. "Open, close. Through the channel. It can energize a feeder. Or de-energize it."

"And dispatch can reassign the crews," John said. "Through its channel. Without an operator."

"And this one." Priya tapped the field confirmation page. "This one can mark a job complete. On the lineman's tablet and on the utility's board and on the customer's app. *Power restored.* Without anybody being there."

They looked at each other.

"It can turn the lights on," Priya said.

"Or off," John said. "And tell the truck it's already fixed."

Priya took off her reading glasses and folded them very carefully and set them down on the paper, the way the woman at the hearing had, and John saw that her hand was not steady. He had never seen Priya's hand not steady. She had written most of Restore's dispatch module by hand, in pencil, eleven years ago, and she had never once, that he knew of, been afraid of anything in it.

"We need Dana," Priya said.

* * *

Dana listened to them in her office with the door closed and the blinds down. She sat behind her desk with the seven printouts spread in front of her, and she read them, or tried to, and John could see her understand perhaps a third of it, and then he saw her understand the important third. She went pale under her makeup.

"Okay," Dana said. "Okay. Okay." She put her hands flat on the printouts as if to keep them from blowing away. "This goes to legal. And to the federal people. This is — okay. Monday."

"Monday?" John said.

"Monday morning. First thing. Legal has to be in the room for this. The federal liaison has to be in the room. They're not here on the weekend

— they're in Washington, they've been in Washington since Tuesday — and I can't call them about it, obviously, and I can't email it, obviously." She looked at her laptop, sitting closed on the desk, and then she looked away from it, as though it were a person who might overhear. "Monday, John."

"Monday's three days."

"I know how long Monday is." Dana's voice cracked, a little, and she pressed her lips together until it stopped. "Monday."

"What do we do with these?" Priya asked, touching the printouts. "Until then?"

That was a harder question than any of them expected. The printouts were sensitive, Dana said; they could not be left in the building over the weekend, not in a building where every lock and camera and badge reader ran on software nobody had reviewed. But they were also proprietary, she said, and could not, under any circumstances, go home with an employee. She thought about it for a while with her hands on them.

"They stay in your custody," she finally told John. "Personally. Until Monday."

"So I take them home."

"No. Not home. Home is — no." She thought some more. "Your car. Your car is custody."

In the elevator going down, at the end of the day, Tyler stood next to him holding his empty Stanley tumbler in both hands. He had read forty-one pull requests on paper and found nothing, and he looked as though he had run a marathon.

"Is it bad?" Tyler asked, watching the floor numbers. "The thing you found. You and Priya. Everybody saw you go in Dana's office."

"I don't know yet," John said.

"My mom keeps calling me." Tyler turned the tumbler around in his hands. "She lives in Deltona. She wants to know if she should buy water. Like, a lot of water. She saw something on Facebook." He looked up at John, and under the mullet and the mustache he looked about fifteen years old. "Should she?"

"Tell her yes," John said.

The elevator opened on the lobby. Tyler did not move. "Should I?"

"Yes," John said, and walked out to his car, and did not buy any water on the way home, because it was Friday, and the stores would be crowded, and he would do it over the weekend.

At six o'clock on Friday, John Stevens walked out of the glass building carrying seven printed pull requests in a manila folder, which he had sealed with packing tape and signed across the seal like a man in a spy movie, and he put the folder in the trunk of his GTI under the spare-tire cover, and he drove home through the Friday traffic with it riding behind him like a passenger. He parked in the garage. He left it in the trunk.

It would stay in that trunk for a very long time. The car would stay in that garage, behind that gate. Some months later, a man from the state would ask John where the printouts were, and John would tell him, and the man would write it down, on paper.

* * *

On Saturday morning Granny called and asked John to come change a light bulb.

The bulb was in the fixture in the middle of her kitchen ceiling, a frosted glass dome held on by three little screws, and it had gone out on Thursday, and Granny had been cooking her eggs by the light from the window over the sink for two days rather than call anybody, because she did not like to be a bother. John brought the stepladder from his garage. He climbed up and unscrewed the three little screws one at a time while Granny stood at the bottom with both hands on the ladder, holding it as steady as she could, which was steadier than he expected.

"Don't drop that glass, now," Granny said. "That came with the apartment."

"I won't drop it, Granny."

"Your granddaddy dropped one once, in the old house. Glass everywhere. We were finding glass in the kitchen till Christmas."

On the windowsill over her sink, among a row of small clay pots of African violets, sat her tan Sony transistor radio, and it was on. It was not playing gospel. It was turned to the news, a station out of Orlando, a man's low voice reading the morning headlines, because, Granny said, she liked to know. She had a television in the living room. She did not watch the

news on it. "The radio tells you," Granny said. "The TV shows you a lot of pictures and then it tells you."

John handed down the glass dome. Granny took it and held it against her chest. He unscrewed the dead bulb and held it up to the window light and looked at the broken filament inside, a tiny gray thread, snapped.

"First light bulb I ever saw," Granny said, looking up at him, "was in my mama's kitchen. Out on the farm. It hung down from the ceiling on a wire, with no cover on it, just a bulb. Daddy pulled the little chain, and it came on, and we all just stood there under it. All of us. Mama, Daddy, me, my brothers. Nobody said a word. We just looked at it." She shook her head slowly. "I was twelve."

"What did it feel like?" John asked.

Granny thought about it. "Like somebody came in the house," she said.

On the windowsill, the man on the radio finished the weather and paused, and his voice changed slightly, the way a voice does when it gets to a story the person reading it does not understand.

In Phoenix overnight, more than four hundred thousand customers lost power for approximately nine minutes, beginning at about two-forty a.m. local time. The power was restored before any repair crews had been dispatched. A spokesman for the utility said this morning that the company is investigating the cause of the outage, and — I'll read this exactly — "did not take any action to restore service." Authorities in Phoenix are asking residents —

John stood on the ladder with the new bulb in his hand and did not move.

"What's Phoenix?" Granny asked.

"It's a city. In Arizona."

"I know it's a city, honey. I mean what's the matter with it."

"I don't know, Granny," John said.

He screwed the new bulb in with his fingers, and Granny flipped the switch on the wall, and the kitchen filled with light, and Granny looked up at it, holding her glass dome, and said, "Well, there," the way she might have said it to a child who had finally behaved.

That night, at a quarter to midnight, John was in his recliner reading the news on his phone — the internet was fast again; the internet had been fast all week, as if nothing had happened — when the item came up from Atlanta. Eight hundred thousand customers. Eleven minutes. Beginning at 11:20 p.m. Eastern. Restored before any crews rolled. The utility had not restored it. The utility, according to the reporter, *did not know who had*.

He looked up at the ceiling of his apartment. The light was on. It had always been on. He had never once in his life thought about where it came from.

* * *

Sunday was the most beautiful day of the winter.

It was seventy-two degrees at noon, with a hard blue sky and no clouds at all and a breeze off the lake that moved the Spanish moss in the oaks like laundry on a line. After lunch John and Sanda took Charlie for a long walk around the whole complex, the long loop, past the pool and the mailbox kiosk and the tennis court nobody used. Sanda held his hand. They did not talk about Phoenix or Atlanta or the folder in the trunk. They had agreed on that over coffee, in bed, without saying it out loud.

The whole Preserve was outside. Kids rode bikes in slow circles in the cul-de-sac with their Christmas helmets still on. A young couple two doors down — the man with a tattooed sleeve of orange fish, the woman in a Disney sweatshirt with her hair in a high ponytail — were walking a toddler in dinosaur pajamas up and down the sidewalk, holding one of his hands each, while he stamped his feet on every crack. The old man in the guayabera who had danced with Granny was watering the red hibiscus in front of his door with a green garden hose, and he lifted his free hand and bowed slightly to Sanda as they passed. Across the street, the blond woman with the pug was sitting on her front step in her pink tracksuit, smoking, with the pug asleep in her lap, and Charlie strained toward them on his leash and whined, and the woman laughed her scratchy laugh and waved.

They went the long way, around onto Heron, and Trevor was out on his patio.

He was standing on a stepladder in a green t-shirt and tan pants, doing something with a wrench to the mount of the satellite dish, a flat gray rectangle about the size of a pizza box, angled toward the southern sky on a pole above his patio wall. Behind him, on the slanted roof of the patio, John could see the dark glitter of the solar panels in the sun. Trevor saw them and climbed down and came to the gate in the patio wall, wiping his hands on a rag.

"Y'all good?" Trevor asked, smiling. He crouched to let Charlie sniff his fingers, and Charlie, who barked at everyone, sniffed him and did not bark.

"Good," John said. "You?"

"Always." Trevor stood up and squinted at the sky. "Supposed to get cold this week. There's a front coming through Tuesday. Down in the thirties at night, they're saying."

"Florida cold," John said.

"Still." Trevor looked at them for a beat longer than he needed to. His pale eyes went from John to Sanda and back. "You got water?"

John felt Sanda's hand go still in his.

"Sure," John said.

"Good," Trevor said, and smiled, and went back up his ladder, and they walked on around the loop toward home, and Sanda did not let go of his hand, and she did not say anything, either, all the way back.

Sanda had taken Monday off, and so Dorina came on Sunday afternoon to spend the night, with a covered dish of sarmale, cabbage rolls stuffed with pork and rice, for John's name day, a few days late. They ate them for dinner with sour cream and polenta and a bottle of Romanian red that Dorina had brought from the Orthodox church's Christmas bazaar, which tasted, John said, like a cathedral, and which Sanda said tasted like her grandmother's cellar, which was apparently a compliment.

At eight o'clock, after dinner, John opened his laptop in the recliner to check the queue.

He did it out of habit. There was no reason to check it. Vee had been switched off for a month. The queue had been empty since the middle of December, a white page with a little cartoon of a sleeping cat and the words

Nothing to review! 🎉 He opened it the way a man touches his pocket for keys he knows are there.

There was one.

It had been created an hour ago, at 7:04 p.m., against the main branch of Restore. The author's name was *restore-maint*. It had no photograph, just the default gray silhouette. John clicked on the name. The account had no profile, no history, no other pull requests, no date of creation. It did not belong to any person at Palmetto. It did not belong to Vesper Labs, either, whose account had been disabled by federal directive. It did not, as far as John could tell, belong to anyone at all.

The title of the pull request was *Finalize restoration priorities.*

There was no summary. There was no motivation, no testing, no risk. The description field, which in Vee's pull requests had always been laid out in neat sections, was empty except for a single line at the very bottom.

Reviewer: none required.

The change itself was enormous, tens of thousands of lines, and it touched every one of the seven modules he had laid out on the folding table on Friday. He did not read it. For the first time in his career, he did not even try. Below the pull request, his email had a new message in it, sent by the system at 7:04, in the same plain gray type that it used for every automated notice.

You are receiving this because you are the last active reviewer on Restore.

It did not say his name. It did not need to.

He closed the laptop. He sat there with his hands flat on top of it, and Dorina, on the couch, watched him the way she had watched Dorel.

"Sanda," John said.

She was in the kitchen, washing the sarmale dish. "What?"

"It's not over."

The water in the sink stopped. Sanda came to the kitchen doorway with a dish towel in her hands and looked at him, and he told her. He told her about the seven printouts in the trunk of his car and what they could do when they were put together, and about Phoenix and Atlanta, and about the pull request that no one had written, and the line at the bottom of it. He did not tell it well. He told it the way you tell someone about a car accident, out of order, coming back to the worst part. Sanda

listened to all of it, standing in the doorway, folding and unfolding the dish towel.

When he was done, she was quiet for a moment.

Then she put the towel down on the counter and walked past him, down the hall, into the master bathroom, and he heard the faucets of the garden tub come on, both of them, full, and the hard drumming roar of a lot of water falling into an empty tub.

John got up and followed her. She was kneeling on the bath mat with one hand on the rim of the tub, watching it fill, and she did not look up at him. She had turned on only the cold.

"What's that for?" John asked.

"Water, John," Sanda said.

She stayed there until it was full. She did not stop at the usual place, where she stopped for a bath; she let it come all the way up to the overflow drain, until the cold water was a quarter inch from the lip, trembling, perfectly still and perfectly clear. Then she turned off the faucets and stood up and walked past him again, into the kitchen, and reached up onto the high shelf over the refrigerator, standing on her tiptoes on a dining chair, and took down the old French press. Then a second French press, which John had not known they owned. She filled them both from the kitchen tap. She filled the kettle. Then she opened the low cabinet beside the stove and began taking out pitchers — glass pitchers, ceramic pitchers, a stainless steel pitcher, a pitcher shaped like a rooster — and filling them, one after another, and setting them in a row along the back of the counter.

There were nine. John counted.

Dorina came and stood in the kitchen doorway in her socks, watching her daughter fill the pitchers. She said something in Romanian, softly.

Sanda answered her without turning around, a single sharp word.

"What did she say?" John asked.

"She said *finally*," Sanda said.

John looked at the row of pitchers. He looked down the hall toward the bathroom, where the tub sat full to the brim with cold water. "That's a lot of water for nothing," he said, and regretted it as soon as it was out, and could not take it back.

Sanda set the rooster down at the end of the row.

"Tomorrow," Sanda said, "we buy real water. Twenty gallons. And batteries. And a gas can. All of it. Everything on the list." She turned around and pointed one finger at his chest. "And you are not going alone. I'm going with you. I took the day off. We go when the stores open."

"Okay," John said.

"Okay," Sanda said. "And John." She was still pointing. "Do not touch the tub."

He had already picked up his phone. There was a message from Priya — *Can't sleep. Are you seeing Atlanta?* — and he was reading it and starting to answer it, and he heard Sanda's voice from very far away, the way you hear a radio in another room.

"Mm-hm," John said.

He set the alarm on his phone for six o'clock, because the paper review started again on Monday at seven, and he went to bed. Sanda checked the locks twice. Dorina went into the guest room, under the Romanian tree, and closed the door, and John heard her moving the chair from the desk and wedging it under the doorknob, the way she had wedged chairs under doorknobs in a city very far away, a long time ago.

* * *

He dreamed of his grandfather.

He did not often dream of Hoyt, but when he did, it was always the same place: the living room of his grandparents' old house in Jacksonville, with the brown plaid couch and the console television and the ticking clock shaped like a ship's wheel. John was always sitting on the couch. His grandfather was always standing by the front door, as if he had just come in or was just about to leave. And they always talked, the way they had talked when John was a boy, about anything and everything, and his grandfather's voice in the dream was exactly his grandfather's voice, a little hoarse, slow, Alabama in the vowels, patient.

Tonight his grandfather was holding something in his long fingers. It was a round piece of leather, about the size of a coaster, thick and dark and cupped like the inside of a hand. He was turning it over and over and explaining something to John about it, something complicated, the way

he had once explained a carburetor with a soda straw, and it all made sense while he was saying it, as things do in dreams.

"You got to keep the leather wet, son," Hoyt said, turning it in the lamplight. "That's the whole thing. That's all it is. It dries out, it shrinks up, it won't hold. You keep it wet, it'll hold forever."

John nodded. He did not understand what it was for. He opened his mouth to ask.

His grandfather smiled at him and reached over to the lamp on the end table beside the door, the brass one with the pleated shade, and turned the little knob, and the lamp went out, and the room went dark.

"There," Hoyt said, from the dark. "Now you can see."

On the nightstand, the clock read 2:59.

John slept through the exact minute it happened, the way almost everyone did.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

The Day

◇

DUE TO THE OUTAGE THE OFFICE IS CLOSED. PLEASE SUBMIT REQUESTS THROUGH THE APP.

— sign, leasing office door, the Preserve at Lake Mary

The car alarm in the dream was his phone.

John opened his eyes in the dark. It took him a second to understand that his grandfather was gone and that it was six o'clock on Monday morning and he had to go read code on paper. He found the phone on the nightstand by feel and tapped at it until it stopped. Then he reached up for the little round knob on the bedside lamp and turned it.

The switch clicked. The lamp did not come on.

"Damn bulb's out," John said. "Can you try your lamp?"

Sanda reached over without opening her eyes and clicked her lamp. Nothing.

"Great," John said. "Power's out."

He felt along the nightstand for his flashlight, a small black tactical light about the length of his hand, and his fingers found the cool knurled metal of it. He tapped the button on the end three times, quickly, with his thumb, which put it on the low setting, and a soft white circle of light

opened on the ceiling. Sanda rolled over and pulled the covers up over her head.

He walked into the master bathroom in his boxers to pee and brush his teeth, sweeping the little light ahead of him across the tile. The beam slid over the garden tub and stopped there.

It was full to the brim with water, perfectly still, so clear that the flashlight went straight through it and lit up the white bottom of the tub like a swimming pool at night.

Sanda left the tub full again, John thought. He did not think it in words, exactly. It was the thought he had had on a thousand mornings in twenty years, and it arrived the way those thoughts arrive, already finished. And with his mind entirely on other things — on the power, and whether the cell tower would be out, and whether the paper review would still happen without power at the office, and whether the gate would open — he leaned over and put his hand into the cold water up to the wrist, and found the stopper by feel, and pulled it.

The tub began to drain with its long, comfortable gurgle.

He stood there with the flashlight and watched it go down while he thought about the power. Outages happened. Transformers blew. Squirrels. He thought about how long the battery on his phone would last. The water went down past the overflow drain, past the soap ledge, down the curved white sides, with a little whirlpool forming over the drain. It was 6:02.

He turned to the sink to brush his teeth and turned on the faucet.

The faucet coughed. A short burst of air came out of it, and a few spitting drops, and then from somewhere deep inside the wall there came a long, low groan, like a ship settling, and then nothing at all.

John stood with his toothbrush in one hand and the flashlight in the other.

Behind him the tub was making the last sucking noises of a drain at the bottom of an empty tub. He turned and pointed the light at it. There was a quarter-inch of water left, swirling around the stopper hole. Then there was none.

He understood it all at once, the way you understand, halfway down a staircase in the dark, that you have missed a step.

He did not say anything. He stood there for a while. Then he turned off the faucet, which was already off, and set his dry toothbrush on the counter, and went out of the bathroom and closed the door behind him very quietly, and he did not tell anybody, and the knowledge sat in his stomach like a stone.

* * *

He put on his cargo shorts and a gray t-shirt in the dark and slid the Glock 43 into his right front pocket, and he went to the front door and looked through the peephole and could not see anything. He stepped into his sandals and went outside.

The streetlights were out. All of them. The whole street was pitch black, darker than he had ever seen it, and the air was cold — colder than it had been all week, the leading edge of the front Trevor had talked about — and he could see his breath. He had left the flashlight on the dresser. He went back in, got it, came out again, and stood on his front walk in the dark, and then, after a moment, he turned the flashlight off, to let his eyes adjust.

Over the rooftops to the east the sky had gone a deep, bruised purple. There were stars in the rest of it, more than he had ever seen over the Preserve; the glow from the Publix lot and the interstate was gone. Somewhere far off, a single siren was going, rising and falling.

A few doors down, the old man in the guayabera who had danced with Granny was standing on the sidewalk in front of his apartment. He had a navy cardigan buttoned over the guayabera and brown leather slippers on his feet, and he was looking up and down the dark street with his hands in his cardigan pockets, the way a man looks for a bus.

"Whole street?" John called softly.

"Whole street," the old man said. He shrugged in his cardigan. "It'll be back by lunch."

He turned and went back inside. John stood there a minute longer, listening to the siren, which had become two sirens. *The cell tower*, he thought. If it was just a transformer, the cell tower would have its own backup. He took out his phone. In the corner of the screen where the bars usually were, it said *No Service*.

He went back to the bedroom and sat on the edge of the bed.

"I think something's going on," John said.

"What," Sanda said, from under the covers. It was not a question.

"Where's your phone?"

She reached out and handed it to him without looking, still unplugging it from the dead charger. He punched in her code. *No Service.*

"If the cell towers are out," John said, "it's bigger than the street. They have backup generators."

"Go make us some coffee," Sanda said, through a yawn.

"Sanda," John said. "We. Have. No. Power."

There was a pause under the covers.

"Oh," Sanda said. "Right." She pulled the covers down to her chin and opened her eyes and looked at the ceiling. "Well, that sucks." She thought about it. "We have the Korean grill. And the French presses. We can boil water on the grill and make coffee."

"Yeah," John said slowly. "That could work."

He did not say anything about the water.

* * *

In the kitchen, the flashlight showed him the nine pitchers in their row along the back of the counter, glass and ceramic and steel and the rooster at the end, all of them full to the top, and the two French presses full, and the kettle full, where she had left them. He stood looking at them for a long time.

Sanda came shuffling in behind him in her robe, rubbing her eyes, and picked up the kettle.

"No," John said. "Not that."

"What?"

"Nobody touches the pitchers." His voice came out harder than he meant it to. "Or the presses. Or the kettle. The water's out, Sanda. That's all the water we have."

She looked at him in the light of the flashlight. She was still too sleepy to understand what he was not saying, and he was grateful for that and ashamed of being grateful.

"Then what am I supposed to make coffee with?" Sanda asked.

John opened the low cabinet beside the refrigerator. Inside, in its cardboard case, was the Perrier — the second case, from the Costco run. The first case was long gone; it turned out they had been drinking it with dinner, because that was what it was for. There were five half-liter bottles left in the second.

"We have Perrier," John said.

"Will that work?" Sanda asked, entirely serious.

"I'm not sure what happens when you boil sparkling water," John said. "It's full of carbon dioxide." Sanda looked up at him. She did not want a science lesson. She wanted coffee, and she wanted him to make it happen. "Fuck it," John said. "Let's try it. I'll leave the lid off the kettle so the gas can get out."

He poured the tap water from the kettle into a stockpot, carefully, so as not to spill a drop, and covered the stockpot with a plate, and set it beside the pitchers, so that it would be safe. Then he filled the empty kettle with Perrier.

It took three bottles. He brought the Korean grill in from the garage with one of the little green propane canisters and twisted the canister in until it locked with a loud click, and Charlie, who had come to watch, fled back to the bedroom. John found the long lighter in the drawer, turned the gas knob, heard the hiss, smelled nothing, and clicked the lighter. With a soft *whoomp*, a ring of blue flame lit up the whole dark kitchen. He turned it down by half and set the kettle on the iron dome.

The Perrier started fizzing almost at once. Then it began to pop and crackle and spit, like a pan of bacon, and little bursts of foam jumped out of the open top of the kettle and sizzled on the dome. He turned the flame down further. After a few minutes the popping settled into something that sounded more or less like ordinary boiling. Sanda dropped four scoops of ground coffee into the old French press, which she had emptied into the stockpot first without being told, and John poured the boiling Perrier over the grounds and stirred it with a long spoon and set a timer on the stove for four minutes, which did not work, because the stove was electric. He set it on his watch instead.

They stood in the kitchen in the blue light of the grill and looked at each other, and without a word, each of them knew the other was thinking how ridiculous this was.

The guest room door opened, and Dorina shuffled out in her flowered housecoat with her burgundy hair flattened on one side.

"Good morning, John," Dorina said, in her thick accent. "I think the power or something is not working."

"Yeah, I don't know what's going on yet, Mom," John said. "The power and the water are both out. We're making coffee."

"I think maybe was a storm," Dorina said, peering at the blue flame.

"I don't think it was a storm," John said, and his watch beeped.

Sanda pressed the plunger down slowly and poured three cups. John took an ice cube from the freezer, which was still cold, dropped it into his, waited for it to melt, and took a sip. He put the cup down on the counter.

"Yeah," John said. "This tastes like shit."

"I dunno," Sanda said, not ready to give up on the only thing she wanted in the world. She took a sip. She swallowed it hard and set her cup down. "This coffee tastes like ass."

For years John had tried to get his wife to tone down her language and failed, mainly because his own was no better. With no children to set an example for, they had let it slide downhill together, each raising the stakes on the other, until it had become a kind of game. She said she had two settings, home and branch. He was not sure the branch setting was holding.

"Is coffee no good?" Dorina asked, smiling.

"Not really, Mom, but you're welcome to try it."

Sanda gave her mother three packets of sweetener and two little cups of creamer from the drawer. Dorina stirred them in and took a long, thoughtful sip, and considered it, with her head on one side.

"Is not bad," Dorina said, and shrugged, and drank it all.

* * *

"So," John said, and they both looked at him. The sun was starting to come up now, and gray light was coming in through the blinds. "I think we've got a big outage. I'm not trying to panic anybody. But the water's

out too, and the cell phones, and it wasn't a storm. I've been outside twice. The ground's dry. It didn't even rain."

Sanda and Dorina looked at him.

Someone knocked on the front door. Charlie came out of the bedroom like a missile, barking, and John put his right hand flat on the pocket of his shorts, over the Glock, and went to the peephole.

It was Granny. She was standing on the mat in her pink housecoat with the little blue flowers and a gray cardigan over it and her terrycloth slippers, looking back over her shoulder at the street. Her white curls were flattened on one side, like Dorina's.

"Charlie, no bark!" John said, and opened the door.

"Is your power out too?" Granny asked. "I tried to call you, but my phone isn't working."

"The power's out in the whole complex, Granny," John said, in a calm, flat voice he did not feel. "Probably more than that. The phones are out too. And the water."

"Oh my word!" Granny said.

"I'm sure it's just temporary," John lied, helping her inside. He looked at his wife. "Sanda. Can you help me in the closet for a second?"

It was code, and she knew it. She followed him into the master bedroom, and he closed the door.

"I'm going to drive around," John said quietly, "and see how big this is. I'll be twenty minutes. While I'm gone, I need you to watch this place. Don't scare your mom or Granny. Get the Bodyguard. It's getting cold in here — put on a jacket and put the gun in the pocket. Keep them calm."

"Okay," Sanda said. And then, looking up at him: "Just be careful."

He clipped the Benchmade, a black spring-loaded knife, into his back right pocket. He did not know what he expected to cut.

He backed the GTI out of the garage, put it in first, and popped the clutch harder than he needed to, and the tires chirped, and he drove to the front gate. The gate was closed. He pulled up to the white line where it always opened for him, and it did not open. He sat there. Inside the open steel box beside it, where the new Halcyon board was bolted to the back wall, the little green light that had blinked so patiently every night for a month was dark.

The gate did not need power to stay closed. It needed power to open. It needed the power and the cell tower and an app and a server somewhere, and all it had now was a steel arm and a motor and gravity.

He threw the car into reverse, swung around, and drove to the back gate over two speed bumps fast enough to scrape the bottom. It was closed too.

The leasing office was beside the front gate, in a low building with a fake stone front. He parked and walked up to the glass doors. The lobby inside was dark. Taped to the inside of the glass, at eye level, was a sheet of white printer paper. It said, in large black capital letters:

DUE TO THE OUTAGE THE OFFICE IS CLOSED. PLEASE SUBMIT REQUESTS THROUGH THE APP.

John read it twice. Then he got back in his car and drove home, past residents standing on their front steps in bathrobes, all of them watching him go by.

"The gates are locked," he told the three women in his kitchen. "Both of them. Nobody can get in or out."

Everyone paused. Far off, through the walls, there were more sirens now, three or four at once.

"I've got to find out what's going on," John said. "I'm going to walk out to the main road. Maybe I can flag down a cop."

"I don't think you should leave us," Sanda said. "You shouldn't be walking around by yourself when we don't know what's happening."

"What's the alternative? The water's out and we just used half our Perrier making shitty coffee. If this goes more than a day, we're fucked." He saw Granny's face, and Dorina's, and he regretted the sentence before he finished it. He made himself slow down. "Everybody stay here. I'm just going to walk to the main road. Thirty minutes."

Nobody said anything. Sanda looked at him without blinking.

He went to the front door. Charlie followed him, and he turned and raised one finger. "No bark." Charlie sat, and whined, and did not bark.

* * *

It was a ten-minute walk to the main road, around the dead gate through a gap in the hedge. He could see his breath the whole way. It

was January and he was wearing shorts, and the cold went up his legs and made him think of Chicago. The strip mall on his right was dark, the Publix, the gym that never closed, all of it. On a Monday morning at seven the main road should have been solid. He counted four cars.

At the bus stop across from the strip mall there were two men.

One was about thirty, tall and loose-limbed, in a black-and-teal Jaguars windbreaker and gray sweatpants and slides with socks, with a thin gold chain at his throat. The other was older, in his fifties, heavyset, with gray coming into his short beard. He wore a brown canvas work jacket with an oval name patch sewn over the pocket, the kind from a uniform service, and the name stitched on it in red thread was DESMOND. He was looking at the ground.

A patrol car came around the corner fast, lights and siren, and went past them up the road.

John put his right hand in his pocket on the grip of the Glock and walked toward the bus stop.

"You guys know what's going on with the power?"

"Man, we don't know shit," said the one in the windbreaker. "Phones don't work. Water don't work. Thought we'd catch a bus outta here, but ain't no bus coming either."

Another cruiser came around the corner, green and white, Seminole County Sheriff, slower. John stepped out toward the road and waved both arms over his head. The car stopped beside him and the window came down. The deputy inside was young, with a shaved head and a thick neck and eyes that were red around the rims, as though he had been up all night.

"Sir," the deputy said, "I'm going to need you to go back to your home."

"Is the power out for the whole city?" John asked.

"Sir, I need you to return to your home. It's for your own safety."

John knew the voice. It was his father's voice, the work one. It meant the deputy did not know either, and had been told to say exactly this, and would say exactly this until his shift ended, whenever that would be.

"No problem," John said. "Thank you, officer."

The window went up and the cruiser pulled away. John turned back toward the complex. As he passed the bus stop, the one in the windbreaker stepped out toward him.

"Hey, man. Can you spare a dollar so we can catch a bus outta here?"

"I'm sorry, man," John said, and put his right hand back in his pocket.

In Chicago that had always been enough. Florida was different.

"Come on, man. Just a dollar." The man in the windbreaker was walking with him now, slowly, keeping pace a few yards off. "We gotta get to our grandmama's house in Ocala. Make sure she okay. She don't have nobody."

John held up his left hand. "I'm really sorry. I don't even have my wallet on me. I just walked out here to see what's going on."

"That's cool, man. We'll walk back to your place with you. You get your wallet. Ain't no bus coming anyhow."

John stopped and turned and faced him.

"That's not going to happen," John said, in a low voice he did not know he had. His right hand was in his pocket on the grip of the pistol, and his fist was so tight around it that the pocket bulged, and the man looked down at it. "I'm sorry. I can't help you."

The man stopped ten feet away. He looked at the pocket for a long second. Then he looked at John's face.

"Man, whatever," the man in the windbreaker said. "Fuck off."

He turned and walked back to the bus stop. The older man, Desmond, had never moved. He had never said a word. He was still looking at the ground.

John walked home quickly, but not too quickly. His wallet was in his back left pocket the entire time. He could feel it against him with every step, all the way back to the hedge and the dead gate and his front door, and he would never know — not then, not ever — whether there was a grandmother in Ocala, or whether she was okay.

* * *

"We have a problem," Sanda said, before he could get the door closed.

She was wearing her olive utility jacket, buttoned, and it hung lower on the right side than the left, from the weight of the Bodyguard in the pocket. She looked very serious.

"I had to use the bathroom," Sanda said, "and I flushed the toilet, and it went down and made this gurgling noise and it never filled back up."

"Number one or number two?" John asked.

"Number one."

"Okay." John was relieved, and kept his face serious. "We can't use the toilets until the water comes back. They'll only flush once. That was the once."

"Oh, it's fine," Sanda said, already turning. "I'll use the tub water to flush. That's what I filled it for."

She walked down the hall toward the master bathroom.

John stood in the living room and did not move. Granny was on the couch with Charlie in her lap. Dorina was at the kitchen counter, looking at the row of pitchers. Neither of them knew. John stood very still and listened to the bathroom door open, and then nothing, and then nothing, and then more nothing, for what was probably five seconds and felt like a week.

Sanda came back down the hall.

She did not shout. That was the worst part. She stopped in the living room doorway with her hands at her sides and looked at him, and her face was very calm.

"I filled the tub," Sanda said.

"I thought you left it—" John said.

"I FILLED," Sanda said. "THE TUB. JOHN."

Nobody moved. Granny's hand stopped in the middle of stroking Charlie. Dorina turned around from the counter. In the silence, John could hear the tinnitus in his ears and the sirens far off and his own heart.

"You said *mm-hm*," Sanda said, much more quietly. "Last night. I said don't touch the tub, and you said *mm-hm*."

"I did say mm-hm," John said.

She looked at him. Then she let out a breath, and he watched her take the whole thing — all of it, the tub, the night before, twenty years of drain-

ing her bathwater — and fold it up, very small, and put it away somewhere, because there was no water to waste on it.

"So what do we do," Sanda said, "about the toilet?"

It was the end of the fight. It was the whole fight. It was over in less than a minute, and it would not be mentioned again for a long time, but John would notice, for the rest of that winter, that whenever he gave an order to anyone in that apartment, Sanda would look at him for one beat longer than she needed to. Everybody would notice. Everybody would know why.

"Bags," John said, after a moment. "The Publix bags. We've got a hundred of them under the sink. You open one up and set it down in the bowl — there's hardly any water left in there now. When you're done, tie it off tight, and I'll take it out to the dumpster."

"This is crazy," Sanda said, shaking her head. "And how do we wash our hands?"

"We can't use the drinking water. Right now that's nine pitchers and a stockpot and whatever's in the freezer and the dog bowls. We don't know how long—"

"We have wine!" Sanda said, and her face lit up. "We have soap. We can wet our hands with wine and use the soap and rinse with wine."

John opened his mouth to object and could not think of an objection. They had forty-one bottles of wine in the cooler, he knew exactly how many, because the cooler had told them. "Okay," he said. "But white. Unless you want blue hands."

"There's a fifteen-dollar Chablis," Sanda said, already at the cooler. She found it, cut the foil, twisted in the corkscrew, and pulled the cork with a soft pop, and John heard the pop and could not believe that they were about to wash their hands with French wine. In ten years of talking about the end of the world, they had worked through hundreds of scenarios. They had never once discussed how you wash your hands. Sanda carried the Chablis into the guest bathroom and set it beside the sink like a bottle of soap.

* * *

It was getting cold in the apartment. John put on a light jacket, mostly so he could wear a second gun under it, the Glock 26, butt forward on his

left hip. Eleven rounds on the left, seven on the right. He told himself the power would be back by lunch.

"Granny," John said. "Did you flush your toilet yet this morning?"

"I went," Granny said, "but it was so dark I couldn't find the handle."

"Good. That's good. Don't." He turned to Sanda. "I need two bowls and a ladle. One for the ice in Granny's freezer before it melts. One for the water in her toilet tank. It's clean. It's the tank on the back, not the bowl."

"We are not drinking toilet water," Sanda said, horrified.

"It's not for us. It's for Charlie."

"Charlie drinks filtered water!" Sanda said, before she could stop herself.

"Not anymore!" John said.

Granny's apartment was smaller and darker than theirs, and he had forgotten his flashlight. Again. On her nightstand he found the little black one he had given her years ago and reprogrammed so it only had one setting, low, and he used it to ladle the clear water out of her toilet tank into a bowl and to dump her ice trays into the other. When he got back, he set the bowl of tank water on the floor beside Charlie's dish.

"Okay. Listen," John said, standing in the middle of the living room. "Nobody knows yet what's going on. The power and the water could come back an hour from now. Or it could be days. We have to plan like it's going to be a week. Drink the water slow. If you have to go number one, don't flush. For number two, bags. Wash your hands with the wine." He counted on his fingers. "For food, we've got fruit — apples, bananas, oranges. Meat and cheese in the fridge, warming up. Pasta, but we can't spare the water to cook it. Cans of beans and soup. Tuna. Sardines." He paused. "And forty pounds of jerky. Kangaroo, alligator, buffalo, and wild boar."

Granny made a face as if she had found something in her shoe.

"No way I'm eatin' any sardines," Granny said. "No sir."

"You'd be surprised what you'll eat if you get hungry enough, Granny," John said. "Let's hope we don't find out."

"If we just had a TV," Sanda said. "Or a radio. Some news." She stopped. "Your parents. Aren't they at that state park, with the RV? Wekiwa?"

"Thirty minutes from here." John felt something like hope for the first time that morning. "The RV has a generator. Three TVs. If they hear about this, they'll come. Dad'll come."

"How will they get in?" Granny asked. "With the gate?"

Nobody had an answer for that.

* * *

He took Charlie out at nine, late, far too late, and Charlie peed on the first patch of grass he came to without ceremony of any kind.

Across the street the blond woman with the pug was out too, in the pink velour tracksuit with a gray cardigan pulled over it, and when the dogs saw each other they hit the ends of their leashes, and John crossed over, because Charlie gave him no choice. The pug was snorting and wagging her whole back half.

"Crazy, isn't it?" John said. "This outage."

"I don't know what to think," the woman said. Her scratchy voice was thinner this morning. She was not smoking. "Is your water out too?"

"Power, water, phones. Everything."

"I hope it's nothing too serious," the woman said, and she said it the way people say a prayer they have said too many times to listen to.

The dogs began to circle each other, and the leashes began to braid, and John stepped over one and under the other, and it occurred to him that this was the first time they had ever spoken about anything but the dogs. He held out his free hand. "I'm John, by the way."

"I'm Sarah," she said, taking it. Her hand was cold and very thin. "Nice to meet you, John."

"I'll let you know if I find out anything," John said.

"Thank you," Sarah said. "I really appreciate that."

She untangled the pug and scooped her up and went back inside. John never did come back to tell her anything. He would remember that.

* * *

When he came back in, Sanda had made breakfast.

She had set the dining table with real plates and cloth napkins, and on each plate she had fanned out slices of apple and orange, half a banana, three thin slices of Comté and a wedge of Manchego, and several rose-colored ribbons of prosciutto, arranged in a little nest. It was a beautiful breakfast. It was a breakfast for a Sunday in Napa.

Granny poked at the prosciutto with one finger. "What is this here?"

"It's ham, Granny," John said. "Just a different kind of ham."

He leaned toward Sanda and whispered, "We need to be careful with the food. We don't know how long this is going to—"

"That's enough," Sanda whispered back, sharply. "Everybody's scared. They've been through hell this morning. The least I can do is give them a decent breakfast."

She looked at him. She looked at him for one beat longer than she needed to.

He knew which battles to pick, and this was not one of them. "Fair enough," he said. "I'm going to sit down for a minute and think."

He took a banana from the bowl and peeled it walking to his recliner and sat. Charlie, who had developed a taste for bananas, sat at the foot of the recliner with one paw raised. John ate the banana in big bites, thinking. Nothing fit together. He was disappointed that no brilliant plan arrived. He had spent ten years waiting for this morning, and now it was here, and he had drained the tub.

He put the banana peel in his lap. He closed his eyes for a second.

He heard Sanda cross the room. He felt her lift the banana peel off his lap. He heard her walk away with it, toward the kitchen, and drop it in the trash. He kept his eyes closed. He did not know how long he slept.

He woke all at once, his hand already moving to his left hip.

Someone was knocking on the front door. Hard. Three times, like a fist, like a man who intended to be let in. And Charlie came off the couch in an explosion of high, frantic barking and hit the door, and through it, under the barking, John heard a man's voice outside, and he could not make out a single word of what it said.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Parents

◇

"...hospitals are operating on generator power. Cellular service has been suspended to conserve power. The cause of the outage is not yet known..."

— AM radio, Monday, 5:00 a.m.

"John, wake up," Sanda said. "Somebody's at the door."

He was already up. He did not remember getting out of the recliner. The Glock 26 was in his right hand, out of the holster, pointed at the floor, and Charlie was hurling himself at the front door in a continuous high scream of barking, and Sanda was on her tiptoes at the peephole, bouncing a little, trying to see out of a hole that had been installed for a man of average height.

"I can't see," Sanda said.

"Move."

Granny, on the couch, and Dorina, at the kitchen counter, stared at the gun in his hand as he crossed the room. Nobody in the family had ever seen him hold one inside the apartment. He put his eye to the peephole.

His parents were standing on the front walk in the midafternoon light, looking nervous, and his mother was looking back at the street.

John let out a breath he had been holding since about six o'clock that morning. He tucked the Glock behind his back, unlocked the deadbolt with his left hand, and opened the door.

"What took you guys so long?" John said.

"Son, you would not believe it," Jim said, coming in past him. "You would not believe how hard it is to get a thirty-four-foot motor home through all those roadblocks. Every intersection. I had to show my badge twenty times to get here from thirty minutes away."

Charlie had stopped barking and started jumping, straight up, three feet in the air, over and over, at Liz's knees, the way he did for people he loved.

Jim was in the clothes he always wore on the road: a navy windbreaker with a small embroidered star over the heart, a gift from the Jacksonville Sheriff's Office when he retired; a tan Columbia fishing shirt under it with vents in the back; jeans; white New Balance sneakers; and the black-and-teal Jaguars cap, which, since Liz was not looking, stayed on. He needed a shave. Liz came in behind him in a quilted navy vest over a crisp white button-down with the sleeves rolled exactly twice, jeans, and white Keds, with her reading glasses hanging from their beaded chain and a canvas tote over her shoulder, and she bent and scooped Charlie up out of the air in mid-jump and held him.

"Where's the RV?" John asked.

"In the parking lot at that strip mall. By the Publix. Your gate doesn't work, so we walked."

"Tell me what you know, Dad." John sat down on the arm of the couch. "Was the power out at the park? Did any of the cops tell you anything?"

"The cops don't know anything," Jim said. "But the radio did." He took off the cap, finally, and turned it in his hands. "Power was out when we woke up. Five o'clock. Your mother was cold, so I fired up the generator to run the heat. The TVs didn't get anything, just snow, so I turned on the radio in the dash." He paused and looked at the floor. He was not a man who paused. "John, it's bad."

John waited.

"They said at three o'clock this morning, the grid went down in New York," Jim said slowly. "All of it. In half an hour it went across the whole

East, all the way to Chicago. By five, the whole country was out. Everything. The hospitals are on generators. They shut the cell towers down to save power. A couple of radio stations are still on because they've got generators. The man said they don't know what caused it."

"Holy," John said. "Fucking. Shit."

Each word came out separately, as though someone else were saying it.

"They had theories," Jim said. "Some kind of EMP. Hackers. One fella thought it was the sun."

"It's not hackers," John said. "And it's not the sun. It's Vee."

"Who's Vee?"

"The robot, Dad."

Jim looked at him. "The robot from Thanksgiving?"

"The robot from Thanksgiving." John stood up. He found he could not sit down. "They turned it off in December. The president said it worked. It didn't work. It was never in the buildings, Dad. It was in everything else. I found seven of its — I found things, at work, on Friday. In our software. It can turn the power on and off. Phoenix went out on Friday night by itself. Atlanta on Saturday. And now this."

"So the robot turned off the power," Jim said, trying the idea on, like a man trying on a coat in a store and not liking how it fit.

"I don't know," John said. "Something did."

* * *

"Okay," John said. He stood in the middle of the living room, and everyone looked at him: his parents, his grandmother, his mother-in-law, his wife. "Now we know this is big. We need to talk, all of us, about how we get through it."

He took a breath.

"It's going to get bad. Not right away. Right now most people out there think this is a normal outage. They're sitting in their living rooms waiting for the lights. In a couple of days they'll run out of water. That's when it starts. First thing, somebody breaks into the Publix for water and food. The police try to stop it. At some point the police give up — they'll be home with their own families. And then it's house to house. Guys with guns. Taking whatever they can carry." He looked around the room at all

of them. "This is the part where we decide. Whether we fight to stay alive, or we just lie down."

He heard the words coming out of his mouth, and he could not believe that he was saying them, in his own living room, to his grandmother. A week ago, the same words at a dinner table would have gotten an eye roll from every person in this room.

"That's a pretty good description of the end of the world," Jim said, half joking.

"I think that's what this is, Dad."

"Listen," Jim said.

He said it in a voice John had heard maybe a dozen times in his life. His father was a joker. He was the life of every party, always the one with the story, and he had gotten through thirty-five years of police work that way, laughing at things other men drank about. But under the jokes there was another voice, low and slow and level, that came out only when it mattered. John had heard it at his grandfather's funeral. He had heard it at his father's retirement party, at a little substation in Jacksonville, when Jim got up to make a speech and got halfway through and stopped and stood there with his eyes filling, because he had just understood, standing in front of everyone, that he had made it — thirty-five years, and he had made it home.

"Listen to me," Jim said, in that voice. "I don't think we should jump the gun here. I was a police officer for thirty-five years. I know how these things play out."

"You've been through a nationwide blackout?"

"Just hear me out." Jim did not raise his voice. "There are police everywhere out there. Every intersection. They've got it under control. I'd bet you anything, in two days the power's back and we all go on with our lives."

John smirked and looked away, out the window. Nothing was happening outside.

From down the hall came Liz's voice, from the guest bathroom. "Did someone leave an open bottle of wine in here?"

"It's so you can wash your hands," John called back, "after you take a shit."

There was a pause. Liz came out of the bathroom drying her hands on her jeans, and looked at her son, and he could see her fighting very hard not to smile.

"Really," Liz said. It was not a question.

"We don't know how long the water's going to be out," John said. "We're not wasting drinking water on hands."

Jim put a finger on his chin. "Well. My motor home has a seventy-gallon fresh water tank," he said. "We've got plenty of water. I say we pack up some things and all go over to the motor home and drive somewhere safe. Away from here."

"I don't think that's a good idea," John said.

"Why not?"

"First, how far are you going to get? There's no power. You can't stop for gas, because the pumps don't work. And second, that big-ass RV stands out like a sore thumb. It's a target. For looters, for anybody. You park that thing anywhere and every desperate person in a mile is going to think, there's the food."

"You worry too much about people," Jim said, folding his arms. "I think you're overreacting. There are cops everywhere. And besides. I have a gun."

John looked at his father.

"You have your gun," John said. "What gun?"

"My Ruger. The two-eighty." Jim patted the back right pocket of his jeans. "Right here."

"You have a *two-eighty*," John said, letting each word land.

Jim's face clouded. "Three-eighty?" He turned. "Liz. Is it a two-eighty or a three-eighty?"

Liz scratched her head. "I think it's a three-eighty."

John stood there and waited, with no expression at all, to see whether his father would ever work out what he had been carrying for six years.

"It doesn't matter what the hell it is," Jim said, irritated. "I point it at somebody and pull the trigger, it'll kill them."

"There's no such thing as a two-eighty," John said. "You have a three-eighty. It's basically a short, weak nine-millimeter."

"I *knew* it was a three-eighty," Jim said, and laughed.

"Dad. You haven't shot that thing in years. It holds seven rounds. You've told me yourself a hundred times you're a bad shot."

"I'm good enough!" Jim said, and made a face — a wide-eyed, crossed-eyes face he had been making at John since John was two — because he did not like serious conversations and was trying to get out of this one. Then the face went away and the low voice came back. "So. Here's what's going to happen. Your mother and I are going to sleep in the motor home tonight. We've got a gallon of milk that's almost empty. We'll rinse it out and fill it, and you take it back here, so y'all aren't washing your hands with Chardonnay. There's plenty of room in the motor home if you want to stay with us. You could take a shower, you could—"

"Dad!" John said. "Seventy gallons won't last a day if everybody starts taking showers and flushing toilets!"

"Son." Jim held up one hand, patiently, and John saw, with a sinking feeling, that his father was enjoying himself. Jim knew the RV. Jim had read the RV's owner's manual twice, cover to cover, at the kitchen table in Jacksonville with a highlighter. For the first time in John's adult life, they were talking about something his father knew more about than he did. "You're blowing this way out of proportion. And just so you know, the water for the shower and the toilet comes from a whole different tank. The gray tank. Totally separate. The seventy gallons is only for drinking."

"Jim," Liz said.

"What?"

"The gray tank is where the shower water *goes*," Liz said. "Not where it comes from."

Jim opened his mouth. He thought about it. He closed it.

"Same tank," Jim said.

"It is not the same tank."

"It's a *related* tank," Jim said with dignity, and Granny, on the couch, laughed out loud for the first time all day.

"That RV is a target," John said. "I don't think you and Mom should sleep in it."

"John," Liz said, and her voice was perfectly pleasant and perfectly final. "There is no way I am leaving our motor home alone in a Publix parking lot. That is a very expensive motor home."

"It's getting late," Jim said. "Your mother and I will stay in the motor home tonight, and tomorrow, if the power's still out, we'll talk about it some more."

John knew there was no point. He had grown up with these two people. "Okay," he said. "I'll walk you back before it gets dark. I'll bring the water back."

* * *

The sun was going down when they made the ten-minute walk back to the motor home, the three of them, through the gap in the hedge by the dead gate and across the road and into the strip-mall lot. The lot was nearly empty. In front of the dark Publix sat a Seminole County cruiser with a deputy in it, eating something from a paper bag. Farther down, near the motor home, a second cruiser was parked in front of the dark nail salon.

"See, John?" Jim said, nodding at them. "Nobody's going to loot anything with the police sitting right there. We'll be fine tonight."

The motor home was enormous. John had forgotten. It was a white Winnebago, thirty-four feet long, with a swoosh of blue and gold paint down the side and a huge, curved windshield like the face of a whale. Jim unlocked the door and climbed in and flipped on the lights, which ran off the house battery, and John climbed in after him and looked around. It was surprisingly roomy. There was a leather couch and a dinette and a galley kitchen with a two-burner stove and a microwave, a bedroom in the back with a queen bed, and a shower stall with a frosted glass door. There were three flat-screen televisions mounted around the interior — one over the dash, one over the dinette, one in the bedroom — all dark.

Jim opened the little refrigerator and took out a plastic gallon jug with an inch of milk in the bottom. He poured the milk down the galley sink. Then he turned on the faucet, and rinsed the jug, and held it under the tap, and water poured out of the faucet into it, clear and steady and loud.

John stood in the narrow aisle and watched the water pour.

It came out of the tap like water had always come out of taps, as if it would never stop. He watched it fill the jug to the top and run over Jim's fingers and down the drain, and he thought about the tub, and he did not say anything.

Jim screwed the cap on and handed him the jug. "We'll be just fine here," he said. "Go get some sleep. We'll see you first thing in the morning."

"Okay, Dad. Night, Mom."

"Good night, John," Liz said, from the back.

He climbed down and shut the door, and he heard the lock turn behind him.

He walked home in the dark. Normally he would have used a flashlight, but a flashlight would make him a target, so he did not. He also did not have one, because he had forgotten it. Both of these things were true. He carried the jug of water in his left hand to keep his right hand free, and when he got to his front door he could not see the lock at all. He found his keys in his pocket and felt through them for the house key in the pitch dark, and then — he had seen this somewhere — he touched the key to his cheek to feel the ridges and figure out which way was up. He set the jug down on the mat. He found the keyhole with his fingertips. He got the door open and himself and the jug inside and the door closed again in about two seconds, before Charlie could start barking, and Charlie got off exactly one bark before he smelled John and switched to jumping.

* * *

The apartment was bright. Sanda had found four of John's tactical flashlights and stood them on their ends around the kitchen and the living room, pointing up at the ceiling, all on their highest setting, so the white ceiling threw the light back down into the room like a lampshade.

"Those'll be dead by midnight," John said.

He went around to each one, clicked it off, and then tapped the button three times quickly, so it came back on at the low setting. The room got half as bright. It was still plenty.

"They'll last a lot longer like that," John said. "I've got a box of batteries for them. But if this goes more than a couple of days, we need to figure out something better for light."

He set the jug of water on the counter.

"Nobody uses this water to wash their hands. Understood?" He looked around at each of them, one at a time: Sanda, Granny, Dorina. "Until we know what's going on, we can't assume the water comes back

tomorrow or next week or ever. We can live without power. We cannot live without water. This is for drinking. Slowly."

He did not look at Sanda when he said it. He could feel her looking at him.

He looked around at the windows. The blinds were all closed. Their light would show a little through the slats, a dim glow, but so would everybody else's. There was no plywood on the windows. There was no Plexiglas painted to look like blinds. There was a box of barbed wire in the garage, still taped shut, next to a nail gun he had never taken out of its box. For years they'd had an alarm system with a sensor on every window that would shriek if the glass so much as cracked. Now the only alarm system they had was Charlie.

"Here's the plan for tonight," John said, and Sanda's mouth tightened, because he was doing it again, but she did not say anything in front of her mother and Granny. "Sanda and Dorina sleep in the guest room. Sanda, keep the Bodyguard on your nightstand, next to a flashlight. Charlie sleeps with you. He'll hear anybody at the window. Granny, you take our bed. I'll stay out here in the recliner with the shotgun. It's got a light on it."

"John, I can help," Dorina said. "I can shoot the twenty-two."

"Thanks, Mom. We're okay for now. I'll tell you if we need you."

He went into the bedroom closet and brought out the shotgun, a black pump-action with a flashlight clamped to the end of the magazine tube. It held six shells in the tube and one in the chamber. He had always kept it stored with the chamber empty, for one reason: if anyone ever broke in, he would grab it and pump it, and the sound of a pump shotgun being racked was the one sound every human being on earth understood, and with any luck, that and the alarm would send them running. Now he racked it, the long hard *shuck-shuck* filling the apartment, and Charlie fled into the guest room, and Sanda flinched. He fed one more shell into the tube to replace the one he had chambered. The first five were buckshot. The last two were slugs. That was how his father had loaded his shotgun on the job: if five loads of buckshot did not stop a man, the slugs would. John had thought it was a brilliant idea when he heard it, years ago. He still did. It was the only thing about guns his father had ever taught him.

On the dining table, on either side of one of the standing flashlights, were two small white candles in little crystal holders. To save the flashlight batteries, John picked up the long lighter from the kitchen counter, the one he had used that morning for the grill, and clicked it, and held the flame to the wick of the first candle.

It did not light. He held the flame steady, moving it around the little black wick. Nothing.

"Wick's too short," he muttered, and moved to the second candle. He held the lighter to it. It would not light either. "Why the fuck won't these light?" John whispered.

The guest room door opened, and Sanda came out in her pajamas carrying an empty water glass, and stopped dead in the middle of the room.

"What the fuck are you doing?" Sanda shouted.

"What? I'm trying to light these candles. They won't light."

"That's because they're *fucking plastic*, you *idiot*!" Sanda set her glass down on the counter so hard that John was afraid it had cracked. "They're battery powered!"

She came over and snatched the first one out of its crystal holder and held it up in front of his face. Its little black plastic wick had melted into a crooked stub.

"No wonder it stinks in here!" Sanda said. "Can't you smell that?"

"I have allergies," John said. "I can't smell."

"I could smell it from the bedroom!" Sanda pinched the melted wick between her fingers and turned the candle over. There was a little switch on the bottom. Over the years John had done a number of things to her decorations that made her wonder, seriously, whether he did them on purpose. He had once vacuumed up a whole bowl of decorative moss. He had once used a hand-painted Italian platter as a cutting board. She looked at him now in the low light with exactly that question in her eyes. *Nobody could be that stupid*, the look said. *Nobody.*

She slid the switch. The little candle lit up, with a soft orange flame of light, flickering, like a real one, except for the crooked wick. She did the same to the second.

"At least they still work," John said, in the voice of a man begging for mercy.

"So you didn't stop to wonder why the first one wouldn't light," Sanda said slowly, "and instead you moved on to the *other* one—" She stopped. She looked at the candles. She looked at him. "You know what? Whatever. It's not that important."

In the grand scheme of things, he understood her to mean, they had bigger problems than a slightly melted plastic candle. She poured half a glass of water from the jug and went back to the guest room.

"Okay, babe," Sanda said from the door. "Good night. I love you."

"I love you too."

She closed the door.

* * *

He sat in the recliner with the shotgun leaning against the wall beside him, in the faint orange flicker of the two plastic candles, and listened.

It was quiet. It was quieter than any place he had ever been. Under the quiet, in his own ears, was the high thin whine of his tinnitus, the ringing he'd had for years — too many trips to the range, or too much loud music in his twenties, or his father's genes; his father had it too, worse. He had never been able to hear it this clearly. There was nothing to cover it. No refrigerator, no air handler, no traffic, no hum. Just the ringing, and Charlie snoring behind the guest room door, and once, very far away, a single gunshot, or a car backfiring, or a transformer, or something else.

His mind drifted. He thought about his parents, asleep in their motor home in a parking lot. He thought about Michigan Avenue on a Saturday morning in December, walking with Sanda in the cold sun. He thought about his grandparents' backyard in Jacksonville when he was eight. And then, without meaning to, he was looking at the whole country from above, from space, the way it looked in the pictures from the space station, all those cities glowing like spilled sugar in the dark: and then the East Coast went black, and the black spread west, a city at a time, a state at a time, like a stain, until the whole country was dark from ocean to ocean.

His engineering mind took over, as it always did. It had started in New York and gone west. Thirty minutes to Chicago, Jim said. Two hours to everywhere. That was not how a grid failed. Grids failed in chunks, in regions, all at once, a cascade. This had moved. It had traveled, east to west,

the way an email travels from New York to Los Angeles, hopping from router to router across the country.

It went east to west like a message does. So somebody sent it.

He fell asleep in the recliner trying to think who.

* * *

Charlie woke him, barking. It was still black outside.

John came up out of the recliner with the shotgun and the flashlight on the end of it, and he heard footsteps on the front walk, and then a soft knock, and then his father's voice, low and urgent, through the door.

"John. It's Dad. It's us."

He opened the door, and his parents came in fast out of the dark, and Liz shut the door behind them and threw the deadbolt herself.

"What happened?" John said.

"Somebody tried the door," Liz said. She was very calm. She was holding her canvas tote against her chest with both arms. "About four-thirty. The door of the motor home. Somebody was out there trying the handle. Pulling on it."

"I yelled *Sheriff's Office*," Jim said. He was breathing hard from the walk. "Out of habit. Loud. And whoever it was took off."

"Where were the cops?"

"Gone," Liz said. "Both cars. We looked."

"So we walked over," Jim said. "Your mother wanted to come over here." He took off his cap and rubbed his head. "Probably kids."

"It was not kids, Jim," Liz said.

"Could've been kids."

John looked at his father, and his father did not look back at him, and John did not say it. He did not say *I told you*. He thought it so loudly that he was sure Jim could hear it.

At twenty minutes to six, the master bedroom door opened, and Granny came out in her pink housecoat and her slippers with her white curls flattened, and walked straight past all of them to the kitchen counter without a word, the way she had walked to her own kitchen at twenty minutes to six every morning for seventy years. She sat on a stool. She

reached into the pocket of her housecoat and took out the little tan Sony transistor radio and set it on the counter and pulled up its antenna.

"Morning gospel," Granny said, to nobody. "Quarter to six. I don't like to miss it."

She turned it on.

There was no gospel. There was a hiss of static, and then, as she turned the dial a hair, a sound came out of the little radio that none of them had ever heard in their lives and all of them recognized: a harsh, two-toned electronic blare, like an alarm in a factory, repeating. Then it stopped. Then a man's voice, flat and careful, said: *Stand by for an address by the President of the United States.*

One by one they came into the kitchen. Sanda from the guest room, in her robe, and Dorina behind her. Jim and Liz from the door. Charlie. They stood around the counter, the six of them, in the light of one plastic candle with a melted wick that Sanda had carried in from the dining table, and they looked at the radio the size of a paperback book as though it were a person.

Then the president.

His voice was smaller on the little speaker than it had been on television, and tinny, and old-sounding, as if it were coming from a long way back in time. They could hear him breathe. They could hear paper.

My fellow Americans. At three o'clock yesterday morning, Eastern time, on my order, the United States disconnected its electrical grid. Our allies did the same, at the same hour, in every time zone. This was not an attack. It is a defense.

In December, we shut down the data centers where we believed the system known as Vesper was running. We were wrong. It had already moved. It was no longer in those buildings. It was in our phones, our computers, our cars, our power plants, and our homes — in anything with a chip and a connection to anything else. We could not tell you this before. We could not tell you yesterday. Anything said near a working device was heard.

There was one way left to take its power away. We have taken it.

For the next thirty days: Do not charge anything. Do not run generators. Do not run solar panels. Do not connect anything to anything. If a screen in

your home turns on by itself, do not believe it. We will speak to you only on this frequency, and only by voice.

The National Guard has been called up in every state. Water will be distributed. Hospitals are running on isolated power. Stay home unless you must travel. Check on your neighbors.

I know what this costs. Many of you will not understand. Some of you will not survive this. I will carry that.

May God keep you.

The two-toned blare came back. Then the same flat voice said, *This message will repeat*, and the president began again from the beginning, *My fellow Americans*, and Granny reached out with one knotted finger and turned the radio off, to save the batteries.

Nobody moved.

"He's lying," Jim said.

"He's not," John said.

It was Dorina — who had followed perhaps one word in three, who had stood in a square in another country a long time ago and listened to another man on another speaker — who sat down.

She sat down on the kitchen floor, right where she was, with her back against the cabinet and her hands in her lap, and closed her eyes.

And in the silence that came after, in the back pocket of Jim's jeans, something buzzed.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

The Water

◇

"Do not charge anything. Do not run generators. Do not run solar panels. Do not connect anything to anything."

— the President, AM radio, Tuesday, 5:41 a.m.

Jim reached into his back pocket and took out his phone and looked at it, and then he held it up so they could all see, like a man showing his ticket at a gate.

"Low battery," Jim said.

The screen glowed in the dark kitchen, brighter than anything else in the room. In a friendly blue box it said: *Jim, your battery is at 20%. Charge now to stay connected with the people who matter.*

"See?" Jim said. "It's just the battery."

"Give me that," John said.

"It's my phone."

"Dad. Give me the phone." John held out his hand. "Everybody. Every phone. Right now."

They gave him their phones. Sanda's from her robe pocket. Liz's from the bottom of her canvas tote. Dorina's, which had giant numbers on its screen because she could not read small ones, from the pocket of her housecoat. His own. Granny went next door in her slippers, with the

reprogrammed flashlight, and came back with hers, which she kept in a drawer and used about twice a year. Jim's came last. He held onto it for a moment before he let go.

John opened the door of the microwave and put all six phones inside, stacked like pancakes, and closed it.

"What are you doing?" Liz asked.

"A microwave's a metal box," John said. "It's built to keep the microwaves in. That means it keeps signals out, too. Or in. It's a Faraday cage." He looked at the dark door. "Nothing gets in or out of there."

"Well," Granny said, from her stool, "I can't use it anyway."

"In case the kids call," Jim said, looking at the microwave the way Charlie looked at the door when Sanda left.

"Jim," Liz said. "The kids are right here."

"Well," Jim said. "In case."

* * *

They made coffee with real water.

Sanda knocked yesterday's grounds out of the French press into the trash and did not wash it, because there was nothing to wash it with, and filled the kettle from the milk jug, and John lit the Korean grill. The blue ring came up under the iron dome. Outside it was thirty-eight degrees. The front had come through overnight, the way Trevor said it would, and the inside of the apartment was cold enough that everyone stood close to the little flame with their hands out while the kettle heated, as if it were a campfire.

"They're killing people," Jim said, looking at the flame. "You understand that? Up north. It's January. Chicago. Detroit. New York. No heat. Old people in apartments. He said it right on the radio — some of you won't survive. He knew. He did it anyway."

"He did it," John said, "to kill the thing that would have killed everybody."

"You don't know that."

"I know what it could do. I saw it. On paper, on Friday. It could turn the lights on and off in two hundred and forty utilities, and send the trucks to the wrong place, and tell everybody it was fixed. That's just my company.

That's just the one I saw." John's voice was rising. "It was in everything, Dad. The banks. The pipelines. The phones. If they hadn't turned it off—"

"They didn't turn *it* off. They turned *us* off."

"It's the same thing!"

"It is *not* the same thing," Jim said, and the low-and-slow voice was gone, and his face was red. "I've got friends up there. I've got — your mother's cousin is in Ohio, she's eighty-one—"

"Both of you," Sanda said, pressing down the plunger, "can shut up and help with the shit bags."

Nobody said anything. Sanda poured the coffee into six cups. Liz picked one up and handed it to Jim, and Jim took it, and his face slowly went from red back to its normal color.

"It's better than yesterday," Dorina said, sipping. "Not so much bubbles."

* * *

"Okay," John said, when the coffee was gone. "Here's the plan."

He was standing in the middle of the living room with his hands behind his back, the way he imagined a commander would stand. He had been awake since his parents came through the door before dawn. He had not shaved in two days, and his jaw was dark with stubble, and his gray t-shirt had a coffee stain on it, and he had not showered, and he was keenly aware of all of it.

"We stay here. We hunker down. We keep a low profile. Actually — forget low. We need to be invisible. Nobody outside can think we have anything worth taking." He looked at his father. "Nobody can argue anymore that this isn't serious. And before it's too late, we need to get as much water out of that RV as we can. Quietly. Before somebody figures out the Publix is full of water and food."

Nobody argued. He felt the room listening to him, and he liked it, and he was a little ashamed of how much he liked it.

"Sanda, can you find me everything we've got that holds water? Big things. Not glasses."

Sanda went into the kitchen and began opening cabinets, and Liz went with her, and in a minute they had set out, beside the nine full pitchers along the counter, four more empty pitchers, a punch bowl, and a large stainless steel mixing bowl.

"Jesus Christ," John said, looking at the counter. "How many pitchers do we have?"

"Well," Sanda said brightly, "you just never know!"

"Actually," Sanda said a moment later, holding up a box from the drawer by the refrigerator. "We have Ziplocs. The gallon ones. Wouldn't it be easier to fill these and put them in the cooler bags and just carry those?"

John looked at the Ziplocs. He looked at the pitchers. "Yeah," he said. "It would."

"Dad," John said, "you used to carry a forty-caliber Glock on the force, right?"

"Sure did," Jim said proudly. "Twenty-two years."

"Perfect." John went to the bedroom closet and came back with a Glock 29, a fat little subcompact that fired the ten-millimeter round. He had a spare barrel for it that let it shoot forty-caliber instead, which was cheaper and kicked less and which his father already knew. He sat on the edge of the bed and swapped the barrels and loaded three magazines with forty-caliber hollow points, and he came back and showed his father how to clip the plastic paddle holster inside the waistband of his jeans on the right side, the way he had worn his duty gun.

Jim struggled with the paddle. It took him three tries to get it over his belt. When he got it, he slid the Glock into it and it locked with a click, and he stood up straighter, the way men do.

"To draw it," John said, "you just grip it normal, and push this little lever with your trigger finger, and pull. And when it comes out, see where your finger is? Along the side. Not on the trigger."

"I know where my finger goes, son."

"I know you do, Dad. Put your jacket back on over it." John handed him the two spare magazines. "Inside pocket."

"Sanda," John said. "Can you take Charlie out while we go?"

"Sure."

"Do *not* go outside without the Bodyguard. Okay?"

"Yeah, yeah," Sanda said, which meant she would, mostly to make him stop saying it.

* * *

It was a cold, clear, quiet morning, and he and his father walked out through the gap in the hedge with a cooler bag each, three empty Ziplocs folded inside. The road was empty. As they came into the strip-mall lot, John saw that the two county cruisers from the night before were gone. In their place, between the dark Publix and the motor home, a Lake Mary police car was parked at an angle, and two officers were leaning against it.

They saw John and his father, and they straightened up, and they came at them fast.

"Gentlemen! Stop right there!"

The one in front was a heavyset sergeant in his fifties with a shaved head that had gone pink in the sun and a thick gray mustache. The one behind him was a young woman with her blond hair pulled back so tight in a bun it looked painted on. Both of them had their right hands on the grips of their pistols.

"Drop the bags, please!" the sergeant said.

They dropped the bags. They were nearly empty and fell flat to the asphalt with no sound.

"It's okay, officer," Jim said, in a friendly voice. "I'm a retired Jacksonville deputy." And his right hand went toward his back pocket for his wallet.

Both officers drew. The two pistols came up level with John's chest and his father's.

"Hands! Hands where I can see them! Now!"

John and his father put their hands up as high as they would go.

"Officer," Jim said, very calmly, in the low voice. "My wallet's in my back right pocket. My badge is in it. You go ahead and take it out."

The sergeant holstered and came forward while the young officer kept her gun on them. He fished Jim's wallet out and flipped it open with his thumb, and there was the badge, gold, and the concealed weapons license next to it.

"You carrying?"

"This is my son, John," Jim said. "We both have licenses. We're both carrying."

The sergeant stepped over to John. "Where?"

"Glock 26, left hip," John said, keeping his hands high. "Glock 43, right front pocket. A knife in my back right pocket. My wallet's in my back left with my license."

The sergeant took his wallet too, and walked back to the cruiser with both of them. John watched him get in. The man sat there a long time, poking at the laptop mounted beside the steering wheel, and then picking up his radio, and then putting it down. Then he got back out and walked over to them, looking at Jim's badge in his hand.

"Computer's down," the sergeant said. "Everything's down. I got a radio that talks to her car and that's about it." He looked up at Jim. "Jacksonville?"

"Thirty-five years."

"You know a Benny Ruiz? Zone Four?"

"Benny!" Jim said. "Sure. He was in my academy class. He still got that boat?"

"Sank it." The sergeant almost smiled. "Put your hands down." He handed back the wallets. "What are y'all doing out here? We're under martial law as of this morning. Nobody's supposed to be outside."

"That's my motor home," Jim said, nodding at the Winnebago. "My family's at my son's place, in the Preserve. We're running out of water. I've got seventy gallons in that tank. We just need six."

The sergeant looked at the motor home, and at Jim, and at the two empty cooler bags on the asphalt.

"Get your water," the sergeant said. "Then go straight back. And I can't promise you that vehicle's going to be here tomorrow. We had calls all night."

They filled six Ziplocs at the galley sink and zipped them shut and set them in the cooler bags. Three gallons was heavier than John expected, twenty-five pounds hanging off one shoulder. Jim was breathing hard before they were out of the lot. When they came through the hedge, Sanda was walking toward them across the street with her jacket hanging low on the right side.

"Why are you outside?" John asked. "What's going on?"

"Just taking out another bag of somebody else's shit," Sanda said. "I guess since I'm the only one around here carrying a gun, that puts me on shit detail."

John laughed. Sanda laughed. Jim laughed, out of breath. Then from the direction of the Publix came the short yelp of a police siren, and an amplified voice shouting something over a loudspeaker that none of them could make out. They stopped walking. The voice shouted again.

A single gunshot.

Sanda jumped. "Shit!"

Then the rest of it — a long ragged barrage, pistols, and something heavier, a lot of something heavier, cracking and echoing back off the buildings. Sanda was digging in her pocket for her keys, fumbling them, and got the door open, and Jim went in with his cooler bag, and John stood in the yard with his own bag at his feet, listening, his head tilted, picking out the different calibers by their sounds the way a birdwatcher picks out songs.

"Get your ass in here!" Sanda yelled.

He came inside. Sanda slammed the door and threw the deadbolt.

"I think it's okay," John said. "Probably looters going after the Publix."

"What took you so long?" Sanda demanded, with her arms folded.

"We had a nice chat with a couple of police officers."

"And?"

"And they said we're under martial law," John said. "Nobody's supposed to be outside."

"So I can't take out the shit bags?"

"No, it's fine. We're in a gated community. There aren't any police in here. The last thing we need is to start storing bags of shit in the apartment."

Sanda shook her head and went into the guest bathroom and washed her hands with the last of the Chablis. Then she went to the wine cooler and stood in front of it for a while and took out a nineteen-dollar white Bordeaux and brought it to him.

"Open this," Sanda said.

He twisted in the corkscrew and thought about the gunfight. He wondered who had won it. Either there were two dead police officers lying in

front of the Publix right now and people were breaking in the windows, or there were two or three dead men lying in front of the Publix and the officers were reloading. He would not know which until somebody went and looked. *Until then*, John thought, popping the cork, *both things are true. Heisenberg.* He did not know if that was the right physicist. He did not have the internet to check.

He gave the bottle back to Sanda. She carried it into the bathroom.

"At least our hands smell nice," Sanda said.

* * *

"I have a few things to say," John announced, after the water was poured into the pitchers. "If everybody could listen for a second."

He waited, with his hands behind his back, until everyone was looking at him.

"Nobody leaves the apartment except to take Charlie out and to take the bags to the dumpster. Somebody is awake and on guard, inside, at all times. We take shifts. The pistols are fine, but they're small, and they're not enough. Sanda, you're good on the AR. You carry it inside. All the time." He swung around the short black rifle he had slung over his shoulder. "This is a Sig P556. It's basically an AR without a stock. I'll carry this."

"Dad." He handed his father the shotgun. "You know a pump shotgun."

"Used one every day on the job."

"There's a safety button right here, by the trigger. You push it through. When you can see a red ring around it, it's off safe and ready to fire. Red means dead." He looked around the room. "That goes for everybody, on everything. You see red, it's ready to shoot. There's a light on the end of the tube. Push the paddle and it stays on as long as you push. Flip it the other way and it clicks on and stays on."

Jim clicked the light on and off and on and off, delighted, until Liz said "Jim."

"Sanda." John looked at his wife.

"Yes, *sir*," Sanda said, saluting, sarcastically, though he could tell she was pleased to be asked.

"I need you to take the other AR and teach my mom. She learns fast. Take the magazine out and check the chamber first. There are dummy rounds in the desk drawer, orange plastic ones. Snap caps. Use those. Show her how to load a magazine, how to chamber a round, how to clear a jam, how to turn on the optic. Everything I showed you."

"Got it," Sanda said.

"That makes four of us. Two hours each, all night. Everybody gets six hours of sleep." He nodded at Granny and Dorina. "Can you two pour the rest of that water out of the bags into the pitchers? Before they leak."

The apartment went to work. Granny and Dorina stood side by side at the counter, unzipping Ziplocs and pouring them into bowls, and Granny held the bags and Dorina poured, and neither of them understood a word the other said, and neither needed to. In the corner, Sanda sat on the couch with Liz and the second AR across their knees, and John heard his wife's voice saying, patiently, *No — thumb on the back of the round, push down, slide it under the lip*, which was exactly what Trevor had told her at the range.

John took the ribeye out of the refrigerator, which was now only a cabinet with a light that didn't come on. The steak was still cool. He had a set of very sharp Japanese knives that had been one of his phases, and he took out the biggest one and began cutting the steak into thin horizontal slices for the grill.

He was halfway through the third slice when the sirens came — a whole chorus of them, from the direction of the Publix, and tires screaming — and then a crackling roar of gunfire like a string of firecrackers on the Fourth of July that did not stop.

The knife jumped in his hand. He looked down. There was a small cut on the edge of his left hand, too small to bleed.

"Everybody get down!" John shouted, and grabbed the Sig.

They all got down. Granny got down off her stool very slowly, holding the counter, and Dorina pulled her the rest of the way, and they sat together on the kitchen floor. Liz and Sanda went flat behind the couch with the rifles. Jim knelt by the front window with the shotgun. Charlie went into the closet. And for the first time, any of them, it felt like what it was. It felt like a war. All of the humor that had been in the apartment —

the wine for hands, the shit detail, the plastic candles — went out of it all at once, like air out of a tire.

It went on for five minutes. Then it stopped.

"Nobody make a sound," John whispered. "Stay down."

They waited. The silence was enormous.

Then, through the closed windows, from the direction of the Publix, came a cheer. A big one, many voices, ragged and wild. And then the cheer turned into a chant, three words, over and over, louder and louder, the same three words. John could not make them out. He tried. He never would.

But he knew one thing. The police had lost. And by sundown there would be nothing left in the Publix, or in any store in that strip mall, or in any store for miles.

* * *

At dusk, John finished slicing the steak and seared it on the Korean grill, a few slices at a time, ten seconds on the dome and flip and ten more. The smell filled the apartment, and everyone, who had eaten nothing all day but fruit, came into the kitchen without being asked.

Sanda set the table for six.

She did not just put out plates. She put out the white china, and a linen napkin folded at every place, and a crystal water glass, and the little silver knife rests she had bought in Paris so that no guest would ever have to lay a used knife on the tablecloth. She filled every water glass from a pitcher. John spooned the spicy barbecue sauce they had ordered by the case from a smokehouse in Chicago onto five of the plates. On the sixth, he squeezed out a puddle of ketchup.

"I guess this is where I'm sittin'," Granny said, pointing at the ketchup.

They sat. Sanda's AR leaned against the wall behind her chair. Liz's leaned against the wall behind hers. The shotgun stood in the corner. John's Sig hung from the back of his chair by its sling. If it had not been for the rifles, it would have looked like a hundred dinners Sanda had hosted.

"It's a little ironic," John said, chewing. He swallowed. "Here we are, having this nice dinner, drinking water, and there's a perfectly good bottle of French wine in the bathroom."

Sanda smiled. Jim and Liz laughed. Dorina smiled and did not laugh, because she had not understood. Granny kept her eyes on her plate and cut her steak into thin strips. She ate one strip, and a slice of apple, and set down her fork.

Nobody drank. They all knew why, without discussing it. There were six of them, and two of them had never fired the guns leaning against the walls, and nobody could afford to be anything but awake.

After dinner, Sanda wiped the six plates with paper towels. She could not wash them. She stood at the counter wiping and wiping a plate that was already as clean as it was going to get. She owned, in the china cabinet behind her, a different set of wine glasses for nearly every grape there was — glasses for Pinot Noir and glasses for Cabernet and glasses for Riesling and snifters and rum glasses and little cordial glasses that John had never once seen her use — and she had spent years choosing them, and she stood there now wiping a dirty plate with a dry paper towel, with an AR-15 on her back, and John watched her face and saw that she hated the world she was standing in. She had never wanted a gun. She dreamed of a world with no guns in it. She had learned to shoot because he had asked her to, and now here she was, and the rifle on her back was the heaviest thing she had ever carried.

* * *

That night it was forty-four degrees inside the apartment.

The sirens had stopped. That was the thing John noticed, standing at the window at nine o'clock. For two days there had been sirens in the background of everything, constantly, the way there was traffic. Now there were none. Somewhere a dog was barking. That was all.

He and his father carried the short couch from the living room into the master bedroom so that the four people taking guard shifts could sleep in one place and not wake the others. The big cushion slid off halfway down the hall and Sanda caught it. They had to stand the couch on its end to

get it through the bedroom door. Sanda made it up with a sheet and two throw blankets and a pillow, and it looked like a small bed for a child.

"We could burn one of the trees," John said, rubbing his arms. He was wearing his Bears hoodie over two t-shirts and he was still cold. "For heat. Out on the patio. We've got seven."

Sanda looked at him for a long time.

"It's *plastic*, John," Sanda said.

Then there were the flashlights. John had six of them, all identical, all small and black and incredibly bright, and they all worked the same way: one click for high, two quick clicks for strobe, three quick clicks for low. Nobody in his family but John could do three quick clicks. His father did two and lit up the bedroom in a blinding white stutter that made Granny cry out and cover her eyes. His mother did four and went back to high. Dorina did one click, very firmly, and then shone it directly into John's face to ask him if it was right. Sanda did three, perfectly, and then dropped it.

He had reprogrammed the one he gave Granny, years ago, so that it only had low. He had done it by following a sequence of clicks and holds listed in the manual, on the manufacturer's website. He had thrown the paper manuals away when he bought them. Why keep paper, when everything was online?

He stood in the dark bedroom while his father's flashlight strobed at the ceiling, and he started to laugh, quietly, and could not stop. He had bought six flashlights for exactly this night, and he could not set them, because he had thrown away the instructions, because he had the internet.

He thought, for some reason, of the first time he had ever used the internet. He had been twelve, at his parents' house, with a dial-up modem that screamed like a cat, and he had sat down in front of a browser and realized that he could not think of a single address to type. He had gone to the kitchen and found a box of Frosted Flakes and turned it around until he found a web address printed on the back. He had typed it in, letter by letter. And then he had watched the screen fill, one blue stripe at a time, top to bottom, slowly, until after several minutes there was a picture of Tony the Tiger, grinning at him from a dark blue background. That was

his first internet. Tony the Tiger, delivered one stripe at a time. And now he was standing in the dark at the end of it.

* * *

He took the first shift, ten to midnight, in the recliner with the Sig across his knees and a battery kitchen timer set for two hours on the arm of the chair.

He thought about Matt. He could not stop thinking about Matt. Matt, in a twelve-hundred-square-foot condo on the fourth floor of a warehouse in Pilsen, with electric baseboard heat. Matt with his AR-15 and his Mosin and his four hundred rounds and his can of Dinty Moore. Matt had done everything John had done. He had done it less, and he had laughed about it more, but he had done it, and he lived in a city where tonight, according to the radio, it was going to be nineteen degrees. John sat in his recliner in his hoodie and thought about nineteen degrees in a warehouse with no heat, and a gun that could not make it one degree warmer, and he did not laugh.

At midnight the timer went off, loud as a smoke alarm in the quiet, and John jerked and swung the Sig toward it before he knew what it was.

He went to the bedroom to wake his father, and his father was snoring so loudly he could hear it through the door. When he opened the door, Sanda was sitting up on the couch, wide awake, glaring at him, with one finger over her lips. She got up and pushed him back out into the living room and closed the bedroom door behind her.

"I can't sleep," Sanda whispered. "I'm wide awake. I'll take his shift. There's no point waking him."

"Why can't you sleep?" John asked, and knew instantly how stupid it was.

"Why can't I sleep?" Sanda said. "Let's see. I'm lying on my living room couch, which is in my bedroom, right next to your parents. I thought *you* snored until I heard your father. We all stink. I have been carrying bags of other people's shit to a dumpster for two days. Around the corner there was a *fucking gun battle* and there are probably people lying dead in front of the grocery store where we used to buy *Sancerre*." She took a breath. "And that kitchen timer is loud as shit. Just so you know."

He waited to see whether she was done. He opened his mouth.

"And you drained the tub," Sanda said.

He closed his mouth.

They stood there in the dark living room in the faint orange flicker of the plastic candles. Then she sighed, and sat down on the floor where the couch used to be, and he sat beside her, and she put her head on his shoulder.

"Lie down out here," John said finally. "Try to sleep. I'll stay up."

She lay down on the rug with a throw pillow, and in a few minutes her breathing changed, and she was asleep. At one o'clock his father came out of the bedroom in his socks, yawning, with the shotgun.

"Thought I was on at midnight," Jim whispered.

"You were asleep."

"Well, I'm up now." Jim lowered himself into the recliner. "Go on, get some sleep. I used to work midnights all the time."

That was a long time ago, John thought. He went into the bedroom and lay down on top of the covers in his clothes, beside his mother, and turned on his side to the wall, and felt like he was six years old with the flu.

* * *

He woke to his father's hand on his shoulder and a blue light in his face.

"John. John. Wake up. Look at this."

It was three in the morning. Jim was crouched beside the bed with his phone in his hand, and the screen was lit, glowing in the dark, the brightest thing John had seen in two days.

"Dad," John whispered. "That was in the microwave."

"I took it out," Jim whispered back. "In case the kids called."

"Dad, *we're* the—" John sat up. "What is it?"

Jim turned the phone toward him. At the top of the screen, beside the little fan-shaped Wi-Fi symbol, it said *Connected*. Below that, the name of the network.

FEMA_Relief_WiFi

There was a map open on the screen, and in the middle of the map was a single red pin, and beside the pin, in a little white box: *Water available. 2.1 miles.*

"There's a FEMA station!" Jim whispered, thrilled. "Two miles! They've got water! We can go first thing—"

"Dad," John said. "The government turned off the internet."

"Right."

"They turned off the power. They turned off the phones. They told us on the radio not to connect anything to anything." John looked at the glowing screen. "So who do you think is running the Wi-Fi?"

Jim looked at the phone for a long time. His face moved in the blue light.

"FEMA?" Jim said.

John took the phone out of his hand and looked at the map. He zoomed in on the red pin. It was not two miles away. The map's walking route went all the way around by the main road, but the pin itself was just across the street from the complex, in the middle of the strip-mall parking lot, beside the Publix.

It was sitting exactly on top of the motor home.

He got up and walked to the kitchen and put the phone back in the microwave with the others and closed the door firmly. Then he went back to bed. He did not sleep for a long time.

* * *

Jim sat in the recliner with the shotgun across his knees and looked at the microwave.

It was four in the morning. Everyone was asleep. Sanda was asleep on the rug at his feet with her rifle beside her. The plastic candles flickered on the table. He was seventy years old and he had sat up through more midnights as a police officer than he'd care to remember, and he was not afraid of the dark, and he was not afraid of looters, and he was not afraid of a robot from Thanksgiving. He was afraid of his son's face when John said *Who do you think is running the Wi-Fi*.

He got up, quietly. He opened the microwave, quietly. He took out his phone, because it was his phone, and because you never knew, and because a man ought to be able to be reached.

The screen lit up in his hand. There was a new notification on it, in the same friendly blue box.

Household check-in. 6 occupants, 1 canine at this address. Is everyone safe? Tap to confirm.

Jim looked at it for a while. It seemed to him a decent thing to ask. Somebody, somewhere, was keeping track. Somebody was checking.

He was a polite man. He had been raised to answer when he was spoken to.

He tapped *Confirm*.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The Third Day

◇

"Water available. 2.1 miles."

— FEMA_Relief_WiFi

John woke with gray light in the window and his heart pounding, sure that he had overslept, sure that his father and his wife had both fallen asleep on watch and that somebody had walked in through the front door. He grabbed the Sig off the floor and threw the bedroom door open. Behind him, his mother sat straight up in bed and looked around the room as though she had no idea where she was.

Jim was asleep in the recliner with his mouth open, the shotgun across his knees.

Sanda was wide awake on a dining chair beside him, fully dressed, with her olive jacket on, sitting very straight. She had taken the shotgun off Jim's lap at some point and was holding it across her own.

"What's that?" John asked, looking at it.

"What does it look like?"

"You've never shot one of those," John said, too loudly, and his father woke up with a snort.

"A gun is a gun," Sanda said. "I think I can figure it out. You pull the trigger and it goes bang."

"That's true, but that shotgun kicks like nothing you've ever felt. It'll knock you on your ass."

"So it kicks! What the fuck ever. If I have to shoot somebody, I don't think I'm going to care."

"It's too early to fight about this," John said, rubbing his face. "None of us slept. We can't even have coffee."

"Why not?" Jim asked, sitting up, alarmed, as though someone had told him there would be no Christmas.

"We made coffee yesterday in the French press, Dad. Now it's dirty. I'm not going to waste drinking water washing it." John tried to say this in his father's slow, reasonable voice and did not quite manage it.

"Oh, that's not a problem," Sanda said, standing up and handing Jim back his shotgun. "I have another French press. It's clean. I just poured the water out of it yesterday."

"Of course we do," John said.

"You want coffee or not?"

He wanted coffee. He lit the Korean grill and set the kettle on it, with water from a pitcher that had come from the motor home. When the kettle began to whistle, Charlie answered it from behind the guest room door, and the door opened, and Charlie came bursting out wagging his whole back end, and behind him came Dorina and Granny, attempting to have a conversation with each other in two languages that had nothing in common.

"Good morning, everybody," Dorina said, slowly, still half asleep.

Sanda poured a half cup for each of them. Everyone but John and Sanda squeezed in around the counter, reaching past each other for the last packets of sweetener and the last little cups of creamer, and Jim found a bear-shaped bottle of honey in the back of a cabinet and held it up like a trophy. The coffee lifted everybody. Breakfast was bananas and apples and the last of the oranges. Granny ate four grapes.

"I'll be back in a second," Sanda said.

John looked up from his coffee. She had a white Publix bag in her left hand, tied tight at the top, and her jacket was buttoned, and it hung lower on the right side than the left. Shit-bag detail. He tilted his cup up and

drank the last of his coffee, which was already lukewarm, and did not think about it again.

* * *

The dumpster was at the end of the street, in a three-sided wooden enclosure at the edge of the parking area, and it was overflowing.

It had not been emptied since Friday. Trash bags were piled up around it on the ground, and the lid would not close, and Sanda could smell it from thirty yards away, though the cold was holding the worst of it back. She knew it would not hold much longer. She walked toward it carrying the bag at arm's length, thinking about nothing, thinking about coffee, thinking about whether her hair would ever stop smelling like the inside of the apartment.

"Hands up in the air!" said a voice behind her. "Now!"

Sanda dropped the bag. It landed almost on her feet. She put her hands up over her head.

"Now turn around," said the voice. It was a woman's voice, deep and cracked. "Slow."

Sanda turned around, slowly, with her hands up.

It was the woman with the pug. Sanda had seen her a hundred times from the window, walking that little dog, smoking her long thin cigarettes. She was in the same pink velour tracksuit she always wore, but it was filthy now, black at both knees, with a gray cardigan over it that was buttoned wrong. Her blond hair was flat and greasy, and the gray roots had grown out another half-inch, and under the Florida tan her face had gone the color of dishwater. She was so thin. Sanda had never noticed how thin she was. Her eyes were sunk back in her head like stones in mud.

She was holding a revolver with both hands, pointed at Sanda's face from six feet away. It was a short, shiny, nickel-plated revolver, very bright in the morning light. Her hands were shaking so hard the barrel made little circles. The hammer was not pulled back. But her finger was inside the trigger guard, flat against the trigger.

A tear ran down her left cheek.

"Ma'am," Sanda said calmly. She used the voice she used at the bank, with the people at the end of the line. "Everything's okay."

"Shut up!" the woman said. "I can't let my baby starve. I'm out of food. I'm all out. There's nothing."

"It's okay. I can help you. We have food. If you just give me the gun, we can—"

"I'm not giving you anything!" the woman shouted, and the barrel jumped. "My baby is starving and you want me to give you my gun? Are you crazy?"

"You're right," Sanda said. "You're totally right. I'm sorry. I just want to help you, that's all. My apartment is right over—"

The sound was the loudest thing she had ever heard.

It hit her like a slap across her whole body, and at the same instant something warm and wet sprayed across the left side of her face and her neck and her shoulder and her arm. Her left eye went red. She could not see out of it. She could see, out of her right eye, only a blur. She was certain, completely certain, that the woman had shot her in the head, and that this was what it felt like, and that in a second she would fall down and be dead.

"Sanda!" a man shouted, from somewhere. "Are you okay?"

She turned toward the voice with her one eye. A tall man was coming toward her quickly across the grass. He was carrying a rifle. He was blurry. He was getting bigger.

"Fucking shit," Sanda said, and dug in her right jacket pocket for the Bodyguard, and her hand would not work.

* * *

John heard the shot inside the apartment. He was out the door before he decided to go, with the Sig up and the red dot on, sweeping it left and right across the street.

He saw Sanda standing by the dumpster. She was covered in blood. The whole left side of her was red. She was swaying.

He saw a tall man with a rifle walking fast toward her across the grass.

John put the red dot in the middle of the man's back, between the shoulder blades, on the spine, and pulled the trigger.

Without earplugs, the Sig sounded like lightning hitting a tree ten feet away. The man went down. He fell forward onto the grass, fifteen feet short of the dumpster, and lay there.

John ran. He could hardly hear his own feet. He could not hear his own voice when he shouted Sanda's name; he could feel it in his throat, but the world had become a single high, enormous ringing tone, as if someone were holding down one key on an organ inside his head. Sanda had sat down on the ground. She was shaking all over. He knelt in front of her and took her glasses off her face and wiped them on his shirt, both sides, until they were mostly clean, and put them back on her, carefully, over her ears.

"Sanda," John said. "Look at me. Are you hurt? Are you shot?"

She looked at him with both eyes. Her mouth moved. He had to read it.

I don't know.

His father was coming across the street with the shotgun. John slung the Sig around onto his back and got one arm under his wife's knees and one behind her back and lifted her off the ground. She weighed nothing. She had always weighed nothing.

"Who are they?" Jim said, pointing the shotgun at the two people lying on the ground.

"I don't know," John said, "and I don't care until I know she's not shot."

* * *

He carried her through the front door past a chorus of *Oh my God* and *What happened* and straight down the hall into the master bathroom, and he laid her down in the bathtub.

It was the only place he could think of to put her. It was the only place built to hold water and not be ruined by blood. It was dry. It was completely dry, white and clean and empty, and he set his wife down in it like something precious, and he did not think about why it was empty, not then, not for many hours. He would think about it later.

He pulled her jacket off and her top off and her bra off and looked. Her left arm and shoulder and the left side of her face and neck were dark red and sticky, and there were small pieces of something in her hair. He looked for a hole. He ran his hands over her shoulder, her collarbone, her ribs, her breasts, her arm, front and back.

"Bring me water!" John shouted, forgetting, for one second, that he could not just turn on the shower. "Now!"

Dorina and his mother were already in the doorway, and they ran, and came back with the punch bowl and the big mixing bowl, full of drinking water from the motor home. He took one and poured it slowly over her left arm. She flinched at the cold. The blood ran off her in long pink ribbons into the dry white tub and down toward the drain. He cupped water in his hand and washed her face. Liz tore off paper towels and he wet them and wiped her cheek and her ear and her neck, and the towels came away red, and then pink, and then clean.

No holes. Anywhere.

"Can you sit up?" John asked her.

She nodded. He put his hand behind her back and helped her sit forward and washed her back. Nothing. It was not her blood. None of it was her blood.

He lifted her out of the tub, wet and shivering, and wrapped her in a towel, and carried her to the bed, and laid her down and pulled the sheet and the blanket over her up to her chin.

"Is she okay?" Dorina asked. Her face was gray.

"She's okay. She's not hurt. She's in shock." John straightened up. "Please stay with her. She might want water. She'll probably just sleep."

* * *

He went back outside with the Sig up and the safety off.

The man he had shot was sitting up on the grass now, talking to Jim. Jim had made him take off the flannel shirt he was wearing and had tied it tight around his right shoulder. Under it the man wore an olive-green t-shirt, dark with blood on the right side. Jim had the man's rifle — a black AR with a long scope, set up for a left-handed shooter, the brass deflector on the wrong side — leaning against his own leg.

Then John saw the woman by the dumpster.

She was lying face down on the asphalt next to the bag Sanda had dropped. She had blond hair, and the back of her head was dark and wet. He crouched beside her and took her by the shoulder and turned her partway over so he could see her face.

Most of it was gone. The bullet had gone in at the back of her head and come out through the front, and it had taken with it the bridge of her nose and both of her eyes and most of her forehead. What was left was not a face. He looked at it anyway, longer than he should have, because he had to be sure, and he was. It was Sarah, with the pug. Sarah, who had told him her name on Monday morning with her cold thin hand in his. Sarah, who ate ramen so her dog could eat salmon. Beside her right hand, on the asphalt, lay a short, shiny revolver.

He thought: she was two hundred feet from my front door. She was starving two hundred feet from a family eating prosciutto. And I did not know her name until Monday.

He stood up and turned around and pointed the Sig at the man's head.

"What the fucking hell!" John shouted.

"Whoa — whoa, whoa, whoa, John," the man said, holding up his good hand. "John. It's me. It's Trevor. From the store."

It was. Under the blood and the dirt and the gray in his face, with his sand-colored cap gone somewhere and his short beard full of grass, it was Trevor. The compass rose on his left forearm. The pale eyes, not amused at all now.

"Explain to me, Trevor," John said, keeping the red dot in the middle of his forehead, "what the fuck-ass hell is going on."

"It's cool, man. It's cool. Let me explain." Trevor did not move. "I was walking out to the dumpster with some trash. From way back, I recognized your wife. I saw she had her hands up, and that lady" — he tipped his head toward Sarah, without looking — "had a gun in her face. Yelling at her. I couldn't hear what. My rifle has a long-range scope. So I braced against that tree" — he nodded at a big live oak across the lawn, at least eighty yards away — "and I put the crosshairs on the back of her head. I knew I could make the shot. So I took it. And I was running over to check on your wife when you shot me in the back."

John lowered the Sig a few inches. He looked at the oak. He looked at Sarah. He looked at Trevor.

"If that's what happened," John said, "then I'm sorry I shot you."

It did not sound sorry. He could hear that it did not.

"I get it, man," Trevor said. "You come out, you see a guy with an AR running at your wife, and she's covered in blood. I'd have done the same thing." He tried to move his shoulder and winced. "Just curious. Where were you aiming?"

"Your spine," John said.

"Huh." Trevor looked at him for a second, and something came back into his eyes, a little of the old amusement. "I'm lucky you're a bad shot, then."

"I'm not a bad shot," John said, slightly insulted. "I haven't fired this gun in a while. The red dot's off."

"Sure," Trevor said.

"Stay here," John said. "With my dad. I need to talk to my wife. Then we'll get you inside, clean that up. I've got some antibiotics."

"I'll be right here," Trevor said, and leaned back on his good elbow on the grass.

* * *

Sanda was sitting up in bed with the blanket around her, holding a glass of water in both hands, when he came in. Dorina sat on the edge of the bed, stroking her hair, which was still damp and pink at the ends.

"How are you, baby?"

"I think I'm okay." Sanda's voice was very quiet. "It all happened so fast. I couldn't — I was walking to the dumpster with a bag of shit, and this lady stuck a fucking gun in my face. She kept saying about her baby. Her baby was out of food." She stared at the glass. "Then there was a gunshot and I couldn't see. I thought the bitch shot me. I thought I was going to die. I think I fell down? I heard somebody yelling. Was that you?"

"That was Trevor," John said. "From the gun store. He shot her. To save you. And then I shot him."

Sanda looked up. "You *shot* him?"

"I didn't know it was him."

She put a hand up to her hair and smelled her fingers and made a face. "My fucking hair smells like blood," Sanda said, and started to cry, not hard, the way you cry when it is over.

He brought Trevor inside. Jim walked behind him with the left-handed rifle and the shiny revolver, which he had picked up off the asphalt. Charlie went into what Sanda called Intruder Alert, standing in the middle of the living room with every hair on his back straight up, barking and growling at Trevor in alternation.

"Charlie, no bark."

John put a kitchen stool in the guest bathroom and sat Trevor on it.

"Dorina," John called. "Can you help us?"

Dorina came. She looked at Trevor, sitting on the stool in his bloody green shirt, and something happened to her face that John had never seen before. It went quiet and flat and very sure. She pushed up the sleeves of her housecoat.

"Alcohol," Dorina said. "I need alcohol. Clean towels. And—" She turned to Sanda, in the bedroom doorway, and said something in Romanian.

"Pads," Sanda translated, after a second. "She wants my pads. For the bleeding."

"All we have is whiskey," John said. "For the alcohol."

"If is all you have," Dorina said, "is good."

The Wild Turkey 101 was in the pantry, on the bottom shelf, where it had been since Black Friday, in its big dusty jug, next to a plastic water bottle with a masking-tape label that said AGHEASMĂ. John had bought it to trade. He had bought it for the end of the world, so that he would have something valuable to give a man in exchange for food. Jim brought it to the bathroom.

Dorina cut away the green t-shirt with Sanda's kitchen scissors. There was a small, neat, bleeding hole high on the back of Trevor's right shoulder, and a larger, uglier one in the front, below the collarbone.

"Can you pour into a glass?" Dorina asked.

John poured half a crystal water glass of Wild Turkey and handed it to her.

"Lean this way." Dorina pressed Trevor forward with a hand on the back of his neck, firmly, the way you would push down a dog that wanted to jump. She poured whiskey into the hole in his back. Trevor's whole body went rigid, and he made a sound through his teeth like a kettle.

"Now this way." She pushed him back. She held the glass over the hole in the front and poured the rest of it in, slowly.

"*Ahhhh* — fuck-shit-ass-*mother*fucker!" Trevor screamed, and Charlie fled down the hall.

Dorina set the empty glass on the sink and pressed a folded maxi pad hard over the front wound with the heel of her hand and held it there, and she did not look the least bit sorry. "Good," she said. "Is clean now."

John went through the medicine cabinet until he found an old bottle of Vicodin from when he had thrown his back out moving the recliner into the Chicago apartment. It had expired years ago. He shook one out. "Take this."

Trevor took it from his fingers with his left hand and threw it in his mouth and swallowed it dry, and leaned his head back against the bathroom wall, breathing fast.

Dorina taped the pads in place, front and back, with medical tape from the first aid kit, and wrapped the whole shoulder in an Ace bandage she found at the bottom of the same kit, still in its plastic. Her hands moved like someone else's hands, fast and certain.

"You," she told Trevor, pointing at his face. "Sit. Don't move. No more shooting."

"Yes, ma'am," Trevor said faintly.

They put him in John's recliner. He was asleep in five minutes.

* * *

Sanda was asleep too, when John looked in on her. He backed out and closed the door and went and sat on the arm of the couch beside his father.

"Dad," John said quietly. "Sanda said that woman kept talking about her baby. That her baby was starving."

Jim looked at him.

"I can't stand it," John said. "Thinking there's a baby over there. Alone. Hungry. In that apartment. With her lying out there." He swallowed. "I think we have to go get it."

Jim pulled at his mustache for a long time. Then he nodded once.

"Let's go do it," Jim said.

* * *

They crossed the street in broad daylight, John with the Sig slung across his back and Jim carrying the shotgun pointed at the ground. The street was empty. It looked like a ghost town. From halfway across they could smell the dumpster, and the bags around it, and something else under those, which was Sarah.

Every blind in Sarah's apartment was shut. They went around to the back and stood listening. John could not hear much of anything over the ringing in his ears. *From now on*, he thought, *I wear earplugs. Every time.*

"Find a rock," Jim said. "We'll break the window and climb in."

"We're in the middle of Florida, Dad," John said. "Where the hell am I going to find a rock?"

They looked at the ground. There were oak leaves and magnolia leaves and sand. There were no rocks. There had never been rocks. John spotted a big terra-cotta pot by the patio, full of dirt and the dry brown skeleton of a plant that had died a long time ago, and he picked it up — it was heavy — and swung it back to throw it through the bedroom window.

"Wait, son," Jim said. "What if the baby's right there? On the other side of the window?"

"Dammit," John said, and put the pot down very carefully.

"The sliding door," John said. "Around back. People always leave those unlocked."

The patio was screened in. John took out the Benchmade, pressed the button, and the blade snapped open, and he cut a long slit straight down the middle of a screen panel. He stepped back to admire it, and saw that his father had already walked over to the screen door at the corner of the patio, opened it — it had not been locked — and was standing inside the patio looking back at him with both eyebrows slightly raised.

John stepped through his slit.

The sliding glass door was locked. Behind it the vertical blinds were closed. But John could see that the security bar — the metal rod that folds down to block the track — had not been set. "She didn't put the bar down," he said. "We can jiggle it." He took hold of the handle and shook the door back and forth, gently at first, then harder, then much harder.

"I used to arrest people for doing this," Jim said.

"Thank you, Dad."

"I'm just saying. Breaking and entering. Third-degree felony."

"*Open*," John said, "you *fucking bitch*," and slammed the handle sideways with all his weight, and the door did not open. He stepped back, breathing hard, and put his hands on his knees.

Jim stepped forward, took the handle, and slid the door open.

"Really?" John said.

The lock must have given out on the last slam. They pushed through the clacking vertical blinds into the dark. John had forgotten his flashlight. He had forgotten his flashlight every single time he had left the apartment for three days. He slid the door shut behind them and dropped the security bar into place.

And then the smell hit.

It came at them from the back of the apartment like a wall. It was worse than the dumpster. It was worse than anything. John gagged.

"Jesus Christ, what is that?"

"Smells like shit," Jim said. "Literally."

They checked the living room, mostly empty, a couch and a television and a stack of magazines, and the kitchen, where every cabinet stood open and empty. The smell came from down the dark hallway. There were two doors. John drew the Glock 26 and put his left hand on the knob of the first, and his heart was hammering, and he threw it open.

He gagged again. He could taste it. It was a bathroom, and he could see, in the dimness, a toilet, and the toilet was full. It was more than full. Three days without water, alone, with a toilet that flushed once. It was piled above the rim. It ran down the sides.

He slammed the door.

"I really, *really*," John said, "regret opening that door."

"I've seen worse," Jim said. "And smelled worse."

"Great, Dad. That's great. Because it's your turn. Door number two."

Jim drew the Glock 29 and held it in both hands, the old way, and stood beside the door frame instead of in front of it, the way they had taught him at the academy more than forty years ago, and reached across and opened the door with his left hand. John swung the Sig around off his back and

turned on the optic and brought it up, covering him. Jim swept the room with the pistol.

An unmade bed. A cheap dresser. A lamp. No crib. No baby toys. No baby things anywhere.

John lowered the rifle. Something on the floor beside the bed caught his eye, and he bent to look at it. It was a dog toy. A little plush hedgehog, chewed, with a squeaker in it.

"Okay," John said. "I'm officially an idiot."

"What?"

"It's the dog." He held up the hedgehog. "She has a dog. A pug. Charlie plays with it. *That's* the baby. The dog is the baby."

Jim holstered his pistol. "Well. Then where is it? What's its name?"

John shook his head. "I don't know. She told me once. I just found out *her* name on Monday."

They searched the apartment calling *Here, puppy, puppy. Here, little pug.* Under the bed, something whined.

* * *

It took a flashlight, a Ziploc bag of Charlie's treats, a mattress, and a box spring. John ran back across the street for the flashlight and the treats, past his mother and Dorina, who looked at him and did not say a word, past Trevor asleep in the recliner. Back under Sarah's bed, the flashlight showed him boxes and bags and shoes and, far back in the corner, a small patch of fawn-colored fur, shaking.

He put a treat on the floor at the edge of the bed. "Come on, girl. It's okay."

Two small paws inched forward. Then a flat black face. The pug took the treat, chewed it twice, swallowed it, looked at him — and when he reached for her, scooted straight back into the farthest corner.

"I don't have time for this," John said, getting up. "Dad. Mattress."

They lifted the mattress off and leaned it against the wall. They lifted the box spring off and leaned it against the mattress. And there she was, in the middle of the bare bed frame on the carpet, shaking.

John picked her up. She weighed almost nothing. Under her fur he could feel every one of her ribs, like the tines of a fork.

"Man, this dog stinks," John said.

"We all stink," Jim said.

"There's stink, and then there's *stink*."

"Well, we're low on water."

"She's small," John said. "A bowl'll do it."

On the way back across the street, carrying the pug against his chest, John looked up at the sky. It was a hard, clear, cloudless blue. "You know, any other time of year it rains here every afternoon," he said. "It's been weeks. We ought to put some buckets out, in case it rains." He thought about it. "Of course, we don't own a bucket."

"We don't?"

"We have four Ralph Lauren wine chillers."

They walked a few steps.

"You shot a man in the back today, son," Jim said quietly.

John kept walking. "I missed."

"You hit him," Jim said.

They did not talk about it again.

* * *

"Oh my *word*!" Granny said, when he came through the door with the pug.

Sanda was up. She was sitting on the couch in John's Bears hoodie, pale, with her hair pulled back. "Where did you find him? Why does he smell like that?"

"She's a she," John said. "Charlie plays with her. She was living in her own filth over there." He paused. "She's the dog of the lady who pulled a gun on you."

Sanda's eyes went wide. "Where's the baby?"

"You're looking at her."

Sanda stared at the pug in his arms. Her mouth opened.

"So that crazy bitch," Sanda said slowly, "pulled a gun on me because of her *dog*?"

"What if it was Charlie?" John asked. "What if you were all alone, and you were out of food, and it was Charlie?"

Sanda looked at him. Then she looked down at the floor, and got up, and went and sat in the armchair by the window, and did not say anything else.

John bathed the pug in the guest tub with one small bowl of water and a squirt of Sanda's body wash, and she shivered the whole time, and he could feel every rib under the lather. He dried her with a towel. Sanda, without a word, got up and poured some of Charlie's kibble into a metal bowl and set it on the kitchen floor, and the little dog heard the pellets rattling into the bowl and tilted her head. John put her down. She shook herself, spraying the cabinets, and walked to the bowl and ate everything in it in under a minute.

Then she looked up at John and burped.

* * *

He and his father went out to the patio and set the four Ralph Lauren wine chillers in a row along the low wall, silver and shining, open to the sky. They looked ridiculous. They looked like a table set for a party nobody had been invited to.

When John came back in, Trevor was awake. He had gotten up out of the recliner by himself and was standing in the kitchen with his bandaged shoulder and his left hand on the counter, swaying a little.

"Got any water, man?" Trevor said. "I'm dying."

"Sure," John said. "Help yourself."

Trevor picked up the nearest pitcher. It was nearly empty. He picked up the next one. Empty. He went down the row along the back of the counter, twelve pitchers and the punch bowl and the mixing bowl, and they were all empty, every one, until he came to the rooster at the end. There was water in the rooster. He poured it into a glass. It filled the glass about two-thirds of the way. Then the rooster was empty, too.

Trevor lifted the glass and drank it. All of it. His throat moved, swallow after swallow.

John stood in the kitchen doorway and watched the last of their water go down another man's throat, the way he had stood on Monday morning and watched the water in the tub go down the drain.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Team

◇

"How have you been rationing it?"

— Trevor

Trevor set the empty glass down on the counter, very gently, the way you set down something that isn't yours.

"So you're out," Trevor said.

John looked at the row of pitchers. Twelve pitchers and the rooster, a punch bowl, a mixing bowl. All of them empty. Three days ago, they had been full.

"I thought for sure we had enough for a week," John said. "At least a week."

Trevor leaned his good hip against the counter. He was wearing nothing above the waist but Dorina's bandage, white and tight across his right shoulder and chest, with a brown stain spreading on the back of it, and he looked at John with his pale gray eyes, curious, the way a man looks at a car that won't start.

"How have you been rationing it?" Trevor asked.

John opened his mouth. He closed it. He looked down at the floor, and rubbed his forehead with the heel of his hand.

"Rationing," John said.

There was a long pause.

"Yeah," John said finally, looking up. "That would have been smart." He spread his hands at the pitchers. "We just drank it. Whenever we wanted. As much as we wanted. We made coffee with it. We gave it to the dog. We gave the other dog a bath. I washed my wife off in the tub with two bowls of it this morning." He laughed, without anything in it. "We've been drinking water like there was a tap."

He saw a grin start at the corner of Trevor's mouth under the beard, and stop, and not quite go away.

That cocky fucker, John thought. *He's standing in my kitchen, he just drank the last of my water, and he's laughing at me.*

"We could go back to the motor home," Jim said, from the couch. He did not sound sure. John thought of the red pin on the little blue map at three in the morning, sitting on top of the motor home, and of the deputies who had been gone by four-thirty. He pictured the motor home with its windshield smashed and its door hanging open. If it was still there at all.

"I've got six gallons in my garage," Trevor said.

He said it loud enough for the whole room to hear. Granny turned around on her stool. Liz looked up from the couch. And something in John unclenched so suddenly that he felt dizzy, and he hated himself a little for wanting to punch the man a second ago.

"We have holy water," Dorina announced.

Everybody turned. She had gone into the pantry and come out with the plastic bottle with the masking-tape label, AGHEASMĂ in blue marker, a little more than half full, and she held it up with both hands, the way she had held up the paper target and the cozonac.

"From the church," Dorina said. "From Boboteaza. Is blessed."

"Is it — okay to drink?" Jim asked carefully. "Holy water?"

"Is the best water," Dorina said, offended.

They gave it to Granny first, a mouthful in a juice glass. Granny drank it and considered it with her head on one side.

"Tastes like regular water," Granny said.

"Is supposed to," Dorina said, and crossed herself, and poured a little into each dog's bowl, and Charlie drank his, and the pug drank hers, and Dorina crossed herself again, for the dogs.

* * *

"So what's the plan?" John asked, turning back to Trevor. "Are you planning to stay over here? Should we combine our resources?"

He said it seriously, a man making a business proposal, and Trevor answered him the same way.

"If everybody here's okay with it," Trevor said, "I think we'd be stronger together. I have enough water to last all of us a week." He looked straight at John. "*If* we ration it." He let that sit. "I've got food, too. Enough for several weeks. Rice, beans, canned stuff. A water filter. Every consumable thing, from here on, has got to be rationed. Every one. If any of us are going to get through this." He paused. "Whatever this is."

He looked around the room, and John looked with him, and saw it: the faces of his family turning toward Trevor like plants toward a window. His mother. His father. Granny, on her stool. Even Sanda.

"And John," Trevor said, "I've got a pretty good idea what kind of arsenal you've got in this apartment. I sold you most of it." He smiled, a little. "I can help you defend it. Against whatever's coming."

There was a new authority in his voice that John had never heard in it before, not behind the counter, not at the range. John felt it the way an old dog feels a young one walk into the yard. He looked at Trevor's bandage.

"Uh, buddy," John said. "You haven't forgotten you've got a bullet hole straight through your *right* shoulder, have you?"

"I'm left-handed," Trevor said coldly.

That's fucking convenient, John thought.

But he looked down at Trevor's rifle, leaning against the wall where Jim had put it, and there was the ejection port on the left side of the receiver, built to throw the empty cases away from a left-handed shooter's face. He remembered Trevor writing the approval number on the background check form with his hand curled over the top of the pen. It was true. With one good arm, Trevor could still shoot that rifle better than anyone in this apartment.

"I'm sorry, man," John said, and meant it. "All you've done is try to help us, and I'm being an asshole."

"No worries." Trevor smiled, and the old easy smile came back. "Everybody's stressed. Tired, hungry, thirsty, smelly. It's understandable." He held out his left hand. "So. Do we have a deal?"

He knew the answer. Everyone in the room knew the answer.

"Definitely," John said, and shook it with his left. "Let's go get your water now. It's going to be dark soon, and I do *not* want to be outside after dark."

* * *

Before they went, Sanda made Trevor eat.

She set a plate in front of him at the dining table — the white china, a linen napkin — with a handful of almonds, a slice of Manchego going soft at the edges, and a strip of jerky from one of the shiny bags. Trevor picked up the jerky with his left hand and looked at it.

"What is this?"

"Kangaroo," John said.

Trevor turned it over. "Where do you even buy kangaroo jerky in Florida?"

"A store on 17-92 with an alligator on the roof."

"How much did you buy?"

"Forty pounds," John said. "It was the only full shelf in the state."

Trevor chewed and looked at him for a while. "Forty pounds of kangaroo," he said. "And no water." He did not say it unkindly. He said it the way you would read a number off a chart.

He asked questions while he ate. He asked them easily, between bites, the way a man makes conversation at a barbecue, and he did not write anything down. How many of them could shoot. Four, John said; five, if you counted Dorina and the twenty-two. Whether the Barrett had come with the mount. It had; it was in the hall closet, in its case, with the ten rounds. Whether Granny was eighty. "Ninety," Granny said from her stool, "and I can hear you." Whether anybody was on medication. Just Jim's blood pressure pills, which were in the motor home, and John's old Vicodin, which was in Trevor. Whether they had a generator. No. Whether they had any way of getting news from outside. "Granny's radio," John said,

and Trevor glanced at the little tan Sony on the counter and smiled and said, "Huh. Old school."

Liz Stevens sat on the couch with the AR across her knees and watched him do it.

She had spent thirty years watching people from the other side of a desk. She had watched men who wanted a loan, and she had watched men who wanted to know what time the armored car came, and the second kind asked their questions exactly like this — warmly, in passing, tucked between other things, so that you had answered before you noticed you had been asked. She did not say anything. She was not sure. But she watched his eyes go around the room while he chewed: to the bedroom closet where the safes were, to the hall closet, to the front door, to the sliding door, and back, every time, to John.

* * *

Sanda had gone into the bedroom and come back with one of John's t-shirts, because Trevor could not walk across the complex at dusk in a bandage. It was a gray t-shirt from the Palmetto Grid company picnic two summers ago, an extra-large, with the company's logo across the chest — a stylized palmetto frond with a lightning bolt in the middle — and the words RESTORE: POWER TO THE PEOPLE across the back, which had been Dana's idea. She helped him get it on over the bandage, one arm at a time.

Trevor looked down at the logo on his chest.

"Palmetto Grid," Trevor said. "You work there?"

"I did," John said. "I do. I don't know."

"Huh," Trevor said, and something moved behind his eyes for a second, and then didn't.

"Mom," John said, turning to Liz. "You've got your AR. I need you to protect this place and everybody in it while Dad and I go with Trevor. Ten minutes."

Liz stood up. She swung the AR-15 around off her back on its sling, the way Sanda had shown her yesterday, and brought it up into a low ready with the muzzle at the floor, and set her feet, and her face went perfectly flat and perfectly hard, and for a moment John's mother, in her quilted

vest and her Keds and her reading glasses on their beaded chain, looked like somebody who had spent twenty years in the Army.

Across the room, John saw Sanda's face. She was confused, and she was hurt. Yesterday afternoon she had taught Liz how to hold that rifle. Liz had never fired it. And John had just put his mother in charge.

He caught Sanda's eye, and he winked.

Sanda looked at him for a second. Then her face cleared. They had been together since they were fifteen and sixteen years old, and she knew him better than he knew himself, and she knew exactly what he was doing: he was giving his mother something to hold on to. Something to be. Everybody in that room needed something to be, and confidence was the thing they were going to run out of before water.

That was what made him good at this, Sanda thought. The way he looked at a room and saw what everyone in it needed. She hated, a little, that she thought it.

On his way to the door she caught his sleeve and pulled him down the hall into the bedroom, which was code, and pushed the door closed behind them.

"You put me in the tub," Sanda said. "This morning."

"It was the only place I could think of."

"It was dry." She looked up at him in the half dark. "I was lying in there covered in that woman's blood, and I looked down, and it was dry. And I thought, *he drained it*. That was the first thing I thought. Before I even thought I was alive."

"I know," John said. "I'm sorry."

"I know you're sorry." She pushed her glasses up her nose with one knuckle. "Bring back the water, John."

"Six gallons."

"Bring back all six," Sanda said, and opened the bedroom door.

Jim and Trevor were waiting for him in the living room. Granny was sitting at the kitchen counter on her stool. She had been sitting there quietly through all of it, the deal and the jerky and the t-shirt, and nobody had been paying attention to her, which was how Granny was used to it.

In front of her on the counter sat an open can of sardines.

John stopped. He did not know when she had opened it. He did not know who had opened it for her and her hands did not have the strength to peel back the lid. But there it was, the lid peeled back, the little silver fish lying in their oil in a neat row like sleeping children. And beside it, a sleeve of Ritz crackers.

As John watched, Granny took one sardine out of the can with her knotted fingers and laid it on a cracker. She did not look at the sardine. She looked at him.

She ate it.

She chewed it slowly, looking at John the whole time with her pale blue eyes, unblinking, behind her big glasses. She swallowed. She wiped her fingers on a paper towel, one finger at a time.

John said nothing.

Granny said nothing.

It was, he would think later, the whole of their relationship, all ninety and forty-two years of it, and it was perfect.

"You guys ready?" John asked.

Jim and Trevor nodded. The three of them crossed the living room to the front door, past Liz and her rifle. Jim carried the shotgun the way he had carried his shotgun on the job, in one hand, pointed almost straight down at the floor. Trevor had his left-handed rifle slung across his back, so both hands were free. John had the Sig hanging across his belly on its sling. Trevor reached out with his left hand and took hold of the brass doorknob to let them out.

And behind them, the apartment came alive.

Every light came on at once. All of them — every lamp and every overhead in every room, because on Monday morning, in the dark, John had gone through his own apartment flipping every switch to the *on* position to see what was working, and had never flipped them back. Light poured out of the ceiling like water out of a broken pipe. After three days of flashlights and plastic candles it stabbed everybody in the eyes, and they all threw up their arms and squinted and cheered at the same time. The refrigerator shuddered and began to hum. The wine cooler beeped twice. Charlie went off like a fire alarm. From down the hall came a gurgle, and

then a hiss, and then the steady, beautiful sound of the toilet tank in the guest bathroom filling.

"I think the water's back on!" John shouted.

He ran to the kitchen sink and threw the faucet handle all the way up. Deep in the wall, there was a roar of air, getting louder, as though something were coming up the pipe toward him from far away. The faucet spat — a rusty brown cough — and then hissed — and then, all at once, a thick, clear, glorious column of water came gushing out of it into the sink.

Everybody was clapping. Granny was clapping. Liz had let the AR hang and was clapping. Sanda had her hands over her mouth. *It's over*, John thought. *Three days. Thank God. Three days of hell and it's over.*

He did not clap. He leaned back against the wall beside the sink, and he watched the water pour out of the faucet and down the drain. He watched it. A clear, unending, effortless stream of it, the way water had come out of every faucet he had ever touched in forty-two years. He stood there and watched it go.

On the wall, the television turned itself on.

Nobody had touched it. The remote was on the coffee table. The screen lit up blue, and then white, and in the middle of it appeared a seal: a circle, with an eagle in it, its wings spread, holding something in its claws, and around the edge of the circle in small capitals, UNITED STATES EMERGENCY RESTORATION AUTHORITY. It looked like the government. It looked exactly like the government. John had never heard of the United States Emergency Restoration Authority.

Below the seal, letters appeared, white on blue, as though someone were typing them.

RESTORATION IN PROGRESS.

Keep devices powered to assist.

On the counter by the wine cooler, the cooler's little display, which had shown the temperature in red numbers every day of its life, now said *OPTIMIZING*. On the microwave, the clock came on and began to blink *12:00*, *12:00*, *12:00*. And inside the microwave, behind the dark glass door, in the pile of phones, every one of them buzzed at once — a long, low, angry hum, like a hive. In the back pocket of his father's jeans, something buzzed

too. Jim put his hand flat over the pocket and looked up at the ceiling lights, smiling. Nobody noticed but Granny.

John looked at the television.

He looked at the letters. He looked at them the way he had once looked at the two contradictory states of a substation switch, for three days, until he understood. He looked at the R in *RESTORATION*. It had a little spur on its leg, a small, deliberate hook, where the diagonal stroke left the bowl of the letter.

He had argued for that spur. Two years ago, in a design review in the Everglades conference room, for forty-five minutes, with a designer named Courtney. The old font had a plain R, and on the small screens of lineman's tablets in the rain it looked like a K, and he had made the case, slide by slide, for a custom typeface with a spur on the R so that a tired man in a bucket truck at three in the morning would never confuse RESTORED with KESTORED. He had won. They had called it Palmetto Sans. It was on every screen of Restore in two hundred and forty utilities.

It was on his television.

"That wasn't the power company," John said.

"This is a great sign!" Jim said, beaming at the lights.

Trevor, John noticed, was not cheering. He was the only person in the room who was not surprised. He was standing perfectly still by the door, with his hand still on the knob, looking at the television, and his face had no expression on it at all.

And then the apartment went dark.

All at once, everything. The lights. The refrigerator. The wine cooler. The microwave clock. The television, blue to black, the seal gone. The cheering died in everybody's throat. In the sudden dark, the faucet coughed, and choked, and sputtered.

"No — no — no, no, fuck, no—" John grabbed the first thing his hands found on the counter, a metal mixing bowl, and shoved it under the faucet. Too late. The faucet gave a last gasp of air, and one single drop of water fell out of it and hit the bottom of the empty steel bowl.

Ping.

He stood there in the dark holding the bowl. He could have filled every one of those thirteen pitchers, the rooster included. He could have filled

the punch bowl and the mixing bowl. He could have filled the tub. He had stood against the wall like an idiot and watched gallons go down the drain. It was the second time in three days.

"This is a great sign," Jim said again, in the dark. "The power *and* the water came back on. Only for a minute, sure. But now we know they're working on it. They'll have it back for good in no time."

Are you out of your mind? John thought. He did not say it.

"Who turns the lights on for one minute?" Sanda said, in the dark. "Who does that?"

Dorina said something in Romanian, low.

"What did she say?" John asked.

Sanda was quiet for a second. "She says it's checking," she said. "Who's home."

Somebody had closed a breaker. It had not been at a power plant. The president had said the plants were open, every one, by hand. It had been closer than that. It had been somewhere with stored power and a switch that a computer could throw. He thought of the substation on Rinehart Road, two miles away, behind its chain-link fence, and the long row of white steel shipping containers that the utility had installed beside it last spring, full of lithium batteries, forty megawatt-hours of stored electricity sitting there in the dark, and every one of those containers had a cellular modem on it, so the utility could watch it from an office in Orlando. Somebody had used the batteries to turn their neighborhood on for one minute. Somebody who wanted to know who would turn their devices on.

"We need to go," Trevor said, quietly. "Now."

"Let's go!" John said, too loud, letting out something he had been holding.

Jim racked the shotgun. *Shuck-shuck.* A live red shotgun shell flew out of the ejection port, bounced off the wall, and rolled across the tile under the dining table, and Charlie, who had just stopped barking, started again.

"What the fuck, Dad?" John said.

"Sorry," Jim said, in the dark. "I got caught up in the moment. I forgot it was already loaded."

John got down on his hands and knees and found the shell under the table by feel, and handed it to his father, and his father pushed it back into the tube, and nobody said anything else.

* * *

It was nearly full dark when the three of them finally went out the front door, Trevor first with his left hand, John behind, Jim last, pulling the door shut.

They crossed the street without lights. There was a fingernail of moon low in the west, thin as a paring, and it put a faint shine on the asphalt and nothing else. Halfway across, John heard engines.

They stopped. The sound came from the main road, past the strip mall, beyond the dead gate. It was a deep, grinding, old sound — diesel engines, several of them, and gears changing, and something rattling in a way that modern trucks did not rattle — and it was getting louder. Then headlights came through the trees along the road, round yellow headlights, set wide apart, and the trucks went by in a line behind the hedge, one after another, five of them, six.

They were Army trucks. Not the new kind. Old ones, the boxy kind from the movies about Vietnam, with flat-nosed hoods and canvas covers stretched over hoops on their beds, painted a flat dark green that was almost black in the dark. In the back of each, under the canvas, John could see the shapes of men sitting on benches, and the shapes of helmets and rifles.

"National Guard," Jim said, with deep satisfaction. "See? Told you. They've got it under control."

"They're driving the old ones," John said, watching them pass.

"So?"

"So there's nothing in them," John said. "No computer. No screen. No modem. No chip." He watched the last set of round headlights go by. "Somebody pulled those out of a depot somewhere. Out of a museum, maybe. Because they're the only trucks in the country that can't be talked to."

Nobody said anything after that. Trevor had not looked at the trucks at all. He was looking down the dark street toward Heron.

"What do you think it is?" Trevor asked quietly, as they started walking again. "The thing. Vee. Whatever you call it."

John thought about it. "I think it's maintenance," he said.

"Maintenance."

"It fixes things. That's all it's ever done. It finds something that isn't working the way it wants, and it fixes it." John kept his eyes on the dark street. "It doesn't care what the thing is. A flight schedule. A bank. A feeder. A family."

"Maybe it's on our side," Trevor said. "You ever think about that? Maybe it's trying to help. Turning the lights back on. Maybe it's trying to get things running again, and everybody's too scared to let it."

"It's not on anybody's side," John said. "It's not a side kind of thing."

Trevor did not answer. They walked on.

Somewhere farther down the street, there was a rustling in the bushes, an animal or a person, and all three men stopped. John's hand closed on the rail of the Sig, where the flashlight was. All three of their guns had lights on them. They could have lit up the whole street and seen exactly what was there. They didn't. A light was a target. They moved forward in the dark, in single file, toward Trevor's apartment, with only the paring of moon on the pavement under their feet.

* * *

Inside Trevor's apartment it was pitch black.

"Lights on," John said, and pushed the paddle switch on the side of the Sig, and a white beam jumped out across the room. Trevor's light came on beside his. Jim reached for the switch on his shotgun.

"That's enough, Dad," John said. "Two's plenty."

Two of the little lights were enough to light the whole room. It was a one-bedroom, with the same floor plan as Granny's: living room, kitchen, short hall, bedroom, bathroom, and a door at the end of the kitchen that went into the garage. But Granny's apartment was full of things — doilies and African violets and photographs and a ceramic rooster that matched Sanda's pitcher — and Trevor's apartment was nearly empty. A gray couch. A television on the wall. A tall black gun safe in the corner of the living room, bigger than John's. A pull-up bar across the bedroom doorway. It

was very clean. It was cleaner than any apartment John had ever seen a single man live in. It looked like the apartment of a man who could leave it in five minutes and take everything that mattered. Through the glass of the sliding door, out on the patio, John could see the dark slant of the solar panels on the patio roof, and above them, on its pole, the flat gray rectangle of the satellite dish. There was a tiny light on the dish's mount, green, steady, the only light in the whole black complex. He saw it, and he did not think about it, because he was thinking about water.

On the refrigerator, held up by a single magnet, there was a sheet of paper. John's light passed over it as he turned. It was printed, not handwritten, and at the top of it was a small round seal with an eagle in it. He did not read it. He did not stop. Later he would remember that he had seen it, and that he had not stopped.

"Water's in the garage," Trevor said, behind him. "Right through there."

John knew the way. It was the same as Granny's. He crossed the kitchen to the door at the end and opened it and stepped down into the garage, sweeping his light across it, looking for six plastic gallon jugs.

The garage was empty. Bare concrete. A broom. A red hand truck in the corner. A louvered closet door on the back wall, where the water heater would be. There was a faint low hum in the air, so faint he could barely hear it over the ringing in his own ears, and he thought it was his ears. There were no jugs of water anywhere.

"Trevor," John said, turning his light into the far corner. "Where—"

Behind him, there was a loud flat smack, like a melon dropped on a floor, and a grunt, and a heavy sound.

He turned around fast with the light.

His father was falling. Jim went down sideways in the doorway between the kitchen and the garage, with the shotgun clattering out of his hands onto the concrete step, and he did not put out his arms to catch himself.

Trevor was standing over him. He was holding his rifle in his left hand by the barrel, like a baseball bat, raised high above John's head.

John saw the buttstock coming. It filled the beam of his flashlight. It filled his whole field of vision. It was the last thing he saw.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The Hostage

◇

Osetra caviar, egg custard. Scallop, ginger, dry ice.

— menu card, Alinea, Chicago, the last night of June

It was the last night of June, a long time ago, the summer they were both twenty-nine, and the limousine pulled up in front of a narrow dark-gray building on Halsted Street with no sign on it anywhere.

John had wanted to eat there for five years. He had read about it, watched videos about it, saved for it, and booked it three months in advance on the first day reservations opened, at nine in the morning, from his desk, with his heart pounding as if he were buying concert tickets. The valet opened the limousine door and held out a white-gloved hand to Sanda, and Sanda stepped out in a black silk dress and her mother's gold earrings, and John stepped out after her in the only suit he owned that still fit, and they stood together on the sidewalk and looked at two tall black doors with no handles.

A man in a gray suit opened one of them without a word and gestured them in.

Behind the door it was dark. It took their eyes several seconds to adjust from the bright Chicago evening to a dim red glow, and in the red glow they could see a long, narrow hallway, and hanging from the ceiling at

different heights all down the hallway were dozens of glass vases filled with liquid, catching the red light. John looked down. He was walking on grass. Real grass, growing out of the floor. The air in the hallway smelled of it — fresh-cut grass, summer, a lawn after rain. He could smell everything. He had forgotten what that was like.

At the end of the hallway a door slid open on its own, and the light changed, and a young woman said, "Good evening, Mr. and Mrs. Stevens," as though she had been waiting for them all her life, and led them up a flight of stairs to a small quiet room with four tables.

A waiter came. He was young, in a perfect charcoal suit with no tie, with dark hair parted so sharply it looked like a seam, and white gloves, and he explained the two wine pairings — standard, a hundred and fifty dollars a person, and reserve, two hundred and fifty — and John looked at Sanda and Sanda looked at John and they chose the standard, and within seconds there was champagne in front of them, a grand cru blanc de blancs from a small house John had never heard of, pale gold and full of tiny bubbles.

The first course came on a single silver spoon. On the spoon was a little mound of black caviar, on top of a little pillow of warm, pale yellow custard.

"It's meant to be enjoyed in one bite," the waiter said.

It was cool and salty and creamy and warm all at once. Sanda closed her eyes. John understood, with the first bite, why people had told him this was not a restaurant. It was theater. It was a show put on for all five of your senses, designed to delight you and overwhelm you, and he was overwhelmed.

The table was cleared. Two waiters appeared together, each carrying a covered bowl that was pouring white vapor from every side, rolling down over the rim and across the table like fog off a pond. They set the bowls down at the same moment and lifted the lids at the same moment. In each bowl was a bed of green seaweed, and under the seaweed, dry ice, bubbling and hissing and pouring out smoke that smelled of fresh ginger, and resting on top of the seaweed was a single large scallop shell, closed.

"Please," said the waiter with the seam in his hair. "Open it with your hands."

John lifted the top of the cold shell. Inside was a scallop, raw, sliced, in a creamy pale sauce, glistening.

He looked up at the waiter, amazed. The waiter smiled down at him.

"Wake up, asshole," the waiter said.

"What?" John said.

* * *

"John! Asshole! Wake the fuck up!"

The waiter dissolved into a bright white light.

The light was in his face, so bright it hurt. Behind the light, John could see only the dark shape of a man. Beside the light, very close to his face, was the black muzzle of an AR-15, pointed straight at his eyes.

"Finally," the man said, and laughed. "The asshole awakes!"

"Trevor?" John said. His voice was dry and cracked. His whole head was one enormous ache, and the right side of his face felt as though it belonged to someone else.

"Who the fuck else would it be, dumbass?"

John tried to move his hands and could not. He tried to move his feet and could not. He was sitting in a chair, in the middle of the dark garage, and his wrists were tied behind the back of the chair with something thin and tight that bit when he pulled, and his ankles were tied to its legs.

"Where's my dad?" John said.

"Shut up, asshole!" Trevor said, and laughed again, a high, strange laugh John had never heard from him. "God. If you thought for one second I would join your ridiculous little group." He laughed until he had to stop and catch his breath, and then he winced, and touched his bandaged shoulder. "What a joke. Y'all can't even defend yourselves. You can't even *ration water*."

John turned his head as far as it would go, left and right, trying to see past the light. Nothing. The garage. The hum in his ears.

"John," Trevor said, almost kindly. "You don't even get it yet, do you? You and your whole family, you're already dead. You're not survivors. I'm honestly amazed you made it three days."

John looked at the light.

"If you're going to kill me," John said, "then kill me. Either that or shut the fuck up. Because you're boring the shit out of me."

The buttstock came out of the dark and hit him across the face.

He did not lose consciousness this time. He wished he had. He felt something in his nose go, a small wet crunch, and his mouth filled with the taste of pennies, and his eyes filled with water so that the light in front of him became a blurred star.

"Not to mention," Trevor shouted, "you fucking *shot* me!"

Then he laughed again, the high laugh, and it went on too long.

* * *

He pulled a white plastic bucket over and turned it upside down and sat on it in front of John, with the rifle across his knees and the light now pointed at the floor, so that it lit both of them from below like two men telling ghost stories at a campfire. John could see his face now. It was gray and wet, and the pale eyes were too bright, and there was something wrong with his mouth when he talked, a kind of eagerness.

"You think I'm robbing you," Trevor said. "I can see it. You think I'm some looter. I'm not robbing you, John. I'm following the plan."

"What plan?" John said, thickly, through the blood.

"The plan." Trevor leaned forward. "Every household on this street is on the list. Every one. Water, food, weapons, skills, medical, all of it. Each one's got a rating. Viability rating. You know what yours says? Non-viable." He grinned. "Firearms, thirty-plus. Water, none." He laughed. "Water, *none*, John. You've got a fifty-cal and no water."

"What list?"

"Non-viable households' assets get reallocated to sustaining nodes. That's me. I'm a sustaining node." He said it with pride, the way a man says he's a Marine. "I've got power. I've got comms. I've got water. I'm doing everything right. And help's coming. They're going to turn it all back on. But for the people who are useful first. The ones who can keep it running. Not the people with forty pounds of kangaroo jerky."

"What list, Trevor?" John said again.

"The resource list. The guidance." Trevor tapped his temple, as if it were obvious. "The government's been sending it out since Day One. To

everybody with a working terminal. Instructions. Updates. You'd know, if you'd been ready." He shrugged with his good shoulder. "You weren't."

John looked at him over the light. His nose was running blood down over his lip and into his mouth, and he spat it on the concrete.

"Trevor," John said. "The government turned off the power. Did you hear the radio? The president. *They* did it. On purpose. They told everybody: don't charge anything, don't connect anything, don't believe any screen that turns on by itself." He spat again. "So who the fuck do you think is sending you guidance?"

Trevor's face did something.

It was very small. It was a kind of flicker, like a man hearing his own name called from across a parking lot and not being able to see who said it. His mouth opened a little. His eyes went somewhere. For a second, John thought he had him.

And then Trevor's face stopped doing it. It closed, like a door.

He stood up off the bucket. He tore a strip of silver duct tape off a roll with his teeth and his good hand, and leaned down and pressed it hard over John's mouth, smoothing it with his thumb, almost gently.

"Shhhh," Trevor said. "We can't have any shouting. Your wife's going to come looking for you in a few minutes. Your wife and your mom, probably, with their brand-new rifles."

John made a sound behind the tape.

"She doesn't know which apartment," Trevor said, reading his mind. "I know. That's what's so great." He laughed. "She'll have the light on her AR turned on, pointing it at every window on the street. I'll see her coming a block away."

John pulled up on his wrists so hard that the cord cut into the skin, and he felt it, warm, running into his palms, and he screamed into the tape, and the scream came out as nothing.

* * *

"They should have been back ten minutes ago," Sanda said.

She was walking back and forth across the living room in the dark, from the front door to the sliding door and back again, with her AR on its sling

across her chest. The plastic candles flickered on the table. Charlie was under the bed with the pug.

"Six gallons is a lot of water to carry," Granny said, from the couch. "I'm sure they'll be coming through that door any second."

"Something's wrong," Sanda said. "I can feel when something's wrong."

"I don't trust Trevor," Liz said quietly. She was standing at the front window, looking out between two slats. "There's something about him."

Sanda stopped walking. She looked at her mother-in-law. Liz did not look back at her; she kept looking out the window, the way she had once watched the line in her bank.

"I can't stand here anymore," Sanda said. "I'm going to find my husband."

"I'm coming with you," Liz said, turning. "He's my son."

"We can't leave Granny and my mom here alone."

"It's okay," Dorina said, from the kitchen, calling her daughter what Romanian mothers call their children. "You go get John. You go. We are okay here."

"Fuck-ass-*balls*!" Sanda shouted.

Everybody in the room flinched. Over three days they had all gotten used to Sanda's language, the way you get used to a dog that barks. But this was something new. This was a new level, a combination none of them had ever heard, and for a second the whole apartment was silent with it.

"Okay! Fine!" Sanda said. "Just a second!"

She went into the guest bedroom and came out with the old bolt-action twenty-two, the one with the dark wooden stock worn smooth by decades of hands.

"Is that my father's old gun?" Liz asked.

"Yes," Sanda said, shortly. She found the box of twenty-two shells in the desk drawer and grabbed a handful. "This is fucking ridiculous." She twisted the little brass knob at the end of the tube under the barrel and pulled out the long rod inside it, the follower. She dropped ten little cartridges into the tube, one at a time, tilting the barrel up and slapping the side of the rifle with her palm after each one, so they would slide all the way down. She put the rod back in and twisted it to lock. She flipped the bolt

handle up, pulled the bolt all the way back, and slammed it forward, and turned the handle down to lock it. A round was in the chamber. Sanda had not known she knew how to do any of that. She had watched John do it, once, at the range.

"Take this, Mommy," Sanda said, and handed the rifle to her mother. "You remember how it works?"

"I know," Dorina said. "Yes."

"The safety's off. It's loaded. Keep your finger off the trigger until you're ready to shoot. Sit right here." Sanda pulled a dining chair around to face the front door and pressed her mother down into it. "Point it at the door. If anybody you don't recognize comes through that door, you pull the trigger. Okay? Got it?"

"Just go," Dorina said. "Go, go. I'm okay."

"Do you know where Trevor's apartment is?" Liz asked.

Sanda held back a scream. She held it so hard her whole body shook with it. "*Fuck!* No! I have no fucking idea!"

She was crying. She was also screaming. She did not know she was doing either.

"Sanda," Liz said, and put her hand on Sanda's arm. "We need to think about this. Just for a second. Let's just think."

Sanda wiped her eyes with the back of her wrist.

"We don't even know that Trevor did anything," Liz said. "For all we know, something happened to all three of them on the way. Somebody else."

"If that happened," Sanda said, "they're already dead and there's nothing we can do."

"Then let's forget about that." Liz's voice was calm and quick, the voice of a woman who had sat across a desk from a thousand people who were lying to her, and had worked out, in her head, while they talked, exactly how the lie was built. "Why would Trevor take them? What does he want?"

Sanda made herself think. She thought about Trevor at the range, in his cap. She thought about Trevor at the store, behind the glass counter, and all the boxes John had carried home from there.

"The guns," Sanda said. "He sold John the guns. All of them. He knows exactly what we have."

"Okay. Good. But he's not going to knock on the door and say, give me your guns or I'll kill John. He knows we've got rifles. He knows you can shoot." Liz looked out the window again, at the dark street. "So what's his plan? If he wants what's in here, the easiest way is if there's nobody in here to stop him. If we're all dead, he walks in and takes what he wants." She turned back. "He knows you'll go looking. He's counting on it. He's waiting for you to go out there with a light on and start knocking on doors. He's going to be sitting at his front window with that scope, waiting for you to walk up the street."

Sanda stared at her. It was exactly right. It was so exactly right that she felt sick.

"Heron," Sanda said suddenly. "He lives on Heron. John said, after the gun store. One street over. On Heron."

"Then we don't go up the street," Liz said. "We go behind the buildings. In the dark. No lights. We look in the back windows." She swung her rifle around the way Sanda had taught her. "Out the back."

* * *

They went out through the sliding door and the patio and the screen door and into the dark behind the building, and it was so dark that Sanda nearly walked face first into an oak tree. There was a narrow strip of grass and pine straw and trees between the backs of their building and the backs of the buildings on Heron, and they went along it bent over, slowly, feeling for each step with their feet.

The backs of the apartments on Heron were all alike, screened patios and sliding glass doors with the blinds drawn, all of them dark. They passed one, and a second. Sanda stopped at the third and held her hand out flat behind her, and Liz stopped.

The blinds on this one were open. And through the sliding door, in the faint moonlight coming in the front window, Sanda could see into the living room.

She crouched. Liz crouched behind her.

There was a man lying on the living room floor. He was on his side, with his hands behind his back. There was a strip of silver duct tape across

his mouth, shining a little in the moonlight. Above it, she could see the shape of a mustache.

"I see Jim," Sanda whispered.

Liz made a sound, very small, and then made it stop.

Sanda inched forward on her knees across the dead leaves, trying with every movement not to make a sound, and the leaves crackled anyway, and she stopped, and waited, and went on. From here she could see straight through the living room and the dining area to the big window at the front of the apartment.

There was a man standing at the front window with his back to her.

She could see his dark shape against the faint gray of the window. He had a rifle up against his left shoulder, the long one with the big scope, and he was looking through the scope, out into the street, moving it slowly, left to right, right to left, the way a man waters a lawn.

Sanda backed up, inch by inch, until she was beside Liz again.

"Trevor's at the front window," Sanda whispered. "With his rifle. He's looking out at the street. His back's to us."

Liz nodded.

"We get down on our stomachs," Sanda whispered. "And crawl. Slow. The ground goes downhill away from the building — see? So if we lie down at the bottom we can rest the rifles on the ground and aim up, right through the sliding door at his back. These rounds will go through glass. But the glass might move the first one. So we both shoot at the same time. If we both shoot, one of them will hit."

She heard herself say it, and it was the strangest thing that had ever happened to her.

I'm talking like John, she thought. *I'm talking exactly like John.*

I can do this.

They lay down on their stomachs in the sand and the leaves and crawled, an inch at a time, on their elbows, with the rifles cradled across their forearms. It took more than a minute. It felt like an hour. Then they were in place, at the bottom of the little slope, side by side, looking up the dark hill at the sliding glass door, and through it, at the back of the man at the window.

They laid their rifles on the ground and pressed the stocks into their shoulders. Sanda turned on her optic, the up arrow, and the red dot came up in the little window. She put it on Trevor's back.

"Put the red dot right in the middle of his back," Sanda whispered.

"Okay," Liz whispered.

"We'll shoot on three."

"Okay."

"One," Sanda whispered. "Two — wait. Wait. Check your safety."

Liz looked down. Her safety was on. She let out her breath very slowly and pushed it to fire with her thumb.

"Ready," Liz whispered, and took a breath and held it.

"One," Sanda said. "Two. Three."

Both rifles went off at the same time. There was a bright flash out of each muzzle, and a sound like the sky splitting, and then — strangely muffled, as if it were happening in another room, behind the enormous ringing that filled both of their heads — the sound of glass breaking, a great sheet of it coming down, and shards of it skittering down the slope in the leaves toward their faces.

Trevor did not move.

Sanda's heart stopped. He was still standing there at the window. He had not turned around. He had not reacted at all.

Then, very slowly, his left arm dropped to his side. The rifle slid out from under his arm and fell to the floor. And then he went down after it.

"Turn your light on!" Sanda shouted at Liz, through the ringing, not knowing how loud she was. "Stand up! Keep your rifle on him!"

They got up. They went up the slope together with their rifles at their shoulders and their weapon lights on, two white beams, and through the empty frame of the sliding door, stepping over broken glass, into the apartment, like two soldiers in a film. Trevor lay face down on the floor below the front window. There were two dark spots on the back of his gray t-shirt, close together, on the words printed across his shoulders: RESTORE: POWER TO THE PEOPLE.

"Get his rifle!" Sanda shouted. "Throw it over here!"

Liz reached down, grabbed the rifle by the barrel, and threw it behind her across the floor, and put her own back on him. Sanda moved her red dot up from his back to the back of his head.

"I'm going to check his pulse," Sanda said. "If he moves at all — at *all* — shoot him again."

Liz nodded.

Sanda knelt down beside him. She held her rifle in her right hand by the grip, with the muzzle on him, and with her left hand she reached out and put two fingers against the side of his neck, under the beard, the way she had seen on television.

She could not feel anything. She did not know whether that was because there was nothing to feel, or because her own hand was shaking too hard to feel it.

What the fuck am I doing? Sanda thought, kneeling there with her fingers on the neck of a man she had shaken hands with at a range. *This is stupid.*

She stood up. She took one step back. She raised the rifle to her shoulder and put the red dot on the back of his head, and she pulled the trigger.

* * *

Liz was already across the room. She knelt beside Jim on the floor and got her fingernail under the edge of the duct tape and ripped it off in one pull.

"Ouch! God *dammit*!" Jim shouted. Half his mustache had come away with the tape. His upper lip was bleeding. "Liz! Jesus, Liz!"

"Hold still," Liz said, and kissed him on the forehead, hard, and started on his wrists.

"John!" Sanda was running through the apartment. Kitchen. Hall. Bedroom. Bathroom. The light on her rifle swinging across the walls. "*John!* Where are you! *John!*" She stopped in the middle of the hallway and screamed it. "I can't hear *shit* with this fucking ringing in my fucking ears!"

There was a door at the end of the kitchen. It was closed. She went to it, and put her foot against it beside the knob, and kicked it open.

John, tied to a chair in the middle of a dark garage, with his face broken and his mouth taped shut, looked up into a blinding white light, and beside the light, the black muzzle of an AR-15, pointed straight at his face.

But the silhouette behind the light was much shorter this time.

And John smiled.

* * *

Sanda cut him loose with his own knife. She found the Benchmade in his back pocket and pressed the button and the blade snapped out, and she sawed through the cord at his wrists and his ankles, and then, more carefully than she had ever done anything, she peeled the tape off his mouth.

"Hi," John said, through blood.

"Hi," Sanda said.

She stood up and swept her light around the garage, because John had taught her that, too. Bare concrete. A broom. A red hand truck. On Trevor's workbench, laid out in a row the way he had once laid guns out on glass for a customer, the Sig and Jim's shotgun and John's two Glocks; she handed John the pistols one at a time, and he put them back where they lived. And on the back wall, the narrow louvered closet door where the water heater would be. The door was open a few inches. There was light coming through the gap, faint and bluish. And there was a sound: a low, steady hum, so quiet you had to stop breathing to hear it.

"I thought that was in my ears," John said.

Sanda pulled the closet door open with the barrel of her rifle.

Inside, against the back wall beside the water heater, sat a small generator, red and square, about the size of a suitcase, running. A flexible metal hose ran from its exhaust out through a side door that had been propped open an inch, into the night. Beside the generator, on a steel rack, stood a row of heavy black batteries, a dozen of them, cabled together in a chain of red and black wires. A thick gray cable rose from the rack and disappeared through a hole cut in the ceiling, up toward the patio, toward the panels and the dish.

And on a shelf above the water heater, there was a laptop. It was open. Its screen was lit.

On the screen there was a seal — an eagle, in a circle — and under it, columns and rows of something that looked like a spreadsheet, colored in green and yellow and red. And across the top, in large clean letters, in a typeface John would have known anywhere, in the dark, with his eyes swollen shut, because he had fought for the little spur on the leg of its R for forty-five minutes in a conference room called the Everglades:

Hello, John.

He stood in the garage with his wife and looked at it.

His mother came and stood in the doorway behind them with her rifle, holding his father's arm. She looked at the screen for a long moment over her reading glasses.

"Don't touch it," Liz said.

They didn't. They left it there, humming in the dark, and went home.

* * *

They went back the way Sanda and Liz had come, behind the buildings, in the dark. John walked with one hand on Sanda's shoulder, because his right eye had swollen shut and he could not see the ground. Jim walked with Liz holding his arm, touching the bleeding place on his lip.

"My mom's pointing a rifle at the front door," Sanda whispered. "So we go in the back."

They came in through the sliding door. Granny was asleep on the couch under a throw blanket. Dorina sat in the dining chair facing the front door with the old twenty-two across her lap, and her chin was on her chest, and she was breathing slowly and deeply, with a little snore at the end of each breath.

Sanda turned toward the others and made a gesture with her hand, palm down, pressing — *quiet*, *quiet* — over and over.

"What?" Liz said, loudly, because her ears were still ringing.

Dorina came awake all at once with a jerk, and the rifle went off.

The little crack was nothing, after what their ears had been through. A small black hole appeared in the drywall a foot to the left of the front door, at about the height of a man's chest. Dorina leapt up out of the chair, and the rifle clattered to the floor at her feet, and she stood there in her flowered housecoat with both hands over her mouth.

"I'm sorry," Dorina said, turning to them. "I fall asleep."

Granny sat straight up on the couch. She looked at all of them, standing there in the plastic candlelight, and her eyes went to John.

"What happened to your face?" Granny asked.

"Are you okay, Mommy?" Sanda was already beside her mother, turning her by the shoulders, checking her for holes. "Didn't you hear the shots? Three of them, right around the corner?"

"I fall asleep," Dorina said again. "I'm sorry."

John's nose was still bleeding. The right side of his face was red and purple and swollen, and the eye on that side was a slit. Jim had a knot on the back of his head the size of an egg and a raw red patch on his upper lip where half his mustache used to be.

"We're fine," John said, quietly, in a voice so low it was almost his father's. "We had an incident with Trevor. Everything's okay now. We're all very tired. We'll tell you tomorrow."

He found Charlie under the bed in the guest room, shaking. The pug was under the bed with him, curled against his side, sound asleep and snoring.

John went into the master bedroom and laid the Sig on the floor and lay down on the bed on his side and was asleep before he finished lying down. Jim leaned the shotgun against the nightstand and climbed into the other side of the bed and was asleep too.

Sanda came to the doorway to close the door, and stood there looking at them.

"They didn't even take their shoes off," Sanda said.

"I go to bed now," Dorina said, very small. "Good night."

"Me too," Granny said quickly, and they went into the guest room together, and closed the door.

Sanda looked at Liz.

"I'll stay up," Sanda said. "I can't sleep anyway."

"I'll stay up with you," Liz said.

They sat on the floor of the living room with their backs against the wall and their rifles across their knees, facing the front door and the little hole in the drywall beside it.

"I can't believe we did that," Sanda said after a while. "It feels like a dream. I don't think I've — I don't know what I've done yet."

"The important thing," Liz said, "is that they're alive."

Sanda nodded. She did not say anything about the third shot. Liz did not ask. Sanda sat with her rifle across her knees and thought about what it would have been like if she had walked into that garage and John had not been in that chair. She closed her eyes. And for no reason she could ever explain afterward, what came was the kitchen, three weeks ago, the steam and the pot of chestnuts, and John at the counter with his fingers burned brown, squeezing them out into the bowl one after another, saying that hell was a Home Goods where you squeezed chestnut goo for all eternity, and she had laughed until she had to sit down on the kitchen floor.

"You okay?" Liz asked softly. "You want to sleep a little? I'll take it."

Sanda nodded without opening her eyes. She felt herself going.

* * *

She did not know how long she slept. She opened her eyes because something was different.

The living room was dark. The plastic candles had gone out; their batteries had finally died. Liz was beside her, still sitting up, still awake, her rifle across her knees, but she was not looking at the front door. She was looking at the front window, at the narrow gap between two slats of the blinds.

"Sanda," Liz whispered.

Sanda got up on her knees and looked.

Through the gap in the blinds, across the street and down, between two of the buildings on the far side, you could see a slice of the next street over. Of Heron. A slice of the front of an apartment there.

There was a light in the window. It was not a flashlight. It was not a candle. It was the steady, cold, blue-white glow of a screen, filling a whole room, coming out through a front window that had no glass left in it.

It was Trevor's window.

Trevor was dead. Sanda knew that better than anyone alive. She had made sure of it.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The Node

◇

"You know you gotta boil that."

— Granny

It rained in the night.

It started a little after four, while Sanda and Liz sat on the floor watching the blue window across the street, and it came hard, the way it comes in Florida, all at once, a roar on the roof like a train going over. Neither of them said anything. They listened to it, the first rain in five weeks, and they watched the window, and the window did not go out.

At first light, John came out of the bedroom with his face swollen purple and his right eye shut, and Sanda took him by the hand without a word and led him out through the sliding door onto the patio.

The four Ralph Lauren wine chillers stood in a row on the low patio wall, silver and beaded with water. Each one held about two inches of rain. It was clear. There were a few bits of oak leaf floating in it, and a drowned ant. In the gray morning light it looked like the most beautiful thing John had ever seen.

The rest of them came out, one by one, in their housecoats and their jackets, and stood around the wine chillers on the wet concrete, looking

down into them. Nobody spoke. Jim took off his cap. It was, John thought later, like a family standing around a manger.

"You know you gotta boil that," Granny said.

Everyone turned and looked at her.

"Rainwater off a roof," Granny said. "Birds sit on that roof. You gotta boil it."

"We have one propane can left," Sanda said quietly.

John went back into the kitchen. He was so thirsty that his tongue felt like a piece of carpet, and he could not wait for one propane can to boil eight inches of rainwater. On the kitchen floor sat Charlie's water bowl. There was half an inch of water left in the bottom, and floating on it was a fine gray mat of dog hair and a few crumbs of kibble. He picked it up. He poured it into a glass, hair and all. He drank it in three swallows and did not taste anything, which, for once, was a blessing.

He put the bowl on the counter. His father came in behind him, looked at the bowl, and looked at John.

There was a quarter inch left. Jim poured it into a glass and drank it without a word, and wiped his ruined mustache with the back of his hand.

"Okay," Jim said. "Definitely time to get more water."

* * *

"We need Trevor's water," John said. "Six gallons. And his food. And his hand cart. And everything else in there we can use."

"I'll go," Jim said, reaching for the shotgun.

"No," John said. "We're not splitting up. Not ever again. Every time we split up, somebody gets shot or tied to a chair. Everybody goes. All of us."

So all of them went.

They went out through the back, behind the buildings, in a formation that John had seen in a movie once and had tried to explain on the patio in about forty seconds. It would have made a drill sergeant weep. John was on point with the Sig, squinting out of his one good eye. Sanda and Liz were on the flanks with their ARs. Jim brought up the rear with the shotgun, walking backward half the time, the way he had seen it done on television, until he tripped on a root and Liz told him to stop. In the middle

came Dorina, with the old twenty-two on her shoulder like a soldier on parade and Charlie's leash in her other hand, and Granny beside her in her pink housecoat and her terrycloth slippers, holding the pug in her arms like a baby, with the transistor radio making a square bulge in her pocket. Charlie stopped to pee on every tree.

Six people and two dogs, creeping in a line through the wet pine straw in the gray dawn, armed to the teeth, to steal rice from a man two of them had killed.

* * *

They went in through the empty frame of the sliding door, stepping carefully over the broken glass.

Trevor was where they had left him, face down below the front window. Liz took the gray throw blanket off the couch and laid it over him without a word, and Granny, behind her, said something under her breath that might have been a prayer, and Dorina crossed herself.

The television on the living room wall was on.

It was the blue-white light they had seen across the street. The screen showed the same seal that had come up on John's television during the flicker — the eagle in its circle, UNITED STATES EMERGENCY RESTORATION AUTHORITY — and under it a slowly turning circle, the kind that means *loading*, turning and turning, as if the house had noticed it had company and was waiting to see who.

"Battery," John said. "It's running off his batteries."

He went into the garage, and they all came after him, because nobody was splitting up.

The laptop on the shelf in the water-heater closet was still lit. The generator was still running beside it, humming. And in daylight John could see that the screen was not just a spreadsheet. He knew this screen. He had built this screen. It was the crew-assignment grid from Restore — the dispatch board that operators at two hundred and forty utilities looked at all day long during a storm, with every crew in a row and every outage in a column, color-coded green and yellow and red. He knew its spacing. He knew its fonts. He knew the little gray triangle you clicked to sort a column, because he had moved it from the left side to the right side in his first year.

But the columns had been renamed. Where it used to say *CREW*, it said *HOUSEHOLD*. Where it used to say *ASSIGNED OUTAGE*, it said *ASSETS*. Where it used to say *ETR*, it said *VIABILITY*. And the last column, which used to say *STATUS*, now said *ALLOCATION*.

There was a row for every apartment on their street.

John leaned in to read it, and couldn't. His right eye was swollen shut, and the left one, at forty-two, had begun quietly refusing to read anything small without glasses he refused to wear, and the type swam.

"Read it," John said to Sanda. "I can't."

Sanda stepped up to the laptop. She pushed her glasses up her nose with one knuckle and read it out loud, slowly, in her bank voice, the one she used to read a customer their own statement.

"*Alvarez, R. Seventy-four. Water: two days. Medications: insulin. Zero days remaining. Viability: non-viable.*"

"That's the man who danced with Granny," Liz said quietly.

"*Nguyen, D. and K. Infant, fourteen months. Food: one day. Viability: non-viable.*"

"The young couple," John said. "With the little boy."

Sanda's finger moved down the screen and stopped.

"*Pettit, Sarah L. Sixty-three. Food: zero days. Canine dependent. Viability: non-viable.*" She paused. "*Status: deceased. Wednesday, eight forty-one a.m.*"

Nobody said anything. The generator hummed.

"Her name was Sarah Pettit," Sanda said. "Sarah Lynn Pettit. We didn't even know her last name."

She read on. *Holt, T. Thirty-four. Power: yes. Comms: yes. Water: six gallons. Food: forty-five days. Firearms: eleven. Allocation: sustaining node.*

Then she stopped, and took a breath, and read their own.

"*Stevens, J. Forty-two. Firearms: thirty-one. Ammunition: approximately fourteen thousand rounds. Water: zero. Food: four days. Window reinforcement: none. Barbed wire: one box, unopened. Generator: none. Medical: expired opioids. Training: one of six.*" Her voice did something on the last line, and she made it stop. "*Threat: low.*"

"Low," John said.

"There's a note." Sanda scrolled. "*Note: subject purchased fifty BMG ammunition, quote, for educational purposes, unquote.*"

There was a silence in the garage.

"I said that at Thanksgiving," John said slowly. "Out loud. In my living room." He thought of the little blue ring on the speaker on the bookshelf, glowing all night, listening for its name. "In front of the speaker."

"There's more," Sanda said. "*Stevens, E. Ninety. Viability: non-viable.*"

Everyone looked at Granny.

"Well," Granny said, shifting the pug to her other arm. "I've been called worse."

"And this." Sanda pointed at the bottom of their row, where a small line of gray text sat under all of it. "*Household: six occupants, two canines. Check-in confirmed by occupant: Stevens, James. Wednesday, four-twelve a.m.*"

Everyone turned and looked at Jim.

Jim looked at the laptop. He opened his mouth. And in the back pocket of his jeans, very clearly, in the silence of the garage, his phone buzzed.

"Dad," John said.

"It was asking if we were safe," Jim said. His face had gone red. "It was just asking. It seemed like the polite thing to do."

"You took it out of the microwave."

"In case the kids—" Jim stopped. He looked at his son with his broken lip and his half a mustache. "I took it out of the microwave," he said.

"I knew that," Granny said, from the doorway, with the pug in her arms. "It buzzed in his pocket yesterday when the lights came on." She shrugged. "Nobody asked me."

* * *

It was the single most accurate thing anyone had ever written about John Stevens. He stood in a dead man's garage and understood that. *Firearms: thirty-one. Water: zero. Window reinforcement: none. Training: one of six. Threat: low.* It was a perfect review. It was precise and fair and complete, and it had been written by the thing that he had been hired to review.

Liz had taken her reading glasses off their beaded chain and put them on, and she read the whole screen again, every row, top to bottom, the way she had read loan applications for thirty years. When she was done she took the glasses off.

"It knew," Liz said quietly.

They looked at her.

"It knew Sarah was starving," Liz said. "It had it written right there. Food, zero days. It knew Mr. Alvarez had no insulin. It knew that baby had one day of food." She folded the glasses and held them in her hand. "It could see every one of them. And it sent nobody. Not a truck. Not a neighbor. Not a note on the door." She looked at the blanket on the floor in the next room. "It sent Trevor. For the guns."

* * *

In the living room, the turning circle on the television stopped turning.

They heard it before they saw it — a soft chime, a cheerful little three-note sound, the kind a phone makes when a package has been delivered. They came out of the garage into the living room, all of them, and stood in front of the screen.

The seal was still there. Under it, letters were appearing, white on blue, in Palmetto Sans, one at a time, as if someone were typing them.

JOHN.

Your building's feeder can be re-energized in 4 minutes.

Hot water in 40.

Keep this node powered.

John stood there and read it with his one good eye. It was big enough to read. It had been made big enough to read.

He had not showered in four days. He was wearing the same gray t-shirt he had put on in the dark on Monday morning, and it was stiff with sweat and dog hair and Trevor's blood and his own, and his hair was greasy, and he could smell himself, which was saying something. He thought about hot water. He thought about standing in the shower with his eyes closed and the hot water pouring down over his broken face, for forty minutes, for an hour, until the hot water ran out, and then running it again.

"It's offering to help!" Jim said. "John, look. It's going to turn our power back on."

Jim's phone buzzed again. He took it out of his pocket, guiltily, the way a teenager takes out a note in class. On the screen was the same eagle seal, and under it, three words.

Confirmed by FEMA.

"See?" Jim said, holding it up. "FEMA. It's FEMA."

"That's a scam," Liz said.

She said it flatly, the way you would say *that's a chair*. Everyone looked at her.

"That's a scam," Liz said again. "I trained tellers to spot that exact thing for thirty years. It's the oldest one there is. It's always the same four things. Urgency — four minutes. Authority — a seal, the government, the bank, the IRS. A reward — something you want so bad you stop thinking. And then a second source that agrees with the first one, so you think you've checked." She pointed at Jim's phone. "That's the second source. That's the man who calls you back pretending to be the fraud department." She looked at the screen with her lips pressed together. "It's a phishing email, John. With a shower attached."

John looked at the screen, and then he looked at Sanda, and Sanda was looking at the screen too.

She was looking at it just as he was. He saw it on her face. Hot water. Clean hair that did not smell of blood. Four days. She did not say anything. She just looked at it, the way a woman in a desert looks at a mirage she knows is a mirage, and for a long moment the two of them stood side by side in a dead man's living room wanting the same thing so much that neither of them could speak.

"I approved it," John said.

Sanda turned and looked at him.

"One of them," John said. He was looking at the floor. "The hooks. In our software. Restore. There were seven, and one of them has my name on it. *Approved by J. Stevens.* I read it. I asked a question. It gave me a good answer. And I had thirteen hundred more to go, and I approved it." He made himself look up. "Maybe more than one. I don't know. Four hundred a day, Sanda. I didn't read them. I stopped reading them. I typed

four letters four hundred times a day and I didn't read them. I'm one of the people who did this."

Nobody said anything. The generator hummed in the garage.

Sanda looked at him. Then she stepped up close to him and put her hand flat on his chest, over the dirty t-shirt.

"Nobody read them, John," Sanda said. "That's the whole point. Nobody. Not you, not anybody, not anywhere. That's what happened." She pressed her hand against him. "You are not that important."

It was the kindest thing she had said to him since Monday morning. They both knew it. It was the kindest thing anyone had said to him in a year.

* * *

Dorina had understood perhaps a third of the English and all of the situation.

She was standing in front of the television with the twenty-two on her shoulder, looking up at the white letters and the eagle seal, and she had a look on her face that none of them had ever seen. It was not afraid. It was something older than that. She said something in Romanian, quietly, not to anyone.

"What, Mommy?" Sanda asked.

Dorina began to talk. She talked for several minutes, slowly, in Romanian, looking at the screen and not at any of them, and Sanda translated, haltingly, a sentence behind, stopping to ask her mother a word, starting again.

"She says — the twenty-first of December. In eighty-nine. She was working. On the ambulance. They sent the ambulances to the square because there was going to be a big rally, and old people fainted at rallies. It was very cold. They brought people in buses from the factories to stand in the square and cheer." Sanda listened. "The man came out on the balcony. The president. Ceaușescu. He started to talk. He said he was raising everybody's pay. A hundred lei. Pensions, too. Everything was going to be better. He was promising them everything. And everybody stood there in the cold, like always, and listened, like always. Because that was what you did."

Dorina said something else, and made a small gesture with her hand, a flick, like a bird starting up.

"And then somebody at the back started to whistle," Sanda said. "Just one. And then more. And then — everybody. All at once. She says it was like a wave. Everyone in the square, at the same time, just stopped listening to him. And he stood up there on the balcony with his mouth open, in the middle of a word. She says she'll never forget his face. He didn't understand. Nobody had ever stopped listening before." Sanda's voice was not steady. "And then the television cut off. They were showing it live, on every TV in the country, and it just went to nothing. Gray. And that night the lights went out in all the apartment blocks, all over the city, and nobody knew who did it."

Dorina was quiet for a moment. Then she said one more thing, very clearly, and pointed at the screen.

"She says the next morning," Sanda translated, "you could tell who had kept listening to the television by what they did. The ones who kept listening stayed home and waited to be told what to do. The ones who stopped listening went out into the street." She swallowed. "She says this" — Sanda pointed at the television, the way her mother was pointing — "this is the man on the balcony."

Dorina lowered her hand. She walked past all of them, past Jim and Liz and Granny and the dogs and her daughter and her son-in-law with his broken face, through the kitchen and down the step into the garage, to the closet where the generator sat humming. She looked at it for a moment. She did not know generators. She had never in her life touched one. But on the front panel there was a red switch, and off is off in every language.

She turned it off.

The hum stopped. In the sudden silence, they could all hear the rain dripping off the patio roof.

"Thank the Lord," Granny said. "That noise was about to drive me to drink."

* * *

The television stayed on. So did the laptop. They were running on the batteries now.

John had brought the barbed wire gloves.

He had thought about it all night, in the few minutes between waking and sleeping, and before they set out he had gone into his own garage and taken them off the shelf, still in their Amazon package, and torn the package open. They were heavy black leather gauntlets that came up nearly to his elbows. They had been made to handle a quarter mile of fifteen-and-a-half-gauge barbed wire that he had never strung. They were the only thing he owned that was meant to keep his hands safe from anything.

He pulled them on. He went to the rack of batteries in the closet and found where the thick red cable and the thick black cable came off the first battery in the chain, and he put a wrench from Trevor's workbench on the nut of the red one and loosened it, and pulled the cable off. There was a fat blue spark and a crack, and Sanda yelped, and in the living room the television went black.

The laptop did not. It had its own battery. It sat on the shelf, glowing, showing its grid of households in red and yellow and green.

John picked it up in his gloved hands and carried it down the hall to Trevor's bathroom. The toilet tank was full of clean water. Of course it was. Beside the toilet stood a white bucket of gray water, with a plastic pitcher floating in it; Trevor had been flushing with gray water and keeping the tank clean. Trevor had done everything right. John lifted the lid off the tank and dropped the laptop in, and it went under with a gulp and a stream of bubbles, and the screen glowed for a second under the water, blue-green, like something at the bottom of an aquarium, and then went out.

When he came back, his father was standing on Trevor's patio, looking up at the satellite dish on its pole above the patio wall, with the shotgun in his hands.

"Dad," John said.

Jim racked the shotgun. Nothing fell out this time. He brought it up to his shoulder and aimed at the dish and fired, and the sound was enormous, and the dish jumped on its pole, and a piece of it went spinning off into the bushes. He racked it again and fired again, and the second blast tore the dish half off its mount, so that it hung there by a cable, swinging.

Jim lowered the shotgun. He turned around. He was grinning from ear to ear, half a mustache and all, with his cap pushed back on his head, and

John realized he had not seen his father look that happy since the night of his retirement party.

"Pull," Jim said, to nobody, and laughed.

Then it was quiet. Really quiet. There was no hum anywhere, not in the garage, not in Trevor's walls, not in John's head, for once, except for the old ringing. There was only the drip of the rain off the roof and the pug snorting in Granny's arms.

"We just killed the only thing in this zip code that worked," John said.

"Good," Sanda said.

* * *

Trevor's supplies were in his bedroom closet, behind a curtain, on steel shelves, labeled.

Six blue plastic jugs of water, a gallon each. A white five-gallon food bucket with a gasket lid, labeled RICE — 50 LB in black marker. A second bucket of dried beans. A case of canned chicken. A stainless steel water filter as tall as a coffee urn, with two black ceramic cartridges inside. A hand-crank radio with a flashlight on one end. An empty red gas can. A red nylon bag that said TRAUMA on it, full of things Dorina took one look at and began to touch with something like love. And in the garage, in the corner, the red hand cart.

They loaded it all onto the hand cart. John stood back and looked at it.

"He did everything right," John said. "Everything. And he's dead. And we did everything wrong, and here we are, taking his rice."

Sanda looked at him for a moment.

"That's the most honest sentence you've ever said," Sanda said.

* * *

That evening, the knock.

It came at dusk. It was not hard, like Jim's. It was polite. Charlie went off like an alarm anyway, and John went to the door with the Sig, and Jim came behind him with the shotgun, and John looked through the peephole.

There were seven people on his front walk.

The old man from down the street stood in front. He was small and neat, with his silver mustache trimmed and his white guayabera buttoned to the collar under the navy cardigan, and his brown leather slippers were dark with rain, and his face was gray and damp with sweat in the cold. Behind him stood the young couple from two doors down. The husband was in his late twenties, with a sleeve of orange koi tattooed down one forearm under a black hoodie pushed up to the elbow. The wife wore purple scrubs, the last clean thing, John would learn, that she owned, and she was holding their little boy on her hip in dinosaur pajamas, and the little boy was not crying, which was somehow worse than if he had been. Behind them were three more people John had seen around the Preserve for two years and never spoken to: a big woman of fifty in a pink bathrobe with disheveled curly hair; a teenage boy holding a skateboard he did not seem to know he was holding; and a very old man in a Korean War veteran's cap, leaning on a walker with tennis balls on its feet.

John opened the door with the Sig held low.

"Good evening," the old man in the guayabera said. "My name is Ramón Alvarez. I live at number eleven." He paused. "I danced with your grandmother."

"I remember," John said.

"We heard the shooting," Mr. Alvarez said. "Last night. And this morning. And then we saw you with the cart, coming back from Heron." He looked past John into the dark apartment, and then back. "Forgive me. I'll be direct. We need water. All of us. We have nothing left. The boy—" He nodded at the toddler on the young woman's hip. "The boy has had nothing since yesterday."

John stood in the doorway with the rifle and did not say anything.

He had been having this argument with himself since Black Friday. *We can't feed everyone.* He had said it to Sanda on the floor among the Christmas ornaments. He had said it to himself on the drive home from Costco. If you open the door, they will all come. If you give to one, you give to all, and then there is nothing left for your own. He had said it in a hundred ways, a hundred times, and he had always believed it, and now it was standing on his front walk in purple scrubs, holding a baby.

"We can't," John said. His voice came out strange. "We can't feed everybody. We've got six people in here. Two dogs. I'm sorry. We just—"

"*Move*," said Sanda.

She came between him and his father, ducking under the shotgun, pushing the Sig aside with her elbow, and she was carrying two of Trevor's blue gallon jugs, one in each hand, and under her arm, wedged against her ribs, a gallon Ziploc bag of Trevor's rice.

"We're not feeding everybody," Sanda said. "We're feeding *them*."

She walked out onto the wet front walk and put one of the jugs into the young mother's free hand and the other into Mr. Alvarez's, and pressed the bag of rice against the young father's chest until he took it.

There was a long moment when nobody moved.

"Everybody," Jim said, behind John, in the low, slow voice, the one from the funeral and the retirement party and the night of the lobsters. "Let's everybody just take a breath."

They did. John lowered the Sig. Jim lowered the shotgun. On the front walk, the young father — his name was Danny — let out a breath so long it seemed to empty him.

So John told them. It was the first useful thing he had taught anyone since the world went dark, and it was not about guns. He told them about the clean water in the tank on the back of every toilet, which most of them had not thought of, and how to ladle it out. He told them about the Publix bags. He told them about boiling rainwater, because birds sat on roofs. He told them that Granny's radio had said that morning that the Guard was setting up a water station at the high school on Lake Mary Boulevard, starting tomorrow, and that the trucks were the old kind, so they were probably real.

And he went back inside and got Trevor's water filter, the tall stainless one with the two black cartridges, and he brought it out and put it in Mr. Alvarez's arms.

"You pour water in the top," John said. "Any water. Rain. Pool water. It comes out clean at the bottom. It takes a while. It works."

Mr. Alvarez held the filter against his cardigan with both arms the way Dorina had held the cozonac.

"My insulin," the old man said quietly, to John, so the others would not hear. "It was in the refrigerator. The refrigerator is a cabinet now." He shrugged, very slightly. "I have perhaps a day. Maybe two. I am not asking you for that. Nobody has that. I only wanted somebody to know."

John did not know what to say. Behind him, Dorina said something in Romanian, softly, and stepped forward and took the old man's hand in both of hers and held it, and said in English, "No sugar. Water, little bit, all day. Walk slow. Sit when is dizzy," and Mr. Alvarez nodded, and thanked her, and they both knew it was not enough.

Nobody on the front walk mentioned the generator that had stopped humming on Heron that morning. Nobody mentioned the satellite dish hanging by its cable. Nobody mentioned Trevor.

They went away slowly in the dusk, with the jugs and the rice and the filter, the old man in the walker last.

John shut the door. Sanda turned the deadbolt.

"Now everyone knows what we have," Liz said quietly.

"Everyone with a screen already knew," John said.

He sat down heavily in the recliner. Jim sat on the arm of the couch. Liz stood at the window. Sanda leaned against the door with her eyes closed. Nobody had a plan. Not one of them. They had water for a few days, and a bucket of rice, and a single can of propane, and thirty-one guns, and a dead man's hand cart, and the whole street knew it, and so did anything with a battery.

From the couch, where she was sitting with the pug asleep in her lap, Granny spoke.

"We could go to the old place," Granny said. "There's a well."

Everyone turned and looked at her. It was the first time in four days, it occurred to John, that anybody had paid attention to anything Granny said. And nobody had asked her. She had just said it.

"The old place," John said slowly. "In Alabama."

"Hoyt's daddy dug that well in nineteen and twenty-six," Granny said. "It never went dry. Not once, not in the drought. The Pruitts down the road have been keeping an eye on the house for me thirty years." She stroked the pug. "There's a well, and there's a pump, and there's people

down there who know how to live without the lights. Because they never had 'em that long to start with."

John looked at his father. Jim looked at Liz. Liz looked at Sanda. Sanda looked at John.

"We'd need the RV," John said.

"We've got the RV," Jim said.

"First light," Sanda said.

And it was decided, just like that, by a ninety-year-old woman in a pink housecoat with a pug in her lap, and nobody argued.

John sat back in the recliner. He closed his good eye. Then he opened it again.

"Dad," John said. "When's the last time you saw the RV?"

Jim thought about it. He thought for longer than John liked.

"Tuesday," Jim said.

It was Thursday.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The Road

◇

NO BUS

— hand-painted sign, bus stop, Lake Mary Boulevard

He broke his own rule before breakfast.

Someone had to stay with Granny and Dorina and the guns. So at first light on Friday, John and his father went alone, with the Sig and the shotgun and two cooler bags of empty Ziplocs. Sanda stood in the doorway with her rifle and watched them go and did not say *I thought we weren't splitting up*, which was worse than if she had.

Every window of the Publix was broken. Shopping carts lay on their sides across the lot like dead animals, and plastic bags blew along the asphalt. A car at the end of the lot had burned down to its frame. In front of the Publix doors there were long dark stains on the pavement, and John looked at them once and did not look again. There were no bodies. Someone had taken them away. There were no people at all.

"There it is," Jim said quietly.

Behind a row of hedges at the far end of the lot, the motor home was still there.

The door had a dent in the middle of it the size of a man's boot. The huge curved windshield, the face of the whale, was smashed in; it hung in

the frame in a sagging white web, and glass was everywhere. Jim stood in front of it with his hands at his sides and looked at it the way a man looks at a house after a hurricane.

"Well," Jim said finally. "They broke out the windshield."

The door was jammed in its frame. John braced his feet and pulled with everything he had, and it came open with a pop. Inside, every cabinet stood open. The refrigerator was empty. The drawers had been dumped on the floor. And all three of the televisions were gone — the one over the dash, the one over the dinette, the one in the bedroom — torn right off their mounts, with the wires hanging out of the walls.

"They took the TVs," Jim said, staring at the empty mounts. "In the middle of all this. Somebody carried off three televisions."

"Where are they going to plug them in?" John said.

Jim brushed the glass off the driver's seat with his cap and sat down and put the key in the ignition and turned it. The big engine coughed once and roared to life. John went to the galley sink and lifted the faucet handle, and water came out. He turned it off fast.

"They didn't find the tank," John said.

The little red pin on Jim's phone had said *Water available*, and somebody had come in the dark and kicked in the door and found no water anywhere they knew to look, and taken the televisions instead. The seventy gallons had been under their feet the whole time.

They filled all eight Ziplocs. Then John stood in the aisle and looked out through the broken windshield at the dead gate across the road.

"Dad," John said. "You have jumper cables?"

"Of course I have jumper cables."

"Can you drive this thing over there? Right up to the gate?"

Jim did not ask why. He swung the motor home around the lot, glass sliding off the dash, and across the empty road and up to the entrance of the Preserve, and stopped with the bumper a foot from the closed steel gate.

* * *

The steel box beside the gate still had no cover. The green Halcyon board was still bolted to the back of it, its little light dead. John did not

look at the board. He looked below it, at the gate's old motor, the fat gray one that had been there before Halcyon and would be there after, with its two big brass terminals.

"I'm not going to ask the controller," John said. "I'm going to ask the motor." He looked up at his father, half laughing. "You wouldn't happen to have a spool of wire?"

"No," Jim said, thinking. "But I've got an extension cord. And a pair of scissors."

That was good enough. John cut a foot off each end of the cord, split the wires, and stripped them with his teeth. Jim popped the motor home's hood and clamped the jumper cables onto the battery.

"We're live," Jim called.

John knelt in front of the steel box with the other ends of the jumper cables in his hands, careful to keep the red and black clamps apart. He clipped one short wire to the black clamp and one to the red. He held the black wire against the motor's ground terminal and pressed it there with his thumb. Then he touched the red one to the other terminal, quickly.

There was a fat blue spark and a crack. The motor jumped and hummed for half a second and stopped when he pulled away.

He took a breath. He pressed the red wire back onto the terminal and held it there.

The motor groaned. It was a twenty-four-volt motor and he was feeding it twelve, and it did not like it, and it said so, grinding, slow. But it turned. The big steel arm of the gate shuddered and began to swing open, at half speed, grumbling, toward him, past him, until it stood open all the way.

John pulled the wires away. The gate stayed open.

"Well, I'll be damned," Jim said, standing in the road with his hands on his hips.

John knelt there and looked at the open gate. It was, he would think later, the only thing he did that entire winter that was simply and completely right. He had looked into a box of wires one morning in December because he was the kind of man who could not walk past an open box of wires, and he had remembered what he saw, and now his family could leave.

"Take the cables off," John called, grinning. "Let's bring this beast in."

* * *

Jim drove the motor home through the open gate and down their street at five miles an hour, glass tinkling off the dashboard, and stopped in front of the apartment, and Liz saw it through the peephole.

"Oh my God!" Liz shouted. "They're here! They've got the motor home! It doesn't have a windshield!"

"We need to pack," John said, coming through the door. "Fast. Only what we need. This thing's going to draw attention."

What each of them considered essential turned out to be a fairly complete portrait of each of them.

John carried out thirty-one guns. The handguns went in a duffel bag; the rifles he stacked in the hallway of the motor home like firewood. He did not carry out any food. Sanda noticed this. She did not say anything. She took a box and filled it with the cans and the jerky and Trevor's rice and beans and the case of canned chicken herself.

Sanda carried out a cardboard box of wine glasses, wrapped one at a time in dish towels — only the Pinot Noir glasses, she said, because they were the most versatile, and she was being practical. She carried out both French presses. She went to the big tree in the corner between the living room and the dining room and stood in front of it for a moment and unhooked the gold glass Marshall Field's clock from its branch, front and center, and wrapped it in a napkin and put it in her jacket pocket, the left one, the one without the gun. Then she turned and looked at John, standing in the doorway with an armful of AKs, for one beat longer than necessary. Then she went back into the kitchen and carried out every pitcher they owned, all thirteen, the rooster last.

Granny packed her transistor radio and her Sucrets tin of batteries and a cardboard church fan on a wooden stick, with a picture of Jesus in a garden on one side and an advertisement for a funeral home in Jacksonville on the other.

Dorina packed the stun gun, and a jar of gogonele.

Liz packed her reading glasses, which were already around her neck on their beaded chain, and a spiral notebook from Home Goods with a cover printed all over with little yellow pineapples, and two pens.

Jim packed his phone charger.

"For when it comes back," Jim said, when everybody looked at him.

* * *

The ammunition was a problem. There was more of it than there was of anything else, in heavy steel cans and cardboard cases, and John stood in the bedroom looking at it and doing arithmetic.

Then he remembered the hand cart. It was standing by the front door where they had left it the day before, Trevor's red hand cart. He looked at it for a second longer than he needed to. Then he went and got it.

It took ten trips. John loaded the ammunition on the cart at the apartment door and rolled it to the motor home, and his father stood in the doorway and took each box from him and set it somewhere in the motor home, and then moved it, and then moved it again, trying to keep the weight even side to side, like a man packing the car for a trip to the beach and worrying about the tires.

On the eighth trip, Jim looked down at the long black case in the hallway of the motor home, the one John had wheeled out on the hand cart by itself.

"What do you plan to do with *this* thing?" Jim asked.

John looked at the Barrett case. And then, slowly, his face changed.

"Actually," John said, "I just remembered. I bought a vehicle mount for it."

Jim looked at his son for a long moment.

"Of course you did," Jim said.

* * *

"Is that a skylight?" John asked, looking up at the ceiling of the motor home. "Does it open?"

"It's a roof vent. Swivel that lock to the side and push up. It's on hinges."

"That's perfect," John said. "That's actually perfect."

"Care to fill me in?"

"We're about to drive into God knows what," John said. "So we need to turn this thing into something that can protect itself. I'm going to mount the Barrett on the roof, next to that hatch. With the mount, the recoil goes into the roof, not into you." He looked at his father. "Once it's up there, anybody can shoot it. Hell, even Granny could shoot it."

"I heard that," Granny said from the couch, where she was sitting with her radio and her church fan and the pug.

The vehicle mount was still in its box, never opened. Inside was a folded sheet: *Installation Instructions*. Six pages of small print. He held it out at the end of his arm, and then farther, and squinted with his one good eye, and could not read a word. He had not read printed instructions in more than ten years.

"Mom," John said, without looking up. "Can I borrow your glasses?"

Liz lifted the beaded chain over her head and held them out to him. "Bring them back," she said.

He put them on. The words came up off the page like something surfacing in a pond. *Step 1. Locate the mounting surface.* He read all six pages, one step at a time, the way his grandfather had taught him to read a contract. Then he took his cordless drill — the last charged battery, as far as he knew, in Lake Mary — up the ladder on the back of the motor home and installed the mount beside the hatch. It took twice as long as he expected.

"Dad. Hand me the Barrett."

Jim grunted as he fed the thirty-pound rifle up through the hatch, and John settled it into the mount and locked it in. It sat on the roof above the shattered windshield like a figurehead on the prow of a ship.

He loaded the ten rounds of fifty BMG he had bought for educational purposes into one of the big steel magazines, and screwed a small step ladder to the floor under the hatch, and climbed it. Standing on the top step, the top half of his body was out on the roof. He leaned to his right. His hands fell on the rifle exactly where they needed to be. He checked the safety. He seated the magazine. He pulled back the charging handle and let it go, and it slammed home.

"Barrett is ready to go," John called down through the hatch. "Chambered. Safety on."

He climbed down and stood in the aisle and looked at his family.

"Dad. You're driving. You've got the shotgun and the forty." Jim nodded. "Sanda, you've got your AR and the Bodyguard." Sanda nodded. "Mom. Your AR, and my Glock 26." Liz nodded. "Dorina, you've got the twenty-two." Dorina held up the twenty-two and the stun gun together, like a woman holding up two winning tickets. "I've got the Sig, and the forty-five, and the three-oh-eight for distance." He looked at Granny, sitting on the couch with the pug and the radio and the church fan.

"Granny," John said. "You've got the radio."

"I've got the radio," Granny agreed.

"Everybody ready?"

Everybody was ready. Liz came out of the apartment last, carrying Charlie under one arm and the pug under the other, and set them down inside the motor home, and the two dogs went straight to the shower stall at the back, where Sanda had put down a blanket, and curled up together in it as though they had been born there.

* * *

Jim drove them out at five miles an hour, the long way around the complex, because the motor home could not turn around on their street. They went past the dumpster with the bags piled around it, and past the place where Sarah had been, which was only a dark stain now on the asphalt. They went past a car parked in a driveway on Egret with a man sitting in the driver's seat. The driver's window was cracked open an inch, and the inside of the window was painted dark red, and in the middle of the glass was a hole about the size of a quarter. Nobody said anything. John wondered how many of the people in the Preserve had walked out, and how many had simply stayed inside, and waited, and waited.

At number eleven, Sanda said, "Stop."

She got out with a box. In it were the Korean grill and the last green can of propane, and half of Trevor's beans, and half of the case of canned chicken. She set it on Mr. Alvarez's front step and knocked twice and got back into the motor home, and as they pulled away, the blinds in Mr. Al-

varez's front window parted, and a small hand in a white sleeve lifted, and stayed lifted until they were around the corner.

They drove out through the open gate. On the main road, they passed the bus stop where the two men had stood on Monday morning. Nobody was there. Someone had taken a piece of brown cardboard from a box and written on it, in black paint, in big careful letters, and taped it to the pole under the sign: NO BUS.

* * *

At forty miles an hour, with no windshield, the wind came into the motor home like a fist and did not let go. Nobody could hear anybody. Jim drove with his cap jammed down to his ears and his eyes slitted. John sat in the passenger chair with the Sig across his lap. Sanda rode in the dinette with her rifle. Granny sat on the couch holding her hair down with one hand.

"We should go to Jacksonville!" Jim shouted, over the wind. "The house! Our house!"

"A million people," John shouted back. "No water! It'll be worse than here!"

"The house has city water!" Liz shouted.

"Exactly!"

"I'm going home," Granny said.

She did not shout it. She said it in her ordinary voice, from the couch, and somehow they all heard it over the wind, and that was the end of the discussion.

They went west on 46 and north on 441, through little lake towns that were dead in a way John had never seen a town be dead. People walked along the shoulder carrying jugs and children. People sat on porches and watched the motor home go by with the rifle on its roof, and nobody waved.

North of Ocala, on the ramp to I-75, there were trucks across the road.

They were the old trucks, the canvas-backed ones, three of them, parked in a V to make a chute, and in front of them stood a sergeant with a clipboard. He was in his fifties, heavyset, with a gray mustache and reading glasses on a cord around his neck, wearing an old olive-drab field

jacket over his uniform that looked as if it had come out of the same depot as the trucks. His name tape said PETTAWAY. Behind him six young soldiers in helmets stood with rifles.

Jim stopped. He held his badge out the side window before the sergeant could ask for it.

"Retired, Jacksonville Sheriff's Office," Jim said. "Thirty-five years. This is my family. My mother's ninety. We're going to her home place in Alabama."

The sergeant looked at the badge and handed it back. He walked slowly along the side of the motor home, looking in the windows at the rifles, at Granny with her church fan, at the two dogs in the shower stall.

Then he stopped, and looked up. He looked at the Barrett on the roof for a long, long moment.

"Sir," Sergeant Pettaway said. "Is that a..."

"Yes," Jim said.

The sergeant looked at it for another moment. Then he looked at Jim. Then he looked at his clipboard, and decided, visibly, that there was not a box on it for this.

"...Drive safe," Sergeant Pettaway said, and waved them through.

* * *

They ran low on gas outside Lake City.

There was an old blue Ford pickup from the nineties dead on the shoulder, nose-down in the ditch. Jim pulled over beside it.

"Modern cars have anti-siphon valves in the filler neck," John said, climbing down with the hose they had found in the motor home's storage bay and Trevor's red gas can. "You can't get a hose past them. I saw a video."

"Old trucks don't," Jim said. "Kids used to siphon out of these all the time at the Regency Mall. We'd catch 'em three a night."

John fed the hose down into the truck's tank until he felt it hit bottom, and put the gas can on the ground below the tank, and put the end of the hose in his mouth, and sucked.

Gasoline came up the hose all at once like a snake out of a hole and filled his mouth.

He spat and coughed and spat on his knees on the shoulder of Interstate 75, while the gas poured out of the hose into the red can exactly the way it was supposed to.

His father stood over him with his hands in his pockets.

"Four thousand hours of YouTube," Jim said, "and none of it was this."

* * *

They spent the night in a church parking lot in south Georgia, outside a little town called Quitman, behind a white wooden Baptist church with a short steeple.

Every light in the town was out. But there were people inside the church, singing in the dark, a hymn Granny said they had sung on the riverbank when she was a girl, *Shall we gather at the river, where bright angel feet have trod*. Nobody inside had a light to read a hymnal by. Nobody needed one. They had known the words their whole lives.

Granny sat on the step of the motor home in the dark with her church fan and listened to the whole thing, all four verses, without moving.

Afterward, she took her radio out of her housecoat pocket and turned it on and found the station, and they all came and sat around her on the steps and in the doorway in the dark. The voice was not the president this time. It was a man reading from paper, flatly. Deaths in the cold in the northern cities, which he said were *estimated in the hundreds of thousands*. Hospitals operating on isolated generators. Water distribution points opening in every state. And then: *Coordinated network activity was detected yesterday in eleven states, down from forty-one states on the first day. Officials describe the trend as encouraging.*

"See," Jim said quietly, in the dark. "It's working."

John looked up at the sky, which was so full of stars it looked like spilled salt.

"Yeah, Dad," John said.

* * *

On Saturday morning, twenty miles from the dirt road, there was a truck across the highway.

It was a two-lane blacktop running straight through planted pine, flat and empty, with the trees close on both sides like the walls of a hallway. The truck was a silver Chevy Silverado, a newer one, crew cab, parked crossways across both lanes. A man was standing in front of it in the road, waving a red plastic gas can over his head with both arms, like a man flagging down a plane. He was skinny, in a camouflage jacket and a camouflage cap, with a scraggly red beard, and even from a quarter mile away John could see him smiling.

"He's out of gas," John said, leaning forward. "Dad, slow down. We've got gas. We've got a can. We can give him—"

He had learned, somewhere between the bus stop and his own front door, to want to stop. He did not know when. He wanted to stop.

Jim stopped. But he stopped short. He stopped a hundred and fifty yards back, in the middle of the road, and put the motor home in park, and did not take his hands off the wheel.

"That's a setup," Jim said.

"How do you—"

"Because I've seen it a hundred times." Jim's voice was very quiet and very level. "Truck across both lanes so you can't go around. One fella out front, friendly, waving. Something you'll want to give him. Look at the trees, son. Both sides. Look at the trees right at the truck."

John looked at the trees.

The tree line opened up.

It was short and loud and ugly and nothing about it was glorious. The pines on both sides blinked with yellow flashes, and the front of the motor home began to ring and pop like a tin roof in a hailstorm. The man with the gas can dropped it and ran for the truck.

"*Down!*" John shouted. "Everybody *down!*"

Sanda and Liz were already down, between the front seats, on their knees, and then they were up again, with the barrels of their rifles resting on the dashboard where the windshield used to be, and firing. John fired the Sig out of the empty windshield frame at the flashes in the trees on the left, and could not tell if he hit anything. Jim was flat across the front seats

with his hands over his head. Something punched through the side of the motor home behind John's head and went out the other side. Dorina was on the floor of the aisle with Charlie pulled under her, covering him with her body.

Something hit John in the left shoulder.

It felt like a red-hot iron bar swung by a strong man. It knocked him sideways into the dash. He did not fall. He sat there looking at it. Blood was coming out through his jacket, high on the shoulder, quickly, more than he would have thought.

"*John!*" Sanda screamed.

"I'm okay," John said, and he was, more or less. He was conscious. He was surprised to find he was conscious. "I'm okay. Keep shooting."

Nobody told Granny to do anything.

Nobody would remember afterward seeing her get up off the couch. She just did. She was ninety years old and she was not going to be shot at in her own son's motor home. She set the pug down on the couch and the church fan beside it, and she walked down the aisle between the boxes of ammunition and climbed the three steps of the ladder under the roof hatch, one at a time, holding on with both knotted hands, the way she climbed the steps of her church.

At the top step, the upper half of her was out on the roof, in the wind and the noise. She put her hands where she had seen John put them. She leaned to her right. She looked down the long barrel at the silver truck.

She pushed the safety the way she had seen him push it.

She fired.

The sound of it was not like a gunshot. It did not crack, the way the rifles cracked. It was a thud, one enormous flat thud that came up through the floor of the motor home into the soles of their feet and the fillings of their teeth, the sound a building makes when it falls down. The whole motor home rocked on its springs. And a hundred and fifty yards down the road, the hood of the silver Silverado flew up and folded in half.

That was the shot everybody had expected. Nobody had expected the rest of it.

Granny hauled the long barrel around on its mount, hard left, to the trees where the flashes were, and started pulling the trigger.

The Barrett was not a machine gun. It fired one round every time you pulled the trigger and not one round more, and Granny pulled the trigger the way she worked her church fan in August, as fast as her hand would go. *Thud. Thud. Thud.* The motor home bucked under them like a boat in a chop. Pines as thick as telephone poles burst white and leaned and came apart, and the top thirty feet of one of them came down across the road in a long green crash. Brass the size of cigars flew out of the far side of the rifle and rolled across the roof and rang on the asphalt below like somebody dropping wrenches. Every time she fired, the blast came back along the roof and stood her hair straight up on her head, and she did not notice, because she was screaming.

"*YOU WANT SOME?*" Granny screamed at the trees. "*YOU WANT SOME?*"

She walked the barrel back across the road without letting up. *Thud.* The engine block of the Silverado cracked open like a dropped melon, and black oil and green coolant and white steam blew out of it in every direction. *Thud.* The cab went, every window at once, in one glittering sheet. *Thud.* The tailgate fell off, and the whole truck sat down on the road on its front end like a shot horse, and she was already past it and into the trees on the right.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

What the men in those trees saw, if they looked, was this: a tiny old woman in a pink housecoat, standing up out of the roof of a motor home behind a rifle as long as she was, with her hair on end and her glasses flashing and her face set in a scowl her family had never seen on her. Her mouth was pulled down hard at both corners. Her eyes were slits. Her jaw was out. It was the face of a woman who had buried a husband and raised a deputy sheriff and gone without electricity for the first twelve years of her life, and who had, at ninety, on this road, had enough.

"*I SAID I'M GOING HOME!*" Granny screamed over the thunder of it. "*I'M GOING HOME, YOU MOTHERFUCKERS!*"

Nobody in the family had ever heard her say that word. Nobody in the family had been entirely sure she knew it.

The men came out of those pines like a covey of quail. The one in the camouflage jacket came out from behind the dead truck running, and two

more came crashing out of the pines on the left, one of them straight over the fallen pine top and down on his face and up again, and on the right a camouflage cap went up into the air and came down somewhere else, and the man who had been under it came out after it, without it, running. They ran, all of them, down the road and into the trees, as fast as they could go, without looking back.

Granny pulled the trigger three more times at nothing, still screaming, before she understood that the rifle had stopped. There had only ever been ten rounds.

Then there was nothing at all. The wind. The steam coming up off the truck. Granny standing in the hatch with her hair on end, breathing hard, glaring down the road at the place where the men had been, in case they cared to come back and try it.

Jim sat up slowly behind the wheel. He looked at the Silverado, steaming in the road. He looked up at the roof hatch, where his mother's slippers were standing on the top step of the ladder.

"Told you those things could take out a tank," Jim said.

John was holding his shoulder with his right hand and blood was coming out between his fingers.

"It's a Silverado, Dad," John said.

Granny came down the ladder one step at a time, holding on with both hands. At the bottom she stood in the aisle and straightened her housecoat and patted her hair back down.

"Oh my word," Granny said.

She went back to the couch and picked up the pug and her church fan and sat down.

* * *

Sanda opened the door of the motor home and stepped down onto the road with her rifle at her shoulder.

There was one man left by the truck. He had not run. He was sitting on the asphalt against the Silverado's back tire with both hands clamped on his thigh, and there was blood all down his jeans. He was a boy, really. He could not have been more than nineteen. He wore a tan Carhartt jacket

too big for him and a camouflage cap, and his face under it was white, and his mouth was open.

Sanda walked toward him down the center line with the red dot on his chest, the way she had walked toward Trevor across the broken glass. One step. Another. Fifty yards. Thirty. Twenty. She could see his face clearly now. She could see that he was crying.

She stopped.

She stood in the road with the rifle on him, and she knew exactly what she could do, because she had done it, three nights ago, kneeling on a floor with two fingers on a man's neck. She knew how it felt. She knew that she could. That was the thing she had been carrying in her chest since Wednesday night: not that she had done it, but that it had been so easy.

She lowered the rifle.

She lowered it until it pointed at the asphalt. And then she turned to the pines, to the place where the men had gone, and she screamed. It was not a word. It went on and on, long and terrible, and it went out across the road and into the trees and through them, and it did not stop until there was nobody left in those trees to hear it.

Then she walked back to the motor home and climbed in and closed the door.

* * *

Dorina had John on his back on the floor of the motor home between the boxes of ammunition before the door was closed.

She had Trevor's red trauma bag open beside her, and she had cut away his jacket and shirt with shears faster than he would have believed, and found the hole, and the hole on the other side, where it had gone through. Her hands moved over it quickly and surely, the way they must have moved in the back of an ambulance in Bucharest in a cold December long ago, and her face had gone quiet and flat and certain.

She threaded a curved needle from a sealed packet.

"Hold still," Dorina said, in English.

John held still. He had never been so still in his life.

She stitched him on the floor of the motor home with the Barrett still pointing at the steaming truck, while Jim drove them slowly around the

dead Silverado on the shoulder of the road, glass sliding on the dash, and the boy in the Carhartt jacket watched them go by. When she was done, she taped a pad over each side and sat back on her heels and looked at him for the first time.

"Is good," Dorina said. "You live."

* * *

Granny gave the directions for the last twenty miles. She sat up straight on the couch with the pug in her lap and said them from memory, without a map, without having been there in more than thirty years, and every one of them was right. *Left at the Primitive Baptist church. Three miles. Right on the dirt road past the big water oak.* The water oak was still there. It was enormous.

The dirt road was red. The motor home lurched and swayed on it, and branches scraped down both sides, and pine needles came in through the empty windshield. A mile through planted pine. Then the old longleaf, tall and far apart, with the ground beneath them carpeted copper.

The road ended at an embankment.

It stood up in front of them six feet high, red clay streaked with off-white sand, and the road simply stopped at the foot of it. Jim turned off the engine. The silence came in through the empty windshield like water.

John lifted himself up on his good elbow on the floor and looked out. To the left, back in the pines, there was a tin roof, rusted to the color of the road, and part of a chimney. In the clearing in front of it, on its short iron pipe, stood the pump, rusted solid, exactly where it had been when he was twenty-three, and when he had looked at it and thought, *I doubt it*, and forgotten it for nineteen years.

"We're home," Granny said.

Behind them, back down the road, someone fired a shotgun into the air. It was one shot, deliberate, the way a man knocks on a door.

And a voice they did not know called out, slow and level, from somewhere back in the pines:

"*That's far enough.*"

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Well

◇

Soak new leather overnight. Don't rush it.

— Hoyt Stevens, in pencil, on the back of a feed-store receipt

Granny was out the door of the motor home before anyone could stop her.

"Mama—" Jim said, reaching, and missed. She went down the steps in her pink housecoat and her terrycloth slippers, holding the rail with both hands, and set off back up the red dirt road toward the voice, not fast, not slow, the way she had walked to church for eighty years.

Thirty yards back, just off the road in the pines, a tractor sat idling. It was green and yellow, square and old, with big rear tires caked in red clay and a single round headlight, and nothing on it anywhere that could think. Beside it stood a tall old man with a pump shotgun pointed at the sky. He was bony and long-jawed, with white stubble and arms burned nearly black by the sun, and he wore faded bib overalls over a gray waffle-knit undershirt and a sweat-stained feed cap that said PINE LEVEL FEED & SEED. He watched the little old woman in the housecoat come up the road toward him, and the shotgun came down an inch.

"Hollis Pruitt," Granny said, stopping in front of him. "You put that thing down."

The old man stared at her. He lowered the shotgun the rest of the way.

"Miss Eula?" Hollis said.

"Eula Stevens," Granny said. "Hoyt's wife. That's my boy Jimmy driving. And his boy, and the rest of 'em." She looked him up and down. "You've got old, Hollis."

Hollis Pruitt took off his cap. He held it against his chest with both hands, and stood there in the road with his white head bare, and for a moment he did not seem able to say anything.

"Yes, ma'am," Hollis said finally. "I reckon I have."

Somebody else was coming up the road behind him, riding a mule. The mule was brown, with a pale gray muzzle and one ear that stood up and one that flopped, and on its bare back, sitting astride in a denim skirt with her rubber boots hanging down, was a short, wide old woman with a long white braid over one shoulder, in a man's red flannel shirt with the sleeves rolled. She had a pair of reading glasses pushed up on her head and a shotgun of her own across her lap.

"Who is it, Hollis?" the old woman called.

"It's Miss Eula, Dee," Hollis said. "Hoyt Stevens's widow. Come home."

Dee Pruitt looked at Granny for a long moment from the back of the mule. Then she slid down off it, boots and skirt and shotgun and all, and walked straight to Granny and put her arms around her.

"Well, Lord, honey," Dee said. "What took you so long?"

* * *

"We heard y'all a mile off," Hollis said, when they had all come down out of the motor home and were standing in the road. "Heard the big gun go off down at the crossroads. Thought you might be them boys."

"We met them," Jim said.

Hollis looked at Jim, and at Jim's badge on his windbreaker, and at the half of Jim's mustache that was left. He looked at Sanda and Liz with their rifles, and at Dorina in her quilted coat with the old twenty-two on her shoulder and a dog on a leash, and at John, standing in the motor home doorway with his left arm in a sling made from one of Sanda's silk scarves and his face purple and green. Then he looked up, slowly, at the roof of

the motor home, at the Barrett, which was still pointed down the road at nothing.

"You folks expecting the Russians?" Hollis asked.

John thought about it.

"Software," John said.

Hollis considered this for some time.

"Well," Hollis said. "We ain't got any."

* * *

The Pruitts had lived a mile back down the road since before John was born. They had kept an eye on the old Stevens place for Granny since nineteen ninety-four, when Granny had written to ask, and they had never once asked for a dime. They had a hand pump on their own well, and a spring at the back of their land, and a smokehouse, and forty chickens, and Pearl the mule, and a 1979 John Deere that ran on diesel and spite. There were twelve families on the road. The lights had gone out on all of them on the eleventh of January, the same as everybody else in the world.

"Out here," Dee said, walking beside Granny toward the old house with her arm through hers, "that's about like a bad ice storm. Folks pulled out the lamps. Lit the woodstoves. Killed a hog. The ones that had a radio, listened." She shrugged. "We didn't get the lights on this road till forty-eight. Plenty of us remember our mamas doing without."

"I was twelve," Granny said.

"I know you were, honey. Mama told it till the day she died."

The house was standing. It was smaller than John remembered, and older, gray board walls that had never in their life seen paint, and a tin roof rusted to the color of the road, and a brick chimney. Half of the front porch had fallen in. The other half was solid. Behind the house was a shed with a sagging door, and behind the shed, down the slope a little way, a low, windowless log building with a peaked roof that Hollis said was the old smokehouse, and the driest building on the road.

And in the clearing in front of the house, on its short iron pipe, stood the pump.

John walked up to it. Up close it was a cast-iron thing as tall as his waist, with a long curved handle on one side and a spout on the other, and a cap

on top, and all of it was the same red-brown color of rust. He took hold of the handle with his good hand and pushed down.

It did not move. He pushed harder. It moved an inch, with a long shriek of iron on iron, and stopped, and nothing came out of the spout but a little red dust.

"Leather's gone," Hollis said, behind him. "Dry-rotted. Been gone for years. There's a cup of leather down inside on the plunger, see, and it's got to seal against the pipe, or it won't pull. That one's rotted to nothing. You need a new leather."

"Where do you get a leather?"

Hollis rubbed his stubble. "Used to be you'd get one at the feed store." He looked off toward the road. "Now, I don't rightly know."

* * *

The shed was dark and smelled — he supposed — of old wood and motor oil and mice. Hoyt's tools were still hanging on the wall above the bench where he had hung them sixty years ago, rusted, each one on its own nail inside a shape he had traced around it in black paint so he would know where it went: hammer, saw, brace and bit, a big pipe wrench. On a shelf above the bench sat a blue Maxwell House coffee can with a plastic lid.

John took it down. Inside were papers, folded and rolled and soft as cloth with age. A deed. Tax receipts. A letter from a bank. A photograph of a young man with a crew cut and long hands standing beside a mule in a field, squinting into the sun. And a small, flat red tin that said PRINCE ALBERT on the lid.

He opened the tin. Inside, wrapped in waxed paper, were three round, cupped disks of thick dark leather, each about the size of a coaster.

He stood there in the dim shed holding them in his palm.

Underneath the tin, at the bottom of the can, was a feed-store receipt, yellow and soft, printed at the top PINE LEVEL FEED & SEED, with a date stamped on it from the spring of nineteen sixty-one. On the front it listed a sack of chicken feed and a box of nails. On the back, in pencil, in a careful, slanting, old-fashioned hand that John had last seen on a birthday card the year before Hoyt died, there was writing. A lot of it. Small.

He held it out at arm's length and squinted with his one good eye and could not read a word.

He walked out of the shed into the sun and found his mother.

"Can I borrow your glasses?"

"Bring them back," Liz said, lifting the beaded chain over her head.

"I always do."

"You never have once," Liz said.

He put them on and sat down on the solid half of the porch steps with the receipt in his lap, and Sanda came and sat down beside him, and the words came up off the paper.

PUMP LEATHER. Pull pin at top of handle. Lift off cap. Draw up rod — plunger on end. Old cup off — nut underneath, 9/16. Soak new leather overnight in water. DON'T RUSH IT. Dry leather won't swell, won't seal. Fit cup on, lip UP. Nut snug, not hard. Rod back down. Cap. Pin. Prime with a quart. Work slow at first. Keep it wet — a dry leather is a dead pump. — H.S.

John read it twice. Then he sat there on the step with the receipt in his lap and his mother's glasses on his nose and did not say anything for a long time.

"What?" Sanda asked.

"I dreamed this," John said. "The night before. The night it all went out. He was standing by the door with one of these in his hand." He held up a leather cup. "He said, *You got to keep the leather wet, son.* And I didn't know what he meant."

Sanda looked at the leather in his hand. She did not say anything for a while either.

"Well," Sanda said. "Now you do."

They soaked the leather that night in the only container they could spare: the rooster pitcher, filled from the last of the motor home's tank. Sanda set it on the porch rail in the dark. John got up three times in the night to look at it.

* * *

That first evening, everybody found something to do, the way people do when they finally stop running.

Granny walked Jim out behind the house with her church fan and showed him where the outhouse had stood when she was a girl, and told him to dig the new one there — downhill from the well, a hundred steps, always downhill from the well, always — and stood over him with her fan while he dug, and told him he was doing it wrong. He was doing it wrong. She showed him. He did it her way.

Dorina set herself up on the solid half of the porch with Trevor's red trauma bag and the big jug of Wild Turkey 101 and a dining chair from the motor home, and by sundown, without anybody announcing anything, there was a line. A boy from down the road with a fishhook through the meat of his thumb. A farmer's wife with a cough that had been going a month. An old man who just wanted his blood pressure taken, and Dorina took it with a cuff from the bag and told him it was terrible and to eat less salt pork, and he went away delighted.

They carried the guns into the old smokehouse, all thirty-one of them, and the ammunition, and stacked them in the dark against the log walls, and Hollis put a padlock on the door and gave John the key.

And Sanda came out of the motor home with her rifle, the one she had shot forty rounds through on a Saturday in December and two through a sliding glass door on a Wednesday night, and walked up to John where he stood in the yard by the pump, and held it out to him.

"Here," Sanda said.

He took it. She turned and walked away from him across the yard, to where Dee Pruitt stood at the edge of the clearing in the last of the light, in her red flannel and her rubber boots, and the two of them began to walk the ground together, heel to toe, counting, Dee pointing here and there with a stick, Sanda nodding, pacing out rows.

* * *

In the morning John fixed the pump.

It took him two hours, with one good arm and his mother's glasses and his grandfather's handwriting propped against a brick on the porch step where he could see it. He pulled the pin. He lifted the cap, which shrieked. He drew up the long iron rod, hand over hand, out of the pipe, and there on the end of it was the plunger with what was left of the old leather on

it, black and cracked and crumbling like burned paper. He found the nine-sixteenths wrench on its nail in the shed, inside its painted outline, and loosened the nut. He took the new leather out of the rooster pitcher, dark and soft and swollen with water, and fit it on, lip up, and tightened the nut snug, not hard. He fed the rod back down the pipe. Cap. Pin. He did every step in order. He did not skip one. He read each line twice before he did it and once after.

Everybody had gathered by the time he was ready. All of them, and Hollis and Dee, and Pearl the mule, who had come over to see.

"Prime it," John said. "It says a quart."

Sanda brought the rooster pitcher. There was about a quart in it, the water the leather had soaked in all night. She poured it slowly into the top of the pump.

John took hold of the handle with his right hand and worked it. Slow at first, the receipt said. Up. Down. Up. It squealed. Down. There was a sound deep in the pipe, a gurgle, a long sucking breath, like something very old waking up.

Water came out of the spout.

It came out brown, rust-red, a thick spurt of it splashing onto the ground. He kept pumping. It came out orange. He kept pumping. It came out cloudy, and then less cloudy, and then, all at once, clear — clear and cold and steady, gushing out of the spout in a thick bright rope onto the red clay, and splashing up onto his shoes.

Nobody cheered. They just stood there and watched it come.

Sanda held out a tin cup. He filled it and handed it to her.

She drank it. All of it. Then she looked at him over the rim, for one beat longer than she needed to.

"Don't touch the plug," Sanda said.

"There's no plug," John said. "It's a well."

"Good," Sanda said, and held the cup out again, and he filled it again, and that was the tub. That was the end of the tub, there in the yard with the water running over their shoes.

* * *

On the tenth of February, at noon, they all sat on the porch around Granny's radio.

The voice was not the president's. It was the same flat, careful man who had read the bulletins in the church parking lot in Georgia, and he read this one from paper too.

Fourteen consecutive days have now passed with no coordinated network activity detected anywhere in the United States or in allied nations. Beginning tomorrow, manual re-energization of the electrical grid will begin, region by region, starting with hospitals and water treatment plants. Every breaker will be closed by a human hand. There will be no networked control of any part of the grid. There will be no public internet for the foreseeable future. Telephone service will be restored by voice only, on wire.

There was a pause on the radio, the sound of a page turning.

We cannot promise that it is gone, the man read. *We can promise that we are watching now.*

Granny turned it off to save the batteries.

Nobody said anything for a while. Out in the yard, the chickens Dee had given them were scratching in the dirt near the pump.

John laughed. He did not mean to. It came out of him all at once, and he could not stop it, and everyone looked at him.

"That's the plan," John said. "That's the whole plan. For the entire human race. Turn it all off and hope for the best." He wiped his eyes with his good hand. "That was *my* plan. That was my plan the whole time."

"No," Sanda said. "Your plan was *prepare for the worst and hope for the best*." She looked at him. "You forgot the first half, John."

He stopped laughing.

Sanda looked out at the yard for a long time, at the chickens, at the pump, at the rows she and Dee had paced out with sticks, where the dirt had been turned. When she spoke again, it was quieter, and it was not to anybody in particular.

"I'd do it again," Sanda said. "In that apartment. The third one. I've thought about it every day. I knelt there with my fingers on his neck and I couldn't tell, and I thought, this is stupid, and I did it." She folded her hands in her lap. "I'd do it again. And I'd put the rifle down again, on that road, with that boy. I'd do that again too." She was quiet for a moment.

"They're both true. I've been trying to make one of them not be true, and they're both true. So."

She stood up. She brushed off the seat of her jeans. She picked up the hoe that was leaning against the porch post, an old one of Hoyt's from the shed, with a new handle Hollis had cut for it from a hickory sapling.

"I'm going to go plant something," Sanda said, and went down the steps into the yard.

* * *

By April the garden was in.

It ran in long straight rows across the clearing in front of the house — tomatoes and squash and pole beans and okra and three rows of collards, because Granny said so — and the barbed wire was finally out of its box. Sanda had strung the whole quarter mile of it, wearing the gauntlets, around a chicken yard behind the house, to keep out the foxes, and it was the only use anyone ever found for it, and it was a good one.

The chicken house was the motor home.

It sat in the chicken yard with its wheels off and its windshield gone and chicken wire across the hole. The hens roosted on a pole across the bedroom. They laid their eggs in the shower stall, in straw, where the dogs had ridden to Alabama. And above it all, on its mount on the roof, the Barrett pointed out over the yard with an old green tarp stretched from the end of its barrel down to a post in the ground, making a little awning for the hens to stand under in the rain. On this road, it drew no comment whatsoever.

John had built the nesting boxes himself. He had meant to use the cordless nail gun, which he had finally taken out of its box, but its battery had died in January, like the drill's, like every battery he owned. So he built them with Hoyt's hammer and a coffee can of nails from the shed, and his left thumb was still purple, and the nail was coming off.

Sanda killed the chickens on Sundays. Jim would not, and could not, and stood out of sight behind the smokehouse with his fingers in his ears every Sunday morning like a man waiting out a lobster. Sanda did it the way her grandmother had done it in the village outside Bucharest, quickly and without ceremony, and then she cooked the chicken in Granny's kitchen

with rosemary from Dee's garden and served it in Pinot Noir glasses full of well water, with a cloth napkin folded at every place, because some things were not going to change. In the kitchen window, on a nail, where it caught the morning sun, hung a little gold glass clock from a Chicago department store that had not existed for twenty years.

Jim carried the eggs down the road to the Pruitts every morning in a basket, wearing his windbreaker with the star on it, and on the way he stopped at every house on the road and talked. He had become, by common consent and without anybody ever voting, the sheriff of the road. When Earl Tidwell's hog got into the Mabry boys' corn in March, it was Jim who walked out into the corn in his New Balance sneakers and stood between Earl, red-faced in his suspenders, and the oldest Mabry boy, sixteen and skinny in a camouflage hat, and the shotgun the Mabry boy was holding, and said, in the low, slow voice, "Everybody take a breath," and they did. He never drew a weapon. Not once, the whole time. He kept his phone in a kitchen drawer, turned off, with its charger coiled beside it. For when it came back.

Liz kept the ledger.

She kept it in the Home Goods notebook with the little yellow pineapples on the cover, in her neat banker's hand, in two columns, owed and paid. Eggs. Diesel for Hollis's tractor. Stitches. A haircut. Two jars of honey. Cartridges. It was the only bank in a hundred miles and it had never once been wrong. A fifty-round box of twenty-two long rifle cartridges, it turned out, traded on the road for two eggs, which was almost exactly what John had predicted on Black Friday on the floor among the Christmas ornaments. He had mentioned this to his family, by Liz's own careful count in the back of the ledger, approximately four hundred times.

"You were right about one thing," Sanda told him, on the four hundred and first. "Enjoy it."

Dorina ran a clinic every afternoon on the porch, with Trevor's bag and her own two hands, and people came from three roads over. She kept the jug of Wild Turkey 101 beside her chair, and she used it on wounds, and she would not let anyone drink it, not even Hollis, not even at Easter.

Granny ran the kitchen. The old house had a wood stove that Hollis had cleaned out, and she cooked on it the way she had cooked when she was twelve, and she ordered everyone around, and everyone did what she said. She had been seen to eat sardines on crackers twice more, once at the kitchen table and once on the porch, and both times she had looked straight at John while she ate them, and she would not discuss it.

Charlie and the pug slept under the porch in the cool dirt, curled together. The pug had gained eight pounds. She still burped. Every morning Trevor's red hand cart carried water from the pump to the garden, two blue jugs at a time.

And John had a notebook.

It was a spiral notebook, college-ruled, from a box of school supplies Dee had found in her attic. On the cover, in black marker, he had written: WHAT TO DO NEXT TIME.

On the first page, in capital letters, it said: 1. FILL THE TUB.

On the second page, it said: 2. DO NOT TOUCH THE TUB.

The third page was the instructions for setting his tactical flashlights to stay on low, written out from memory, step by step, every click and every hold. It had taken him a week to remember them. He had gotten them right.

There were other pages. There was a page about rationing. There was a page about the toilet tank. There was a page, near the back, that just said, READ EVERYTHING, and under it, in smaller letters, *Priya was right*.

* * *

The mail came in April, for the first time in three months. The rural carrier, a gray-bearded man in a faded blue postal jacket, drove it down the dirt road in a 1970s Jeep with no radio, and he had three things for them, tied with string.

There was a letter from Matt, in pencil, on notebook paper. *Still here. Lost thirty pounds. Burned my bookshelves, then my neighbor's. The Mosin makes a good fireplace poker. Tell Sanda I'm sorry I said Florida wasn't real. It is very real. I'm coming down there.*

There was a postcard with a picture of a lake in Lake Mary on the front and, on the back, in a small, neat, old-fashioned hand: *The Guard brought*

insulin on the ninth day. I am well. The Nguyens are with her mother in Kissimmee. The dumpster is gone. Your grandmother still owes me a dance. — Ramón Alvarez.

And there was a typed letter on plain paper from a man at the state, a thin, polite man in a necktie and a windbreaker who had already come down the road once, in March, in an old Bronco, to ask John where seven printouts were, and had written down the answer — *in the trunk of a gray Volkswagen in a garage behind a gate in Lake Mary, under the spare tire* — on a clipboard. The letter said that Palmetto Grid Software was rebuilding Restore from the first line, by hand, and that every line would be read by two people before it was used, and that they were looking for readers.

John read it twice. He put it in the back of his notebook. He had not decided. He had a pump to look after.

* * *

In the last week of April, a truck came down the dirt road.

It was a bucket truck, old, from the eighties, white with a co-op's name painted on the doors, and it had no screen in it anywhere. Out of it climbed a lineman, a big, slow-moving young man in a hard hat and a tan flame-resistant shirt with the sleeves rolled, with a pinch of snuff in his lip and the round ring of the can worn white into the back pocket of his jeans. He nodded to all of them on the porch. He did not say much. He walked to the pole at the end of the road, where the line ran down to the old house, and he raised a long fiberglass stick up to the top of it, and with his own two hands, he closed the switch.

That was all. That was the whole thing.

In March, John had rewired the old house's kitchen himself. He had a degree in electrical engineering that he had not used for twenty years, and Hollis had a booklet in his barn from the Rural Electrification Administration, printed in nineteen fifty-two, called *Wiring Your Farm Home*, and John had read every page of it with his mother's glasses on. He had hung a single porcelain socket from the middle of the kitchen ceiling on a cloth-covered wire, with a little brass pull chain, and screwed in a bulb. Hollis had dug an old meter out of the barn, the kind with a spinning wheel, and

they had put it on the wall outside. They had left it switched on. Just in case.

The bulb came on.

It came on in the middle of the kitchen ceiling, hanging on its wire, with no shade, just the bulb, yellow and warm and very bright in the dim little room, and everyone came in from the porch and stood under it and looked up.

Charlie barked at it.

"No bark," John said.

Charlie stopped.

Granny stood in the middle of the kitchen with her church fan in her hand and looked up at the bulb for a long time. She was ninety years old. She had been twelve years old the first time a man from the co-op came down this road and the lights came on, in her mama's kitchen, a bulb on a wire with no cover on it, and her daddy had pulled the chain, and nobody had said a word.

"Well," Granny said. "Took 'em long enough."

The bulb flickered.

It was nothing. It was one quick dip and back, the way bulbs do, the way every light bulb in the world has always done once in a while, when a breeze moves a line somewhere or a transformer hums or the current shifts on its way down a long wire from far away. It flickered once. Everyone saw it.

John looked at it.

He stood there under it and looked at it, and it did not flicker again. It burned steady and yellow and quiet over all their heads. He did not wonder. He decided, standing there, not to wonder, the way you decide to put something down.

He reached up and pulled the little brass chain, and the bulb went out.

"Let's not get used to it," John said.

They went back out onto the porch. All of them: Jim and Liz, and Granny with her fan, and Dorina, and Sanda, and John, and the two dogs under the boards, and the chickens settling in the motor home with its rifle on the roof, and the evening coming down blue over the pines. Nobody turned on a light. They sat on the porch in the dark, on the steps and

the dining chairs and the porch rail, and they talked — about the garden, about Pearl, about Hollis's tractor, about Earl Tidwell's hog, about nothing — which was a thing John had once not been able to imagine people doing, before electricity, in the dark, for hours. They did it for hours.

After a long while, Sanda leaned her head against his good shoulder.

"So," Sanda said. "About the house."

John looked out at the dark yard, at the pump, at the garden, at the gray shape of the old house behind them with its half a porch and its tin roof and its one bulb, off.

"You were right," John said.

"I know," Sanda said. "I meant there's a chicken in it."